Henry’s Garden

Prologue

The history was complex and mostly hidden for such a long time.

There are many versions of the story, as contradictory as they are similar, these variations, but all of them say that a strike of lightning printed Henry Wells' face on the window.

These versions go as such.

Most go with one version where he wasn't near the window, the most popular telling of the tale from the nineteenth century up until the 1960s. In this version, they say that that Henry was being lynched by an angry white mob on the county square lawn and, all of a sudden, an awful big Southern thunderstorm came through, awful, an awful big thunderstorm, *yada yada*, so they'd say. The storm was roaring, barely any visibility in the rain it was so hard, and you couldn't see two feet in front of you, they'd say. It was a big awful storm, and, *all of a sudden*—it was always "all of a sudden"—in this storm that came about the square itself all of a sudden too, *a bolt of lightning hit*, a strike hit, hit a large and mighty old tree nearby, all of a sudden, all of a sudden, they'd say, and, as every Southerner knows, and as most oral versions insist, *every* bolt of lightning ends in a what they called a "fireball," a "fireball" they'd call it, a "lightning 'fireball,' laughably enough, it never clear what the hell they were talking about in meteorology, physics nor reality broadly, and, so, it was the so-called sudden Alabama evening thunderstorm lightning fireball that imprinted the face of that Henry Wells on that window, something like that, most agreed.

That's a popular and old telling, a version wherein he *wasn't even anywhere near the window* when the lightning hit.

Another, later version would say that, when the supposed lightning struck that tree across from the courthouse, he was standing in one of the garret windows looking down at the lynch mob on the lawn,

standing in the very window that was the very one everybody was on about to that day, slightly more believable physics-wise, his actually being in the window when lightning struck, or its hind-end "fireball," or whatever, lightning striking or whatever, though none of it made any goddamn sense, and that's surely because lightning doesn't print things on stuff, doesn't transfer image data, especially at a distance from where it strikes; you cannot make sense out of nonsense.

In these main two popular versions and in any case, there's Henry, a white lynch mob, a window and a strike of lightning; in all versions, Henry has been arrested for burning down the prior courthouse in the square two years prior to skipping town and returning to Pickens County (some versions claim that this African-American man from nineteenth-century Aliceville, Pickens County, Alabama, a formerly enslaved man, skipped town and went to *Mexico* for two years, just skipping to and fro; no version really accounts for his whereabouts for two years or his goings and comings from Timbuktu or whatever you have, or Mexico, the Lord knows, who knows). Upon his return to Pickens County, he was promptly arrested in Carrollton or Aliceville, most likely his mama's house in Aliceville, but that detail as to his whereabouts upon his arrest in Pickens differed depending on who was telling the story, and, as it was mostly told in public by the late-1960s in the wake of the Civil Rights Movement, while Henry was in custody, one night, the sheriff took him from the jail to hide him from any unjust potential harm, which he was said to have been worried about, taking Henry and hiding him in the new courthouse garret room. They said he did it because he was a reasonable and *good white man of standing*, saying he did so, thus "protecting" Henry by "hiding" him—on the top floor of an unfinished, then under-construction courthouse garret room with window frames on all sides, windows too —*supposedly*… it supposedly had windows—and not jack of this was ever mentioned when these crazy white people got that Henry Wells glint in their eyes and told the story with glee and much drama. The sheriff was hiding him, supposedly, him from potential violence,

which he was said to have done upon hearing that a lynch mob was likely cooking in Carrollton for everybody in town had learned that Henry Wells was back in Pickens County and in police custody. If any of this element of the narrative was true, in removing Henry from the jailhouse, an actual and whole building, and putting him up in the unfinished, under-construction courthouse, this white man basically took poor *ole*' Henry Wells from what you call "inside" to the "outside," in all reality—considering the basic facts about inside and outside and how those two things work in tandem, just a matter of architecture—this supposed white hero, this good white man, as they'd say, this sheriff offered Henry up on a platter, if that story has any truth to it.

Further, beyond the lies—they did not care and admitted: we killed him and they urged that he fucking deserved it, pretty much.

These white people, the story goes and history attests, not only admitting it but justifying it, as the story would go in all its versions, self-admitted and part of the central narrative rhetoric, part of the tale's South*ah*n charm, told a story that *openly reveled in their ancestors' rage*, their narrations always empathizing with how white people in the Reconstruction era were crazed and violent, but justifiably and righteously so, bitter as hell about Civil War losses, especially turned out regarding Yankee building burning campaigns, the old Pickens County courthouse burned down, recently constructed after another prior one was burned down by Union troops, the fire and its centerpiece nature in the square too symbolic and so significant that the next courthouse, the third one which stood in the county square across from the modern fourth one, this building and its famed window would have a vice grip on the place for at least the next century.

They couldn't let anything happen to that courthouse, their precious third courthouse with their bizarre spook lynching ghost story window.

In any case, it's a lynching ghost story, a lynching ghost story window, and, in all versions, at some point, a white lynch mob does

form, and Henry, either standing in the window (mere frames with glass, no walls, again), or being actively and brutally murdered on the lawn, he calls out in all versions and says: “I am innocent! If you kill me, I will haunt you for the rest of your lives!”

There was one more detail that was added sometimes, something based upon a rumor that you could only see the Face in the Window from the outside. The former county commissioner had gone up and he said you couldn’t see it from the inside.

It was always dark up there, up at the top of the courthouse on the inside, nobody having been gone up in a good while, nobody having gone up since the prior county commissioner and local Freemason Worshipful Master—”Worshipful Master,” what they called him, and he was also a former Grand Wizard Klansman, and so he was also called a Wizard and a Master. He was a businessman. This was Mr. Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr., and he went up in 1985 and had been talking about it for near a decade, when he died the prior year, 1993, legless, an amputee, spending his days situated in a baby crib in a sun room in a house in downtown Gordo, propped up in that flea market baby crib on pillows and watching the hit television show *911* as his daughter drank black Folger's coffee and Diet Coke and smoked her long-ass and skinny Virginia Slim cigarettes—Itragene Belle McDaniel, Sr., that was his daughter.

Somebody was said to have noticed it one late-winter morning in 1878, noticed this supposed face in that window, noticed it in the morning the day after Henry Wells was said to have been lynched, it was said, that somebody hollering: “It's Henry Wells!”

The town came out and was aghast, and they yelled: “It's Henry Wells!”

To this day, they look up and they say, “It's Henry Wells!”

They all hollered such, as it was told so long after the February night poor Henry Wells was said to have been murdered in cold blood at the hands of a white lynch mob in Pickens County, Alabama, over in Carrollton.

If you looked just right and saw it, it was a *horrific sight* and everybody loved it, grew up with it and needed it.

They couldn't do without it.

Justice was a mechanism unknown to Henry's Garden, and it did not impact their literary rhetoric, justice, not at all, the mythos of the Face in the Window as a legend, tale, warning and freak architectural feature so brutally unjust, a disgrace. The people needed their ghost stories and they clung to the image and made meaning out of everything by sieving it through the logic of the window, the Face in the Window. Everybody—at least the white people—loved how spooky it all was, how South*ah*n it all was.

Again, the way it was all told, different versions and all, that face in that there beloved window belonged to a Black man, a man who was literally lynched or almost lynched—who really knows—lynched, lynched by an actual white mob during a supposed fucking sudden thunderstorm, or he was up in the window, it all so unclear and none of it making any damn sense anyway, any perspective on it, the lawn or window theory; that's just the reality of the situation. There's that and the fact that somebody *must*'ve put that image up there, just *must*'ve, the only thing that could made any sort of sense, and not many seemed to pick up on that, that nor as to whose advantage it was and why it was done.

Lightning is not a press as it does not print.

It was certainly the work of godforsaken Pickens County, Alabama, white people in the Reconstruction-era South, certainly white people with clear reasons and motivations, clearly what had happened, the situation so extremely delusional that it was truly just amazing to behold it all.

There was a Face in the Window and nobody was allowed to say otherwise or honk or scream. This was Henry's Garden.

It was a real *whodunnit* and they treated it like an amusing looky-loo, the whole damn town and beyond Carrollton gawking until their neck vertebrae grew crooked, rubbernecking this lynching story for

over a whole century, gawking at Henry and getting neck-specific scoliosis from looking at the window just right—crooked necks, twisted hearts, glazed eyes, empty heads, busy hands.

They read those poltergeist Jeffrey books, the Alabama one, *13 Alabama Ghosts and Jeffrey*, and the others. They had guest speakers talk about the courthouse in their classes, lecturers and yarn spinners from near and far. The central-Alabama ABC 33/40 affiliate came down from Birmingham and so Channel 4 CBS come over from Mississippi, from just across the border, all of them making a visit regularly, near quarterly, it seemed, or at least every other year or so, like the story had changed and more, extensive, droning coverage was necessary. 7th graders county-wide would submit drawings of the courthouse to an art competition every year, watercolors, pastels and cross-hatched ballpoint pen portraits from memory, photos, and sometimes, some years, a teacher or two at Carrollton Unit School would walk CUS pupils to the square up the street so that they could examine their muse, the whole county's muse, the old Pickens County courthouse, and so some of this art was of the still life genre.

Local idiot and amateur, "local historian," as they called her, a woman who was a major face-in-the-window enthusiast, a woman called Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley, Jane Ellen, she would take Carrollton Unit School students to the square and have them clean lime off of the Confederate statue on the east side of the lawn, them cleaning as she told them the story of "the Face in the Window." Without batting her white eyes, she'd make these mostly Black students clean a Confederate monument in Henry's Garden, where there are stories tilled in the soil. It was a damn lynching amusement park, the *Pickens County Herald* covering these trips that were racially charged forced labor situations, all in the name of South*ah*n heritage, so cute that they put it on the front page of the *Herald*, Mrs. Hadley smiling about the legacy, smiling her goofy face off, cheesing for the camera, her with the kids all huddled in front of the monument, smiling proudly about what had become her life's work, the Face in the Window, the legacy

of the Face in the Window, this courthouse, this lawn, Henry's Garden, her, a community figure and leader, her doing her best to maintain it.

Anyhow, there was all of that, and, too, local and out-of-town churches alike gave walking tours of the courthouse grounds, just walking in circles, these people, walking and piddling around the county square with their ghost lynching window story that they loved so much and were so damn proud of as they were telling the tale, like ants on a pheromone trail, a death spiral, around in circles they'd go.

They would make art about, go see, report on and tell the story until they died, Mrs. Hadley even getting killed because of her compulsive need to talk about and investigate this window, prattling on about it until she died, just as others did too, died naturally or otherwise, maybe by brutal accident, so many brutal accidents happening in Pickens County, death the only thing to stop them from talking about it.

Part I: The Famously Recursive South

I. The Face in the Window

There was, at a time, this building in Alabama. It was in Pickens County, Alabama, over in the town of Carrollton, the county seat. A wonder that it stood for as long as it did. As best they could, many had worked to maintain it, this very old brick building, a Reconstruction-era courthouse, a tourist attraction, retired and falling apart, but a historical treasure to them and nowhere near abandoned, though not used for many years for the execution of the law. It was prized. They loved to talk about it. This courthouse was a very famous building in the region, indeed, and that's because it was supposedly haunted, the ghost story involving the building why they all loved it so much. This famous structure was quite the sight, as it had had a peculiar feature, which was a bizarre window. There's a whole legend about this building and that window, see; there was something you could see in it, indeed. Truly, back in the day, if you took a good look at the north-side façade, at the third-floor garret window, you would see something in that strange window. That much was true. There was something there, at minimum, some optical sensation of note. A visible smudge on the window, there it was. They said it was a face. It was a smudge, it was a stain, and it resembled a face, a tortured face. These matters at hand they'd refer to simply and broadly as “the Face in the Window.” That was the situation.

They said, in fact, that the face belonged to a lynched Black man, a Mr. Henry Wells.

The Face in the Window is no longer there. Look it up on the Internet if you want to see it. There are images online.

The building in which the window was set no longer stands in the Pickens County square over in Carrollton. A crazy lady knocked out the window in 1996; she was touched in the head, had the bipolar, and she did something extreme manic. After her exuberant vandalism, they

later demolished the building. Then it was dust. They didn't want to remember it anymore after doing so for so long; they had to abandon their communal, indeed mobbish, ritualized recollection, the repeated lynching of Henry Wells in their minds, their tending to the *legacy* of the Confederate South in that place, which was what it had all been about, the legacy. After they razed the site, they built themselves a little sitting garden there, one with rusty benches and dead flowers and bedraggled crab grass. Crows use the little park more than Pickens Countians. They finally abandoned the place. Almost nobody even lives there anymore. The only jobs to be had are at a private prison over in Aliceville.

This famous courthouse, the old Pickens County courthouse, is a building that will be of much concern in this tale before us, which, in no particular order, is mostly a story about: the adventures of Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr. and her associates, the deranged lady who knocked out the window everybody carried on about for so long, saying it was haunted; it's also a story about Pickens County and its many little towns, the state of Alabama, The United States of America and even Mexico, too; it's about evolution and history, human development, memes and genes, religion; it's also importantly a story about Henry Wells, the formerly enslaved man whose face that they said you could see up in that window. The basics of transnational trafficking operations are considered at points in the narrated events. This book is about the past, history and its follies, the role of legacy in legend and legend in legacy.

It is about the fruit of hate on the vine of ignorance as it grows on a lattice alongside proudly cultivated and chosen idiocy—about bigotry's trellis and its harvest seasons.

It is about what they did in Pickens County, the story before you. This here book is a rendition of a famous Southern folktale and ghost story, and it's just one perspective on it all, one more version for the pile. Consider it. The story of the Face in the Window is usually told with the same title, and that title is always “The Face in the Window.”

Instead, here the story is entered into the record under another name: *Henry's Garden*.

Before it was all destroyed, if you had stood there for a minute in that old county courthouse square and looked just right, moseyed about the lawn and taken a gander at that building, you would've perhaps intuitively understood the significance of the story, the ghost story about Henry Wells and the legend of the Face in the Window—maybe, you *maybe've'd* understood what it meant, how it all worked, what statement was made by this architectural oddity so many around there all so excitedly and proudly called the Face in the Window, a total sensation, this spooky window with its discolored spot that they called a face. They would say the Face in the Window and they thought it were obvious as to what that meant. Nobody was sure, yet they were certain, and these people couldn't wait to tell you about it. Around there, the people loved to amaze everybody who came around to see it. They'd tell them the story. They'd show them. They'd give anybody who came around change for a dlkjkollar so that they could use the binoculars machine that stood on a cement block on the courthouse lawn, twenty-five cents for one minute, an opportunity for a closer look. If *you'd've* gone prior to the window being smashed apart, the locals would've gladly instructed you to look like so and just right... j*usss'* right... look in a certain manner, like so... *just right*.

You had to look just right.

Had you done as instructed by the locals who were happy to show you—cock your head sideways and hold your hand out; block the sun, squint, look just right—you would've stared in such a manner where you'd be faced head-on with the ghastly sight in one of the windows of that storied, derelict and ruined Southern gentry town nineteenth-century courthouse. You'd have seen it, this faint image that resembled a wailing man.

They said that lightning put it there, the Face in the Window, the face of Henry Wells. That's what they said. Lightning put it there, supposedly. This is what they said cross-eyed with conviction.

This so-called face was said to belong to the formerly enslaved man called Henry Wells, a man with natural rights denied, and, had you looked, you sure would've seen the apparent visage that they were so obsessed over. Sure would've, unless you were blind.

You had to look just right.

You could've heard it, too, if you looked just right, but only if you had what the good Lord calls "*eyes to see and ears to hear*." Had you regarded and heeded it all in your attention, had you looked just right, you could've carried on looking and it might be that *you'd've* seen it, this face thingamabob, yes, but and also, in your tending to the matter, too, you could've heard it, the horror, heard in the wind Nina Simone's burdened croon, a mournful Billie Holiday as well, the lament, seen it all and heard those forlorn voices too, bearing painful witness. Listening, immersed, perhaps agape, you could've heard the dousing and the blood, smelled the combustible past in this wicked place, felt it in your skin, hurting your ribs, the heart.

The lunatic woman who knocked out the window eventually called Itragene could hear that song, "Strange Fruit," its languid impressions as everywhere as air for her. In her unbridled madness, she often heard voices and music nobody else could, messages everywhere channeled by cables wired through invisible and complex grid systems.

> Southern tr*eesss*...
> … str*aaaaange* fr*uit*

Perhaps you would've had it in you that you *couldn't've* but to have helped sense for yourself that there were leaves drenched in blood, that the roots of the trees and the square itself were bloody.

They simply called the sight the Face in the Window, and they repeated this phrase incessantly, saying it over and over and over again like an incantation, just kept repeating it. Generation after generation, they initiated their children into the legend and its legacy, and with each generation's passing the origins of the story became more lost until, by the end, they would've believed about anything. The children

of the forefathers were often mostly just ignorant and happy, telling their version of events which they had inherited from prior tellings, but, in their time, their ugly grandpappies and those men's up-nosed, hateful wives actively lied, lies, and a bunch of them, too, lies the absolute only way that this surreal tale could have ever come about—shameless people just making it up.

The whole affair began as a matter of scaring the absolute fresh Southern hell out of Black people around there, in fact, understand. For so long, over a whole century, they told the story, insisting around there that the purported Face in the Window belonged to a Black man who was a former "slave"—he was a human being who was enslaved, properly considered—a man who they also said was *lynched*.

Lynched.

They had no shame. It was a scary sight and terrifying place, inhospitable even though the locals would smile at you and bless your heart. It was a scarecrow, a memetic control mechanism for the legacy. That's what it was, a hateful statement piece intended to intimidate a population that had endured total captivity and then intense segregation. This was inequality assured by legacy in the form of a legend, a ghost story.

It was just a harmless ghost story, they'd act like, playing dumber than even they were.

It was a lynching ghost story window. That was the meme, a lynching ghost story window.

A haunted window as a concept, this is so vague unto itself, no telling what it even meant, a window haunted by an image, something or another, and, whatever it meant, it riled them up. It meant a lot to them. It was a tourist attraction, a scarecrow and a story, an optical transpiration and material fact. None of it making much sense, when it was still there, this oddity and curio strange fruit was just simply all they'd be on about, all they talked about, and this was all the time. They would always be on about this courthouse and its putatively haunted window.

“The *Faaaaaaaa*y*ce* in the Window,” they'd say.

“A *lightnin' fireball*. Every lightnin' strike ends in a *fireball*, you know. That's what printed his face on the windah.”

“That [*you-know-what*] up in that windah! Come get*chu* a look'*adit*, that damn [*you-know-what*], *hoo* sho 'nuff, it’s that Henry Wells yonder strung up there-like!”

They'd holler and laugh as they pointed at the window and its strange fruit.

“Henry Wells! Look! It's the ghost of Henry Wells, his face in that there windah!”

They lo*vvved* to talk about it, couldn't wait to show you if you hadn't already seen it. They wrote so many things about it. They loved the title, the meme, that string of words, the… Face… in the... They constantly wrote short stories titled “The Face in the Window,” all these short stories and more written by these Pickens County school kids, all of these works titled the same—”The Face in the Window.” It didn't matter the assignment, the pertinent curriculum, be it for history or language arts class, even Sunday school, they'd write with glee these stories, reports and essays that they always titled the same, “The Face in the Window.” Young and old, they loved this lynching ghost story window and the building it was set in, that old courthouse that they had and adored so much, or at least the white people, for the overwhelming most part. It was the town bread and butter, the central attraction of a tourist industry that was rather vibrant for such a small place. It was a mantlepiece in public education, the treasured local folktale and a pride of Alabama state-wide. They believed it all. They thought it was so fun and spooky. They believed what they said.

“The Face in the Window,” they'd scream and holler.

Locals all just said it all the time. Interlopers too, tourists from all over, after any of them saw it, they'd call it the Face in the Window as well, carrying on about how they saw a haunted window over in Carrollton, Alabama.

They populated their bookshelves with books on it, writing their

essays, so many little essays about Henry Wells written, so many versions of the tale written down and shared.

There would be children running around everywhere carrying the most official, written version in the *13 Ghosts and Jeffrey* series, a book series written by Alabamian folklorist and raconteur Kathryn Tucker Windham. This was a woman who famously happened to think that her own house in Alabama, in the town of Thomasville, Clarke County, was haunted by a poltergeist that she named Jeffrey. She talked out that poltergeist a lot. She loved to talk about Jeffrey, of "whom" she even had a black-and-w hite photograph, which was this odd photograph taken in her house's stairwell, and in the image you can see where a shadow is hitting the wall of the stairwell, this photo, again, depicting a wall with a shadow on it as its subject—her Jeffrey was as much nonsense as all that was to do with the Face in the Window. This was a woman who travelled across the South collecting ghost stories, conducting oral ghost story audits at the state level, inspecting the lore, and she famously wrote up thirteen ghost stories per state for many Southern states and published these records as a series of books: she wrote about Alabama ghosts in *13 Alabama Ghosts and Jeffrey*, Georgia in *13 Georgia Ghosts and Jeffrey*, and, looking west, she had her *13 Mississippi Ghosts* and, yes, *Jeffrey*, for Mississippi and then, also, for Tennessee, *13 Tennessee Ghosts and Jeffrey*. She wrote these state-specific books as well as other titles with various foci, coverage of a range of Southern ghosts, but with some special attention paid to Alabama, writing more in *Jeffrey Introduces 13 More Southern Ghosts*, *Jeffrey's Latest 13: More Alabama Ghosts* and *Jeffrey's Favorite 13 Ghost Stories*, her other books. In her canonization of Alabama ghost stories, Pickens County was proud to be home to two state-level Alabama ghost stories, in fact, Henry's ghost in Carrollton living alongside the Tombigbee ghost over in the rich and white vacation town of Pickensville along the Tombigbee River. In all of her books, she always narrated the ghost stories at hand alongside her Jeffrey story, which she'd tell in a preface, told that

Jeffrey story in every book, the same Jeffrey story over and over, the titular "*and Jeffrey*" part. Kathryn Windham Tucker's goings-on about these Southern ghosts and a poltergeist in her stairwell named Jeffrey with whom she was friendly was all included in her book that came out the same year that the Pickens County School District officially and finally began desegregating, 1969. This was her book *13 Alabama Ghosts and Jeffrey*. She'd go to schools all over the South, but particularly across Alabama, telling the tales she collected, talking about things like Henry and his haunted window, "the Face in the Window," as well as things like "the Hole that Will not Stay filled," a hole in Cahaba, Alabama that won't stay filled no matter what they put in it, they say, which was another lynching story, in fact, one about a white man killed for being outspoken against the Confederacy and the like—two Alabama ghost story lynching tales, a damn horrific genre unto itself.

All of the accounts, Windham's included, attested that Henry Wells was lynched because he burned down the prior, second courthouse, the one with the famous window being Pickens County's third courthouse, both of them built just after the Civil War, one burned down and the next one standing for a long time—until 1997, a bit of time after the window was smashed out with a hammer in 1996. The modern, fourth courthouse that they used for the law was across the street from it on the county square roundabout, the front door facing Phoenix Avenue, ghost Henry Wells' driveway.

On and on they'd go, "A bolt'*ah*'lightn*in*' put it there, the face of Henry Wells."

Lightning etched that man's face while he was amidst his being lynched, they'd say in horrific fact, beaming as they said it, every detail worse than the last. Etched by lightning during a lynching, they said, or something incredible like that, etched, printed, the Lord knows, branded.

Haunted or not, it was all cursed.

The white people around there were truly so worked up about it all,

sweaty and on repeat, talking about it all the time. They were in hysterics about it most often. They'd tell the tale with crazed enthusiasm. They'd get this Henry Wells glint in their eye. They couldn't hold it in, and they had to tell you about the Face in the Window.

"*Mhmm*, the face of Henry Wells," somebody would say.

"*Mhmm*, he *burint* down that c'oythouse, sure did," somebody would assuredly assert.

"They'd had done *jus*' built the new c'oythouse after them Yankee burning campaigns, sure had. Just after the Civil War. Henry Wells *burint* it down. *Mhmm*, just to be mean and nasty."

Some people would anachronistically say that Mr. Wells was in a "gang" and that the gang did it, burn down the courthouse. They fancied Henry to be Tupac; gangs as a sociological occurrence didn't even exist in the time Wells walked this Earth alive. They did not find their claims to be absurd. They were the ones with anything resembling a gang, projecting—white people had the Klan.

"Henry and his associates were *known*, if you follow... "

"Henry and his buddies would rob you and burn yer store down. They had done it so many times, and *just tah be cruel'n'mean* to h'white people. The Sheriff was a good h'white man. He executed tha' law."

These people were real, and they were believers, for sure. They held down jobs and had long marriages, raised kids and held other responsibilities that required some degree of sense. They'd carry on in life, all the while truly buying it that lightning printed a slave's face on a window for all of them to admire forever and ever, or whatever they were on about, all of it a local fact of life, this nonsense, this cherished bullshit.

They were idiots.

Really, none of it ever added up. Even so, with all of it clear nonsense, no questions were allowed. Curiosity was not welcome; interrogatives generally and inquiries specifically were all a mighty

harm to the work of securing their much-sought Southern heritage in a such a place as this place was. Yes, this was what they'd say had happened and this was what had been going on for so long, for over a century by the time it all came to a head in Pickens County, and it came to a head in 1994.

They worshipped this idolatrous window with its execrable aesthetics, this absurd ghost story, this folktale and freak architecture feature of the old county courthouse.

Looking wasn't enough.

Telling the story *over and over*, and over and over and over again —this just was just not enough for them. The drive to tell the story was an insatiable hunger for more. They were addicted; they'd huff the ghost of Henry Wells and walk in intoxicated circles in the square.

It consumed them, the big lie that it was that ole' Henry Wells up in that window that they had that they'd go on about so much. The endurance and scale of the deception was stunning. Telling the tale for *over a one-hundred years*, the Face in the Window was so precious to them. They feasted on the ritual of telling the tale, masticated on the strange fruit and its bizarre portrait, ate up the memory of Henry Wells. They loved it, ate it all up until they were sicker than they already were, vomiting this bile and trash into the mouths of their diseased children like bald and mean birds. They loved this lynching ghost story window, what it meant and what it did in all their lives, this racist fetish object and community control mechanism, this memetic weapon.

They just loved it, the people responsible for the legacy, couldn't help themselves, the bigots and powerful idiots in Pickens County who honored it as heritage—go*o*' *ol*e' Suht*hahn herita*h*ge*.

It was just a harmless ghost story, they'd be like.

They *loved* this lynching ghost story, the lynching ghost story window—just loved, loved, *loved* it all. Very few white people found that peculiar. They didn't notice how weird or nonsensical it all was. Or, so it seemed like that, at least by all outward appearances and in

polite company, depending, but the real truth about it was bothersome, sinister, even, just beneath the surface in Pickens County; it kept metastasizing.

You had to look just right.

They were *sick*, *obsessed*, and it all meant *a lot* to them, so much more than was good, all of Pickens County's white folk absolutely fixated, from half-white and half-Black Carrollton to mostly-white Gordo, to the majority-white town of Reform and the pretty much all-Black town of Aliceville, where a handful of whites did live, Ethelsville too, a mixed-race and tiny place, Macedonia, Memphis, McMullen and Pickensville, on the river, fancy and all-white, as well. All over Pickens County it was like this, this obsession reigning, a county with many towns—due to the racism and constantly reallotting land in the name of segregation, there were *fifty-five* whole entire towns that were legally recognized in Pickens County by the 1990s, amazingly—many hamlets, Alabama Zip Codes, areas and places to live and be, entities, collections of property, little municipalities, some unincorporated areas, sundown towns that weren't even towns at all, places not legally recognized one bit but that were very real, places and spaces, segregated neighborhoods in the Alabama woods. Pickens County was a county with many towns and villages, little places to live, all of them haunted one way or the other by that face in that window that they had and couldn't get enough of, haunted they were, haunted from McShan to Cunningham, cursed in Beards Mill, Benevola, Stevens, Vienna and Zion, to name just a few of these many towns in Pickens, some of which had incredible names like "Vienna" and "Zion," which were two of the smaller towns right outside of bigger small towns, some people living outside of town, too.

Many a town and more, the middle of nowhere, Henry's Garden, people living all over, but barely anyone living there, and there was only one window to rule them all. It looked like an oil slick, this putative face. It was barely there. They were near hallucinating. It was just a stain on a window and Pickens County itself and its fifty-five

whole entire towns.

If you look just right, the twilight of the Face in the Window is a dark comedy. All of it had been so horrific and for so long that it would become unbearably funny in some respects when it finally started to unravel around them, these white people and their lynching ghost story window that they loved so much.

Not everybody believed it, all this stuff about the Face in the Window, not by the time of the culmination of relevant events in Pickens County that commenced starting spring 1994. It was getting a little goofy at that point. The white people squirmed. This was not comfortable for these white people. They did it to themselves. The Face in the Window ghost story matured into a proper idiot plot, which is a narrative that could end sooner than it does but not for the sheer fact that the characters involved are idiots and the action is prolonged due to their idiocy.

Black folks just specially weren't bothered much by it by then, finding the whole situation utterly ludicrous. They'd laugh about it. This was just how it was by then.

Black Carrollton Unit School students played around and janked on the believers all the time on the school bus, beside themselves laughing about it, clowning on the white kids who believed it, the bus going around the square roundabout and passing by the window, Black kids yelling about that fucking n-word in the window, yelling about that *you-know-what* and pointing at Henry Wells while taunting the white kids, brusquely demanding of them that they share with them their favorite version of the story, mocking the whole concept and its enterprise, daring them to go on about this shit that was just so ridiculous to Black people by then.

"Go on 'head, crackah. Tell me another m*uh*'fu*ggin* version, pasty ass. You crusty *and* you white."

"You *gay* if you believed*'at*."

Struggling to come up with a biting yo mama joke, the white kid getting the beclowning would have their big brother call the Black kid messing around like that the n-word and maybe throw a punch.

"He jankin' on you good. Whatchu gon' do about it?" Black kids would keep instigating this line of tomfoolery, laughing their asses off.

After some thought, the white kid would make his yo mama joke and yell it, voice quivering.

"Daz racist," a Black girl says loudly about the joke over the back of her seat, turned around and sitting on her knees.

The Pentecostal girls would be giving blowjobs in the back seats, the young and already abusive white males yelling the n-word in a call and response to the Black kids saying such, never missing an opportunity, never too busy to look up and yell this coveted slur, not even while receiving fellatio in their youth were they too busy to miss their shot at saying the n-word.

"If you get to say it, my white ass gets to!"

The bus would go down the road, all the windows down, and all you'd hear was a cacophony of voices screaming the n-word, the n-word being said over and over—a verbal n-word torrent vortex—the bus windows acting like gramophone horns hooked up as the audio system for an n-word sound effects switchboard with many settings, nuanced knobs and effective switches.

The bus driver reminds them that they are all being recorded by the camera mounted at the front of the bus. It has a circular little reflective mirror and you can see the whole bus in it. The expletive flies around the forty-five-minute totality of the bus route. A quiet kid reads a book about Alabama ghost stories, on the third read of the chapter inevitably titled "The Face in the Window" by arrival at home and being dropped off; there are only a handful of books that discuss the Face in the Window, every local school in possession of hundreds of books across the half-a-dozen titles out there, never a waiting list at the school library, which, modern 1990s people, they called a "media center." The

kids cross the dangerous country highways, the blinking school bus stop sign the only thing holding back vehicles that weigh tons as they cross the paused traffic that could at any moment start moving again and with deadly consequence. There have been accidents in the past. They check out their ghost story books from the media center and they carry home books and carry on about the Face in the Window to their mamas, who have all heard it before.

The white bus driver would complain about them *you-know-whats* on her bus route over supper to her husband, so this soundtrack of the n-word on repeat would continue into evening—in her home and other domiciles on the bus route, both Black and white households—the soundtrack reignites in the morning as she goes to pick up the kids for it is a new day at Carrollton Unit School. She is also a cafeteria worker. She works the register. She lets white kids charge on credit the fancy items in the lunch line that they have in addition to the free lunch line, where there are fresh cookies for sale, a little plastic bag with two hot and melty chocolate chip cookies for a quarter, and she embarrasses Black kids counting their nickels and dimes for some cookies, saying to poor Amos, who is poor, Black and special needs, "Hurry up, rain man. *Holdin' up the line…* Now git."

The white kids have chocolate on their chin. They eat fresh, hot cookies and drink excessively large and sugary Slush Puppies from the fancy lunch line, which disappears, second, once, first, all the white kids do, mostly vanishing off to Pickens Academy down Commerce Avenue, the all-white private school. By the mid-1990s, Pickens County has unofficially but effectively re-segregated primary and secondary education in the area, the failing Carrollton Unit School eventually shut down and demolished, an almost completely Black school by the time of its demise. Their mascot was an Indian and they were the Carrollton Indians.

When they are there at the unit school before they disappear, the white kids are terrified of these Black kids laughing at them, which is something they learn from their parents.

"Never let a [*you-know-what*] humiliate you. '*Mem*ber that," these kids would hear some version of that, and regularly.

So, these Black kids would laugh at the Face in the Window, it only a joke, not a gun, though white people acted as if their lives were at risk, like they were in a new danger because it had become so clear that the spell had been broken.

Stop laughing, they'd think. Stop it. *Stawp*.

The white kids maybe would've laughed, too, if they had learned to look right and stopped listening to their mean and hateful parents. In the general sense, it was a crazy thing to believe, this stuff about the Face in the Window, yes, and that's what the Black kids were getting at with all the horsing around, reappropriating it and deflating its terroristic power in the community and over Black local life. These Black kids weren't afraid like their grandparents had been—crazy to believe it, yes, but around there it was treated as even crazier to think it were all bullshit, if you were white, at least. It was even a potentially dangerous to think such a thing around there as a honkey in this life. You had to maintain the façade.

You had to look just right.

You had to be proud to be h'white.

○ ✦ ○

The twilight of the Face in the Window, the veil lifts and people cease to believe. Take a bow. It is the 1990s and the music is good.

Here comes ole' Itragene.

Her whole entire full name was Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr. and her alias Ma Iddy.

Itragene.

Itragene, there she was, with her wild, Greek-origins, mid-century Southern rich white girl name, "Itragene," pronounced "*Eye-trah-gene*," a pretty ugly name. She was lost in her head in her sixties, our

Itragene, by the time it all started to happen in the mid-1990s, the things involved in the affairs leading to the final destruction of the legend and the building it was all about, window included, smashed to pieces at Itragene's hand.

Itragene is certainly touched, but she understands some vital stuff, her mission clear and grounded in real injustice—to end the curse of the Face in the Window. Her belief is that all human beings are equal, created in the Image, her heart substantive in its concerns, considered. She has frequently been out of her mind, her madness deepening her compassion—madness only is such if one says the wrong things out loud to other people who might not see whatever's on the table the same unconventional way as one does. *One must* keep some stuff to themselves. *One must* make arguments that matter to others to make significant progress in this world—*I must understand that not everybody is receptive, that there is intractability*. *One must* keep their visions to themselves, just as the Fleetwood Mac song instructs. Itragene had the bipolar and it was not diagnosed, and, so, not treated, she didn't take any meds, though she loved and took stimulants sometimes. At times, her condition was worse than at others.

Itragene Belle Sr.

Everybody around there either knows her or knows about her, a force, a mythical creature in the local discourse. She feels like a fairy with burnt up wings, couldn't fly, unable to escape despite a magic about her, or maybe she was just a dirty doll without a head, thrown out the window of a moving vehicle by a spoiled child and into waters below, a lost creature hiding in the kudzu on the banks of the Tombigbee River, forced to eat hyacinth bulbs in salads prepared in exile. She chews on and digests invasive river plants, afraid of going to a grocery store like the Jitney Jungle over in Reform, the Gordo Piggly Wiggly, the Reform Ashmore's, the Carrollton Food Mart—there could be hateful townspeople who say hurtful things in any of those, like late night drinkers at the end of a bar where they sell chicken feet and gizzards for cents on the pound, regulars.

Itragene Belle Sr., born in Tuscaloosa and raised in the town of Gordo, famous around there for its annual Mule Day festival, a celebration of the town's poultry industry, she is real skinny, what they call “skinnier than a porch rail,” “rail thin,” “*gordo*” meaning “fat” in Spanish, her hometown named after the Mexican-American War 1847 Battle of Sierra Gorda, and “*sierra gorda*” means “fat hill” and Gordo has many hills. She lives atop one of these hills all over Gordo; from her prominent downtown Gordo home situated at the end of Main Street, she sees the giant chickenfeed tower reaching high into the sky above Gordo and blocking the sun. She sits in a room with a wide and deep view of downtown Gordo. This is the sunroom and it has bright green shag carpet. This Gordo woman decides to smash that window over in Carrollton or just take it down somehow, to rid the county of the curse of the face in window, a strange woman with idiosyncratic and mad ways, trying to make this happen, this removing the Face in the Window, trying to make history, taking a stand, out of her Thanksgiving gourd. A crazy lady, a loon bird biddy known by everybody, a legend around there as much as poor ole' Henry Wells up in that window, her father is Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr., a successful man, county commissioner for a mighty long time, over four decades, the Calloway family widely celebrated—they upheld the legacy. Itragene did not, however; she rejected the legacy. The money’s all gone when daddy dies in ‘93. She gets excommunicated from the old aristocratic class, her fallen in their looming eyes, the townspeople, her struggling, becoming the most fixated she’s ever been on this notion that she'd take care of that window, damn them all, her knowing she must do this by her own hand or by proxy in mysterious and careful machinations. Her mission is her only comfort, gives her a sense of purpose. Not minding being an outcast, the mission requiring it, the work, the Lord's work, in her exile, it takes her forty days and forty nights. She kept forty Bic lighters in a kitchen drawer at the house in Gordo, and they are backups, for she loses her lighter all of the time. She returned from the wild and lit a cigarette.

Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr., *née* Calloway.

She is a gnome.

Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr.'s preoccupations sometimes blossom into actions, which become events in their sequenced enactment. Her perm never set right, she's always smoking cigarettes, does this when she bathes, smokes. She is a mother herself. Limbs poking out, thin white riverbeds with blue tributaries, bulging veins, her house slippers always dirty, all that's ever on her soot feet, muumuus are all she ever wears. Had she the chance, she'd accept it—had she the chance to do it all over again, her sorry life, she would, and exactly the same. She would leave no detail out. *One must* not reconfigure the past or one risks becoming somebody else other than who that one person is, which inevitably causes problems later on for everybody. *One must* count what's important, she figured, must enumerate things that matter, things beyond tabulation, enumerato. She heard voices, saw things that were not there, her hallucinations a scaffolding for her cognitive states and beliefs constantly interfacing her rapidly oscillating moods. It felt like chicken wire in her ribcage; chronic costochondritis, she takes Advil for it, and it's all that cortisol in her tiny body and the inflammation. She'd go to a salon, it in the home of a woman called Linda who'd brush away cigarette ash that would fall on your scalp and in your lap as she worked her way around your head with her hair clippers, it in Ethelsville, filled with the sound of gossiping, old clucking chickens smoking cigarettes and the noises that they made with their beaks, the sound of daytime television, deep and productive coughs. Itragene always washes her hair too early after treating it, every single time, that about the only time ever, too, neglectful of bathing. One of the only durable features of her person, you couldn't even say it's falling out, a thick head of hair, smelling like nothing other than a cigarette. Where did I put my lighter? *One must* be prepared. Her kitchen drawer that was full of backup lighters was there, the cutlery, it was in the sink. There are at least forty-five lighters total somewhere—three can't be found, one in the car, one

somewhere in the sunroom. The drawer had forty lighters in it.

Resignation is affirmation, is it not? Gnomic, she is trying to figure this out.

One must… improvise.

She screams at herself in the bathroom mirror and theatrically throws her hands around in the air, making fun of the enemy who she has put in her head so that she can interact with them and so that she can figure them out, and in a controlled environment, which is the inside of her head.

She is interested in divine revelation.

She puts these people in her head on like a mask that is for the full body and not just the face, screaming in the mirror.

"It's just a harmless ghost story! *Whut*? H*uhhhh*hh? You don't like it because you're a *you-know-what*-lover?"

She does this again, says the same things, but in a mid-Atlantic accent for a second time, and this is just for good measure.

"Look, *see*, see… —it's just a hahm-less stor-ay, see? Whaht, whahhd? Whaddt, chump? Hoo-ah! You don't like it, kid, 'cauze you're an n-word lovah? This ain't *The Maltese Falcon,* Matlock. Atlanta ain't Mexico City, bustah, and this is Gordo."

She is laughing, no way they'll get it. Only she gets it; she knows.

The chicken knows. She taught herself this as a child.

One must… practice.

It was suddenly March 1994.

She had been popping diet pills with stimulant properties for weeks and she was zooming. She was down to thirty-seven lighters.

She was having an intense enthusiasm and was certifiably psychotic.

She was having a spell. The bipolar had taken over her life for this bit.

One thing—the main thing—holding her back was that she didn't know how to get up there. That was pretty much it, really. It'd take her years to achieve her goal once she got on it all and everything got

going in the mid-1990s. It would take her near three years to execute the plan. You didn't see any security outside the courthouse, but that place was on lock and very much surveilled; the chicken knows. It was three floors up and nobody was allowed to use the stairs by then. Also, once you were on the second floor, you had to go up a ladder in the main courtroom to get to the third level of the building.—you had to hop into the ceiling above the judge's bench, and her body wasn't what it used to be, a worn down on-and-off again speed addict who was always smoking her Virginia Slims, drinking her Folger's coffee and Diet Cokes. She was so usually depressed and had to stimulate the shit out of herself everyday so she could move some and think at all. She rarely ate or slept, instead staying up all night listening to the local county police scanner, being nosy and seeking answers and purpose in the night. Cigarette smoke was her permanent cocoon.

She just wasn't quite sure how to scale the building, the main thing.

In fact, she was unsure as to the majority of the logistics required for her stunt, but she did know one thing for sure, however, and what that was what she wanted to wear when committing her righteous crime of vandalism, all of this a grand, visionary and aesthetic affair in her mind and on her heart, this insane lady prone to ecstatic visions in her enthusiasm. A black and shiny leather, full-body jumpsuit like Catwoman as played by the stunning Michelle Pfeiffer in the 1992 film *Batman*, that was the goal. She figured this was the best look. Maybe that would be it, her look for the job, she figured.

She really liked the idea of a leather catsuit, thought it would suit her countenance. She wasn’t sure how she’d get up there. Much to consider.

And then there was always daddy, Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr.

“A donkey and a chicken fall into a crik and only one lives. The other one drowns. There’s a bridge and a road where they could ask for help, but it’s too high for either one of them to reach it. Which dies first?” Father?

Itragene is nine years old and she has come up with a riddle for her

daddy.

One must… master disassociation.

"*You*," daddy scowls, "*You* die first, 'cuz I'd go'n put'chu in and hold your head under, get rid of you for good for finally."

Daddy sips his amaretto. Itragene stares at the pale ambrosia salad on her fine China plate.

"Daddy—the choice was between a donkey and a chicken. It's a riddle, daddy."

She waits expectantly, no answer.

"The donkey dies first. Do you know why?."

There's daddy. She looks at him.

Breaking out *madly* snickering, clearly unwell and she's only a child, "The chicken knows! He was the only one there except the donkey, and I know that it was the donkey that died first and that only the donkey died because the chicken told me that riddle. The chicken knows. One must know that the chicken knows." Punchline. Get it?

It's a matter of not drowning, and *one must* swim…

There is a punch and then there is the being tossed across the room. There is the couch arm with its angled wood and then there is her head, a bruise the next day.

One must… not speak of some things. Can you imagine?

Oh, daddy… there's always daddy, Thaddeus Jr.

What can you say about our Itragene, poor ole' Itragene… She was a good woman, flawed but a good one. She made do. When she ate, she usually only consumed peanut butter on Saltine crackers and Snickers bars. She was so frail. Surprisingly, she didn't have the sugar; it didn't run in her family on either side.

Born into a brutal cycle of intergenerational violence, she tried her best as a mother.

This crazy lady who hated that window so much and all that it meant spent a lot of time with her daughters, who were out of their minds in the end too.

She has two children, fraternal twins.

“Necromancy, that's what it is,” she had said to her daughters as they passed the county courthouse and the Face in the Window one Halloween eve.

It had been 1966 when she said it. Them two girls' mama was always saying stuff like this when they were growing up.

Never standing a chance, she was crazy from an early age, and she'd been saying stuff like this about that window since her teen years. It got worse, her constitution, after the States nuked Japan in 1945. Her undiagnosed condition, manic depression, as it was then known, worsening that year, and noticeably so, adults picking up on it that something was not normal about this child, her just a kid, at the tender age of fifteen, her finally truly, totally and completely losing her mind for the first real time her only, first and final fall semester in college, 1948, over in Tuscaloosa at the University. The apocalyptic nature of the end of the War changed her forever. After that, she was never fully positive that the world was still there, just not fully sure, no way to prove it. She didn't have astrolabes nor a telescope. She wasn't sure if the planet or even outer space was what either appeared to be—extant—she hadn't seen any satisfactory proof that the whole planet wasn't blown up August 1945. She was worried she had done and gone and found herself in hell at times, dead and already in hell, facing an eternal punishment. She didn't really believe in hell at the same time, a cruel concept. She didn't always know where she was. She always felt she lacked the technical tools she needed, but she nonetheless tried to make sense out of everything she encountered in her sorry life. She tried to help others. She bought a compass in Aliceville one time, got it for herself at a “Black store” and in a “Black town,” Aliceville, where Henry Wells' mama lived in her day. She’d show anybody that compass and tell them about her plans; she had wanted to go into the woods and get lost, find her way out. She never used that compass—she lived in downtown Gordo, nowhere near the woods. There was a park with a magnificent slide. Two nuclear bombs, civilians; she couldn't believe it, never could. Who could? Who could believe what

they did to the Jews of Europe? She had a hard time with these things.

"Necromancy," Itragene repeated that 1966 Halloween stroll about the county square with her daughters.

"What's nec-... necro-wait, mama, ain't that a bad word?"

One of her six-year-old daughters asked her this on their Halloween stroll, her daughters both dressed up as Twinkie snacks for trick-or-treating that year, and, when she asked this, her child in this world, her daughter baby struggled again with the word and also with her large costume, asking her mama, "What is *negro*-mansey... mama?"

She batted at the face hole opening of the Twinkie; she couldn't see a thing in that Twinkie, this child.

"No, no, no, *not* that word—we don't say *that word* no more, not no more. We say 'colored' now, and don't you ever call Miss Bessie or any other *colored person* by anything like that starting with an 'n,' nothing like that—you know, *you-know-what*. The n-word. We don't say that or anything like it, not even anything that sounds like it, especially around Miss Bessie, especially especially. That ain't Henry Wells, baby, up in that window. Necromancy, baby, that's what I said. That's what it is. 'N-e-c-r-o-m-a-n-c-y,' babygirl. It's messin' with dead people, *tryin*' to make something dead come alive—wrong, it's wrong wrong wrong wrong wrong *wrong,* and it's in Bible. Bible speaks on this, babygirl."

"In Bible": That's how she'd say it, an odd preposition like that, a signature way she said it a lot, her signature idiolect, "in Bible," sometimes "through Bible," and other stuff like that—"let's pray in Bible," "Bible speaks on this," her prepositions askance and missing definite articles, her characteristic enallage, her speech slanted by her idiosyncratic, mad ways. She was full of novel insight as much as her body and mind were a unified pipeline to delusional vortexes which had great pull, grand rapids in cascading thoughts. She used her prepositions to cover her tracks, left off "the" in her chosen phrasing to keep you on the edge of your seat wondering which Bible she was

talking about, playing language games in her mad mind; Bible speaks on this; it's in Bible; pray in Bible. Catachresis, Bible speaks on this. Importantly, when she said "Bible," she did not mean the Christian Bible. She was talking about the Hebrew Bible, in fact, this gentile woman from Gordo, Alabama, in the old gentry County of Pickens. She called this "Bible 1.0," the Bible of the Jewish people, the Hebrew Bible, *Tanakh*. She considered the Christian Bible to be "Bible 2.0," a second installment with a lot of bad Greek writing and harmful Roman ideas in what became a worldwide trilogy with the advent of Islam. She knew a little Arabic and kept her Quran hidden even from the girls. She liked the Gospels in Bible 2.0 but found the rest of it unnecessary and full of lies. Who the hell is Paul? she'd joke. Jesus was a fool like her, a clucking chicken. Jesus never meant to start a new religion, religion as such not even a concept with which the man was familiar because it didn't exist back then. . Jesus knows it's all in the bits and nobody has ever committed to a bit as hard as that man, the most famous person in the world. His bits are His way. She'd lament how Bible 2.0 had resulted in Jews running all over the place, chased by the professed believers of Christ who bludgeon them while raising above their heads the image of a dead Jew on a stick, Jesus on the cross, the man himself, an awful and ugly representation of that man's dead body on a Roman cross that they worshipped. Death cult, she thought. The real blasphemy is taking the Lord's name in vain, she felt, and that has nothing to do with cursing.

"He got what he was asking for—a lot of attention, but nobody deserves what he got... Poor ole' Jesus," she'd muse to her girls when they were growing up.

The Hebrew Bible and some sacrilegious version of the disparate Gospels, which were all different accounts, all you needed, she figured, and the Gospels weren't necessary though sufficient, take it or leave it. Jesus was everywhere, she figured, so you'd still hear about him even if you only ever touched Bible 1.0 and had no experience with Bible 2.0. This seemed fair. She called the Abrahamic admixture

of 1.0 and 2.0 “Bible 1.5.” It was midrash, Alabama midrash, and not all of it were to be written down. She was oracular. Jesus was the way, a narrow path. You had to look just right, she believed. It wasn't about being perfect but learning a dance. Though she outwardly identified as a Southern Baptist, this absurd and good woman secretly identified as a crypto-Jew, her preferred term, a secret Jew in Pickens County, one who happened to believe that Jesus were Messiah.

She was so smart, could learn anything. She could do anything she set her mind to, it seemed, at least in regard to her special interests and hyperfixations. She loved Bible 1.0.

In secret, for it was dangerous, she'd show her daughters this text, sharing Bible with them in their coming-out-of-Jim Crow Alabama town. She used the 1917 Jewish Publication Society Hebrew-English edition of Bible 1.0, what all twentieth-century Conservative and Reform Jews used in their liturgy, but certainly not Baptists, especially those hateful Southern Baptists, a denomination born from a disagreement about slavery. This gentile woman did not grow up Jewish nor did she know a single Jew; there was no synagogue in sight and people around there would've thought that a thing called a “temple” were something to do with witches, no idea about anything to do with Jews besides “they killed Jesus,” which was another lie, she knew; she didn't believe in the myth of Jewish deicide nor was she a supercessionist.

“Where do the Mennonites live, mama?”

The kids would ask her this when they were young when they would go to the county square for some Mennonite Bread, a monthly trip. This was what the people called it, around there, “Mennonite Bread,” and this was the name for the bread that some Mennonites had been arduously and dutifully sojourning to the area and selling for as long as Itragene could remember. Every third Wednesday of the month, Mennonite Bread day would arrive. Most of these Mennonites were based in Indiana. They weren't even from the area, but they nonetheless came down and sold their bread, reliably so, and they had

done this for so long, before vehicles, making their little Mennonite way down south by cart and horse. They would sell this bread with purpose. They were alert. They understood supply chains, demand, guns and butter. They had started selling this bread in 1878, amazingly, starting shortly after the murder of Henry Wells, in fact, with the spread of the legend across North America amidst the Spiritualist movement that swept the whole trans-Atlantic world at the dawn of the twentieth century and connected the channels by which the story of the Face in the Window concretized itself and spread all over the country; they got wind of it and headed down on a regular patrol, they did, once a month, the Indiana Mennonites. They had vested interests. Itragene had had her eye on them Mennonites for a good while. She was onto them, had been for a long time, though she couldn't fully put her finger on it, what she thought they were up to, what but beyond making these long journeys to sell mere sourdough bread, and she was suspicious no matter how damn good that bread was, and it was real good.

People around there were *nuts* for this Mennonite Bread. They loved to eat it with melted Velveeta. This bread was so good. They did far better than breaking even, selling so much Mennonite Bread each trip.

"Up north. Indiana—Pennsylvania, Ohio, babygirl. That's where the Mennonites live."

"Why do the crows come out downtown, mama?"

The girls would ask their mama this too on many occasions, some of them truly amazing times, times where crows would be attacking people in the square, the girls looking on at all of this. The crows would indeed attack, and they would come out in large numbers, heaps of crows, too-many-dozens-to-count, they'd say, just too-many-dozens-to-count, a unit of measure that spoke to the impossible and reminded them of the sure comfort of Piggly Wiggly egg crates. When the crows hung out in the square, it all looked like a warped lynching amusement park in a deleted scene from Hitchcock's 1963 film *The Birds*.

"Somebody made them mad—*could* be the *necromancy*... animals

know things and crows can keep a grudge against a person, a community, even, keep a grudge for generati*ahns*."

She thought that the crows understood metaphor. Sometimes, when she was hearing voices, the crows would speak to her. One of the crows was named Jaybird. He was married to Amber, his main squeeze, though Amber was a raven; Itragene appreciated their subversive relationship, like a mixed-race couple. These crows were ahead of their time! Their wedding one day would include even squirrels, no discrimination. Crow sits send messages, she estimated, and these crows would sit in big bunches in the square and attack. They just knew about the violence, Itragene was so sure, crows of the earth being innocent and having eyeballs, having intergenerational *Corvus* county courthouse memory, she would muse, referencing zoological literature that she had in her possession amongst her diverse references in her gonzo personal library—knowing something, knowing something, them crows, it seemed to her. There was also something up with the Mennonites.

There were the crows, there was the Face in the Window. There were the Mennonites selling their bread.

This was our Itragene's idea of a place that she called *Henry's Garden*, what she called it.

Henry's Garden, a radical reformulation.

This woman called the situation about poor ole' Henry Wells that everybody else all called the Face in the Window just that—Henry's Garden, thought it was poetic. She proposed "Henry's Garden" because it was as good as "the Face in the Window," that ignorant and obfuscating title that they had so enthusiastically slapped over the whole thing, their absurd shorthand for such a very involved story that extended beyond there being a smudge on the window that everybody thought was a face. Henry's Garden equally as helpful a name, indeed, equally helpful as to going about describing what was really going on in these parts. It also sounded more inviting, and Black people were long overdue a safe invitation into a public life.

It was all so terribly revolting, and she was going to show the world, make everybody understand. Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr. was determined.

She was a widow and the mother of two, Charlice and Itragene Jr., Itragene's twin daughter girls, the two of whom everybody called Maddie and Big Iddy, Charlice and Itragene Jr., respectively.

It was spring 1994, babies grown, and she had lost her goddamn mind. She was lost in the 1960s, the 1940s, her young adult years and beyond; in her sixties, out of her mind, she was living in her vision to liberate Henry Wells, at last, it seemed.

Itragene couldn't get it out of her head, this meme—"strange fruit," hadn't been able to since the sixties.

This was our Itragene's world, Pickens County, Alabama, her a Gordo native. This was her home, Carrollton the county seat of it all, and she called it all "Henry's Garden," the county square and beyond, all the towns in Pickens that were part of this violent territory.

Henry's Garden.

It was there in the garden that the chicken crossed the road and everybody who was around there was already consumed, and they never paid attention otherwise, for they were all talking, and, so, they did not hear what this poultry had to say. You ever seen a dead chicken talk?

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"Am I… hallucinating? These lights are so bright…" I'm not muttering again, am… ah, *shit*. *One mustn't* mutter, *one mustn't* mutter, she rambled at herself.

"Huh," she's now saying aloud.

"What was that, Itragene? Or, what was it… " the host says, shuffling giant notecards: "Ma Iddy. Everybody give it up again for Ma Iddy... "

They're clapping. They really are. It is all so incredible. …how unexpected. *One must* be prepared to make significant progress in this world!

"Oh, nothin' nothin'. Gee, how do you do this with these lights, hah? Well… the place?—you mean like, overall? Oh, it was honted, you could say, yeah, in more ways than one, honted by a lynched ghost… or histor*ee* itself," stunned at the attention she has brought upon herself by this time, July 1996, Itragene tells the famous man on the TV, who is David Letterman.

National television. CBS. A major network broadcast event. She had made the news for knocking that window out. She actually had prevented all-out war, they said, a transnational race war led by Mennonite gangs, in fact.

" …honted by the past and what they did. They all called it the Face in the Window but I nicknamed it Henry's Garden," she snickers, almost sticking her tongue out for some reason, Itragene.

The famous man has begun shuffling giant note cards again which he does until he finds his place and he asks, "Can you tell us about the, …what is it, the Flat Sisters of Gordo, the Flat Sisters of Gordo. You're a Gordo girl, aren't you?"

"I have better material than that—did*ju'*h come across the Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre in your research for this episode?"

Madonna audibly says to everybody, "Jesus Christ, this *state,*" laughing, sitting to Itragene's right, leaning forward a bit.

The famous man host goes, "Alabama, folks! Alabama, Alabama, bam, bam, bammm… At least it ain't Mississippi… that's what I hear people say," he says as he acts out the serial onomatopoeia by bringing his flat palm from up above his head and down onto the desk three times—three bams. It isn't violent when he slaps his desk, but it is silly, and he is the entertaining host, after all. As he enacts these motions, a snare drum winds up and lets off in the background and a sax goes "dahhh *wommmmmmp*."

"Let me make sure everybody gets it. It was so depraved. Dave,"

she told the host like an old friend. She carried on.

"What was most absurd about it wudn't that *they'dh'd* been saying that they saw a face or somfthin' up there in the windah," she said heavily. "There was something up there *on* that windah—*on*, catch that? 'On' it, not 'in' it—don't make no sense," she said, swiveling her head to gauge how many picked up on that about the face being on the window versus in the window, waving a Diet Coke with a paper towel stuck to the bottom of it in front of the studio audience's faces. She could barely see, it was so bright.

"Not inside the window, folks!" Sound effects like breaking glass go off.

"The absurd part was truly that this simple fact about a window having a stain or discoloration on it, and that was it, all they had, had that window in the state it was in and that is what sustained the whole notion for so awful long for all of these people that it was that man's actual face up there, and printed by lightning, they'd say," she laughed, "*pfahh*."

"Tell us about the photo," Dave said.

"Oh, that's a good one. My daddy—he was the county commissioner for a real long time, 1940-1989—went up in 1985 and he talked about it until he died in 1993. He said you couldn't see it from the inside, was the thing. They had been allowed to go up there to the garret room, daddy, him and some of his men he knew from business. I don't *have* the photo, but my daddy did have it somewhere and he showed me—you couldn't see anything in the photo on the windah from the inside."

She wanted to write a book.

She told the audience about it all. She was on a roll.

"It's difficult to describe the literal face in the window as an optical phenomenon, a mark, a discoloration... It was, in fact, difficult to see. This supposed face haint was really faint," she declared.

She rhymed on purpose. She thought Yankees would get a kick out of the word "haint," and they did laugh. It's a funny sounding word,

after all.

"They tacked an arrow to the brick, nailed a BEEP arrow [she said "goddamn arrow"] up there, they did, sure enough did, the jokers running the show in Pickens County. It was all a real Jim Crow-themed circus. They pointed this retroreflective sign that they threw up there at just the right spot on the dark window pane, which was properly the bottom right, one of four thick pieces of glass, a big *ole*' sign pointing at a supposed Black man who was forever wailing for all the town to see, forever and ever, as long as that courthouse were to stand and with that window, a window you inevitably noticed, with that big arrow and all pointing at it. They put that arrow there just to make sure that you apprehend it, absorb it, take it in, never forget it, the Face in the Window, the Face in the Window, the Face in the Window, they'd say over and over and over until they died, making sure you never forget it, put that arrow there to make sure that you don't forget it all or ignore any of it, put that arrow there so that that nobody, and—*and* also, that nobody, nobody at all, see—including you and nobody else, understand—that nobody forgot," she said at a point before a commercial break, taking a deep breath.

Madonna initiated a boisterous applause before the ad for Pizza Hut came on, and this was an applause in New York City for this oral history Itragene had prepared her entire life for in Alabama to deliver.

More guests were scheduled to join her and Madonna on the couch. She laughed at her own rhyme, "faint haint." She wasn't so bad at the TV.

She was a master storyteller.

She wanted a damn cigarette. How long all of was all of this? How long was it gonna take?

"Do you like Nina Simone, Madonna? Is that what I am to call you —Madonna? I love her. I love Nina Simone. She was so passionate. She shot her manager, I think. Henry's Garden was always so loud, baby… but I always heard her in the wind," Itragene put out there, a notion Madonna found lush to contemplate.

She had more to say, some of it just rephrasing what she had already established.

She was saying so much to Madonna.

Sandra Bernhard comes out after the commercial break, a popular late-night guest across the various national networks. She joins Itragene and Madonna on the *Late Show with David Letterman* couch. Itragene scoots over to let her sit.

"Honey," hugging Itragene, "We've gotta talk. Honey, Madonna calls me all the time. But do I answer? No. I let her sweat it out. So don't… " she continued, spreading her arms in a distant embrace of the audience, "don't tell *me* about show business, baby!"

Bernhard sat on the couch; the show continued. It was 1996, then, there.

More guests. Madonna sang her 1994 hit "Secret."

Mmmmmmm...

Applause. Autographs. What a spectacle.

The sidewalk and the city.

She eats at a Red Lobster in Times Square. And the Lord saw it and saw it was good.

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By 1994, some of the Mennonites who sold their famous bread on the Carrollton town square had finally relocated to Pickens County after schlepping down from Indiana to sell their bread for over a hundred years. They had shortened their commute a mighty distance. They weren't alone in making such a move—there was a mass movement of Mennonites all about and across North America at the time, beginning in 1990, and, so, these Mennonites who had this peculiar relationship with Pickens County who moved there had cover, a popular movement their camouflage.

Reclusive, they started settling off downtown Reform in 1990, just off Highway 82, right next to the Pentecostal area in downtown Reform (pronounced "Ree-form"), the Pentecostals mighty different in their ways but the other unassuming white religious minority around and with whom they were the friendliest out of anybody there.

It's an early spring morning in Alabama.

Wednesday, March 16, 1994.

Under that window, that truly haunting window, the local Pickens County downtown Reform Mennonites have set up to sell their famous Carrollton town square Mennonite Bread. People drive in from all over, including neighboring counties, Mississippians included, not just folks from the fifty-five towns in and about Pickens. It was a monthly ritual, the third Wednesday of the month, a regular inpouring of a plentitude of starving people wanting this coveted Pickens County Square, Reform Mennonite Carrollton bread that used to come from Indiana, the famous Mennonite Bread of Pickens County. The courthouse was a magnet in the region in general as it was, but particularly the third Wednesday of the month, Mennonite Bread day. Mennonite Bread meant a lot to these people, these hungry, hungry people who loved Mennonite Bread and their lynching ghost story window, too. Bread and strange fruit these people ate in gobs.

On the south side of the county square lawn on this morning there is standing a little Mennonite boy, and he is feeding some of this treasured bread to some birds, out of sight of his mother's watchful eye —it was a glare, a *Look* she would give, a stunning *Look* that would stupefy the target of her harsh glance, a bewitching glare she wielded that would freeze the target of this shafted gaze, a witchy look and deed. Feeding Mennonite Bread to the crows, this little Mennonite boy. They'd been selling bread there for generations, the Mennonites, the boys and men in their black outfits, women and girls in their black and light blue dresses, denim skirts and bonnets. Sometimes, the Mennonite children would feed a crow or two, just like what was happening at that moment—some crows and a few sparrows, too, red

jays, a couple of blue birds, the little Mennonite children would feed. The Mennonite kids had been feeding them crows for near a century, near as long as Henry had been up there in that there wind*er*.

A massive murder of crows was flying above it all, the scene before us, in fact, and they circled around the county square, looking down and making a racket, an undulating and spinning, black pointillist cloud that was partly blocking the Alabama morning sun's rays—*caw*, *caw*, *caw*—ca*h*w ca*h*w ca*h*w, *cawww*.

These big black birds swooped.

These familiar, enormous birds were flying motifs, these intelligent birds just meaning so much to these people, these crows.

It was always like this in the morning—just too many crows. Too many to count, even.

They had a crow problem, and the whole county remarkably mostly ignored it. One was not allowed to speak of it, in fact, a harsh and unspoken rule. Look at the window, look at Henry Wells, and pay no mind to the crows.

They didn’t want the wrong kind of attention.

If you asked about it, this crow problem, which few ever had, the ruling class of the townspeople would look at you with a vacant and committed stare and act like they had no idea as to what you were even on about, maybe even absently laughing, and they'd do this in a crazy way, too, notably unhinged. They ignored the crows, acting like it weren’t a worry, and they floated as they were to do in the humid air and many tornadoes.

These crows were nonetheless widely known to circle the square in gargantuan groups like this, known to stalk the area, known to seem to have a real bone to pick, known to bother people, like crows can and do do, sometimes. They would only do this in the morning, this *Corvus* circling the square, this lawn patrol, this guarding and cawing —mornings only.

Nobody seemed to know who had pissed off all of these crows, exactly, but time does march on, and generations of Pickens Countians

were birthed, children everywhere and almost everybody a cousin—pretty much within the bounds of race and the legacy of money, of course and clearly, with rare and much despised exceptions—and so did the crows procreate, their generations passing down this presumed grudge against Carrolltonians. The town had a crow problem, it seemed, appearing that way, but nobody would go on at length about it or truly identify it as the aberrant zoological issue that it was.

Known to be there always in the mornings assuredly, nobody seemed to know where they went in the afternoon nor where they roosted in the evening. It was truly worrisome and irksome, these a superstitious people and crows associated in their minds with Death, a bad omen. The way they carried on in regard to the crow problem was rife with contradiction. They ignored what worried them. Bad omens, it was thought about crows that if you saw one outside of your own home that Death was coming for you or somebody you knew, which came in threes, Death. The crow issue wasn't just literary or about the superstitions that dominated their subconscious, though, though metaphors can and do kill, but the issue was also kinetic, about crow violence, this: these crows would *attack*.

Yes. Attack, understand—from every whichaway a direction. This was the only time they responded to the crows: once it went kinetic, once they had to.

They would attack. It was nuts. People lost eyes, ears were slashed, hair was torn from heads, but nobody was allowed to fully acknowledge the problem or freak out.

“That's just them crows,” they’d act like and they’d say, all of it insane but just how things were done around there and had been for a long time.

There were countless injuries all the time.

There were at least three well-documented events that were violent incidents with actual fatalities. These were earlier years, the years 1911, 1934 and 1967, specifically, 1967 seeing an incredible three fatalities as part of one event, two women and one infant, the baby

assumed deceased—assumed, at least, the poor thing carried away by a crow as the townspeople in the square watched, amazingly enough, crows a strong and large bird, that poor *ole*' lil' itty bitty baby, Lord bless his heart, baby Johnathan; they never found anything but his blankie, they said, and it was swangin' in the wind on an electrical line when they found it, messing up incandescent light bulbs on the blocks over past the courthouse where rich white people lived off Phoenix Avenue in downtown Carrollton's small wealthy residential area.

They ignored this issue as much as they could. They didn't talk about it, but, after all of those rather recent deaths, they quietly managed it, in a way.

At the unit school over in Carrollton, Carrollton Unit School, they'd teach you in kindergarten-through-senior year in language arts classes that crows were big in folklore, and they were well studied in folklore, but teachers never mentioned in that literary context the local omen right down the street on the county square, just a minute walk. They didn't even mention the crows when they'd get that Henry Wells glint in their eye and tell the story of the Face in the Window.

Only indirectly would they do a thing when they did anything about it at all; never mentioning the source of danger, the crows, they'd nonetheless teach relevant crow infestation skills in the yearly first aid lessons that every teacher had been required to teach since 1967 as a practical matter, lessons like "how to preserve an eyeball for surgery," "tourniquet tricks for deep thigh wounds," "everyday ear guarding," stuff like that, stuff that came to be required given how many Carrollton pupil crow attacks there had been given the number of aggressive crows and the amount of time that the unit school kids spent right there on the lawn under that window, and this was beyond the fatal events of '67, such as what happened with one little girl, a student at the unit school, who in '65 famously lost her left eye to a crow attack, beady-eye Becky they called her until she graduated, even though her name was Elizabeth Sally, the attack ruining her life, making a leper of her, a pretty little thing until she lost her eye to the

incident and stopped taking care of herself, the crow attack ruining this girl's life, ruined her life, and she ended up only ever eating lunch again with an unpopular girl who everybody properly called Ugly, calling her that because that was her name and also because Ugly didn't have a nose. Ugly didn't have a nose of which to speak, but she wore sunglasses all the time, nobody sure how they stayed on her face, and this is what they bonded over and discussed at lunch, Elizabeth Sally upon graduation finding herself in Memphis where she became a busker and pretended to be blind in her good eye, them bonding as kids over each of their mutual maintenance of large collections of sunglasses, Ugly and Becky, Elizabeth Sally, sharing a passion for sunglasses consumer options in their local area and available catalogues.

People paid attention to the crows, had to, but they never discussed it explicitly as an issue, though they took measures in light of the crow violence, crows mattering lots, their big beating wings reflected in that window.

One landed, *caw*, one, two and, *caw*, *caw*ww, then, suddenly, all of them coming down from out of the air, the rest were following—this was a lot more crows, a bunch of crows, an *absurd* amount of crows, really and truly, nearly *five-dozen of them*, it looked, countless crows, really, *too-many-dozens of crows to know for sure*, too-many-dozens to count, dozens and halves-of-a-dozen being the units in which people around there counted a lot of things, stuff like a bunch of crows, dozens and half-a-dozen, a measure similar to a bushel like that in which you measure peas from the field, dozens and half-a-dozen, the known and familiar, reliable egg unit, something for measuring stuff around there, a unit of stuff in which you could observe almost anything, and it was a unit that they all understood, and *it's all they knew*, when it came to counting, this unit, only knew this unit, this unit, a dozen and its half, nothing less, more or in between, one or the other, a two-piece abacus. It was binary, this counting math, and Boo Radley was either in the chifforobe or he wasn't, one or the other, and

likewise there were a dozen or half-a-dozen of this, that and the other, one or the other, dare not anything between.

Coming down from out the cloudy Alabama spring morning sky, they started a little and brief crow sit atop the three-story old Pickens County courthouse in the middle of the county square lawn, no longer used for the practice and execution of the law, though the county clerk's office was situated on the first floor, the only floor people were allowed to visit by that time. A county registrar woman carrying a large fountain soda Dr. Pepper, a coffee thermos bigger than her head and a breakfast sausage biscuit wrapped in aluminum foil walked through the large, wooden south side door. Thick panes of old, durable glass shook as the door swung back over to the threshold. She was about to settle in for the day's work ahead issuing fishing licenses—" *that time of year*," she was thinking, clutching her aluminum foil biscuit in her hand. Hungry, barely able to wait to eat her biscuit and drink her Dr. Pepper at her desk, there she'd be later, happy, full but wishing she had a little more of her fountain soda and biscuit, sipping what was left of her near-empty Dr. Pepper: *Sdrrrr*, "*ahh*."

Her loud vehicle radio spooked the crows, at least a dozen, made the little Mennonite boy feeding the birds jump too, also grabbing the registrar's attention, her peeking out the window after hearing the racket, mumbling, "Oh, that's just poor ole' Itragene," gently laughing and rolling her eyes.

The Mennonite boy's mother looked at the car. People in their own vehicles sat behind the driver smacking their lips, cursing, because the driver was also going very slowly around the roundabout, and these other drivers were filled with rage, morning traffic road rage in the Carrollton town square.

Itragene Sr. was holding everybody up and her radio was turned all

the way up.

> SUNDAY, Sunday, SUNDAY —at the Birmingham Riverchase Galleria…NAFTA CLOSEOUT SALE!!!

The radio was blaring inside and she passed wind in the loud cabin of her car, filling the air with what they called around there "a poot," and she was grateful that it was a poot and not some poop. She passed dry winds. Her left blinker was stuck in the on position as she cruised around the roundabout, though she was going south around the county square and about to turn right instead and head off down Commerce Avenue. The sun hurt her eyes. She couldn't see, didn't know where her large sunglasses were. She was cold, too, our Itragene, driving her giant Lincoln Town Car with the heat blasting on high, all of the windows down, driving her standard-issue Town Car, the one that so many old white ladies drove around there, wide cars, taking up a whole lane in the road and an inch more. She was driving really slowly, not minding the road, farting, distracted because she was examining and dissecting out the driver's seat window to her left the gutters on the courthouse, as she was to do, plotting her climb to remove the Face in the Window one day.

A few more crows landed on the west side lawn, going to there from the top of the courthouse, briefly, flying, then, away toward and over the Pizza Doctor, flying, them crows scared by the loud morning radio that was blasting out of Itragene's gray Lincoln Town Car that she was driving way too slowly around the roundabout, holding everybody up, but in a town and county of towns where nobody honked except on Highway 82.

Itragene Sr., our Itragene, driving the Lincoln Town Car, distracted by the architectural features of the courthouse, she was manic as shit, sleep-deprived and delirious, near falling asleep on her steering wheel, a true public nuisance in the moment and a danger to herself and others. She was barely able to drive, delirious as hell.

It was another morning in the square—crows and vehicles and

passersby, the promise of independent commerce in the form of a bread stands and the activities of local legends. Itragene's loud car had terrified the crows and hurt the eardrums of the people, terrified them all like so, but nobody was honking at this woman there about the roundabout, though she was going around the square so slowly, exceptionally so, so slowly she was going, even for this slowpoke place, basically parked except she was moving a little bit, nobody honking at all, only lots of pissed off people muttering and huffing behind steering wheels with their own not-too-quiet car radios, radios just everywhere in Pickens County, there sound all the time, no quiet in such a quiet place, the air full of blasting radios all the time, Alabama and Mississippi radio stations in the air like rolling clouds you could always hear moving the thick air in a storm that never rolled through all the way, always buzzing, static, voices, humid noise.

A lot of people couldn't sit with themselves in the quiet and needed constant noise to settle their nerves. This town and county were guilty as hell. The memories of this land weighed on them, crow or no crow, it all a decaying settlement, this part of Alabama.

"*Phewww*," she whistled as she drove, barely able to keep going.

A sex store jingle for a place right over the Alabama-Mississippi state border started blasting from Itragene's sloth-trot Lincoln Town Car, sound waves as loud as that Lincoln Town Car was a big-ass car.

> The fun begins a-a-aht Fantasy Land, with videos and noveltiiiiiesss, adults come to Fantasy La-a-and.

That Fantasy Land jingle was everywhere.

It was everywhere, like radios were all over the place, wherever you went, that damn adult novelty store commercial song just everywhere and everybody—*everybody*—had that stuck in their goddamn head, young and old. They'd hum it, whistle it. Children were everywhere and they heard this ear worm jingle about sex toys and pornographic videos in their good Christian community, a dry county, no legal alcohol sold, not anywhere you went, no matter where

or when you went, all week, Monday-Sunday.

In the vehicle behind Itragene's slow Lincoln Town Car, there was sitting a harsh and brute man, sitting in an old Ford truck who had been driving in circles, then on his third lap after finally getting a glimpse of his ex-wife walking into the south side door of the courthouse—the registrar inside eating her aluminum foil biscuit with her big fountain soda Dr. Pepper.

"Christmalmigh*d*y, get goin', *ole*' woman," this man said out loud, knowing exactly who it was in front of him, hating Itragene.

He was biting and barking at the air like a leashed yard dog when he said it, spit getting everywhere, getting spit on his mustache and gross, big and wiry, unkempt beard, spitting tobacco juice into a Mountain Dew bottle he'd had in that big truck of his, kept it in the console for a week for this purpose, to spit in, chewing his tobacco and swarshing its juices, sitting and spitting in his Lilly pad, faded old green and rusty truck, the air in the cab abloom both a foul peppermint snuff smell and evergreen pine. He had a John Deere hat on, this ugly spitting character truck man, a Bass Pro Shops car freshener on his rear-view mirror and a bunch of illegally trafficked machine guns in his truck bed covered by and wrapped in many a tarp, and he was stuck there, sitting and spitting in his truck directly behind this impediment of a driver.

"Fucking bitch. FUCKING b*aat*chhhhh AHHHH," he uttered in as if in distressed pain.

Red in the face, sweat running down his temples off his ginger head. Truly ridiculous, his behavior. He was out of his mind about this roundabout holdup, real road rage on the county square.

"Ahhhh, I hate you, you bitch, you fucking bitch"—and he started to weep—"*took my wife you fucking bitch you fucking bitch*."

This Lincoln Town Car of our Itragene's delaying everybody was muling ahead at a steady galivant, its pace punctured further by speed bumps and worn-down shocks, popping up and down, screeching, this giant car, this car of hers, a car making a racket, a car whose driver

everybody knew.

He hated “that old bitch” so much; he hated her because Itragene had informed his former wife once about his predilection for one of the girls around town in the world's oldest profession, her being a crazy busybody.

Directly ahead of the man in the John Deere hat, a skinny and rough-looking, but pretty white woman stumbled out of the tiny Pickens County Sheriff's Office police station on the corner of the square.

This wild-looking woman looked mad as hell, had bright and big blonde hair with a yellow hue, looking like she hadn't treated it in a while with purple tint, if she ever had at all, her hair closer to a yellow crayon than anything you could call “platinum,” which was what she was clearly going for, that type of woman, the kind of woman upon whom Dolly Parton based her look, as Parton's famously said, “the town whore.” She had prominent roots in that head of hair of hers, too, and she was wearing a white spaghetti strap top with high-waisted denim jeans, white fabric shoes with thin plastic yellow soles on them and they were dirty, the soles and the rest of the footwear, dirty shoes they were; a wreck from head to foot, her hair was clearly messed up from a night in the cell, her hair a hairspray-matted-mess.

Blasting from the Lincoln Town Car radio as this shaggy woman barged out of the police station: “*... the greatest hits of 1994... Yeahhh babyyyy... 94.1 ZBQ*,” an enthused and stretchy, bouncy voice that everyone knew said.

This radio voice of the hits station guy, this familiar 94.1 ZBQ voice, it echoed off the buildings around the square, slinkily putty-like, that familiar voice followed by the news, quieter and somewhat muffled, beadier harmonics and less excited, but still loud, the message enunciated in a women's Ole Miss communication studies major voice, a billowing vocal fry that pounds your face, that feels like going up and down on a riverboat in choppy waters behind a big shipping barge, every consonant a harsh crest thwacking wave, every vowel an

elongated, cradling trough in the waters of Southern speech: "G*ohl*hyden Tr*i-an*gle factor*ij*ies are the l*aydtes*t in th'Go*l'e*n T*ri*-an*g*'l t*ew's*xpect to furth*er* feel thee'imp*a*ct *uv*f N*AF*T*A*, a visit to th'a'area'*s*xpet*ed* from Presid*en*t *Clint*on with*in* th'comin' wh*eek*sz, where the Pr*esid*e*nt* is sched*y*uled tah meet with *lo*cawl con*cern*ed manufact*y*ur*y*ers. And now, the weather across the Golden Triangle."

"Fuck you, Bill Clinton! *Fuckkk* you, Bill Clinton!"

She screamed that, the woman freshly freed from jail, and she screamed more in her fresh freedom. She screamed something incoherent, screamed something about outrageous prices for spaghetti sauce and who owed her money in town, wandering around the county square scratching her American, Alabama Piggly Wiggly government cheese-yellow head, yelling and hollering. She was going to the store for cigarettes; she needed a goddamn cigarette, especially after seeing that goddamn truck.

"*Goddamn harasser, stalker*, sick fuck," she was thinking upon the sight of the spitting man in his green and rusty truck, scratching her white-girl nappy head, just screaming, spitting mad.

It seemed that everybody around here was always fuming, spitting mad, just turned out all the goddamn time to a point of true fucking hilarity.

"Too old to drive, too old to drive," a preacher's wife said aloud to herself over the soft sounds of Christian pop playing on her big-ass Lincoln Town Car door speakers, her saying that and sitting in her own gray Lincoln Town Car behind the John Deere spit guy, this tusk-tusking and harrumphing termagant the same age as the woman in her Lincoln Town Car behind the holdup, same exact age as Itragene, sixty four, this matron prig the wife of a Southern Baptist preacher in town, the preacher at the big Southern Baptist church off the square.

This was Mrs. Sister Jackson, Eunice, the preacher's wife. She's dressed in all gray old white lady clothes. Her jacket has a brooch on it above her heart and it is an emerald raven with a bunch of sticks gathered in its beak.

Madonna's 1992 hit “Erotica” blasted from a speaker.

“Please, fuck *right* off! Fuck right off! Get! *ughhhh*-ah*hhHHh*!” The county's favorite whore screamed this over America's favorite whore, Madonna. She did this while also dancing to the music as she screamed.

The percussion claps penetrated the square air with Madonna's mezzo-soprano talk-singing.

> *Ohhhh*…
>
> Erotica.

The liberated town whore lady released from jail continued screeching and loudly—

> Erotic.
> Erotic.
> Erotic.

—making her racket while then also looking at that truck and that tobacco-chewing man.

Madonna carried on.

> Putcher hands…
> … my body

That lady was screaming and Mrs. Sister Jackson was tusk-tusking. The chickens that cluck the loudest and with the widest provenance in Pickens were all practiced liars and they'd never met a mirror in which they didn't avoid their own reflection.

The preacher's wife, Mrs. Sister Jackson, she pursed her sister lips there in the roundabout on the square and her white, peachy mustache shone in the morning Alabama light and she looked, in that golden light, the baseline of the Madonna hit playing and booming, shone it

did, her mustache, as she looked into the light and at the whooping woman freshly liberated from the corner jailhouse, thinking, "Uh shame on'h*y*er'r*ay*ce, a *shame*, shame, shameful, carrying on like'*a*t*, a sh*ay*me on her race; all you can do is pray for her, all you*'kg*an do*'es'*pr*a*e*y*'*f*'*h*er."

Madonna sings, "Erotic."

"That Madonna'z also a shameee on her race," Mrs. Sister Jackson was fuming.

Erotic.

… put you in a tra-a-anceee.

II. Poor Ole' Itragene and her Shekel Math

People were all over the place. That third Wednesday morning of March 1994, the third monthly Mennonite Bread day of that year, there was a whole bunch of Mennonite Bread in translucent blue plastic bags being carried all over and aluminum foil-covered biscuits being toted everywhere that you could see, blindingly shimmering, the place, all over. People held up their foodstuff in its packaging and it all glistened brightly in the rising Alabama spring morning sun—everywhere, downtown Carrollton crowded and humming loudly, these hungry people and their foodstuff, really big drinks, hot and cold beverages, people *runnin' across the road real quick-like*.

The town square is abuzz and radiates possibility.

Itragene has finally lurched her behemoth of a vehicle over and onto Commerce Avenue, her Lincoln Town Car's speakers now blasting the '80s hit "Land Down Under," and she's turning off the square, a right-hand turn.

I met a strange lady...

The poor thing has been driving so slowly that her adventure around the county square in that big gray Lincoln Town Car of hers can be told across two whole chapters of a book, and with plenty of detail still left to the imagination.

She clears the roundabout.

… vegemite sand*wich*

Her car has headed south, lurching down Commerce Avenue she goes. In the damp wind, Styrofoam cups and white paper napkins snow across the county square lawn; many chip bags and whole

newspaper sections blow around in little twisters in the spring wind; there is a bag of aluminum cans, fallen out of a truck bed, and the cans sit in a pile by the Commerce Avenue stop sign where it meets the square, pouring out from a busted trash bag, yellow jackets all over this high fructose corn syrup-covered litter.

In her bopping round about the square in her monstrous car, driving that enormous Town Car of hers, she was barely minding the road—focused instead on her Henry Wells fixation, her driving-force obsession, her analyzing the courthouse for places to grip and from which to suspend herself. Itragene Sr. was barely even seeing the road; only the courthouse occupied the ecstatic vision of her dilated pupils.

She is headed to the nearby parking lot where she intends to park, which is the Carrollton Unit School parking lot, and she has just narrowly missed seeing the woman who has popped out the jailhouse, the lady with the yellow hair who was hollering about local matters of an obscene nature, dancing there on the square to Madonna's "Erotica."

The yelling, *yeller*-headed woman acting up on the square is called Maddie. This town whore is the offspring of our Itragene Sr.—the town whore, that's what Charlice called herself, the town whore, this woman named Charlice but who is called Maddie.

There they were, March 16, 1994. This was their lot in life, this mother and daughter and the other townspeople. The people around were who was there; everybody from around there was there, this busy morning in Carrollton.

The Mennonite boy feeding the crows Mennonite Bread is called Enoch and he has been there in a continued frenzy feeding his people's precious bread to the crows. He is spinning around and around throwing the coveted bread of his people, the bread they used to make in Indiana and, by then, make in Reform.

This famous Pickens County square downtown Reform Mennonite Bread of Carrollton, Alabama, is selling faster than the stands can be replenished by these darkly clothed, reclusive people, the local

Mennonites.

Crows look on at it all from all over the square, swooping in for bread that the little boy's throwing around him; the energy in the square is frenetic; the little boy spins in childish, fun circles, dizzyingly throwing bread at great velocity, as fast as a baseball pitch, the crows surrounding him as if this child is the homeless lady in *Home Alone II*, but here it is tiny-ass Carrollton and its crows infestation and he isn't homeless. He is just a little Mennonite boy and he has always loved feeding the crows bread; the crows love him; the crows love the bread, perhaps even love the Mennonite Bread more than the townspeople who ate theirs warmed up with Velveeta.

There they all were, the townspeople of Pickens County and those who drove in from the surrounding area, for it is Mennonite Bread day, always a major affair in the square. Many merchants come out on Mennonite Bread day, leeching off the inpouring of the crowds manifested by the bread selling, hawking their wares. The medicine man has been driving around the square and looking for a place to park so that he can sell his questionable goods. A local craftsman has been setting up to sell wallets, purses and shirts, which he makes, makes by hand these carry items that he sells, accessories he has for reasonable prices and, too, all of his prêt-a-porter inventory, all of this he makes himself, and all of these locally made goods are Native American in theme.

Little Enoch's mother looked at people.

On the other side of the square, the north side where the square meets Phoenix Avenue, the little Mennonite boy on the south side at Commerce Avenue—Itragene's car in the distance heading south, music still audible from the square—little Enoch's mother, a hateful, bigoted woman, was looking at people, glaring at everybody at whom she glanced for that is how she looks at people, with a glare, it always a glare.

She is not unique around there. The ugly face she makes is a local mask and cherished custom and it's doesn't cost a thing; that Look that

she gives is a particular contortion of the face, a replicable and popular facial expression that they all share and imitate one another in doing it over and over, a face she and many others make liberally; the *Look* is a meme that all the wicked people know in these parts, an imitable unit of South*ahn* culture; the *Look* is an expression of white power, a memetic weapon. The Look is a particular, learned and imitated manner of contorting one's face in sadistic regard, an expression of disdain in total attention paid to another in regard of others. The townspeople have done this for so long, giving the this here Look, throwing that Look—they'd just Look a certain way at people, make an ugly and nasty, up-nosed face with their eyebrows crooked, mouth snarling, pupils acting like bullets that penetrate the target of the glare. The Look is arresting. The Look is a tool, a tool that they had had for so long by then, just one available tool for maintaining the legacy, a performative element in a repertoire of broader violence. Giving the Look hurts them, too, the hateful townspeople who mean-mug in this fashion, them getting themselves more twisted up than they already are because their innards matched their exterior, throwing that Look, initiating them further and deeper into their own perversity, dancing with the Devil, living out particular sequences of memes like the Look that, taken together, all add up to a scornful and despicable, as well as idiotic string of enacted behavior, a particular imitable string, a sequence of learned behavior. This is how violence begets violence: it is learned and passed down.

It is a matter of character and population disciplinary violence.

The Look is a matter of evolution in culture, of maintaining the legacy through behavior that is imitated with high fidelity and variation in time and space. This is how legacy makes use of pliable human bodies as a matter of history, and this is particularly true when it comes to the role of legend in legacy and legacy in legend. History haunts the living.

Their hateful behavior was ritualized. These white people were copying one another in their hatred and had been for a long time,

throwing that Look around. For this unfortunate lot, this was all it, all that there was to this life, their lot in life, this, this it, it it and that was it, all that they had—their hateful ways—all that there was, with history repeating itself through the benefit of their compliant bodies, the famously recursive South, the same things happening over and over in the population, legacy manifesting as a force that penetrates flesh, materializing itself as history in the constant reenactment of hateful memes central to the legends they tell themselves. This was their *bit*, their bit in the historical record, their bit, a familiar series of memetic behaviors to which they committed their lives, one big act for life and then death, these mean people living out life with their tired scripts, their recursive loops of the memes that mattered around there to legacy, such as the *Look*, this all-too-common visage of psychopathy particular to the sort of white supremacy that reigned the lot.

This here Look? The Look was likely the last thing on this Earth many Black people saw in Pickens County, Henry Wells included, however he died, murdered by white people in any case that's been presented in the many versions of the story.

Can you imagine the way they looked at that man?

White people would just Look at you. They'd give that Look that they had so hatefully perfected around there, white people, most often looking like that and giving that Look of theirs when they saw Black folks. They looked mean and crazy and they were such.

There was the Look and there was the Face in the Window, these Pickens County things, these local memes, this lot in life that these people had.

The square. It is 1994. It is springtime.

There is that face up there in that window that morning, like it always was. The Face in the Window watched on at all these people who all had their morning business around the square, where there is commerce, the smell of Mennonite Bread commerce abloom.

Maddie had walked out of the jailhouse just as Itragene was going

about turning off the square, Itragene finally heading south after making her way so slowly and holding everybody up in the roundabout—the two of these ladies nearly caught sight of one another, but they were each in their own worlds, not looking where they were, a good minute it would be before they crossed paths again, but they would indeed and eventually meet over there in Carrollton that morning, these Gordo girls, mother and daughter, hook up and head back in the Town Car to the house over in Gordo.

Looking for each other that morning, Maddie and Itragene failed to connect on the square there, nearly crossing paths but each going right passed one another. It would take only some minutes before Maddie and Itragene come up upon one another, minutes wherein a lot transpires, about half an hour.

Everybody around saw them there, though they did not see each other; the people around looked at them.

Everybody in the county knew them and knew about them, the Calloways local celebrities, known as wide and far as the outer skirts of the Mississippi Golden Triangle to Birmingham and Montgomery—even all the way to Atlanta, people knew about the Calloway family and how far they had fallen and how tarnished the legacy of Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr. had become.

Itragene and Maddie, who often didn't look where they were going, would be out and about and people would Look at them.

"Poor *ole'* Itragene," said a woman to somebody, looking off in Itragene's direction, throwing her her nasty Look, making her an ugly face that was a dime-a-dozen around there.

"I heard she's been livin' in *that house* over'in'*over'n*-there'*in* Gordo fo' *free*."

"*Mhmm*," some woman replied without opening her mouth, a guttural sewage sound.

These clucking chickens were taking a morning walk down Tuscaloosa Avenue, right off the square by the post office and bank, heading west, heading downhill.

"*Mhmm*, after her daddy stopped doin' all that stuff she didn't have any'v'*aw*ll that money left, not one cent," it was quickly asserted.

"*Iiiiii ain't gonna say* what *Iiii* think happened'*tah*'aw*h*ll'at money," somebody else who overheard them started, and they knew them, the other two already gabbing about it all, and that's what they said, that they weren't gonna say nothing, as was often said around there while saying a whole lot.

The three of them continued talking, all of them concluding about her status around the county that it was all to do with *her thinkin' she's better than everybody else*. That's what they always said, in particular, that she was snobby. They'd throw her that lowdown, mean Look and say that *she* was actually the pretentious one, out of their minds and truly believing their delusional projection.

"She jus' thank she bett'ur'in'evr'bod'ee-else."

It was endless, the gossip about our Itragene, her Maddie too. Nobody really badmouthed Big Iddy, mind.

Everybody had something to say about Itragene, poor ole' Itragene, Maddie too but especially her mother, our Itragene. Everybody was always on about her downfall, her continuous, never-ending downfall, rock bottom never possible in their endless and cruel imaginations where they tortured Itragene in their mind's eye. Itragene never stood a chance, and that was true even though she came from "a good family," even more true, in fact, due to the weight of legacy in such a place as Pickens County, Alabama.

She knew what the evil eye was. It was that Look. People would often throw her way that Look of theirs.

The people of Pickens, everybody most all over, they were generally so cruel that they'd build hell themselves if they could, just for sheer entertainment, for sure, if they could. They'd throw Itragene into an eternal pit of fire and torture and just sit and watch, just grab her by the ankle and toss her in and laugh, pop popcorn and get set up on the couch, a godless people for the most part, monsters carrying crosses, eating their pies made of strange fruit, the bodies of Black

people reflected in their eyes swinging from the trees of the gallant South. There were the crows in their eyes.

That morning, Itragene was there to pick up her babygirl and Maddie was waiting for her mama after another unremarkable night down at the county jailhouse.

Itragene was high on diet pills and Maddie were still a bit drunk.

Also, Itragene had been talking to the ghost of Henry Wells quite intensely for a bit, now, by that drive, her barely able to stay on the road or in her lane, not looking where she was going. They had Looked at him, too.

Itragene was in her vehicle still, but she had at last and finally stopped her car and parked.

She was parked over in the student parking lot in front of the schoolhouse in downtown Carrollton on Commerce Avenue, the Carrollton Unit School parking lot. She was pulled up and parked in a spot like it was hers, like she had paid the semester fee for the privilege, a spot which was reserved for a student and that did not belong to her. Not her spot, but she knew it'd be empty and available. She drove over to Carrollton and snatched it up while it was free. She knew it would be free before she got there, as a matter of fact, it something that she learned on the police scanner; she heard that the teenaged McShan boy who usually parked there was in jail—methamphetamine and paraphernalia—and he wasn't getting out that morning, a high bail and he was from a white trash family. So, she knew the spot would be empty. The police scanner was full of useful Pickens County information like this, such as free parking, chock-full of information about the goings-on of Pickens County and the townspeople of the county's fifty-five towns, and it was a pathological obsession on the part of our Itragene.

There she was, sitting in the car, finishing the last sips of a Jack's fountain soda Diet Coke with chewable ice.

So good, she fiendishly thought. *So good, so good, gewd-gew', so* gew'.

She was also chewing the last morsels of a buttery and flaky sausage biscuit with lots of grape jelly, greasy, it all a mess all over the car, crumbs everywhere, a purple fleck of grape jelly gob on her muumuu—this biscuit, like the soda with its chewable ice, just as well, in her view was, *So good, so goddamn good*, she thought, and she thought it in a peculiar way insofar as she didn't really think it at all, but instead just witnessed it fly by; these cogitations occurred but not of her will, transpired in a way where she didn't really consciously think, didn't catalyze her own thoughts as a person. She was just watching "her" thoughts fly by, as one does in manic psychosis.

She was so manic and had been psychotic, too, for a bit, a few days. She was always peculiar and believed in things she shouldn't say aloud, but she was *truly* psychotic, then, should've been in the hospital, not well. Not only was her mind spent, but her physical health was in serious crisis, an elderly woman who had not slept for day and was barely eating, this Jack's biscuit breakfast sandwich her first warm meal in a week.

Her thoughts have been moving faster than her cognition, her labile and spent mind operating beyond her will. The phrase "so good" is looping in her mind and she can't stop it, though it is light torture.

So good, so good... I love Jack's sausage biscuit. My drink is good and I'm blessed. Thank you, Jesus the Christ. *Toda, Yeshua HaMaschiach*, her thoughts went by and said in their passing through that content, thoughts in her mental field that were occurred in a manner that escaped the velocity of her will to think of any of it; she could not instantiate thoughts, not anything at all, her thoughts running a mile a minute like a film reel and all she could do were watch the show, her sympathetic nervous system electric, her feeling chills upon every thanks she felt she had thought, her eyes moistly gleaming with

tears of rejoice, tears forming upon her bottom eyelid brims as she thanked Jesus for her breakfast biscuit sandwich and good chewable ice.

Toda, *toda*, over and over she thought it, *toda*—"thank you" in proper and actual Hebrew, stuff Israelis said over and around where they were at, over in Israel-Palestine.

תודה

Toda.

תודה תודה תודה
תודה ישוע

Toda, toda—toda, Yeshua.

Itragene was so out of it, sitting there in the Carrollton Unit School parking lot. She was very, very manic and she was feeling everything so intensely, every thought a canyon of meaning and the alluvial byproduct of a river of mighty purpose that only she could ride.

She is grateful for her girls, but especially her Maddie.

Itragene has these fraternal twin girls, her relationships so different with each one, always. She's always been co-dependent with Charlice, or Maddie, a girl's girl, and she barely ever spoke to Itragene Jr. at all (when they were on speaking terms back in the day), them not having much in common, first off—Itragene Jr. was more a quarterback than a cheerleader like her girls' girl sister and mother—the two of them almost estranged they had such little contact, Itragene Sr. and Itragene Jr., Itragene Jr.'s choice, this icy and distanced relationship, not our Itragene Sr.'s. Big Iddy was like that, thought she was better than everybody else, but especially her mama and twin sister.

People called Itragene's offspring Charlice "Maddie" for no apparent reason, and they called Itragene Jr., her other twin daughter child, "Iddy," "Big Iddy," specifically. Maddie lived with her mama and Big Iddy was a "Tuscaloosa girl," a self-described "Classic City

cowgirl," lived in Tuscaloosa, Big Iddy did, lived big, what they called 'round there a "high-dollar" life, fancy-like, right on Lake Tuscaloosa in a big house she owned, paid for in cash, having almost nothing to do with her immediate family. Big Iddy had a big wraparound deck and everything, the Alabama ritz. Big Iddy had a big house with a wraparound Alabama ritz deck and everything. Maddie and Itragene, on the other hand, unlike Maddie's sister, they barely had enough money to get by and intoxicate themselves to ease the pain.

She was thinking about Maddie, how she had to pick up Maddie.

She had lost it, that March 1994, lost control of the narrative and her mind like she truly never had before. Sitting there in that parking lot, Itragene was amidst the nervous breakdown of her lifetime, dwarfing her first and only true and sustained manic psychosis she had endured in her eighteenth year.

Her brain meat was heavy feeling, and she could taste it and she felt sick; she felt toxic; her brain was going so fast and so far, her hearing so many voices and the warped bang of sheet metal falling stories and stories down an elevator shaft in the tallest building in the world she could conceive, her brain matters sheet metal, so bright and loud, banging all around in her as she descended further into madness.

It is so bright inside of me...

She'd been up for days at that point, the Pickens County police scanner sparrow. She had stayed up all night the night before for the third night in a row, drinking Folger's coffee and her Diet Cokes, smoking her long-ass Virginia Slim cigarettes, eating some Snickers bars and Jiffy peanut butter for sustenance; she had consumed her drinks, smokes and minimal food while listening to the police scanner, staring off into the yonder.

She would often read and write, think.

These were the things that she did normally during her treasured late nights. She would always sit at a little table with a police scanner sizzling and filling the room's air with jagged sounds, this reading and writing, this thinking that she would carry on with, and did it all the

time. She was carrying about her studies and intellectual, spiritual pursuits with a new, special and pointed, manic fervor in recent days' unfolding, her losing her mind, pretty much, losing it fully around Sunday morning after having not slept for 72 hours, and it was now, then, Wednesday. She was not well.

She'd sit there next to the police scanner in a big bay window at a little table, musing and writing, her reasoning on paper in no. 2 graphite and blue ballpoint pen, sometimes with a manual typewriter, an Underwood 315, a popular Spanish model her father got her as a teen, one of the few kind things he did being buying her books and other materials for intellectual work—better that way, he figured, as she'd be occupied and not talking to him. He hated her, daddy did.

Having been up for days, she was *also* popping diet pills that had stimulant properties and she had been popping them back for a few weeks, with increasing frequency, her having fallen in love with phentermine, or "Phen-Phen," which is a legal form of speed everybody was all about then, and it was a key diet pill active ingredient, everybody on it around then, everybody losing so many pounds and nobody admitting how, them rapidly oscillating from balloon bodies to walking skeletons and back again to their original, round state. They said they were running, but you never saw any joggers, really, not in and about any town in Pickens County; most of these people couldn't afford treadmills, and the ones who could, they would never. People kept selling their clothes to each other and gaining the weight back, buying back the larger clothes that they had sold to a large person who, now, all of a sudden, would be very skinny, it all a real little economy for the body dysmorphia of Pickens County residents and their little legal go-go pills.

She loved her Phen-Phen, a god-awful, rough amphetamine analogue, not clean like something such as dextroamphetamine, which she loved, too, and would sometimes score from her daughter's best friend who always had pills, a man called Columbus Chulahoma. She had had fenfluramine a few times.

The last nights, she stayed up, did not sleep at all. Itragene, those last days, would sit almost non-stop. No sleep, none—just police scanner, Phen-Phen, coffee, soda, cigarettes and her other *matériels,* such as her pencils and record player, her gear for long nights lost in her seeking.

She'd sit where her police scanner was in the bay window, sitting at her little table. There, all night and into the morning, she'd sit and sit, and all of Gordo could see her, the poor ole' crazy thing surrounded by glass and no curtains ever pulled, her on display, there, like a performance artist ahead of her time. The view on the right side of the bay window is blocked by a giant cattail plant that has been there for decades, but otherwise Itragene's got a clean view of downtown Gordo from that bay window and Gordo has a clean view of her. She was long a downtown Gordo fixture, Itragene in that window of hers, the window of her sunroom in her prominent home downtown at the end of Main Street, Itragene's Gordo Garden.

She'd sit there in this giant, beautiful, feature bay window in a room that was mostly windows, a huge room that was her favorite room, the sunroom, which is where her yellow, floral couch that she'd had since the 1970s was, nestled into the back, outermost right corner of the room where window met window, creating an isosceles triangle of negative space behind the couch, a set up where it made space behind the couch, where, in that negative space, was also a stand where her record player was prominently situated betwixt the windows, behind the couch, easily reached from the couch while on her back, the record needle, as well; across from the couch was a wood-encased television with bright yellow fabric speakers on its sides, and the TV wood box had a radio and tape player atop it.

Next to the couch was where they kept the baby crib. There were no infants around; the baby crib was where her daddy had spent his latter, twilight days. He was an amputee. Her daddy didn't have any legs, or, rather, didn't have his shins. Thaddeus Jr. had rested in that baby crib during the day, sitting with Itragene all day, him fitting inside

the crib perfectly. He'd be propped up on pillows in that baby crib they got at a flea market near Birmingham, over in Hoover, watching TV or blankly staring at the solid wall opposite the crib.

The carpet in the sunroom was shag and bright, garden-yellow green, the room mostly surrounded by windows like an indoor lawn, Itragene's own. When the sun hit the house interior the way it does sometimes, rays of light reveal dust floating in the room above this bright and tall carpet, she would stare into the light, seeing the face of her god.

She had lived there with her father, Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr., since her Wyatt died of ALS in 1976, the girls sixteen at the time, Itragene in her late forties. Wyatt McDaniel was even worse to her than her daddy, and she was happy when he died. Wyatt thought she thought she was better than everybody else and he would beat her and the kids drunk; by the time of his diagnosis with his progressive, terminal illness, the abusive persona he had cultivated became trapped in a body which could not perform basic tasks of taking care of himself. He wilted and died and nobody missed him.

She went to a disco in Birmingham the night the doctors delivered what they assumed would be regrettable news, the news that Wyatt had succumbed to his ALS, but she hopped up in the waiting room at Druid City Hospital over in Tuscaloosa and clapped when they told her. She snorted Alabama coke and danced that night, the night Wyatt died; she went to Birmingham to dance alone, making it home days later, having had a great time. She was happy, relieved and pensive, joyous.

She married Wyatt Earl McDaniel—white trash, a Pentecostal, herself a Southern Baptist—against her father's wishes, tying the knot 1951 in front of the Biloxi Lighthouse on the Mississippi Gulf. She endured a decade of miscarriages before she had her twin girls in 1960.

1960, she was suddenly a mother to Charlice Pamela McDaniel and Itragene Belle McDaniel, Jr..

Itragene Jr. was just called Itragene the first three years of her life.

She would become a junior at Itragene's hand at age three. Our Itragene Sr. dubbed the girl child who was her namesake a "junior" in 1963, renaming her a "Jr." upon reading Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* that year, it moving her in some mysterious manner regarding the name of one of her children, reading the book upon publication, three years after those babies were born and she was losing her goddamn mind at that dark house with her monster of a husband, her speed days over, the psychotic depression engulfing her for most of the decade beyond irregular spurts where she scored stimulants, her only able to read a little bit, not taking care of herself, much less her children.

Most often, the kids would often eat baked beans and cheese toast.

As he had since she was a child, her father travelled a lot, up until 1989, when he lost the knee-down portion of his legs. Before he lost his legs March 1989, he was always in Montreal, he'd say, taking care of seemingly endless county commissioner business in Montreal, he'd say, there so much you'd think Montreal and Gordo has some sort of twin city exchange program. His final trip abroad, he went to Mexico, and that's when his legs disappeared, his only admitted trip to Mexico, which the family knew about only out of necessity because he got an infection in Mexico and their assistance was required in his transfer from a hospital in Matamoros, Tamaulipas, to one in the States over just across the border in Brownsville, Texas. Thaddeus had never mentioned going to Mexico and he simply never did, even after that—never mentioned Mexico, and, if you mentioned his one known trip there, he would give you the vacant stare with which upper crust Pickens Countians would warp reality, a vacant stare and a pretension that they have no idea what you're talking about, staring like this at you until you gave up in the pursuit of the relevant truth at hand. Dadday lost his legs in Mexico and Itragene had never known how—or *why*.

Daddy would always Look at her.

○ ✦ ○

She had heard it all on the police scanner starting around 3am, heard her coordinates for later in the morning, got signals intelligence — "SIGNIT" as she knew it to be called—regarding all that would set her morning agenda.

Itragene had driven to Carrollton to try and find her daughter Maddie, who had been arrested the night before for disorderly conduct, what Itragene had heard on the police scanner around 3am. Itragene knew they'd let her Maddie go the next morning, as the police always did.

Much of the time, the police scanner set her priorities for the day like this. She loved that police scanner almost as much as people around there loved their Face in the Window.

Itragene's Maddie had gone out drinking after her afternoon shift down at the Piggly Wiggly, which was the only shift she ever worked because everybody knew she was going to be drunk 8pm onwards and that she wasn't going to be awake until at least noon the next day, her putting in about twenty hours a week down at the Piggly Wiggly, right off Highway 82 when you first get into Gordo coming from Carrollton or Reform and up on that big hill that was there, just enough hours to say she had a job, everybody knowing her like they knew her mama, but in Maddie's case many also biblically having been acquainted. Maddie got around, such as it was how that Maddie made most of her real money and supported herself and her mama. She was a sex worker, though she rarely worked even that gig, just charging a lot when she did. She was gorgeous and came from a legacy family and could charge whatever she pleased. She worked around Pickens County and also had some clients in Mississippi—Columbus, Fair Hope—even as far as Palmetto in Alabama she'd go, north of Pickens, but she mostly worked in Tuscaloosa. If she used enough gas to and fro, she made clients pay travel expenses. In demand, she wasn't familiar with street work, a gorgeous if roughened woman with

piercing, ice-blue eyes, natural sandy blonde that was at times yellow and other platinum, depending on how stable she was.

Never charging her with prostitution, though everybody knew what she did for money besides work the cash register at Piggly Wiggly, the local authorities were always picking up her Maddie and sobering her up in a cell so she didn't do anything else the many evenings of her arrests to hurt herself, or generally anything shameful to embarrass her family any more than she already had in their eyes. They would throw her a Look. She was there so much that she even had “her own pillow” down at the jailhouse, even, one raggedy and nasty yellow throw pillow that the county sheriff kept in a desk drawer for her, all of it quite unsavory when you ponder it, the sheriff calling her “Pretty Miss Maddie” as he'd cuff her. She hated being talked to this way, more than being arrested itself, this manner of being spoken to something she truly hated, had nervous tics about it when she thought of it. She gritted her teeth through it and partly, passively chose in it all as her life in a manner that was more a surrender to it all than an opting for any of it as her path, this repeated local humiliation, repeatedly getting arrested for being rowdy, knowing there were no real consequences and that it was all a Pickens County game, none of it a kink for her but it was certainly some sort of backwoods fetish on the behalf of members of the Pickens County police forces, from the Gordo Police to the Carrollton Police and the Pickens County Sheriff's Office, too.

They had been on hard times since Thaddeus Jr. died, the Calloway patriarch.

Like with Itragene, Maddie was protected in some ways, abused in others, and all at the hands of the townspeople of these wicked little towns in Pickens, especially the ones with access to power, gossiping nonstop about her and her mama as they abusively oscillated between helping and harming them; many of these white people all felt they owed Thaddeus Jr. for his much celebrated service to the white race, but they were mad as hell at Itragene and her local daughter, Charlice the Maddie, for not keeping up appearances, for being as anti-racist as

their little white heads could figure given their identity and circumstance, mostly, and everybody figured they were fine with faggots and such, too, which they found typical and clearly also unacceptable.

It had started two nights ago. The Henry stuff.

Itragene was known to have "enthusiasms," but this was a full-blown break with reality. She had *really* been talking to the ghost of Henry Wells the last couple of days, really talking to him—sometimes vigorously muttering to herself.

Henry came to her in a vision, as he always had appeared over her life during "rough patches," appearing and winking at her and he had seemed really friendly, a friendly ghost, a friendly familiar Black man whom she could trust, and she could trust so few Pickens people—Bessie Jones and her mama Alma, the Calloway domestic help, them and Maddie, and that's it, and Alma she hadn't spoken to in years, and Maddie had a bad habit of getting drunk and pilled up and telling everybody's business to people, so she was not the most secure confidante, though reliably there for you, listening in earnest and with concern and empathy even if she got fucked up later and betrayed your trust by intoxicated mistake—by 'naccident, as Maddie and many other locals mispronounced the word "accident."

There in the parking lot, right before she finally got out of her humongous Lincoln Town Car, Itragene swallowed two translucent, bright orange, gel capsule diet pills.

She gulped.

Then, she truly started the process of getting out of the car—the *process* of getting out of the car. It was a *process* for her sorry body.

In regard to the process of getting out of the car, she had initiated liftoff.

Her house shoe hit the gravel of the parking lot; she whistled, "*phewww,"* as she pumped herself up off the driver's seat with her wrists in a hydraulic fashion—she was going "ph*ewwww*," whistling in the effort as she achieved air, all of it an effort, the process of getting

out of the car.

Her house shoe, a formerly pink one that was mostly black and threadbare and that just looked like a dirty sock with some even dirtier plastic padding on its underside, one of two of a dirty pair of house slippers, hit the gravel and then she climbed out, slipper having hit gravel, contact made with the world outside of the Town Car, her revealing in this maneuver to the whole world, at this stage in the process of getting out of the car her cooter, showing them all her "moochie," as they also called it around there, showing all of Pickens County, Alabama, her whole goddamn cooter as she opened her legs wide and the muumuu she was wearing rode up her bird legs, revealing that she had a pair of stretched-out JCPenney panties on, a pair that she had had on for days, and she otherwise only wore this muumuu of hers, one with little chickens dancing all over it, a pale blue muumuu from K-Mart with bright yellow chickens on it, bright yellow dancing chickens.

"Hey, Mrs. McDaniel," a Carrollton Unit School student said to her, walking past towards the schoolhouse across the street, the wet, dew-covered, bluish gray standard-issue parking lot gravel crunching under foot.

"Hey, baby," Itragene replied, leaning against the car at this point amidst the broader process.

She was heaving at this stage in the process of getting out of the car, having closed the door and put her snatch away, trying to catch her breath. She gathered herself, lit a cigarette, which helped her vision line up, the first couple of puffs, a little more stimulation from the nicotine, her leaning there against the car, her vision having been quite blurry before—she was so delirious from not sleeping.

Goddamn, shit, she was thinking, fast, really fast: *Goddamn shit, goddamn shit*.

She set off up the street, heading north towards the square.

She was carrying her Diet Coke can with a paper towel stuck to the bottom, which she had put on the can to collect condensation after

transferring chewable ice from her Jack's Styrofoam cup to her aluminum can, as she always did, the square-folded paper towels getting stuck to the cans and her leaving a trail of them behind her like a slug but it was Bounty paper towels rather than slime. You could probably find her if she got lost in the woods, as there'd be a trail of Bounty paper towels leading you straight to her, right to her.

She was crazy, she was, deliriously wandering up the road looking for her drunk and crazy daughter, who was the town whore in the square, freshly out the jailhouse, who had been dancing for the whole town to see to the controversial and horny Madonna song "Erotica."

It's so cold, she thought—*Got*damn, it's so cold, she kept thinking; My fuckin' foot hurts, she was thinking; she had gangrene in her left big toe.

It was so cold, she kept on annoyingly and aggressively noticing, thinking, *So goddamn cold*, over and over.

It's so go*t*damn cold, she thought, and other variations damning the cold and her place in it, walking towards the county square wearing barely any clothes, the March-morning damp wind whipping through her skinny, bruised legs.

People around town would gossip that Itragene stole the house she lived in. It was a rumor that had some truth to it. The story about as to how she inherited the house was known around the county and state by the tagline "The Flat Sisters of Gordo," it a famed tale like the Face in the Window, the townspeople loving to give titles to gruesome events like that ghost story lynching window that they had and what had happened over in Gordo with Itragene and the house, which all led to Itragene finding herself with a house in her very own name, though her father left her nothing and she had never been well enough to work.

This was a house her daddy had rented for a long time, since the

1960s. At a point, as well and importantly, he had stopped paying rent. He never explained himself about that nor as to why such a wealthy man was even a renter to begin with, verily the richest man in Pickens County. Thaddeus was said to have had at least eleven million in the bank. Everybody assumed that, upon his death, it would be there and be split evenly among Itragene and her siblings, all five of them: Vonnie, Petunia, Leopold, Archibald and Amicille.

They rented from two rich elderly twin sisters in Gordo, the Johnson sisters, Emetrice and Ambrosia, who lived right across the street from Itragene and her family in their own prominent downtown Gordo home. They owned the house where the Calloways stayed, and they simply let the Calloways stay at some point, even though Itragene had stopped sending in her father's rent checks. This was a terrible pressure and embarrassment for our Itragene. Thaddeus Jr. stopped paying for anything at all altogether at a point, matter of fact. He said the county owned him. It ran in the family—he was fucking crazy, too, but mean and hateful, as well, worse as he got older, as tends to happen with aging narcissists, the man a true psychopath. As he deployed Itragene Sr. to beg county-wide for everything they'd need to survive, she found herself hoping that, in the particular case of the house, if she didn't address the problem, by the Lord's grace, it would go away, and, sure enough, it did, no words exchanged and never a rent check sent in again.

Everybody in and around Pickens County said that the money was gone and that the Johnson sisters took pity on them, like a lot of people did.

And then it happened.

Having let them stay in the house for some time, the Johnson sisters perished of this Earth after a transfer truck ripped through their front yard and ran right over them, June 1993, on Mule Day. The two sisters were famously flattened while they were busying about in one of their flower beds, the big rig running over them and their fresh-from-the-nursery hostess plants. They had the life squashed out them.

Upon their unfortunate demise—being flattened by a chicken truck in their downtown Gordo front yard just across from Itragene's own household, and on Mule Day, of all occasions, people downtown at the festival becoming hysterical when they saw the truck run over them and crash into the Johnson sisters' own beautiful sunroom that they had like Itragene did—it came to be known that they left the house to not only the Calloway family, but to Itragene in particular.

A nervous attorney had informed Itragene of all of this, sweating bullets as he informed her one 1993 late-June day that the house was, by then, hers, him speaking to her from what was then officially and legally her front doorstep. This legal representative for Emetrice and Ambrosia Johnson was so apparently distraught of a kind, sweating not as much due to heat as the feeling that he had a gun to his head while it also happened to be hot outside. Stumbling through explaining why she was now the owner of a house, he pretty much told Itragene that they had felt the worst for her and that they figured the whole family could make use of the house, but especially her; this was their supposed reasoning giving her this giant and prominent house, telling her, pretty much, that they felt it needed to be in Itragene's name, the deed, since she was the most pathetic and sure enough disabled one.

They were "Godly women," it was often said about these prominent Gordo and Pickens County residents, the Johnson sisters, and this sweaty attorney said that when handing Itragene the deed: "they were Godly women."

"They sure were, Godly women, *mhmm*, sure," Itragene said, hungrily grabbing the deed and closing the front door of her own house.

Thaddeus Jr. dead the earlier in the same year as the flattening of the sisters from Gordo, it seemed like it was Itragene who was the only one in the Calloway family who had inherited anything at all from anybody, as well, though some suspected her sister Amicille had gotten an inheritance, thougth Amicille denied this. When Thaddeus Jr. died, Itragene's eldest sister, Amicille, who lived in Birmingham, she oddly

and mysteriously developed the ability to conspicuously spend extreme amounts of money, far more than she had before, she and her husband well-to-do already, but not Vanderbilt rich. They bought a private, small jet airplane out of nowhere, and there was no money left for *any* of the siblings, Amicille denying she got any inheritance whatsoever, a look of terror in her eye, something off, Itragene thought.

Something had happened, and the money Itragene and Maddie expected to live off of simply wasn't there.

Itragene considered her home ownership a miracle.

Commerce Avenue—Itragene's finished the involved process of getting out of the car.

Itragene and her daughter Maddie were within eyesight of one another, yet again, there in downtown Carrollton, both unaware, again, too, as they had been minutes before with both of them across from one another on the roundabout, not seeing one another yet again, even though they are both ultimately looking for one another so they could go home together to Gordo; they were looking but not paying much attention.

Maddie was on the opposite side of Commerce Avenue as Itragene, in front of the used car dealership situated after the furniture store on the corner of the square and right before you get to Carrollton Unit School, walking south in an angry trot, her crack out, and her mama was going north on the opposite side of the avenue and also walking the opposite direction, dragging herself south, both of them in their own worlds, not looking where they were, improperly dressed and too exposed to the cool and damp morning air, and neither saw the other, the second time they had missed one another in a mere fifteen minutes.

Some more minutes pass.

Down a ways from the county square on Commerce Ave., Maddie has paid for a pack of long Virginia Slims, the same brand her mother smokes; and up at the square where it meets Phoenix Avenue, having finally reached this spot, Itragene is wiping her brow and taking the last sip of her Diet Coke, putting a cigarette out in the empty can, setting her varied refuse next to her foot on the dewy county square lawn grass and mud, square-folded Bounty paper towel included, signature Itragene Sr. residue.

With great effort, Itragene stands up from crouching and carefully putting down on the dewy earth the can and wet paper towel and all and she's looking up at the Face in the Window.

How am I gonna get my ass up there? She was then thinking, examining the reflective street-sign that was nailed to the edifice, an arrow which pointed at that directly the smudge on the window that looked like a wailing face.

Enter the ghost of Henry Wells.

Yes, enter the ghost of Henry Wells—or, at least, Itragene's idea of what a dead Black man from the Reconstruction-era South would be like as a specter a hundred years or so after his lynching and at the site of his purported murder at the hands of a white lynch mob.

'I wanna know how the hell I got up in that window, myself! That ain't even me and my pretty face, a shame the town can't see it, my pretty face,' "Henry Wells" pops up and "says" this.

She's hearing voices, especially the voice of the ghost she considers a friend, who is at the time also a man with whom she was rapidly and pathologically "falling in love"—and that is Mr. Henry Wells himself.

'That ain't even me and my pretty face!'

There she is in her dancing chicken muumuu, surrounded by hungry people and their Mennonite Bread, standing still amidst the commotion, the Mennonite Bread hubbub, her like a deranged '90s pop star in a music video on MTV or VH1, just there standing there, still, the modern world flying by all around her at rapid speeds.

‘Shame they can’t see my pretty face!’

In that moment, it is just her and Henry. The Face in the Window winks at her as she looks up at it.

‘You like my pretty feet, girl?’

Exhaust has begun to fill the air, as well as music from the same vehicle; it’s “California Dreamin’” by the Mamas and the Papas that’s playing, and real loud.

Music is amplified in its beauty and all songs have hidden messages for Itragene in such a state as the state she is in, this song totally enveloping her, a brim that is the surround and a sensual boundary that is the square’s sense of place.

The music has already started and it has gone through the sound and all there could hear it carry, all present also breathing in the vehicle’s exhaust, too.

> All the leaves are brown…
> (All the leaves are brown…)

“Mrs. McDaniel? Are you doin' all right?”

A gentleman has approached her, and he asked her that, a man with whom she used to go to church when she used to go.

The man is carrying a briefcase, a nice one, having some taste—refreshing around there. The friendly man waited for a response from Itragene, setting his briefcase down on a ragged and irregular but big enough patch of the lawn's many varying sod patches, just big enough to be a nice spot for the bag, the rest all mud.

They know one another and she likes him, and it is mutual, him finding Itragene terribly pitiable and truly entertaining, and he is the long-term boyfriend of her daughter’s best friend in town, the man called Columbus Chulahoma, who is a white man who has posed as a Native American in Pickens County for years, a man also called “The Little Indian in the McShan Meadow,” for people in the area think him Native because he had lied to them and said he was, him living in a little tin trailer situated up on a bunch of stilts in a big field that floods

all the time that they all erroneously call around there a “meadow” even though it is just a field that is next to a creek that floods all the time.

Inside the head of Itragene, Henry Wells has been plainly visible, dancing a great dance on a great architectural feature in her mind's eye, which she’s being calling “the Portico” for days, this architectural feature she’s hallucinating. By then, Henry is just a dancin' Bojangles in the mind of this white woman from Gordo, a presence, a man who she couldn’t get out of her head, no choice in the matter as to what she hallucinates and how it looks. She was not racist, but the things going on in her head were, at times, so humiliating, or would be, if anybody found out, that something she would feel in the immediate aftermath later that spring, when she does get a bit better, recovers and miraculously lives; bipolar I is an often-terminal illness.

If I was in LA…
(If I was in LA…)

The song is still all around her.

They sing the initials “LA,” the Mamas and the Papas, and this sequence of letters—L-A—reminds her of an old Alabama joke where they call lower Alabama “LA.” She wants to go there with Henry, lower Alabama, her sweet Henry, who has been dancing in her mind to the song; she wants to go to the beach with her Black boy, her man; she wants to go there with Henry arm-in-arm, head towards the warm Gulf of Mexico with its hurricanes that sent tornadoes their way every year. She’s on the beach and green and salty waves lick her on the sand. *One must* enjoy themselves. Henry prepares the sandwiches, for they are at the beach for the day.

“*Stopped into a church*,” she said, slightly singing along to the Mamas and the Papas song infiltrating every nook and cranny of the county square.

I passed along the way.

…pretend to pray.
(I pretend to pray...)

The song is continuing, and this friendly man is standing there with our Itragene.

Preacher like the cold...
(Preacher like the cold...)

"Knows I'm gonna stay... " twittered the man.

The man is called Mr. John Henry and he is the popular local mortician, a lanky, tall, pale gentleman with a thin mustache and fine but olive skin, a pale man who tans well in the summer, and he has very taut skin, his face like a latex glove on a hand one size too big for it, the only mortician in Pickens, his funeral parlor located on Highway 82 between Reform and Gordo, a man trying to meet her halfway, him singing along too, playfully dancing a little with his shoulders.

"… *on my knees,"* John Henry sang and shimmied with a thin-lipped, sweet and good smile.

He is neither good-looking nor unattractive but somehow above average in his looks, something to do with accessories. He doesn't look at people, but he pays attention. He's a good guy, one of the few around there making decent lives in a place where they swam in polluted rivers with hard-shelled gator-people.

Itragene then, amazingly, is down on her knees.

And at that absurd and also pathetic sight, her barely wearing anything in the cold and getting soaking wet from being on the ground, mumbling to a song playing on the radio in the county square on some noxious speaker and enacting its lyrics live—

Got down on my knees,
I pretend to pray...
(I pretend to pray...)

—car exhaust everywhere. He's looking at her and Mr. Henry's

concern grows greater, the mild concern blossoming into full-out worry, which is concern's more pointed partner in attention.

She was just soaked, wet and dripping, a saturated paper towel of a person. He was so worried about her, then, hadn't seen her in a few weeks and did not know she was in such a sorry state, which was very apparent.

The song continues, the crowd chattering, the gossiping, drink-sipping crowd wandering around the two of them—hungry, hungry people and their Mennonite Bread, big wallets out and giant purses open. A lot of these purses and wallets and other accessories about the square in motion, many of these are locally made personal carry items, and they are vaguely Native American-themed, or so it's thought, nobody really having any idea, and the accessories are made by the white man called Columbus Chulahoma, who is also gay, as John Henry is, as well; John Henry and Columbus Chulahoma, the two of them had slept in the same bed the night prior, as they do most nights, but they do not acknowledge one another on the square, and they never do, for it is dangerous.

"We should be nicer about Henry, I think... We should be honest. Somebody should *do* *<u>something</u>*. We should be true," Itragene said to the mortician in a plastic, absent way that trailed off at the end as he lent her his hand and pulled her back to her feet, her voice light and congested, rattling.

She stands up from her kneeling.

"*Phewwww,*" she whistles as she achieves liftoff, all part of the process of standing up.

She has now stood up. She is on her feet.

She is covered in pieces of grass blades and soaked in dew. There is a big green grass stain on the side of her body unto which she had knelt hardest and ground her stick of a knee into earth, her right side, a stain there on one of the yellow chickens dancing near her knee on her blue muumuu. Upon establishing her center of gravity standing, a bloody bandage promptly falls from somewhere under her muumuu,

just peels off and just falls right off of one of her ever-present and slow-to-heal wounds, landing on the ground next to her disgusting right-foot house slipper. At her feet is a revolting palette of elements: there's the nude-colored bandage that has just fallen off, and it's bloody, has coagulated brown blood splotched on both the front and back sides, and there's her dirty and near-black pink house slippers and, also, the spring-green but sparsely rooted Alabama crab grass, so much mud from the dew on the lawn that was mostly dirt, Henry's Garden not well-maintained after Thaddeus Jr.'s death, the "lawn" mostly muck and trash.

Another woman has walked up, a large woman who is truly unfortunately sized, as wide as a county road, she is, a three-seat backside silhouette, a woman capable of hiding a quarter-of-a-dozen people behind her, a big woman in a denim skirt big enough to have a tent revival under. She smells like shower soap. Everybody loves her hair, her head so full and with so many curls, which are artificial, but people act as if God gave her this feature. With her dark brown, long and tightly curled, permed hair that always looks wet (but it's the effect is just a lot of water-soluble hair gel and Ozone layer-killing hairspray), one of the most popular Pentecostals in town, this bulldozer of a lady, she is a popular woman around Pickens amongst the townspeople, a steadfast Pentecostal woman who is also a science teacher at Carrollton Unit School and a gifted singer, her "Silent Night" rendition at the annual school Christmas gala leaving not an eye in the crowd dry. She is known to handle snakes, speaking in tongues at church and holding up the same snakes she'd show her science classes as part of primary education—science she taught but without the evolution part. This woman is Mrs. Plethora Sanders, a Carrollton teacher living in Reform, like a lot of Pentecostals, just off of Highway 82, downtown Reform.

"We could all be a lil' nicer about everything and to everybody, couldn't we?"

She said that, that Mrs. Plethora Sanders.

“That's right, Mrs. Sanders—” went the mortician, who was quickly and subsequently cut off by Itragene.

“‘Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you,’” Itragene told them with great enthusiasm, quoting part of Bible 2.0, staring at her conversation partners with a glassy but friendly look, it a deranged but friendly a look; it was a disconcerting face that she was making, really, all of her distinguished, sharp Calloway features appearing in their worst, exhausted light.

Itragene busies about her body, making small grunting noises of expended effort when she navigates her own person.

After she tells them this, when she quotes Bible 2.0 to the people who she knew prayed in Bible 2.0, there is an awkward and heavy pause, and after a highly orchestrated retrieval of her lighter from her muumuu pockets and the lighting of a new cigarette, exhaling smoke from her nose and holding her long-ass cigarette in her right hand by her side, nearly singeing one of her muumuu chickens, she speaks.

Itragene said, “Ephesians 4:32.”

Somebody else has started approaching and overhears them talking, having just parked her car, her own gigantic Lincoln Town Car. It’s the preacher's wife who had been stuck a couple of cars behind Itragene about twenty minutes or so earlier—the square roundabout is still so busy, *people running across the road real quick-like* on all sides and cars just coming and going round and round they go. Her body is fat but unremarkably, standard rich Pickens big, but not so large that she needs to gauge doorways and hallways widthwise before entering them as Mrs. Plethora Sanders has to, but her head, Sister Jackson’s head, well... Mrs. Sister Jackson has a phenomenal head, and it is remarkable. It is bigger than anybody else’s in town and her face that was on the front of her head... she has a huge mug—just humongous—a big copper plate of a face, beyond moon-faced as they’d say around there. Little disturbing little eyes, too—bright yellow at the pupil and a contrasting dark blue nearer iris’s edge, and

that combination didn't look right—tiny, darting, beady, glowing, cat eyes-in-the-dark, bioluminescent-seeming and piercing blue eyes with hazel centers at the pupil, and her face is always scrunched in permanent judgment and yucking, tutting and tisk-tisking, clucking and snorting, clicking, smacking and harrumphing, her face a soundboard of being sickened, disgusted, and not hiding it. She made ugly faces. She would give the Look in unremarkable, average ways.

Moments pass as she approaches them, her looking at them.

"Hey, Mrs. Sister Jackson," the teacher and mortician said in unison.

Mrs. Sister Jackson had looked at them as she approached them, had been looking their way, at them and through them.

The sister speaks.

"Wh*ay*le I *do* indeed appreciate your words, Mrs. McDaniel…"

Mrs. Sister Jackson was saying something sharply in Itragene's direction while fiddling with something in her purse, riffling through her purse, pulling out a butterscotch candy and popping it out of its transparent, golden and crinkly cellophane wrapping and slamming it past her wrinkle-lined and taught lips into her pie hole, continuing, sucking on her candy, rotating it, now, against her tiny bottom front teeth.

"... I would be mistaken if I didn't urge that you do *quote the* act*y*ual *Bible*."

Mrs. Sister Jackson has her bible copy in hand—the English (as in England) version of Bible 2.0—the sister has reached in and grabbed it from a side pocket of her enormous lavender purse, one with giant amber plastic buttons, a large-print New King James Version of the Christian Holy Bible, a physical book comparable in size to a small moving box or young child.

She's fingering through her Christian Bible, Bible 2.0, Mrs. Sister Jackson, the giant words of Christ in red, riffling in Bible, fingering through Bible—she fingered through, stopped at the appropriate spot, pompously reading aloud in a voice that is like a beetle caught in a

window pane between the glass and screen, a buzzing that sounds like Zs in a fight, and her voice is also like sand being poured onto crinkled aluminum foil at a vacation bible school arts and crafts table, irregularly punctuated, a high frequency and crunchy, static in her voice. Her vocal fry was that of crusty and dry catfish; she always sounded like she needed a glass of water.

"And b-ay y*ee* k*ayn*do'w*uhn* to an*uh*ther, t*eyah*d*hearted*, forgiving one'n'ther, even's G*ah*d for Christ's s*ay*ke *halfvth* forgiven'*u*."

That's the set of noises she made and the order she made them in, and that is what she said, Mrs. Sister Jackson.

You had to look just right when you listened or you'd miss what Mrs. Sister Jackson had just said; you'd have to do some lip-reading, the sounds she makes just not intelligible.

"I just love Ephesians," Mrs. Sanders, the science teacher, said.

A crow flies between them all and past them. They can feel the air moved by the bird.

Inspired by all this talk about Ephesians, very casually and quickly, Mrs. Sanders has now started beautifully humming the hymn "Soldiers of Christ Arise."

She's humming "Soldiers of Christ Arise," she's humming and singing multiple songs at once; she's blending the hummed "Soldiers of Christ Arise" melody, which is one that has to do with Ephesians, with an articulated singing of the chorus of "Amazing Grace" atop it. She's live, she's remixing; she's just a vessel for God, she'd tell you about her gifts.

This would happen with her on occasion, the public singing. It doesn't bother people when she sings at them, as it would be just so beautiful, her voice a treasure. Well, it does at that moment and more generally bother Mrs. Sister Jackson, stuff like this bothering her, a woman for whom it is never the time nor place for anything if she isn't the one doing it and especially if she didn't start whatever it is that is getting all of the attention.

She is like, in her head, "All she wonts is some attention, *hmmph,"*

as soon as Plethora starts singing, and, out loud, she is like, "*Ughhmmph, mmmmph, hmmph*."

She tisk-tisked out loud and lightly belched.

Mrs. Sanders sings; passersby stop, most of the folks already familiar with her singing. People pause in awe. They've heard it before. People start humming along and tapping their feet, slapping their thighs and bopping their little heads that the Lord hath given them. The crowd begins with a whimper and they're getting going, and its' getting louder. Their hums becoming sung notes and their tapping becomes ecstatic, them reaching up to god and some even trembling.

"The Holy Spirit is here!"

A man said this holding two loaves of Mennonite Bread.

He is now putting his bread on the ground and he is then holding his arms up in praise of Jesus.

About three minutes and a three-quarters pass by the end of it, the singing.

She sang and sang.

Mrs. Sanders was alternating between hymns further after "Amazing Grace," as she was attracting a crowd, getting some nice attention, her taking all that gathering of folks as encouragement, and she kept on singing, leaned harder into the moment, going on, always returning it to the main themes of Ephesians and tune of the hymn she started with, "Soldiers of Christ Arise."

"Soldiers of Ch*riiiiist*, ... *ah*h*r*ize," she had sang it like that, with her own little fun spin on it, her singing "arise" as an impressive yodel-vibrato meld, yodeling in an Evangelical tremolo, sounds she artfully combined, the "r" somehow and skillfully articulated from the back of her fundamentalist throat, not unlike in the secular French and it was real redneck English.

"*Ah*h*r*ize"—like that, in the throat, she sang, she yodel-vibrato melded.

So, she sings like this, switching between and layering different songs but regularly and rhythmically returning to "Soldiers of Christ

Arise." She is like a DJ of Christian hymns but she can do all the voices herself, and, finally, after about as long as a song would go on the radio, she is ending with the chorus of the Christian pop hit that is on a bunch of commercials on the TV at the time, a Christian pop hit by Twila Paris called "God is in Control."

Everybody knew this song, even if they hated Jesus, as it was truly everywhere, nowhere safe from this earworm.

And with her, the crowd had joined in the finale: "GODdddd-uh'z IS*SS* IN CONTROL!"

They were hollering, a redneck Greek chorus that didn't explain anything in any classic sense of a chorus as much as it confused matters instead: "GODdddd-uh'z IS*SS* IN CONTROL! WE BELIEVE THAT HIS CHILD*REN*. WILL. NOT. BE. FORSAK*E*Nnnnn*N*! GOD*DDDDdddd-z-uh'z*-I*S* I*N* CONT*ROL*! Whoah-h, ho-*oh*, oh, GOD IS IN CON*TROLLLLLL*L. Whoa, *oh,* oh, GOD IS IN CON*TROLLLLLL*!"

The people clap at the end of the varied performance and Mrs. Sanders says to them all that this was all just another instance of her being nothing more than a vessel for God. People shake their heads and do their Amens and agree.

"By faith alone."

"Amen."

"Just a vessel."

"Take no pride, Amen."

"Don't admire me—love the song and the words of God and worship Him," Mrs. Sanders said.

"Covet not these gifts! Thank you, Sister Plethora."

"What a voice."

"Such a shame, should be on TV and the radio... "

Mild applause, and the shuffling begins, the walking around the square, and then there's all the Mennonite Bread, too, everywhere and all around the place.

There's that dang Face in the Window, like always.

"Henry" has been looking onwards from the window at it all, wailing face in-tact, and, beneath the window, Mennonites have been struggling to keep their bread stands full, hauling it from their truck beds and sweating, looking at the townspeople, them, the Mennonites, looking down on them just like the townspeople looked down on them, mirroring the Look and lost in the funhouse, the ill regard mutual.

It was all a competition when it came to Jesus and people would just Look at each other in hypocritical judgment, and they were never embarrassed. If their hell is real, it'll be an eternal staring contest that occupies them for all Time.

Everybody throws the Look at one another. They mill about, piddle, chit chat and say not more than jack shit. People look around, amble about. They look at each other.

Itragene was barely there, barely there at all with them, and she has been talking to Henry Wells in her head, the background soundtrack both the singing and the vehicle that was still blasting music even as the community came together to sing at Jesus, so loud, all of it, all of them, and all of that—all of these sounds had overlapped in the characteristically loud square—Simon and Garfunkel's "Sound of Silence" is coming on.

> Hello, darkness, my old friend...

It's so loud, everything in the surround, the whole sound.

Moments occur and the song eases its way through the transpiration of life and its business in the square, and the track is a bit into itself by some seconds or so.

> ...the vision that was planted in my brain, still remains, in the sound of silence.
>
> In restless dreams, I walked alone.
> Narrow streets of cobblestone.
>
> ... 'Neath the halo of a street lamp...
> ... the cold and damp...
> ...the flash of a neon *light* that *split the night*.

Henry Wells, visible to all, in a flash is he, for he is caught forever wailing, for his visage had been printed by a flash of lighting on the old county courthouse windah.

She knew this man, Itragene, in a queer way, knows Henry Wells. He was such a bright light in her life, this dead, formerly enslaved man who they had murdered in Pickens County and he did, indeed, haunt this place; spirits are a matter of material that accretes, *one must* know.

> Hear my words so that I may teach you.
> Take my arms so that I may reach you.

The vehicle with the loud music is a big and suspicious van that belongs to a man and the van belongs to a man called Tom, who is the local medicine man, and his vehicle—a van with a bunch of spray painted landscapes full of happy black-and-white cows that are feeding milk bottles to pleasantly good and happy baby piglets, the bottles in their hooves that look like human fingers; there are five cows total on the van, and the piglets, some of which run in fields in addition to the ones being nursed, just too-many-dozens-to-count—is parked across the street in front of the fourth, modern courthouse that they use for actual courthouse stuff, the law.

> ... like silent raindrops fell, and echoed...
> ... the sound of silence...

The medicine man, the one called Tom, Tom McGee, is getting ready to sell cow and pig bone marrow "Spam"—"A real and contemporary spin on a modern, American tradition!"—and he also has this "rattlesnake butter" stuff that he's got, which is more oil than butter, coming in used and variously-sized mason jars he buys in sets at the Columbus Goodwill over in Lowndes County across the Mississippi state border, where he lives and drives in from, "good for anything from back aches to hemorrhoids," he'd say about the

rattlesnake butter in a megaphone, scream it from atop the van where he climbs up on the roof once he is situated and has his products displayed—and so much exhaust—the whole square is decibels above what's healthy for the human ear, particulate thick in the air and the van's excessive exhaust is sticking in their beaten-up respiratory systems. It's truly louder than a New York City subway station, and when the train is arriving, at that.

> In restless dreams, I walked alone.
> Narrow streets of cobblestone...

The hubbub continues. The square is abuzz. Some bit of time passes and the "The Sound of Silence" (1963) is so loud and keeps happening in time because that's how songs go, second by second—the song is playing on the radio and it's really happening, as music is in its essence time in space, compositions of vibrations of space as time that make up the sound about a place that is, in part, the place itself.

> And in the naked light, I saw,
> Ten thousand people, maybe more,
> People talking without speaking,
> People hearing without listening,
> People writing songs that voices never shared,
> And no one dared
> Disturb the sound of silence

Tom turns off the radio on his cow piglet van. Then, the radio turned off, it was the sound of silence:...

... ...

The sound of silence—... ... ...

... ...

... It had been going on and oh so loudly... the song called The Sound of Silence... and *even* going on at *the same time* as the famous Mrs. Plethora Sanders as she was singing her tunes with the community. The sounds had been layered in chaos.

...

That's all before the radio goes silent; Mrs. Sister Jackson, who has just been saying something, stops speaking.

These two things occur simultaneously: the radio going silent and Mrs. Jackson's words finishing, same exact moment.

The sound of silence: ...

Seconds earlier, before the silence, Mrs. Sister Jackson had gone, LOUDLY, "Put *the armor of God!*" This is when Tom turns off his radio—at the same time as the preacher's wife speaks her word.

Itragene, by then, that morning, was counting such synchronicities—such as the music going off while the Sister Jackson locution ended in silence, too, at the same times—and calling them "a shekel" in a psychotic arithmetic she was doing that she called "Shekel Math."

It was just counting nonsense, what this Shekel Math business was, and this is how it goes: Mrs. Sister Jackson *has just said something* and Tom has *just turned off his radio*. There is the sound of silence. That is one shekel.

... ...

One shekel, that's one shekel... *One must* ... count their shekels...

... ...

All of a sudden, too much has been lining up for her to not notice—the sister clucking cutting short while the radio simultaneously went quiet—and there is this suspended and sharp moment of silence: *One shekel*...

Mrs. Sister Jackson has just been saying this thing about the armor of God, and her statement has finished at the exact same moment in which the medicine man called Tom has just turned off his radio. *That's a shekel*...

The same moment happens 1,000 times for her; Itragene is counting in her head.

Over and over again this moment occurs in the sight and sound within Itragene's mind and body, her whole sensory apparatus stunned into this multiplying moment.

She is thinking this: The radio going off and Eunice saying that at the same time, that was something else! THAT IS NOT NOTHING. IT'S... it is Jesus talking to me. It's a shekel. One must count their shekels...

She thought to herself about the counting after she acknowledged in her thoughts the simultaneity of the radio going off and Mrs. Sister Jackson clucking.

○ ✦ ○

This is the psychotic arithmetic of "Shekel Math."

For our Itragene, one shekel = one thing that matters and that counts, such as a synchronistic moment of silence. The synchronicity that morning had been more than one loud thing having gone quiet together simultaneously, two things, in this case there in the square that morning, out there in this world where she is, both things that are germane to the moment, for her.

Shekel Math—you had to look just right.

It was, in fact, as of that morning, March 16, 1994, that all of this Shekel Math business started for her. By the time she was standing in the square, she had just really formalized it, and just hours before. She did not concoct this alone, she felt, but learned it from a persona in her head that was a projection of her acute manic psychosis, *i.e.*, a hallucination. She was hearing voices and seeing things that were not there.

I'm counting *my* shekels, she was thinking and thinking it with a manic cocksureness all morning. You had to count your shekels, she was so sure.

They are signs from God. People are always looking for signs, but they don't keep count, not like our poor ole' Itragene was doing with her Shekel Math.

One must do something: *one must*... speak and name, count...

By that point, about 9am on that 1994 March morning, question after question was leading to diffracted answers and they kept flashing in her cogitations, her frontal lobes afire and the dopamine circuitry of her brain aching, her Alabama Kabbalah—*What are these things? How are they the same—sometimes the same thing? How are they different? What are these things? It's a shekel, it's a shekel*…good, *gew',* goo, *good*… hmm, *less* than a *dozen*… *hmmm, gew', goo', good, mhmm*… counting my shekels. *One thing jumbled up in one thing*…

One must count their shekels, she knows this by that morning, knows it with everything in her.

Synchronicities and delusions of reference, events that are synesthetic in nature and between and across the classic five senses, avalanching associative delusions, her mind is ablaze with meaning that adds up to her but doesn't truly make sense, and, almost always at this time, she is hearing voices and seeing things. She can, of course, see the Face in the Window as a literal optical sensation—she is also seeing a damn ghost in her head, who appears in abstract spaces when her eyes are closed and in the room when they're open, her feeling their facial expressions in her face as if they are here own, and she is talking with him, Henry, and is, even and in fact, *falling in love with him*, carrying him around wherever she goes.

She was out of her mind, living out her destiny to remove the window talking to figments of her imagination.

Henry wasn't the only persona she was hallucinating by then. She was doing something. She was doing something and she was so delusional and hallucinating *a lot*.

In addition to Shekel Math, she had this other idea that had come to fruition that morning. Both of these things were just a psychotic person trying to make sense out of what they were experiencing in this world. They're schemas, memetic schemas.

There, moments prior, in the square, when the medicine man's radio was still playing "The Sound of Silence," Itragene only was picking up on a few of the lyrics, ones that felt germane to her in that

moment, and those are the ones that are about *10,000 people—maybe more*—who are *talking without speaking*, which is an idea, this ingathering of lots of people who speak beyond speech, some fortunate lot, that's mighty important to her and her other notion she had besides Shekel Math, and that was the lot of folks in her head that she was hallucinating she was coming to call—"*the Assembly of Israel*."

The Assembly of Israel of Gordo, Alabama, folks.

She's got Henry in her head, her Shekel Math, and this thing called the Assembly of Israel, of which Henry is a part. Itragene's got some notions, by that phase in her acute manic psychosis, with bipolar and all.

The Assembly of Israel is a hallucinated cast of rotating characters. She has buddies, like Henry Wells, and she hallucinates them, and it's all called the Assembly of Israel—the Assembly of Israel of Gordo, Pickens County, Alabama.

The Assembly of Israel comes to include Henry and even more *personas*, which, personas, are not actual people but entities that take anthropomorphic form in her psychotic hallucinations, creatures in her mind, her mind a place where they are real and have been made up, not real but extant in the neurons, some ambiguous part of reality—personas like her dead, mute daddy, Thaddeus Jr., who is around but never speaks, and, also, as of that morning, a new personage: Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, who was alive and well in 1994, which Itragene has taken at this time to mean she is telepathic, in addition to being able to channel the dead in her poor ole' little white Gordo head, such as Henry Wells..

By that morning, she has come to call this crew of hallucinated personas "the Assembly of Israel." Just the way it has unfolded.

Justice Ruther Bader Ginsburg was the persona that (/who) teaches her, earlier that Wednesday morning, how to do her Shekel Math, as she experiences the matter at this challenging time in her life.

Assembly of Israel. What fun. How neat. They'll be so jealous of me. *Shekel Math*.

The moment of the synchronicity in the square—the music cutting off and Mrs. Sister Jackson going "The armor of God!" [sic]—it was a total coincidence, but, nonetheless, was real as an orchestration of sorts for Itragene. It was like Jesus himself had coordinated the parity in occurrence. The Assembly of Israel was just a name for all the people in her head who helped her do things like keep track of it all, all that was happening in this world to her, the people in her head who taught her skills, including Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg and the ghost of Henry Wells, the former of which brings the whole topic of Shekel Math up in the first place. All of this makes sense in a true manner, in Itragene's mind, but it isn't quit adding up, this psychotic stuff being her making sense out of what was going on and happening to her.

Confused and delusional in a manner that was downstream of the hallucinations, her hallucinations causing her delusional beliefs, she was mixed up. You'd be like that too, had you been through what she had and with her genes and memes.

Justice Ginsburg had been talking since earlier that morning.

Ginsburg had started speaking to her around 1am.

She thought she had been initiated into the Jewish way of the shekel, thought that was not only a thing but a very special thing. She felt special for the first time in her entire life.

She thought all Jews did this, this obsessive and psychotic counting. It'd be offensive were she sane. It simply wasn't her fault. She meant it as a compliment, anyway: Good on them and good for them, them Jews for counting their shekels! The poor thing was a white woman born 1930 in the Deep South, her daddy was a Klansman, and it was all so potentially not great, though prejudiced is nowhere near the right term: she only thought these things because she so desperately wanted to be Jewish, admired their skills, and she just had to be with her Lord God, Jesus. It was aberrant, made sense to her (and her only), and it was not hateful at all.

Bible speaks on this.

The air crackled with meaning for Itragene, meaning only she

could pick out of the atoms.

All of a sudden, Itragene's thoughts had gone wild and she had found herself not on the square. This had just happened in a nanosecond, in the neurons. She had lost her mind that spring, and she was losing her entire environment at times, all in the neurons.

She had seen a bright flash of light that drowned out her surroundings.

She lost her visual field. Her senses got mixed up.

She heard light, smelled sound, and felt sight.

The Face in the Window was there, she saw, in all the light, an arena and battlefield between Good and Evil. That's "the Portico," she kept calling it and naming it until it was what it was, a real meme and myth for her—a place with architecture that could be visited time and time again, extant.

And, beyond her ability to control it, the psychotic arithmetic begins in her head, the shekel counting.

The music and the words, the total impact, like a plane had crashed in her mind, her going, Shekel…shekel, shekel, that's a shekel… that's a shekel and that's not and that is and that would be had that happened or this... *One mus...t* count the things that matter, their shekels.

'No, no, my dear, no—wait, wait. Be deliberate, now, be careful. That'*s not quite* a shekel.'

Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg has appeared there in her psychic environs to correct her Shekel Math, going on in Itragene's mind and her mind only, 'A shekel is something that *adds up to something* that you can hold onto, something that means something…'

"It has nothing to do with money," Itragene actually says aloud, not really alarming her party there in the square, as that was just poor ole' Itragene mumbling to herself. She wasn't there. She was in Gordo at home. She was in her head and she had company.

'Did you think anything upon feeling it were a shekel?'

Ginsburg is inquiring within a line that is an involuntary utterance on the part of the mind of our Itragene, a part of a script playing out in

Itragene's head beyond her control, words said *to* her and *in* her that operate on the substrate of her own mind, but having the recursive and autopoietic appearance of a telepathic phone call—*i.e.*, her hearing voices, and, as well, seeing things, too, Justice Ginsburg a faint face floating out before her in her vision in a manner where she is before and within Itragene's eyes, her visual centers, like Ginsburg were a ghost even though she was alive, but it's 1am on March 16, 1994, there over at the house in Gordo and there is Ginsburg, too, before her eyes in a manner where she's also in her eyes, inside her retinas, Ginsburg there, even as she gazes up at the Face in the Window, there, in Carrollton, that morning, seeing the company of two that morning.

The Assembly of Israel is all places and the Way of the Word of Bible 1.5.

She had added Ginsburg as a new character amongst the cast of faces and voices in her hallucinatory, psychotic mind, an effervescent crew that she was calling *the Assembly of Israel*, the so-called Assembly an idea rattling around her head that was an adequate-enough description for the rotating cast that populated the architecture in her head, seeing them in an internal hallucination gathered at a spot, a spot which she called "the Portico," and this was the Hollywood Squares-like arrangement of people in her head as an optical sensation, her seeing a portico of sorts in her mental visage, a front porch in heaven, some holy architecture of a kind concocted by her mind, and this Portico she saw was a bright white brim of an opening of a roof in the crown of her head in her mind's eye, if she looked up, whites of her eyes showing if her eyes remained ajar, and standing around the Portico, looking down on her, advising her, was the Assembly of Israel, the people all of whom she hallucinated in her head, completely out of touch with reality, her having *fully fucking lost it*.

The people in the Assembly of Israel were hallucinations—visual, auditory and between the senses within the whole and parts of the body, as well, all of this hallucinatory business as fully and totally somatic as it was sensual and cognitive.

It was 1am, earlier that Wednesday morning, and she was adding Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg to the roster of the Assembly of Israel, the Justice joining Henry and her dead daddy Thaddeus Jr. in her head, Ginsburg having appeared before Itragene's own eyeballs, her very own and very open eyes, pupils black moons, which, stuff like this, it had started happening, last couple of days, and a lot, her having full-blown external hallucinations, mainly faces floating before her own.

Justice Ginsburg appeared to Itragene as a face in her bay window, outside the house and looking in at Itragene at her police scanner table, the sight of which was instantly triggered in Itragene's head as she heard on the radio torch songstress Melissa Etheridge's 1993 release and hit still rotating nonstop on the radio by 1994, "Come to My Window."

The first living Assembly member—and also-actually-Jewish person about whom she was hallucinating and with whom she felt herself to be growing friendly—Ginsburg had appeared before Itragene as a detailed statue in the form of a burst of light, a classical bust composed of light, just a dignified head and shoulders, no body, initially.

A face in the windah over at the house in Gordo—Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg.

So, out of the blue, all of a sudden, there was Justice Ginsburg staring into the bay window from the nighttime darkness, looking directly at where Itragene was sat next to the police scanner at her little table in the sunroom's big bay window, Ruth Bader Ginsburg a novel face in her home window.

Itragene had turned the scanner down some once she saw the sight and she gazed, practiced, as if she knew what she were doing, channeling, her soul uplifted and filled with purpose and her mood euphoric, guided by the lesbian torch songstress Melissa Etheridge pine for her lady at her window as the sonic and lyrical soundtrack, the radio, the police scanner, too, all of which she listened to together at

night, still on, it all animating and annihilating Itragene's mind.

just to reach-c*h'chu*...

There is so much light inside of her; her ecstatic vision is filled with light on this dark Alabama night.

Etheridge's extended vibrato gave form to her uttering "*reach-ch-ch you-ou-ou, just to reach-ch'chu*" in the chorus, and that had chilled Itragene on this dark, crescent-moon Alabama spring night in the year '94, her feeling a buzz in her whole body, hearing friendly zaps in her joints and cartilage, staring at this new but familiar face in the window with the soundtrack that she had, a face that was not Henry Wells, but, for a change, Justice Ginsburg.

"Ginsburg" had "said" something "to" her (inside her), then, upon her appearance and Itragene's recognition of her presence.

'All right, congratulations, honey—you finally have an actual Jewish person appearing before you, and I'm happy to be a part of the Assembly of Israel for your special mission. Isn't that Melissa Etheridge great? I think she "likes the lady pond, dipping her toe in the lady pond," as I've heard Southerners say.... Nothing wrong with that. We have to pursue Justice and Equality. Anyway, all right—all right, honey, what you need to know, what you've gotta learn to do, first and foremost, so that you know what's real, is your Shekel Math. Now, ok, you're probably thinking something antisemitic as soon as I say "shekel" and that's because you're an ignorant person born goy, and that's not your fault, but you're on your way, you're on your way—OK, now, what is a shekel? The nations wish they knew, the goyim—and that's not a slur, not even as harsh as "gringo"; it just means "nations" and nations don't have shekels; we do and there is a lot of coveting. OH, AND OH, ONE MORE THING: Look here. Ok, shekels... first, you can't get greedy; that's the mistake people make who conflate shekels with currency... or religion with nationalism... '

The Justice was speaking so rapidly, faster than Itragene's own verbose personal thoughts and, as had become the case the last manic

days, what was her stunted and stuttering verbal speech; this was always the case for the voices inside of her head, these hallucinated people being able to speak more rapidly than she could apparently think, noticeably so in her perception, by all phenomenological appearances, them always a beat or two ahead of her, somehow, her unable to predict the next word in a conversation with these hallucinated personas as she could with other people, other, real people, that is, real people who weren't projections in her psychotic mind.

'You might ask that,'—"Ginsburg" was rattling on—'What is a shekel? First of all, money has nothing to do with it, again. A shekel is something that you can hold onto because it means something to you, something that matters, a shekel, and so, then, holding onto your shekels, you know what's real; shekels are things that matter because they mean something to you, a type of enumeration—have you read *Ki Tissa*, lately? Do you keep up with the *parsha* calendar? I know you love *Torah*, my sister in Moses. You need these shekels and you need them counted, life enumerated. Bible speaks on this. You have to tally what's real at the end of the day or they'll get you, they'll trap you in a *Jew trap*. Do you follow, honey? This is what *HaShem* instructs Moses up on the mountain to do—to tally and enumerate with shekels. So, *Ki Tissa?* Familiar?*'*

Itragene had indicated that she did follow, that she understood. She began to reply to show her comprehension, a lull in Ginsburg's speech finally having arrived.

She speaks aloud.

"When you take a census of the Israelites to register them, each shall give a ransom for his life to the LORD when they are registered, so that no plague may come upon them for being registered. This is what everyone who is registered shall give: half a shekel according to the sanctuary shekel (twenty gerahs to the shekel), half a shekel as an offering to the LORD."

That is *Shemot* 30:12-13, NJPS translation. *One must...*

Ginsburg cut her off.

'Enough with this "one must" stuff!'

How's just thinking straight?

'That! That is fine. It's an obsessive thought you have, honey—"one must..." "one must..." Sounding a little too much like Susan Sontag in her desperation for some attention, who, though a vibrant public intellectual, is rather insecure. You should see her notebooks where she writes down words in fear of forgetting them. "One must" only follow the commandments*, all six-hundred and thirteen*.'

So, Itragene had indicated that she had, indeed, read that portion of *Torah* called *Ki Tissa*, and recently so, as it had been recently the *parsha* for the week. *Ki Tissa,* Itragene Sr., recognized, was a significant portion in Exodus, and she accurately recalled that Moses does go on there about tallying with something he calls "shekels," out in the middle of the desert after their escape from Egypt, out in the desert where money wouldn't apparently matter, and our Itragene indicated this comprehensive understanding she was expressing to the person inside of her head in a manner where the communication took place only inside her head, Itragene—outwardly appearing catatonic, though her innards were moving at light speed and her vision was full of a light emerging from within her person—afraid to move in any outward gesture, afraid to nod, afraid anybody who might be wandering around outside would notice that she were talking to a face in a window that wasn't Henry Wells' window on Phoenix Avenue; the former was not acceptable, talking to any other window except the one in Henry's Garden. You could talk to that scarecrow on the county square in that window, but no Jew in the window at home!

"Ruth Bader Ginsburg" continued in her signature and crisp rasp, her Jewish- and Brooklyn-specific accent.

'So, at the end of the day, every Jew under attack, and that's every Jew in this world, *you do your Shekel Math!* You do it all day but you must always be sure to check in on it all in the evening. At the end of the day and when you wake up, you count up a*w*ll*llll* the things that

have seem to have mattered to you over the day or the day prior, things that matter upon waking up—you gotta go over your shekels over and over so nobody can steal your memory—and these things, shekels, they are usually *synchronicities, in Jungian terms*, moreover; you call and count something as a shekel *if it's something you believe, something that matters,* something that means something in that *it adds up to something real and is significant enough to count*, to tally, like something mattering because the things we're on about lead us to things that have happened at the right moment at a specific conjuncture of space and time, all such moments a relative event (Einstein) and situation (Newton) that would be foreclosed as historical possibility if things were other than they were. Let me quote you something THe psychoanalyst Carl Jung ...whom I believe you studied in art school? A learned girl—that you are in the Word; time to bone up on arithmetic!'

Ginsburg threw a dumbbell at her and was suddenly dressed as a Russian gymnastics coach.

Ginsburg-in-her-head was rattling on, clearing her throat, changing outfits, getting in Itragene's face from within her head about her eyeballs, hard to place where any of this was extant.

This is like the worst acid trip and Itragene's never done acid, an old school fan of stimulants, benzos and barbiturates, a woman of the gentry class of Pickens County, Alabama. She loved her Phen-Phen but wouldn't touch a mushroom.

'"Synchronicity reveals the meaningful connections between the subjective and objective world."'

Jung, that's Jung, Itragene "said" by thinking it at and around the Ginsburg-in-her-head, mouthing it some.

Itragene felt a sudden, very real feeling of Ginsburg dropping a giant Jung tome on her foot, Ginsburg apologizing for her clumsiness, Ginsburg having mistakenly dropping it on the toe she had gangrene in but refused to medically acknowledge, it inconvenient to her plans at the moment; there had been no book, really, of course, but that big toe of hers really did hurt, and her body made sense out of the pain, so she

hallucinated the book, and it was objectively worrisome, though not to her in her state, her barely able to feel her toes on any given day, anyhow.

Ginsburg taught her Shekel Math and she had immediately used it once she departed the house for Carrollton to get Maddie from the jailhouse in her giant Lincoln Town Car, that Wednesday morning.

After spending all the wee hours of the morning in the window at her table "learning 'Shekel Math,'" later, when she's on her drive out of Gordo, earlier that morning, around 8am, and she was on her way to the Carrollton Unit School parking lot for her business, and she was still in her neighborhood, her having been driving west through the residential area of downtown Gordo, she had seen a truck for a local pest control company—*Lavender Pest Control*.

She already didn't like that Lavender Pest Control. She was suspicious of them for crazy reasons and good ones, too, it would turn out by about 1995.

It was then and there, upon the sight of this Lavender Pest Control truck, that everything started to click for her, in the way that things "click" for the mad, particularly the manically psychotic.

So, she saw the first one, then it cascaded; she saw one Lavender Pest Control truck, then another shortly, thereafter, immediately followed by another—three total *and* in quick *sequence*.

It has to be something! Am I onto my first sheekellllll?! I'm so crazy, I'm Itragene. So wild that I'm even here. Why me, Lord?

She had almost swerved off the road as it all happened, several times just missing fully jumping the curb to the sidewalk, swerving hardest amidst this upon the shekel she had then come to count in the next moments after seeing the first Lavender Pest Control truck—indeed, before she would make it out of Gordo on her way to Carrollton, she went to find that she had, in fact, applied Shekel Math to her reality. She had come to find that she had achieved Shekel Math praxis after her Ruth Bader Ginsburg education.

She found that she had "counted shekels," significant ones, and

counted them in a mere two minutes' accumulation, her rapidly finding that this is when she "'truly' 'learned'" what a shekel was insofar as it had any stable meaning in her mind, this shekel notion canalizing as it became practical and applied, applied Shekel Math, Shekel Math then quickly becoming a foundational delusion with downstream beliefs and actions, derivative delusions and things done, committed—*applied Shekel Math*, she had thought upon it all "clicking" in the way things snap together for people facing madness, particularly manic psychosis.

So, there she had been, right before she saw the Lavender Pest Control truck, her driving along earlier that morning, around 7:07am, the car edging rightwards ever so slightly as she rummaged for her cigarettes and lighter and stopped watching the road for a moment. She had been bumping up on the curb, then, almost running onto the sidewalk, making her way back into her lane with ease, blindly, just not looking or paying any attention, a public nuisance.

This was how she drove, how she used her Alabama driver's license.

There was this Lavender Pest Control company around Pickens County, a little local LLC based in Reform, "Lavender Pest Control," it was, which our Itragene had always considered to be an antisemitic name for a pest control business, given the stereotypes in Nazi Germany regarding Jews and vermin—she'd just spend all day associating this with that—stereotypes and bigoted visual culture that she had studied carefully over her life, obsessed with antisemitism; the loose, associative and absurd connection, for her, what made it "antisemitic," was that the color lavender is associated with Jesus and, so, Jesus, a Jew, the most famous one ever, He was somehow the butt of the antisemitic joke in her insane mind always working on all cylinders with her little unique theological commitments.

Bless her heart and her Bible 1.5, Shekel Math, the Assembly of Israel, the Portico and who knows what else.

Who knows—but those Lavender Pest Control trucks were out to get her, her, her" a Jew," at least in her poor little *ole* white Gordo

head. She had long been suspicious of this little LLC, Lavender Pest Control, but now she was *terrified* of them. The trucks took on new meaning. And that? That mattered. That counted.

A shekel dropped into her lap and she felt the weight.

So, she was driving along on her street, had been, that morning, 4th Avenue NW, and she sees one of these trucks, at the sight of which a friendly, bald pest control man dressed in a discolored purple jumpsuit was getting out and waving at his customer that morning, who was already greeting him from their front door, a goofy grin on her long, old face, a happy springtime pest control customer eager to have her cabinets sprayed for roaches, water bugs, what they called around there "starfish," "and a whole bunch of different kind of ants.

"*That time of year*," her neighbor three doors down had been excitedly telling her friends for a week, a woman who also waved at Itragene.

"Hey, Itragene!"

She'd linger over the pest control guy when he did his work, gabbing away, happy to have company and giving him strong coffee and Splenda-based "'sugar' cookies," just trying to get a little bit of attention, which is all she wonted.

She just wonted a little bit of attention.

Itragene didn't see her neighbor, hadn't seen or heard her neighbor's yelling and waving, her focused elsewhere, though not on driving, but focused on this pest control truck, running on no sleep and the acidic fumes of diet pills and Folgers coffee.

She became terrified, always fuzzily worried in her peripheral list of concerns regarding this Lavender Pest Control company, though one sighting of a Lavender Pest Control truck is nothing—"nothing," at least, in the terms of the mathematics of shekels, and, so, she was also "realizing" this, that it were no harm, this one truck, since it was just one truck, one truck, even if it was alarming, her "realizing" in the deranged logic she was calling Shekel Math because she had hallucinated a Jewish Supreme Court Justice explaining this Toucan

Sam Fruit Loop concept to her, her delusional and believing that this Shekel-Math-business would become not only integral to her "'Jewish' observance," but that it was a universal metaphysical initiation faced by all converts, her believing such stuff with everything in her while having grand and vast visionary hallucinations, both visual and auditory, and also somatic, manic psychosis engulfing her mind and body totally; overall, Shekel Math and the Assembly of Israel considered, amongst other notions she had, she thought she was getting let in on some secret, herself "observant" in a bizarre logic, an observant, astute genius Jew born unto stupid and evil gentiles, really antisemitic ones to whom she could never reveal her supposedly Jewish identity, much less her other Muslim shit she had had before later in acute psychosis and would experience this time, as well, just later, something that only happened for her in very advanced psychosis —her *lil'* Al-Bama *Allahu Akbar* apophenia as her rebellion against the legacy that was her heritage and not her pride, nor shame, but historical obsession with destroying its legends.

Amidst the initial sighting of the truck, Ginsburg had chimed in at that very moment in her ear, when she saw the first truck, saying, 'Don't worry, honey—not a shekel, not a shekel, that—just one—so, don't be afraid, not yet, but keep yourself alert, because you never know, especially if it's something you're already familiar with like this fucking Lavender Pest Control—real suspect, real suspect; I have a file,' hallucinated words Itragene was to take to heart.

That's not a shekel, OK—*GREAT*, Itragene had thought real loud as a rejoinder and acknowledgement to Ginsburg that she were taking it all in, that she were understanding shekels in the wild, parroting the comforting notion from the Ginsburg who was in her head, our Itragene trying to console herself, but, it got crazy, then, her then turning the corner and seeing *another* Lavender Pest Control truck.

Panicking, Itragene went, *Goddamnit*, that's a *shekel* because it happened *right after the other*; I've got one *shekel,* praise be and praise He.

‘That's right,’ Ginsburg had said proudly, warming Itragene's entire body upon her perceiving that she was counting her shekels correctly and that her mentor affirmed her progress, only having had just learned this amazing new arithmetic that wasn't real in any way.

Henry Wells had then chimed in, in his characteristic sing-song voice in the chaotic and loud and bright vortex that was her mind.

‘I myself ain't never had no two shekels to rub toge*thah* '*n*' you do know that if I did the white man would just *snatch it straight from me*, talmbout' saying I stole it, the way jokers do things!’

Itragene agreed with Henry and she took note of Ginsburg's remarks, she had, driving there in Gordo, trying to make her way to Carrollton for her Wednesday morning errands that were dictated by local police scanner radio activity that she had heard while out of her gourd and not sleeping.

This was just the Henry Wells in her head, as was the case for the Justice, just her idea of what a Black man from the nineteenth century would say about the given situation in 1994, his lines usually obvious and not too standup-worthy a line, flat in character—racist, really, essentialist, her knowing no better and trying her best—delusional and hallucinatory, Ginsburg more award-winning in her performance as Assembly of Israel cast member, Itragene having seen so much footage of her that she had absorbed her memes—little bits of cultural information that can be copied, like wearing glasses, facial gestures, or talking a certain way—Itragene had absorbed her memes, Ginsburg's, down to her facial mannerisms and the sound of her voice, her manner of speaking and cogitating.

Ginsburg hits her gavel and it’s loud.

She had no idea how the real Henry Wells behaved, but she knew Ginsburg’s memes, units of culture that replicate and are imitated, passed between persons.

She did this with everybody whom she admired, memorized them, their memory a blessing, as the Jewish saying goes—*May their memory be a blessing*.

It was so goddamn loud in her head, by then, often bright, hallucinated people popping up and disappearing, all the people in her head talking over one another, so-called cooperative overlapping gone haywire in one crazy woman's mind, a crazy white woman from Gordo, Alabama, a damn crazy gentile lady who called herself Esther at times in secret and who thought she was Jewish but her family were Klansmen and so Southern Baptist that they had themselves helped start the denomination over a disagreement about slavery, the shame of a fallen gentry family and their heritage in the legacy, Itragene's own inner monologue drowned out as well, in addition to these foreign entities talking to and over one another, body snatchers, creatures she had created in her own mind in her mind that—*who?*—were having apparent, derivative thoughts themselves that she could hear and that, at times, supplanted her own, these endogenous but alien thoughts, and, other times, these alien thoughts would be complementing her thinking and inner monologue, the times when her voice broke through enough for a one-woman monologue to transpire, all of this shifting the cognitive load about her mind between herself and persons inside of her, such mental machinations even leading to analytical breakthroughs of different "parts of her," so to speak, "in character," did the figuring on some matters.

Quickly, Ginsburg had urged her, 'Not only is a synchronicity a shekel, but if two synchronicities happen in a row, that's a shekel itself; so, at this point, you've seen two, and that's a shekel, so keep your eyes peeled—'

"Fuck, goddamn shit. I don't need this shit," Itragene had been yelling aloud and in reality, also inside herself, but also outwardly, and, dangerously, she was accelerating the gas pedal congruently to her rapidly shifting mood—nanosecond transitions between hysterical, manic euphoria, ecstasy, flashes of ecstasy and insight, and a sheer terror that was so pure and blunt it probably bruised her brain, caused brain damage, denaturing her amygdala, this progressive mood disorder bubbling over and all that had canalized before making itself

so apparent and fortified by their renewed psychotic presence, that with which she managed as she did, whatever this was just beyond her capacity to control.

Having seen a second Lavender Pest Control truck and earning herself a shekel in her mind, she had, then—that morning in Gordo before she stumbled to the square from the unit school parking lot—turned left towards the direction of the highway, and she had found herself seeing, *another* Lavender Pest Control truck, her thinking, My *HaShem HaYeshua*, thinking so fast, agape, frozen still, but going really fast inside, white-knuckle gripping the steering wheel of her giant car.

The esteemed Justice and George H.W. Bush appointee, then, she had been starting going on again about how to count shekels, speaking up again, her cadence noticeably and quickly accelerating in speech rate.

'So, now you've seen three in a row—the first back-to-back moment with the trucks was just a shekel, one shekel right there; the third truck was seen after the second one, another shekel between the second and third sightings, by truck three, though we had a series that was a series of a series—that's one through three—so, two pairs, two pairs and one unit of three, half a half-a-dozen, in other words, and, so, there's the three in a row that is another enumerable shekel, your total balance, now, coming out to three shekels; I think you call that a quarter-of-a-dozen around here—anyway, that's a shekel, three in a row and otherwise preceding, providing the possibility of a third, hence its worthiness of enumerating with a shekel (*a hefty set of shekels, since you are already familiar with the parties involved, though we don't measure that, just making note of it*), and here is HaShem in your life: you've seen three,' Ginsburg had been sort of frantically repeating herself, 'and that's another shekel and...— '

Itragene had, then, "cut off 'Ginsburg'," "finishing the Ginsburgin-her-head's 'thoughts'" that were actually crafted from Itragene's own cognitive substrate, had been her own thoughts presented in a

derivative cognitive characterization.

Then, it came to pass that she had spoken inside herself, Itragene, her as herself, now, at that moment, her then continuing the stream of thought started by the Ginsburg in her, but, now, then, she had been thinking with her own authentic voice, her thoughts alone, wrapping up the thought that Ginsburg, a personage inside of her, had first started articulating, Itragene finishing the thought.

—and earning two shekels in a row in such a short period of time, especially because it's the same thing over and over with which I'm familiar (*I'll make note of this but not count on it)*, that is also a shekel.

'You've got it, Esther.' Ginsburg smiled so brightly as she told Itragene this.

Call me ma—call me by my name, Ma Iddy.

One must... put on the armor of God, Itragene calmy thinks. Sorry, I'll stop saying "one must." No more, this point forward. One must not have intrusive thoughts!

"I promise, no more obsessive 'one must,' as it's been driving me crazy for years," Itragene said aloud to the hallucination of Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, who was riding shotgun in her Lincoln Town Car as they hit Highway 82 and headed to Carrollton to pick up Maddie.

It happens in a nanosecond, all in the neurons (The synchronicity, the shekel)..

Again, the moment keeps folding in on itself out on the Carrollton town square that Wednesday morning.

The present is continuous.

A) ... /The radio goes off. /... *sound of silence*.

B) ... /Sister Jackson goes, LOUDLY, "Put *the armor of God!*"/ ... *sound of silence*.

The same things happen over and over and time is frozen for our Itragene.

Itragene has begun to enumerate. She labels the radio going off event "No. 1," event No. 1, and the Sister Jackson clucking as event "No. 2."

No. 1 and No. 2. = *1 shekel*. There is a set of events—events No. 1 and No. 2—there in the square, March 16, 1994, about 9am. The radio isn't on because it's been turned off. Sister Jackson has said, LOUDLY, "Put *the armor of God!*"

There is the sound of silence.

...

Again: the radio went off; Sister Jackson clucked. This happens at the same time.

...

ONE MUST... COUNT THE THINGS THAT MATTER... *ONE MUST* ENUMERATE AND TALLY WHAT MATTERS.

Our poor ole' Itragene and her Shekel Math has been in this moment counting it all—No.s 1 and 2.

She says aloud, "This is one shekel. 1. One. *Uno*. *Un—Ani*."

John Henry goes, "I'm sorry Itragene?"

John Henry had said something to her but she was lost in another moment prior and did not notice him say anything. If she had, it might have grounded her, but she was off to the races in her acute psychosis.

Itragene is thinking this weird shit in a loop atop her also hearing everything in the square that was going on in the sound as well as, additionally, an inner soundtrack of "Strange Fruit," which she hears incessantly, that ole' Nina Simone, just nonstop. Torture because the song is brutal; a shame in many ways, and one way was that she loved the song, but my God, there are times and places for things and this

song was a mighty downer. All the damn time; she was so sick of it. "It'll drive you crazy," she's said before out loud, talking about that song.

The medicine man has turned off his vehicle van's radio (No. 1).

LOUDLY: "Put the armor of God!" (No. 2).

The sound of silence.

(Over and over and also somehow all at once; it'll drive you crazy).

This pair happens in the same moment, the two things being when Sister Jackson was clucking and then the words stopped (No. 2) and when the medicine man Tom was turning off his radio (No. 1) and there was no more radio sound, and the square has now faded for Itragene and she is no longer there at all, even though her person is completely footed on the square.

Strange fruit... Nina Simone; 10,00 people... talking without speaking.

Hearing without listening...

IT'S SO FUCKING LOUD AND I CANNOT TAKE IT ANHYMORE! I'M GOING TO ... MYSELF! I NEED TO GET A GUN. I NEED TO END THIS. I CANNOT TAKE IT. SOMETHING ISN'T RIGHT.

Strange fruit... Nina Simone; 10,00 people... talking without speaking.

(Hi, I'm Itragene...).

Hearing without listening...

"Put the armor of God!" (No. 2)

The medicine man has already been done with having started to turn off his vehicle's radio, the music van with the cows. (No. 1)

I CANNOT TAKE IT ANHYMORE!

"Put the armor of God!" (No.2)

The medicine man turns off his vehicle's radio and it takes a moment, the van with the baby pigs drinking milk. (No. 1)

I CANNOT TAKE IT ANHYMORE!

"Put the armor of God!" (No. 2)

I CANNOT TAKE IT ANHYMORE!

The medicine man is turning off his vehicle's radio as of now. (No.1)

"Put the armor of God!" (No.2)

I CANNOT TAKE IT ANHYMORE!

Manic psychosis is so loud. The smarter you are and the more you know about in this world, the more shit there is in your audio field that only you can hear, and Itragene has so much source material.

The medicine man has turned off his radio. (No. 1)

"Put the armor of God!" (No. 2)

The medicine man turned off his radio. (No. 1)

"Put the armor of God!" (No. 2)

The medicine man's radio is not on, as he's just turned it off. (No. 2)

I CANNOT TAKE IT ANYMORE!

...

Poor ole' Itragene and her Shekel Math.

...

This is Henry's Garden in hyperspace.

Apophenia.

Itragene's frontal lobes on fire, burning, actually truly and verily aching physically—her mentality itself would ache, the most abstract part of her as a person, her notions hurting her body.

Then the sudden smell of burning flesh...

This is when the synchronicity punctures Itragene's person—...

...

The sound of silence.

...

Apophenia.

Synesthesia; hallucinations beyond the five senses—litanic anaphora and *ostinato*. Pathological counting and unbearable

hypergraphia. It is so loud in the *sound of silence*. Memes that matter in the mind—poor ole' Itragene has been counting her "shekels."

Hyperspace; do the math: 5D, up and down and left and right are fine for mobility, but there are also other ways to move, to ambulate amongst reality itself in its binding fabric, but it's not real at all, not extant, none of it—only in Itragene's head, where things that are not real do, indeed, exist. *We are* thermodynamic creatures and *one must* never forget Newton... *one must* navigate in 4D when one can, for it is moral, and one must not forget Einstein, a Jewish genius... this all, too, this, too, this is all, too, it is *Torah*...

Bible 1.0. Pray in Bible; Bible speaks on this.

This happens in a nanosecond, in the neurons (The synchronicity, the shekel) Extant.

...

... //// Mrs. Sister Jackson raises her voice quite a lot, near yelling, LOUDLY: "Put *the armor of God!*"

The medicine man turns of his radio. ///...

...

Itragene sees a biblically accurate chicken, screams—so many heads and eyes but it's all in one face, beaks at all sides possible.

It is 1876 and Henry Wells begins to scream... He had seen the Look and then he died, wailing forever and ever in an image, if their words had any truth to them.

The chicken knows!

Eunice, the Sister Jackson, this one here, her, there, at that moment where she's saying it, this here woman, this ridiculous lady, she is misquoting Bible and it irks Itragene beyond thought, who prays in Bible and knows Bible deep, and it irks our Itragene beyond speech, bothers her in her system apparatus; she is having a limbic response. The Sister's tongue sizzled in error, her oblivious because the nerves in her mouth were oblivious, the roof of her mouth long burned to a rubbery and flame-retardant state; she's never embarrassed and will say whatever to just about anybody about anything she wants, and she

usually does it just for some attention.

When Mrs. Sister Jackson speaks like this, misquoting Bible 2.0, she is inflecting the King's English with the frying pan of upper crust Pickens County enunciation, every word a cracked egg sizzling on the skillet of her pan-tongue licking her little butterscotch hard candy parked in her bottom front gum, denaturing the words as a string of information in the experience of linguistic exchange, their rhythm denatured, the basic syntax and meaning of these words so mangled, her speech all ruined and spoiled and smelling of Death, her indigestion never ceasing—both poor and rich, most of these Pickens white people have lived their whole, full and entire lives sieved through their oily exegesis of the heritage of the legacy, sieving everything they do in history through their inadequate exegesis, their up-nosed, black-bottomed skillet cornbread burnt exegesis, their hateful exegeses bubbling up and over in flecks of spittle at the corners of their lips on both sides of their frothing mouths, and there's the concurrent canalizing, their sorry and bitter ways of theirs that they had and boasted of, those horrid ways and acrid, ritualized behaviors as woven into their personalities as could be, it being how they go about things and what they are like, just who they are (a matter of character), their crackling exegesis always, always piping hot, dangerous—jumpy and old and mean and turned out mad and toting guns—roofs of mouths burning like a late-night Waffle House griddle full of orders being fulfilled and it's Friday and the place is packed full of hungry people, and her exegesis there like it was, it was on proud display, Mrs. Sister Jackson's ways and views, her hermeneutics, it the same way for the sister lady and people just like her, cookie cutter crackers, lost in their judging others by their acidic notions that they have around there in their local speech, their misfired and corrupted words, stacking their notions and interpretations like greasy burgers that kill over time, full of cholesterol, anaphora the defining feature of their limited vocabularies, them saying the same things over and over and no matter the degree to which any of it makes a lick of sense—*this*

is, after all, the famously recursive South—their confusion and agitation all a case of Dionysian error in hermeneutics, them speaking, and, over and over, confused, their tongues would be sizzling the whole time, and harshly so in all of the judgment, it burning, hot tongues like hot plates all over the place, the hot-tongued people saying this, that and the other was "against the word of God," fury in their eyes and ways and lives in every respect, something they have asserted for so long even though speaking words in English is a skill missed on the unfortunate lot, but "against the word of God," they'd say, no idea about what the Word said or the Ways of the Lord, this lot barely knowing anything about words, how to sequence them to create meaning a skill lost on them, dexterity in language and thought not something they have never ever cared about, not ever, no idea had amongst them about neither sentences nor paragraphs, not clauses even in their simplicity, just knowing nothing at all like such matters of linguistic concern, grammar, spelling, them speaking in outbursts of disquieted confusion and agitated misunderstanding, not understanding clauses, even units of talking that are even shorter than a sentence, not understanding none of it, no, not none of that, speaking a mystery to them and not none of that understood, nor phrases of any kind, verse, even scripture—because they truly hated the Word—morphology not nowhere even near being in the picture as something they'd know was even a thing out there in this world, knowing nothing at all like such matters of linguistic concern, it all missed on these people, and they are left with individual Temptation and hate, left, just there and about and left behind—proud idiots; they cultivate their hate by the bushel—left with their sorrows in a dry county, left with shit infrastructure (at least the segregation and squandering of the commons is working, they feel), left with staccato words in a that way they stack them in parataxic series, all their things in their language coordinated as strings of words with no logical sequence, nor orchestration of meaning nor reasoning, nary a glissando of rhetorical intuition at all, not one bit of it around in nobody, them speaking at one another and past another,

too and all the time, and there they'd be and be just like that, how they were, just missing the basic requirements of a successful communication that would allow them to be serious people making significant progress in this world, diplomacy and negotiation not as fun to them as going kinetic, trying to be great rather than being good and behaving for the Lord they were on about so much, them living in this broke-down county that they destroyed themselves rather than integrate Black people, *bless their poor hearts*, permanently stuck in thought in a dependent clause purgatory, the lot never able to express nothing right, their minds cul-de-sacs and dead-end roads. She thinks in catchphrases and cannot go deep on any theme, her brain a barrel of cheap memes, her thoughts a Barrel of Monkeys with their interlocked arms, one-by-one and in a row, nothing more complex than the most basic of simple ideas, no branching ideas, no ideas at all. She will look at anybody and tell them about anything, and usually what she says is a damn lie and she says it just for attention, all she knows how to do. She is not capable of love and her tongue's wagging occupies her days, keeping her busy.

III. Jane Ellen the Idiot, the Woman Called Ugly & the Flat Sisters of Gordo

"I-*uhhh* might-*uhhh* be-*uhhh* the smahrtest girl that-uhhh Pickens-*uhhh* County has-*uhhh* evah-*uhhh* pr*oh*'d*u*ced-*uhhh*, evah, evah-

uhhh," she's thought so many times about herself, an old white woman called Jane Ellen, known local fool.

She has basically always talked like that, this: with this weird "-*uhhh*" attached to the end of words, her mouth hanging open and she'd be making that sound, "-*uhhh*," sounding as if a thought has escaped her or something, sounding like an idiot.

It was a big misunderstanding that led to her talking like this. It happened in French class.

If the long-winded, tedious, annoying-as-hell Carrollton native, and noted-as-such "local historian," called Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley had learned—or had "learned," more truly—one thing in the early-1950s, over the county line, over in Tuscaloosa County and the college town of Tuscaloosa, Alabama—*Tusk'e-ka'loose-uh'-uhhh, Alah-uhhh-bam-uhhh*—at the University in Tuscaloosa, the Classic City, T-Town, over in T-Town, it was something to do with the schwa e, the French schwa e, which is referred to as the "fallen e" in the French language, *e muet* or *e caduc*. Indeed, in her mind, if she had learned anything over at Paul Bear Bryant's very own University of Alabama during her days over in Tuscaloosa as she lived out the best years of her life as a Crimson Roll Tide legacy girl, an SEC sorority gal with a poodle skirt and a turned-up nose, a snobby legacy girl of the heritage of her forefathers' histor*ee*, a rattlesnake legacy girl from a river gator Klan family of Old South, Black Belt wealth in their heritage, a segregated and legacy-and-in-the-heritage sorority girl, Greek, free and happy, a legacy girl with her Crimson Roll Tide pom-poms ready on game day —*Rolllll-uhhh Tide, Roll Tide-uhhh, Gooo 'Bama-uhhh, Gooooo Crimson Tide-uhhh! Roll Tide; Roll Tie'-uhhh; Roll Tie'd-uhhh...* —a rich, *h'*white legacy girl, a heritage girl of the *legh-ah-say*, a happy and free legacy Carrollton girl, a daughter of the gentry of that godforsaken, legendary and heavily segregated, aristocratic and historically violent Jim Crow county seat town of Carrollton, Alabama —right before you get to Mississippi on Highway 82—over there in famous Pickens County, Alabama, this legacy girl from Carrollton

called Jane Ellen, it was the schwa e, what she had "learned," indeed —"learned" only in her little pretty ugly white head. What she had "learned" back then was actually an odd notion of her own making, and she carries this notion with her forever, this *odd notion*, a *mighty strange, peculiar notion*, that she, in fact, had went and picked up out of the good Lord's thin Southern air, picked it up by God knows what means, this lunatic, over at the University in Tuscaloosa, a notion with her until death, a notion about the *schwa e,* the *schwa e,* indeed, the *schwaaaa* e, what she had and has a peculiar notion about.

She didn't learn anything about the schwa e.

Never has.

She is an idiot, after all.

That was in the 1950s, and she's still on about it by the mid-1990s.

This is what she thinks she learned, though, this schwa e business, and until this day of the green Earth's year of 1994, a Friday, March 18, 1994, which happens to be, during this season of change for Pickens County, a few days before her death.

She thinks she learned the French schwa e. She didn't learn anything about it neither in college nor has she since then; she's under the impression that she has it mastered, however, in any case, has been for long time. Back in the day, see, she developed some peculiar and twisted notion about the schwa e, one that was idiosyncratic to her, unique to this skillet cookie and her bitter, little ugly head only, her and her white waffle brain, as stupid and persistent in all matters as she has always been. She was exposed to this matter of linguistic concern in French 101, indeed, but it just didn't take as a concept, in college nor afterwards, just simply never took; ever since French 101, she has mispronounced the French schwa e, such as when she ever attempts to utter the French definite article "*le*" and it comes out as "lay," when, in fact, and as she was taught so many times but it never broke through to her sparse neurons, one pronounces "*le*" more like "luh," or, in IPA, /lə/.

It is the mid-1990s, and she's had a lifetime to remediate this

misapprehension of hers and it is a defining characteristic as to how she talks.

She uses it non-stop, her idea of a schwa e.

She imported the notion to English, see. Ever since college, though she has never been able to apply the French schwa e, she has consistently been applying her notion of the French schwa e to English, and she's always near nailing it, this sound, her saying her "'English' schwa e" like this, going: "-*uhhh*."

That's the sound she makes, her mouth hanging open the whole time as she goes: "-*uhhh*..."

She is a goddamn idiot, a true idiot in the heritage of the legend as legacy.

"The *scwhaaaa* e-*uhhh*. UhhmHmm-*mhmm*, *mhmm-uhhh*," she has thought so often, and smiling as she thinks it, does all the time, so satisfied, proud to be so educated, as she has always perceived herself to be, so educated.

"-*uhhh*..."

A dumbass.

"-*uhhh*..."

An idiot.

Friday, March 18,1994, and it's just another day for pride in the legend and the legacy in the history of their godforsaken heritage, another day in Pickens County, one more opportunity to experience more involved and tedious bullshit starring these attention-seeking and hateful people—it's another cool Alabama spring morning and it will reliably heat up by lunch and white people will reliably complain everywhere about how hot they are.

"Professah-*uhhh*... " goes Jane Ellen, as if she is about to say something to present company, but the words just trail off and she goes "-*uhhh*..."

Present company isn't paying her no mind, anyhow.

She's craving some attention, too, so she can't stand it, present company not listening.

Jane Ellen's standing out on the Carrollton town square this Friday with some company she's been keeping for a bit, now. Jane Ellen has been keeping company with a gentleman from out of town, a gentleman from New Orleans, a Tulane zoologist, matter of fact, a zoologist.

The conversation lulls, and it's been like this; it hasn't just had lulls in it, their conversation, but it is—it is itself—a lull, their exchange; this conversation is mostly silence. It's mostly just been quiet, although Jane Ellen has been piercing the silence every so often by shrieking, shrieking something or another about the window, otherwise besides the quiet, her oscillating between the two, staring intently staring at the garret room window on the third floor and talking loudly.

The idiot's disfigured, in fact.

She's deformed from all the looking.

She made her neck crooked from looking so much.

She's got a crooked neck. Her neck's crooked; she takes aspirin every day because it hurts. Her ligaments are thin and all torn up in her neck; the vertebrae bones in her neck are fused together in several uncomfortable manners, and it's all her fault. She's like that as a product of her hateful and idiotic habits, did it to herself—it's from all that looking that she does at that window that did it to her, looked so much that she's got scoliosis of a type that's confined and specific to her neck. The doctors told her it's called cervical scoliosis. She's a tall woman. She looks like an upside-down L, because her head is cocked permanently to the left, a near-perfect right angle, too, her head sitting atop her crane of a neck. With that crooked neck and all, she's got this head that's permanently locked in a way where she's always looking down at her left shoulder and foot, this head of hers on that neck the way it is; she can't help herself in the grocery store in the checkout line—be it the Gordo Piggly Wiggly or the Reform Jitney Jungle, Wal*Mart, too, wherever there is a line and she's standing in it—she peeks over other Southern white ladies' shoulders and peers into their

purses, always judging, too, always judging the contents she can see from such an angle as the way it is that her head is positioned and properly tilted—literally can't help herself, given her generous height and the punishing angle at which her head rests.

She cranes over.

She's a slender person, a long, broken snake. She's bent out of shape, you could say, has her own tail in her mouth, and she's mean as a snake, too.

The man who she's with is called Professor Kevin van de Tuffin, a Kevin van der Tuffin of New Orleans, Louisiana.

Professor van de Tuffin is a cylinder-shaped person. The good professor resembles a dirty oil barrel in size, shape, proportion and also surface characteristics. Coming up to about a little more than yay high of Jane Ellen's waistline, this short man's clothes are oily and speckled with crumby foodstuff and grease, and they've have got a week's build up. He's an individual who is rotund waist-wise, but he's also a flat man, speaking head- and shins-wise, as he's flat up top and flat down bottom. He could roll down a hill and tip over at the bottom and land flat, fine, happy and free. Not much bothers him. He could stand on his head or feet; his head could wear shoes and he gave his feet haircuts.

Professor van de Tuffin is eating at this moment, as he is to do.

Jane Ellen says something.

"Professah-*uhhh*, I do sure hope that *you've'uhhh..."—and there it is,* her "*schwa e*" that she loves so much—"... I just, and I'm sorry to say it again, I just hope that *you've'uhhh* made some-*uhhh* progress, Pr*ofess*ah van duh-*uhhh*r T*u-uhhh*-ffin," Jane Ellen says to the man.

She can never say it, God help her—van de Tuffin. She can't ever say the "de" part; present company's got a name that has a goddamn schwa e in it, see, and she just can't say it right because she can't stop concatenating two "-uh" sounds rather than sticking to the one, which is the actual way to say it, one "-uh": van d*uh* Tooffin—easy, this slack-jawed idiot going "van duh-*uhhh*r... "

Duh—it's not that difficult.

By this here weekend, Jane Ellen is in trouble.

She's got issues and problems beyond her inability to speak English like a normal person and her neck pain.

She's got big troubles.

It's partly because of the company she's been keeping. This is one place where her troubles are starting to emerge, this engagement with the professor from New Orleans. The man has been hired by Jane Ellen for the task of figuring out what to do about the crow infestation in the county square; nobody has ever gone and touched that lightning rod. There's the unspoken rule around the county, mind, that you just don't mention the crows, understand.

She's done got into this mess—and one that extends beyond the crow issue—because, the little power she's had, she's let it go to her head. It's gone to her head—and all of it downstream of her pride, because of her blinding and deafening pride—*i.e.*, her idiocy.

She's been getting more cross-eyed and slack jawed, just getting dumber, lately. Her idiocy has been blooming and she's got dozens and dozens of bushels of tiny pea thoughts and she can't tell up from down, Jack from Sally. What little power she had was this: for a bit now, she's been the executive director of a group that is officially, on paper headquartered in Carrollton.

Just for a little while she's been heading up this group, a Face in the Window preservation nonprofit called the Window Watchers. The local famous idiot was put in charge of the legacy of the legend that was their heritage at that critical time in history.

She hasn't been doing a good job at this Window Watchers post, and, now, she's in a real damn mess; she's a proud, confused and agitated protector of the legacy in the legend and, now, she's let that little power that she's had in the legacy go to her head, and she's near about facing the consequences of her actions as a matter of history precisely because she's so proud. Blind and deaf, she's been paying no attention to what she's been doing, lately, worse than usual, even for

her.

This Window Watchers stuff is pretty new.

Pretty new, the Window Watchers has just been set up, this happening upon the recent death of Thaddeus Jr., one of his last dying wishes and in his final will and testament. She is too stupid for the job, but Thaddeus appointed her before he passed. She self-deals and neglects responsibilities, though none of it is on purpose, her barely capable of acting with intent. Her unintentional neglect of Window Watchers executive director duty to the heritage of the legacy as the legend is profound, accident or not, a profound neglect of due diligence and executive duty, a neglect so profound that it alters the course of events in the history of the legend of the Face in the Window overall, totally.

The legacy is about near blown up, at this point in the mid-1990s and this season of change, spring 1994.

By now, in her entanglement with Professor van de Tuffin, she's been stepping out of bounds big time by addressing the crow issue.

Nobody has ever gone and spoken on it before, not amongst the gentry in this old aristocratic town, especially. Nobody has ever touched the issue of the crow infestation, but this touched-in-the-head woman goes and does it. They've never acknowledged the crow issue beyond obligatory first aid treatments on some necessary occasions. "It's just too-many-dozens of crows to count," they say, and they leave it at that, speaking in the idiom of the local egg unit that has always, it seems, comforted them so—it's a reminder of a cool Piggly Wiggly poultry section on a harsh Alabama summer's day, these people a proud people who love eggs and the cool air in a Piggly Wiggly grocery store.

The new and novel trouble she finds herself in is due to her hubris as her prideful idiocy, her doing whatever she feels like, acting like she's better than everybody else, and this is, of course, one of her axiomatic beliefs she's got about herself and her purported gifts and talents—"Me... the smahrtest girl that-uhhh Pickens-*uhhh* County has-

uhhh evah-*uhhh* pr*oh*'d*u*ced-*uhhh*..."

Born in 1934 in the Black Belt to a legacy Klan family wherein nobody worked but instead lived off of the slavery wealth that they had, she is a native of the gentry and a member of its aristocracy, the formal, state power of which is headquartered in her native hometown of Carrollton; Carrollton is just the official power, however, the power on paper. Pickens County's informal, extrajudicial power is headquartered in the McShan Woods, and that informal power is the real power, and she's all tangled up in the invisible powers and machinations which fuel Pickens County.

The McShan Woods is the home of the legendary McShan Mafia and its legacy.

The McShan Mafia—established the year 1940, the same year our Itragene's sister called Vonnie was born and the same year that Hellen Belle McDaniel, Itragene's mother, just up and disappeared without a trace.

The McShan Mafia's godmother has a pet raven she calls Ezekiel, and Ezekiel can reliably mimic Jane Ellen's idiolect speech. Ezekiel likes to hang out mornings on the Pizza Doctor front door awning in the square, nobody noticing really, with all the crows.

The raven goes "-*uhhh*." It throws its head around going "-*uhhh*." The godmother is always feeding Ezekiel copious amounts of Mennonite Bread, to which she has constant access that extends beyond the third Wednesday of the month. She listens to Ezekiel mimic the sounds of Pickens County, treating it like a police scanner to stay up to date, deep in the McShan Woods, where she lives and tends to Ezekiel and other matters.

Little old white lady Jane Ellen is a white-collar criminal, turns out, sure is. She works for the McShan Mafia—as do many other upper crust Pickens County folks, just the way it is and has been for a long time. Jane Ellen serves as one of the main hands in Pickens County for the McShan Mafia. She has a number of diverse tasks and responsibilities as a local hand, but for the most part, lately, over a

little over a year, now, she has served as the executive director of the Face in the Window preservation group called the Window Watchers.

The Window Watchers it a money laundering front for the McShan Mafia, understand. The Face in the Window is more than a legend in the legacy, but a true part of their heritage, which is organized crime, the machinations around the legend itself serving as a front for illicit activities. The photo booth on the first floor of the courthouse, for instance, takes more than one-dollar bills—people come through and deposit money by the thousands under the guise of an innocent photo that prints with the words "Wish you were here in Carrollton!" This is just one of many deceptions.

She has always been like this, just obsessed, and it's only gotten worse with age. She's more obsessed than even our Itragene has ever been, just obsessed with this window, and in a manner that is sustained and not episodic like with Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr. of Gordo, Alabama—who takes breaks from the topic and is a learned woman with a broad variety of interests including being self-taught but fluent in French, a master of the fallen French schwa e—this here woman's endurance is truly remarkable, and ugly in kind, when it comes to the Face in the Window. She has a thoroughly hysterical approach to the legend, quite visibly unwell, her public instability obvious to anybody who sees her and her behavior. Her clear obsession and pathology is all so clear in public and it's even worse in private, and it's only gotten worse with age. Nobody has ever called her crazy to her face or pursued anything of consequence in regard to her sanity, such as hospitalizing her or giving her meds. She needs medical help, in fact, and beyond the neck, for she has an untreated thought disorder, as it is, which is the schizophrenia. She's got the schizzies, though nobody around town knows; it's been diagnosed, just not treated and she has never told anybody and keeps it a secret—the schizzies just like her mama had going on, another touched in-the-head Pickens County gentry white woman, who died by suicide; she took arsenic when little Jane Ellen was eleven years old, and she fell face-first flat into her

stuffing and turkey and potatoes in the dining room at their prominent home in downtown Carrollton Thanksgiving 1945—Jane Ellen has never been able to forget it, the gravy splashing all over the place, including her own face, as her mother's dead head plopped down with a smack onto a fully loaded Hadley heirloom Thanksgiving dinner plate, there at the Hadley supper table, where she laid in rest until they moved the body. Nobody ever has suggested that she get help nor does anybody ever report her to the nurses and doctors with their clipboards, and this is the case even though this aggressive old woman is and has always been certifiably psychotic quite often, it apparent, too, and all the while being a true danger to others and herself. She's constantly talking to ghosts and poltergeists, amongst other schizoid quirks.

It's also worth mentioning that, in part, she's never been properly considered crazy because she believes the exact same foolish things as everybody else, such as the lightning theory, the notion that lightning can print images, such as faces, say, on a window—all of it just nonsense, old 19th-century nonsense, spirit photographs and such horse crap, a very old idea, a "spirit photograph," and the like.

She believes it, but so does everybody else—the white people, at least— they believe, don't they?

She believes the same things that everybody else does, but with more vigor. She's deformed and she's sick, and any heartache—or worse—that she's verily got coming her way is all her own fault, just like her neck.

She is an idiot. It could be put in worse terms.

A crow is pecking at her ankle and she's bleeding a bit, the left one, blood on her old white lady shoes, black calf penny loafers. Numb in her prideful gazing, she does not feel it and sustains yet another injury, her skin freckled with scars from prior instances of such crow violence as she assumed nirvana looking at the winder.

She's in big trouble with the McShan Mafia.

She's done a lot, the thing is.

She's near the end of her time on this Earth by this Friday, as is it a fateful weekend in this world for Pickens County and its main characters, who are, for the most part, people who have insisted on too much attention and getting what they are asking for, at the end of things, as the legend is losing its power, and what they get is a lot of attention, getting what they are asking for—this weekend is a fateful one for her in a singular way, Death coming to claim her carcass, but this weekend is also fateful for others with whom she is mighty entangled.

The *Pickens County Herald* coins the persistent meme, titling her death "The Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre."

She's dead by Sunday, dead by Sunday, the Christian Sabbath, the thing is, thing is—getting some of that attention she loved so much, her death a gruesome murder, another historical entry into the record of the legacy of Pickens County, Alabama, a murder so grotesque that the description of the physical facts don't even seem possible in this world, but it's true, every bloody and fruity detail, even the unsavory stuff about the Ruby Red grapefruit meat they found on the scene, just all over. It's a murder that is truly par for the course for this wicked place and a true pageant of its pride in legacy as its heritage. As with the Flat Sisters of Gordo, the townspeople of the county name this gruesome event, too, the murder of local historian Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley—the Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre.

Her last words may have just been her going "*-uhhh*, *-uhhh*"—her favorite locution, her favorite vocalization. That schwa e that she loved so much, Lord have mercy, that woman.

She went "*-uhhh*" and she died—in that order, too, one can imagine.

Given the evidence at the scene of the crime at her downtown Carrollton home, we do know that she did not make an ugly and goofy face for any time that lasted after the moment of her death, her slack jawed default face, for she didn't have a jaw no more—part of the crucial facts of the case of the Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre is that

the homicide, in its execution, had it that her left-angled head was right blown off her crooked neck, and with it went her face and that goofy, open-mouthed stare she had that was so characteristic of her when she was alive, blew her head off, to start with, amongst other measures so heinous, such as innovations in the murder like the novel deployment of an heirloom grapefruit spoon—just imagine such a thing, and an heirloom, of all mementos of the heritage of her forefathers, who were of the legacy she died defending.

The McShan Mafia, the things they'd do in the name of the legacy... They've always been ruthless and would do anything you can imagine in the name of the legacy... and the way that Jane Ellen was so compliant... until she started misbehaving so much near the end, all of which was to do with her pride and meddling in her arrogant vision of herself as a local historian... Misbehaving, trying to be great and up to no good, instead of being good and behaving, a common idiot plot motif of manners, got what she was asking for in the end, which was a lot of attention.

March 18, 1994, a day near the end of her life, two days prior.

By this mid-1990s spring, she has been so busy, Jane Ellen, the thing is, truth told.

She is lost in the gravy sauce, in over her mashed potato head due to her idiocy and its concurrent symptoms such as neglect in paying attention to stuff; she hasn't been paying attention to what she's been doing at any given time, too busy to pay attention and not looking right at what she's been doing.

"-uhhh."

She wets her lips.

There she is with her company she's keeping, the zoologist, and she's standing there and she's having a meeting this here Friday morning before us, in fact, a little *tête-à-tête*, speaking to present company. It's a casual meeting, a little informal conversation with a man who she's hired for a job, and that job is taking care of the crow problem, present company a zoologist from Tulane, a man who is

about some feet shorter than her, her a tall woman and him a short man, a tall and thin woman and a short and pudgy man, hired him for a job, a job that she sees as a crucial part of maintaining the legend, which is the crow issues, and the two of them are standing on the county square on the north side of the lawn, the Face in the Window side, her favorite place in Alabama and Alabama was her favorite place on this Earth that we know.

She wets her lips again and breathes deeply, touches the back of her neck and lightly massages in a manner that does nothing, her neck aching her this morning; it's only getting worse with age, and it's that time of year, with the weather such as this, and all, with the high humidity and with all the pressure changes that come with the rain, and all.

She is near screaming something, now. She's rapidly oscillating her behaviors between looking and standing still and gesticulating like a court jester juggling many objects.

"Also, Look!! Loooooook, Looook, Look! *K-K-K*evin, look up, would you-*uhhh*? Look-*uhhh* right there-*uhhh*!"

She is, of course, pointing at that goddamn window, as she said this.

A raven called Ezekiel watches on, perched atop the Pizza Doctor front door awning, unnoticed and lost in the black blanket of the crows, which are everywhere, for it is the morning time in the town square.

The man called Kevin van de Tuffin, as of this Friday, he has been squatting there in Pickens County for a good bit and getting paid handsomely for it, working for the Window Watchers for months, months by mid-March 1994, and there is a lot of money being thrown his way, so much money being funneled into his pockets, funds that have been bleeding out of this organization of which Jane Ellen is the executive director, this here Window Watchers non-profit.

He doesn't look at the window, at which she is wildly gesturing.

Just as well, he's not physically capable: he can't look directly at it,

as he is a two-sided man with lateral-set eyes. He's blind from the front of his person, but he has clear views of his sides and decent intuition about what's going on behind his ears, for his eyes are set more in a more separate manner than they could be more intimately situated, opposite ends of the globe that was his head world. His eyes are not close to one another, opposite one another like opposing teams, one defense and one offense, two different holes in the can, spoiled food and recycling, plastic only.

He is also a man who is not one to pay attention, a prerequisite for looking just right at anything, any matter of concern.

He is eating his breakfast, the fish man. His mouth opens and closes like a bass.

He loves breakfast, just like lunch and supper and snacks in between all of it all day- and night- long. He is consumed by his mastication, the act of eating totalizing in attention, chewing and swallowing, his consuming his foodstuff, him just loving to eat, flat like a fish, such as a flounder, and eating a worm on a hook right before the fishing line goes taut and he's caught. He doesn't care. He'll flop in your boat and open and close his mouth hole. He uses his lobster claws to take his socks off of his hooves in the evening, hating hot feet in bed, where he eats and sleeps in a blanket of crumbs and shards of foodstuff like a hermit crab. He is like many sea creatures—living in the moment.

She's looking at him, having swiveled her crooked neck so that her head's sticking out above her chest a bit and looking to her right (the only way she can look to her right), like an injured giraffe in her motions. She's looking at him sideways; he looks right back at her with his left-side eye and blinks, continuing to eat his biscuit breakfast sandwich, opening and closing his mouth, unaware of her even though he's looking right at her—blank, no thoughts. He opens and closes his mouth.

All she wants is some attention, in that moment, and he ain't paying no mind to her. Look at me, she almost says. Pick me, pick me,

look at me—all she ever has been like, never enough. It may have been a different story had she some aquarium fish flake foodstuff with her, because that would've gotten his attention if anything, pet fish flaked foodstuff.

"Mhmm, you can even-*uhhh* see it when the sky's all bright 'n gray like this. You have to look just right!"

The idiot was still carrying on that day, said that.

That arrow that they've nailed to the edifice next to the window is always shiny no matter the weather, any and all light bouncing off the surface of it, and there is a bright sheen of gray sky reflecting straight back at her and right into Jane Ellen's eyes, as this sign is to do, as it is a retroreflective traffic sign and it has been designed to reflect photons no matter what lighting conditions.

She keeps telling him to look "just right."

"Jus' right, Look-*uhhh* jus'-*uhhh* right—and you'll-*uhhh* see that Henry Wells-*uhhh* up in the windah-*uhhh*."

She said such.

Professor van de Tuffin is not listening nor is he looking, this a man who is presently very much consumed by his breakfast biscuit sandwich from Jack's, and who can blame him, Jack's breakfast famously dang good, so good that even Itragene's rail-thin, manic ass had to get a biscuit the other morning, two days ago, when she went to Carrollton to pick up Maddie from the jailhouse, and even though she hadn't eaten in a week.

Just that good! Famously so.

The company she's keeping isn't paying her any attention.

He is in the ecstasy of a Jack's breakfast biscuit sandwich.

She's done about finally had it, and she thinks she might be in trouble with the McShan Mafia—of all things for a Pickens County legacy girl to go and do!

Jane Ellen has been realizing in those last days that she might be in trouble, realizing that she has really done and gone and went and made a mistake in pursuing the crow issue in the manner she's gone about it

this last year, and, by this point, it is dawning on her finally, her realizing that she made a mistake in pursuing the damn crow issue, something she'll never find out for sure, though she suspects some folks in the gentry are angry with her, particularly some forces in Tuscaloosa with reach in Pickens—she'll never figure it out, ultimately, the matters in regard as to if people have had it with her bullshit, since dead people, after all, don't get to renew their understanding of mistaken notions, second chances no longer possible once things have twisted up and let off in that direction—Death.

It was true: these forces *had* had it with her bullshit, the invisible forces of power in the legacy that are situated over in Tuscaloosa, the leadership of the McShan Mafia, where the power has been since 1993, with the death of Thaddeus Jr., all part of his legacy in its heritage.

After all, have you ever heard a dead chicken talk?

She was ugly. She was a crook, a true psychopathic, schizoid, anti-social white-collar criminal, a daughter of the legacy, a mother in the gentry, an old white lady involved in nefarious Pickens County doings all of which was to do with how they maintained the legacy at all costs as the pride of their heritage in their obsession with this legend called the Face in the Window.

It was true indeed, indeed, truth told... truly the reality that the crow investigation had been an outright *fatal* error from the outset and, at that point, just the money aspect should've worried her more than it had already, by then, though it *was* beginning to worry her, enough to feel the heat.

She was in so much trouble.

See, regarding the crows, she had misappropriated so much money, had dipped into funds set aside for other matters—that and more, novel financial crimes left and right this woman committed. She didn't know what she was doing, lost without the leadership of Thaddeus Jr., who just told her what to do and she did, no such guidance, those latter days of hers in this world and on this Earth.

By that mid-March, she was realizing what she had gone and went and done, though, at last, had a little inkling in her and gnawing at her, and she found herself in a new desperation, starting to get it in her ugly head, a rare click she could hear in a crack in her cartilage and neck ligaments, as it was so rare that she had cerebral uptake of anything and her mechanisms of knowledge were unoiled and rusty—she had committed some financial crimes, big ones, and by total 'naccident in her ignorance of the law, all a big mistake and then a few more downstream and branching off in further compliance issues with the law. As she was becoming aware, what she had been doing in regard to paying the van de Tuffin man was actively and actually straight up *defrauding* the non-profit called the Window Watchers, and all just to pay this Tuffin van de Kevin man.

In over her little pretty ugly head.

She was indeed panicking because she was slowly realizing what she had gone and went and did.

"What am I gon' do, Jeffrey?"

She is asking this question a lot, asking the company she, at this point, has been keeping since 1969, a poltergeist named Jeffrey, since the year that folklorist and ghost story collector Kathryn Windham Tucker told all the world about her Jeffrey, her Alabama house famously haunted by the poltergeist she named Jeffrey and had a photo of—a shadow hitting a wall in her stairwell, the subject of this famous image, that photo of a shadow hitting a wall, another one in the legacy who was dead serious and pointing at something idiotic and expecting you to take it in and mistake legend as history. A picture of a damn shadow on a wall.

She kept some odd company, for sure, Jane Ellen, and Jeffrey the famous Alabama poltergeist was some of the company she kept.

"What do I gotta do, Jeffrey? Are they-*uhhh* gonna kill me?! Wutttt-*uhhh* am I-*uhhh* gon' toh'do?! Jeffrey, Jeffrey, please-*uhhh* help me out-*uhhh*... I don't know-*uhhh* h'WHUT I'm gon' do... I don't know h'WHUT I'm gon' do... "

She is keeping this company and losing what few marbles she has left.

This here Jane Ellen and her spooks, her poltergeists and ghosts... her and that windah... idiot Jane Ellen and her pride in the heritage of the legend as the history of the legacy...

She's been keeping the company she keeps and doing some weird shit, for sure.

Facing a wall, back turned to the room she is in, she has asked this question—what was she gon' do now?—of a particular wall in her Carrollton home so many times in these last days of hers, alone in her home and talking to the shadows on the wall at night by candlelight; she's been sitting in a dining room chair in the hallway, sitting in the narrow and long hallway in her grand downtown Carrollton home, sitting in the hallway and at the end of it where the mirror and a small bookshelf are, and this is her church, where she talks to the dead, where she tries to talk to dead Black people who are relevant to the legacy of the Old South, and these shadows on the walls are entities she has long called "her spooks," "her" "spooks."

There she'd be her talking to the shadows on the wall, chatting up her spooks.

Her and her spooks, her favorite one being Henry Wells, of course —these people... it is not politically correct, but. They're truly proud idiots.

She was an idiot, a big one, had the untreated schizzy whizzies, had the schizzies, too, was enabled, too. She made herself useful to the legacy in accepting her position as the executive director of the Window Watchers.

She was actually and literally, and by the letter of the law, defrauding the non-profit and was only just then realizing because, mostly out of an avoidant denial of her incompetency and irresponsibility, she had neglected keeping the books on this project, and she had finally started to look at it all.

A criminal—Oh my word, what am I gon' do now? she was like

over and over in her head, the novel anxiety she'd never known becoming familiar to her—she was so good at being avoidant, one of her true talents, her capacity to thin out her attention and direct in crooked manners that which it could tend to in its novel narrowness, her walking around with her crooked neck, looking like a plumbing tool set to an angle for a difficult job with tight and fussy corners as fussy and aggravating as her.

She had busied about for a long time in her native Carrollton but she was finally recognized in a major way, the last year or so.

This here professor with whom she found herself speaking that morning is white, but he had him a surname that she just could not place and, when she had asked him recently of what stock his people are, he had had no idea, which is about as much as he had seemed and seems to know about anything, including zoology and crows, nothing in his skull but separately set and side-oriented eyes, and teeth that look like fingernails, jagged and chewed, sharp, too long.

A few days prior, Jane Ellen and Ugly had been counting cash at the cabin in the McShan Woods that the McShan Mafia owned, one of their many safe houses in the area.

"He-*uhhh* may-*uhhh* as-ah well-*uhhh*'ah'been from Brazil," she had told the woman they called Ugly the other day as they worked on the Window Watchers books.

She continued, talking to Ugly, "The way he doesn't-*uhhh* even know where his people-*uhhh* are from. My, and a *professah-uhhh* at a major-*uhhh* univers'dity-*uhhh*, what we have let our country come to. Goddamn you, Martin Luther King *Juuniyah*!!!"

She raised her fists in fury.

Ugly was eating her bologna sandwich and had stringy shards of discount Piggly Wiggly sandwich meat stuck in her mouth corners, along with bread; Ugly was always eating a bologna sandwich.

That was the other day.

Jane Ellen hated Ugly, hated to work with her, didn't like her religious politics, or looking at her—Ugly didn't have a nose—but she

had no choice and they were on the same team, both local hands for the McShan Mafia, the woman called Ugly being one of the most reliable and most trusted hands amongst the gentry criminal employee roster, a ghost story lynching window enterprise in Pickens County. She always wore sunglasses even though she didn't' have a nose—nobody knew how they stayed on her ugly face.

Ugly could barely contain her laughter when she saw what Jane Ellen had gone and done; Ugly hated Jane Ellen as much as Jane Ellen hated her and the schadenfreude was piping hot. The books were a mess. Every time she looked at Jane Ellen's dumbass, her nose hole whistled with glee.

Regarding the company she was keeping on the square, the zoologist, Jane Ellen was bubbling and was feeling a judgment of him but didn't let it fully surface.

She was making this ambivalence clear when she walked around the nice big house that she had and lived in over in the wealthy white residential area off downtown over in Carrollton, talking to herself and muttering, making it clear to present company this about the judgment and her fear of it, her novel anxiety and desperation, talking to the thin air because she likes to keep Jeffrey the poltergeist for company, her little oddball quirk she's got amongst other schizoid tendencies.

"I have-*uhhh*, uh...h'well, Jeffrey, I-*uhhh*'ve, uh.. avoided? Avoided looking directly at-*uhhh* it," she said one day, recently, muttering to herself and dusting her Henry curios at her house, some she kept on a shelf in her own big nice white-lady sunroom.

She couldn't even finish the statement.

She was pissing in the guest bathroom after dustin' her Henry curios she had lining the top of the claw-foot tub, one of which was a soap holder shaped like a window. She was on the commode and then she saw a shadow on the wall move—"There he is, *Jeffrey*!"

"I am ah-*uhhh*'tellin' yew, Kat-*uhhh*! I am-ah-*uhhh* telling you-*uhhh* that I know-*uhhh* what I saw-*uhhh* and I know-*uhhh* **H'WAHT** I know-*uhhh* and I know-*uhhh* that <u>HE **IS IN MY *HOUSE***</u>, *too*!

Jeffrah-*uhhh*'ree'ay visits me-*uhhh*. He does! **I <u>don't</u> know <u>WHY</u> *you are* <u>snickerin'</u>**—it ain't funny, Kat-*uhhh*. **Listen**! Kat-*uhhh*, listen to me! I am worried he is going to kill me-*uhhh*. When I turn up ded'n'ah'floatin' over in Lake Tuscaloosa, *you'll* ***wish***-uhhh *you*-uhhh*'d listen'd then*! **<u>LISTEN</u>-*uhhh* to-*uhhh* me-<u>UHHH</u>!.**"

All she wonted was some attention.

Endless with this woman. She wasn't afraid of no fucking Jeffrey and talked to him all the time.

"Now, look, Jane Ellen, I done told you that Jeffrey don't bite," Mrs. Windham told Jane Ellen one night after she called in the middle of the night having a panic attack.

The famous Alabama folklorist Katherine Tucker Windham had actually, recently, started to avoid her phone calls. Mrs. Windham would pick up and see who's there, and just hang up if it were Jane Ellen, telling her later, every time—when she'd inevitably see her at some function, given Jane Ellen's unique talent at being everywhere all the time, especially if it meant hob-knobbin' when she was boppin' about—that she didn't know what happened—some wires getting crossed, no idea, she'd be like and wave her away. Maybe it was Jeffrey, who knows.

Just wontin' some damn attention, really—all that motivated our local historian, Jane Ellen.

She was callin' Katherine nonstop, there for a while, ringin' up at some ungodly hour "with her nerves upset" because she'd sighted Jeffrey at her Carrollton home at the wrong moment and it'd given her a scare. Just nonsense. She was also always inviting herself over to the house in Thomasville, over in Clarke County where this ghost story telling lady lived with Jeffrey herself, had a photo and everything and wouldn't shut up about it in her *13 Ghosts and Jeffrey* series—same damn story in every book, same damn photo of a shadow on her fuckin' wall, the only evidence she had that she had a poltergeist in her damn house. Just another old white Southern lady stuck on repeat in the recursive South and its local commons, on about whatever—on

about some legend which was her pride in the heritage of the legacy of the Old South, that one was—all her deal was, too.

She didn't see Jeffrey, didn't see shit, her just literally muttering to herself and talking to shadows on the wall, this crazy old white woman with the schizzies and the idiocy, and this was her heritage.

The thing was, and this is the truth told: she didn't know how to look for *squash shit*. She was deaf and blind, and Jesus probably don't claim her.

We are talking about RICO charges territory with this Jane Ellen. This is serious stuff. The Mexican cartels are involved... just all sorts of trouble ah'comin' to Pickens...

She is in so much damn trouble by this March Friday in '94, this fuckin' old woman—truly impressive skills at the walking onto rakes.

So, she had avoided looking directly at it, avoided making an honest assessment of the Tulane professor's silly activities that went nowhere because such an assessment would've indicted her too, since she had hired him, and, so, she continued to facilitate payments from the Window Watchers funds because she would rather be in denial of how foolish her hiring practices were than make any executive decisions worth something or not make it worse, her having already technically having been defrauding the Window Watcher with abandon—itself just money laundering, for the most part, anyhow, mind, blackmail and extortion, too, but that was Ugly's wheelhouse and not Jane Ellen's, that a job for somebody even uglier than Jane Ellen, uglier and smarter, these delicate matters of legacy maintenance through violence—her just wholly unqualified for this directorship position, an imbecile.

But for indeed, a true idiot herself, she, and in an uneven manner tempered by her moods and flavored with her ever changing and confused notions with the schizophrenia and all in tow, was getting vaguely worried that he were an unqualified and even dumb man, and, downstream of that, though she couldn't truly and fully admit it, she knew that his presence was a mistake and one made by her hand. This

ambivalence in her psyche and its concurrent cognitive dissonance caused a lot of unbridled psychological projection on her part, her censuring him in her mind and constantly evaluating him with her eyes, sending him darting looks of condescension, pardoning herself amidst it all—in denial and seeing the Truth knock at her door and she kept pretending she wasn't home, and Death was right after; she couldn't run anymore and the jig of her life was 'bout up—making the situation worse because she had no self-awareness.

She would absolutely give him the famous Look. He was just one of those crackers that just got under her skin even if his loyalty to the h'white race was clear, and for certainly Kevin was a happy and inadequate white man and he was a racist, indeed.

But there they are, Jane Ellen and her present company, flounder the van de Tuffin, and she is asking him about his progress.

Her ankles have dew on them and dried blood from the crow pecks.

"Umph, *phew*, phewwww boy," he is saying with his mouth full, so full, hungry and happy and free.

"Good, it's so good, Mrs. Hadley, that Jack's."

He said that and she rolled her eyes and was quiet for a moment.

Reluctantly, she agrees with a mutter, Jack's precious flavor undeniable, her rolling her eyes and not hiding it.

Consumed with his gullet, eyes looking inwards towards his centerpiece nose to center his chew's gravity, he doesn't see her making her nasty faces at him—never did, though she rolls her eyes all the time at him.

The Tulane professor is stuffing his van de Tuffin face, making noises, gobbling his breakfast, ramming his second Jack's sausage biscuit down his food chute of a mouth and throat, drowning in grape jelly and grease, his second biscuit of the day and also his second during their casual meeting. He is always ravenous.

"It is so gluttonous," Jane Ellen thinks and does often say to others about him.

No progress had been made and she was figuring it never would be, and she didn’t know what to do besides pretend it wasn’t happening and just continue draining the Window Watchers of its illicit cash that was backed by guns, gang violence.

This man was some random zoologist who Jane Ellen had gone and found, no clue what she needed or what she was doing; she had no idea about any of the matters of concern and neither did he. The crows were everywhere. He couldn't make sense of their behavior, hadn't really tried, really. In any case, no progress made literally at all, a full failure going on months by then, he had been given more than several handsome cash installments by the Window Watchers, Hadley counting the bills in the secret safe and cash room at the so-called non-profit's actual headquarters, a cabin by a small lake somewhere in the McShan Woods off Highway 82, right before you get to the pin needle-sized Pickens town of Ethelsville and then Mississippi.

Jane Ellen was the most annoying Hadley and one of two of the last standing, all of her siblings and cousins and in-laws and all long passed, a widow, her the last Hadley around beyond her daughter, who was the Pizza Doctor owner and proprietor, a place Kevin van de Tuffin also loved so much, acting like New Orleans didn't have any food or something; Pickens County was cheaper than New Orleans and he was flush with illicit cash in excessive and suspicious sums.

She was so annoying, a pester. Her bothering people was all to do with her vision of herself as a “local historian,” an expert on the Face in the Window.

So, Jane Ellen had this bit, see, one to which she committed her life, this I’m-a-historian, delusional nonsense of hers, committed to it and she didn't know the bit was just an ignorant dance with herself and nobody else of importance, taking herself so seriously. She was truly and in fact known by many as a local historian, something most would say with a laugh behind her back, her a woman who did earn a liberal arts degree over at the University in Tuscaloosa but only because the professors gave the rich white kids passing grades that were all

unearned. History was her passion, her idea of it, at least. She was obsessed with the history of the Face in the Window.

She was in so much trouble.

What she had done—beyond defrauding her handlers in Tuscaloosa and the McShan Woods—she had actually found old *Pickens County Herald* news clippings from the nineteenth century that flipped the entire Face in the Window narrative: *first of all*, there was *no window there at all* February 1878, the courthouse under construction and there just a window frame, no window at all, by the supposed time of Wells' purported lynching, it impossible that the "lightning fireball" printed his for reasons beyond the already covered physics of image transmission and the nature of lighting, as the window simply didn't exist, also a mighty big concern when it came to the physics of the Face in the Window; *second*, *he wasn't lynched*, really and truly, sadly dying instead nonetheless in his jail cell from an infected gunshot wound, which, at the end of the day, was him dying under the cruel foot of white supremacy in the Reconstruction South, but just not technically a lynching.

None of it was true.

None of it. It was all totally and completely made up.

The nature of the discovery was not obvious to Jane Ellen—she just thought some shit like well, it complicates matters, but that's history, always something new to figure out, just horse crap crock nonsense like that.

She could barely contain it, wanted to tell everybody, but she did keep it to herself and for reasons mysterious to even herself. She was also really busy with the Window Watchers at the time of discovery and too busy to insist amongst the gentry about her notions. And, fundamentally, she just had no idea that she had blown up the entire narrative. It was a ghost story, so who cares about the specifics; that was his face, end of story, no matter what she found.

"Just a born historian!"

She would declare and yell it, "I-*uhhh* was-ah-*uhhh* just *born*

to'ah-*uhhh* be-ah *historian*!"

She would always be on about it: history and how good she was "at it"—"just so good'*ah*'d'eht," she be like and she'd say.

She wasn't, wasn't "good at it," history, or much of anything else, for that matter besides tying herself in ungodly knots of intrigue. This hateful and mighty bigoted woman could barely read.

She was just *obsessed* with old newspapers, however illiterate she was.

"Seems *germane*," she'd say, showing somebody some old and irrelevant newspaper article, nonsense, usually.

Due to her position in society, they humored her and it makes her so delusional by old age that she then didn't know right from left, up from down. She got away with so much that Itragene would've never gotten away with, Itragene, despite being upper crust herself, labelled crazy from an early age. Itragene was crazy and Mrs. Hadley was just annoying. Itragene didn't uphold the legacy and Jane Ellen did—only this distinguished them, Itragene coming from one of the most preeminent heritage families of the legacy in the Old South.

"She can't help herself, bless her heart. She loves them newspapers," they'd say around town.

She bothered people to the point that it was often truly and legally harassment, criminal behavior of a predatory nature and she would get away with it. She'd call you at any time of the day. She'd show up to your house, screaming about the newspapers she had or asking to see your photo albums and personal official documents family collections, shaking people's family bibles on coffee table and examining the hair locks that fell out, she'd interrupt supper or a baptism to tell you what she thought she had to tell you immediately. She'd get away with it, too, tipping her glass of sweet tea at you and laughing later after she harasses you into coming over for some supper at the Hadley supper table, out of her gourd, no idea why she's even laughing when she'd do it. She was unhinged.

Newspapers, some money and the house she inherited and her

daughter was all she had, that Jane Ellen. It was mostly just Jane Ellen and her newspapers. Her Elisa worked a lot over at the Carrollton square Pizza Doctor.

"I've-*uhhh* just got the histor*ee* bug-*uhhh*, can't help it! I've got the history bug! I just love it, you know," she'd say, surrounded by old newspapers, lost.

"I'm just so good at it," she'd endlessly boast, never once embarrassed about it.

The crow thing was afield from her historical work, but she was really invested in it, wanted to be a hero, trying to be great and up to no good, which is what most people are who try to be great are doing, being up to no good. Trying to be good was better and Jane Ellen had never taken to behaving or listening to nobody—nobody but her daddy and Thaddeus Jr. and they were assuredly dead as they were Klan through and though.

Being in charge of the Window Watchers had gone to her empty head. She was on a power kick, using funds she had no business allotting to anything such as this van de Tuffin man.

She got obsessed with the crow issue, at a point in 1993, fall, when she started seeking assistance. She was lost without the guidance of Thaddeus Jr.

She called all over the Southeast looking for assistance with her too-many-dozens of crows to count in her beloved Carrollton—"just too-many-dozens-to-count, a bunch of crows!" she'd said to anybody whom she could get on the phone, too many crows, too many that exceeded the local egg unit calculus of dozens and its halves.

After no success calling all over, finally, there was Kevin, a professor over and down in New Orleans who called her back, a zoologist nominally employed at Tulane, a man who gave his word that he would be able to finally crack the crow case.

"I wrote a widely-sourced article on crow behavior, matter of fact, Mrs. Hadley," he had told her on the phone—a lie, it was actually an encyclopedia entry that nobody had ever read, a piece that he had paid

the publication to publish and the content of which he had forgotten, publishing it years ago, his only activity at all as a scholar of the animal kingdom.

Jane Ellen had secured this funding for a man who, ultimately, had no idea, either, her a fraudster and him a fraud, this man doing nothing more than falling in love with the regional burger franchise Jack's, as well as the local Pickens county pizzeria, Pizza Doctor, but only the location in downtown Carrollton right on the square, a pizza place right next to the county jailhouse, him not liking the other, second location that they tried opening over in Reform, the Reform location the first attempt at franchising something that was designated to remain strictly in the front yard of Henry's Garden, this Pizza Doctor pizza place, which everybody loved. The Tulane professor was so hungry and wasteful with his Window Watchers payouts that he basically funneled all the money back into the county's local economy eating Jack's sausage biscuits and pepperoni pizzas with a lot of cheese from Pizza Doctor, where Jane Ellen's daughter worked as the only worker, usually, her the manager and store owner, proprietor. Cheap and with no regard for her own wellness, she almost never had any help, her cutting corners, costs and her life short, never having any staff beyond herself, her making so many pizzas alone, mad at you for coming in for a pizza, irritated but productive, making so many pizza pies, an amazing amount, her an elf with her pizza tools and toppings, a pizza banshee in a wild forest of towering and filled pizza boxes, big and square, canopies of orders ready for pickup in her shop, dozens every half an hour sometimes, every fifteen minutes during high school football season on Fridays, a pizza-making Olympian and she had had no training beyond hard work down at the Pizza Doctor. Young Hadley had created magic, did something useful, unlike her mother, Elisa Hadley in her pizza pie jungle, Pizza Doctor of Carrollton, Alabama, and it was just not something that could be franchised because they couldn't clone Jane Ellen's babygirl Elisa, a one-woman pizza printer, a pepperoni Picasso who'd write "Happy

Birthday" or whatever else you wanted on a pizza pie as long as it weren't vulgar, messages she'd lay out raw, rapidly and precisely writing with these fresh and cold pepperoni slices between her nimble fingers, these pepperonis, thick ones, coming out crispy and grease-pooled, the written message cooked in to fulfill the customer's chosen request for a pizza message, Elisa Hadley another fast one around town hooked on diet pill Phen-Phen and just a bendy straw of a person, rail-thin and bent over what she was doing real fast, a slurped out Slush Puppy in life, her tired, fast body, mind, all of it hurt, her in pain like a lot of the sorry folk around there—her soul ached, but she made the pizza, served the townspeople. Kevin couldn't get enough.

It is a chilly March morning and the crows are absolutely everywhere. Jane Ellen and the professor stand there in the county square, crows pecking at Jane Ellen twice the mere fifteen minutes they stood there discussing it all.

Hired late January, by mid-March, no progress has transpired, just not happening, and they've been at it for months, the two of them.

She worked for the McShan Mafia, the real gentry of Pickens County, Alabama, and she was a dead chicken walking.

You ever seen a biblically accurate chicken?

It's got beaks facing the four corners of the world and it is standing in an ocean of gravy sauce.

On the southwest corner of the square, a raven called Ezekiel flies away from where it has been perched on the Pizza Doctor front door awning. It flies so high and fast and it plays back the recording, *"No progress at all professor-uhhh?!" Cawwwwwwww-uhhh!"*

Ezekiel lands in McShan, greeted by a frail figure dressed in all black, a woman called Helen Belle Calloway, a faithful Mennonite woman. She lives in a tall structure that is built at the bottom of many hills deep in the McShan Woods over on some land owned by Pentecostal McShan lots of landowner Maw Maw Pascale. This is Big Iddy's grandmother, Maddie's too—that is, our Itragene's mother.

They said that the Mennonites all lived in one spot near downtown

Reform. But there were some much-rumored, never-seen McShan Mennonintes.

She is one of the much-rumored about McShan Mennonites—present in local legends of the McShan Woods, them saying since the 1800s that on some nights if the moon's right, you can see the Mennonite minutemen of the McShan Woods, mysterious Mennonites who patrol the nights in the McShan Woods.

Jane Ellen is walking away from the square and back to her house after this unsuccessful meeting regarding the progress on the crow problem that was never going to progress one bit. She adjusts a brooch on her jacket, which she always wears, an emerald raven with a bundles of sticks in its beak—*fasces*.

In any case, Jane Ellen and Kevin have nonetheless spent a lot of time together, over the last month in particular. As it was, in the end of all of this when it comes to the local historian, when it comes to Jane Ellen and her demise—as it'd come to pass, actually, Professor Kevin van de Tuffin *was one of the last people to see Jane Ellen alive…*

"Cawwwww. Caw. Caw—'no progress-uhhh!'"

"Hallelujah," it was said by Mrs. Plethora Sanders.

This was the Wednesday prior to Jane Ellen discussing with her company the lack of progress on the crow issue, Wednesday, March 16, 1994.

Itragene was there in that moment not only in her person, but perception. She had snapped back and she was in the square again, moments after the medicine man turned off the radio and Mrs. Sister Jackson's words from Ephesians about "the armor of God" had completed their time in the air as sound waves, words the preacher's wife had damn just yelled a second ago, the teacher's subsequent

speech—her Hallelujah—snapping Itragene to and from her silent and careful dancing with Henry in the privacy of her own Tokyo-level lit-up mind, her nearly falling and Mr. John Henry catching her arm just in time.

Itragene was over in Carrollton, downtown, there on the square amongst the company she had—there was our Itragene, and her interlocutors Mrs. Sister Jackson, the preacher's wife; Mrs. Plethora Sanders, the science teacher who could sing; and there was John Herny, the friendly local mortician—and Itragene was hearing this utterance of "Hallelujah," and the ground was spinning as she came back into her body, which she had exited at the occurrence of a synchronicity, one which she counted as a shekel, her fourth that day.

It was about 9am, still.

It was about bout forty-five minutes that had come to pass since Itragene first pulled her loud and slow Lincoln Town Car off of Court Street after taking Highway 17 to Carrollton via Highway 82, turned right and went around the roundabout, passing Phoenix and Tuscaloosa Avenues, turning south down Commerce Avenue and parking at the Carrollton Unit School parking lot, missing Maddie twice, once in the square and in front of the unit school just earlier.

She hadn't been there in Carrollton for long at all, and was ready to go home to Gordo,.

Only moments ago, the square had witnessed the crowd and Mrs. Plethora Sanders singing "God is in Control."

She had Men at Work's "Down Under" stuck in her head and an audio tape in her car radio. She loved that song, found it relevant to the US South even though it was a tune about Australia, the land down under.

The science teacher, Mrs. Sanders, had said it, the hallelujah which catalyzes sense anew in Itragene her proprioception, the hallelujah that begins to lead her back to her body where she actually is in time and space, a material and historical subject in the land of legacy, the land down under, indeed.

She lit a cigarette; she had just had one. Not much time had passed since her last one. The feeling in her hands returned, her vision cleared, and she was OK, in that moment, and she hadn't been moments earlier—moments that felt like an eternity of torture, though she had just earned herself a shekel with all of the synchronistic action in these moments and this makes her glad.

Hallelujah, indeed, she was thinking. I have *four shekels*, now, hot damn! We earn our keep, don't we, Jesus?

Itragene was snapping back and she was in the square again and she immediately then was tending in her shot attention to Mrs. Sister Jackson, who had just misquoted Ephesians and pissed her off in general with her ugly attitude that she has had on display since she approached them with that godawful cliché Look on her face that Itragene knew so well.

"I do believe you meant to say, 'Put *on* the armor of God'—'on,' 'on,' importantly. You were missing the preposition. The way you put it, not clear where you put the armor and this is Bible we're talking about, serious stuff! That's Bible for you, ain't, it, sister?"

Itragene said this and she smiled a wild smile, a mad Cheshire Cat display, the corners of her mouth stretched so wide her left jowl was in Columbus and her right in Tuscaloosa.

Mrs. Sister Jackson did not take lightly the correction.

She ignored it. She made a face, a vacant stare, flatlining in signal.

Itragene had an idea, then.

This vacant stare is a cousin of the Look, and it is the *Bless-Your-Heart Mask*, Itragene decides then and there, having always wanted to name this meme, but she had never cooked up anything funny enough, and Bless-Your-Heart Mask was funny enough. She almost laughed aloud, but didn't and in fact she chose not to, as it would've been a loud guffaw and she knew this about her constitution, sense of humor.

Itragene recognized this face and, in fact, took it as a victory, given that she had been the one to make Mrs. Sister Jackson go blank.

Swas wise enough to know that it is a deception that is a

boomerang, here, in the land down under. It's a gaslight, fundamentally, a personality-disordered habitus, this facial expression that is meant to steal a reality by acting as if they have no idea what you're on about or that you're on about anything at all; it is the sin of lying but amplified into the physical, taking thoughts, the epistemological and abstract, and negating the person who has them as a person in their person, an ontological affront.

Mrs. Sister Jackson was manipulating Itragene, acting like she hadn't said a word, but, in the end, she was the one who went numb, not Itragene, who could see the way history constricted the humanity of those who maintain the legacy as a pride in their bloody heritage. The legacy was a suicide cult, in so many ways; they killed themselves to spite themselves, killed themselves so that you dare not to live in their corporeal presence there in that legendary town of Carrollton.

"Sister *Eunice*?"

Itragene tried to get the preacher's wife's attention but only half-assedley, just sort of enjoying watching this dissociative number *Eunice*, who hated her first name, had just pulled, a trick on nobody but herself.

"*Hallelujah*," is said again.

John Henry and Mrs. Sanders said such, bolstering the hallelujah that had given Itragene the grace of being present, the sister still ignoring Itragene and looking like drywall in the face, blank.

There was a brief pause as the conversation was running thin and the four of them weren't really sure why they were still standing in a group.

Mrs. Sanders, spotting some friction, she started and stopped, trying in a sideways manner to soften the friction of Itragene's critique of the reading of Ephesians aloud, but she gives up.

Itragene had been nowhere, but they were still on the county square lawn, the four of them and all the hungry Mennonite Bread-buying third Wednesday-of-the-month crowd.

Mrs. Sister Jackson snapped back and continued on with her

enormous Bible 2.0 with its big-ass letters: "'P*ooh*t *aw*ohn the whol'ah*r*mor'*y*euv Go*h*d, tha't*y*ieu may'bee'ayble t*ooh* stan'*d*'g*ens*t the way*h*lz'v th'de*b*v*e*l,' Ephesians 6:11."

She smiled smugly, didn't miss a single word!

"Mr. Henry?" Itragene utters aloud, voice gravel.

"Yes, Itragene? Call me John—you always call me John, Ma."

He said this with a wry smile with eyes to match. He really liked Itragene, felt for the poor thing.

Itragene was dizzy, started to wobble.

Itragene stumbled for a moment, woozy, light-headed, her vision going black for a moment, replacing the magnificent and hallucinated light from within that she had been seeing inside of herself—her dizzy, woozy, woozy out of nowhere, but her mania was manifesting in waves and she, then, suddenly, just all of a sudden, she regained her grip on it all and then spoke in absolutely lucid terms, more lucid than she had all morning, speaking with force and affirmatively, while simultaneously realizing how entertaining, funny it was that she were talking to both Henry Wells and John Henry, two Henrys of a sort, both Henrys at the same time, independently, a dead man who was very much alive to her and a man whose biscuit was buttered by Pickens corpses, Mr. Wells and Mr. Henry, Henry and John, Mr. Henry and Mr. Wells, them together in Henry's Garden, earning a shekel in her mind, given the coincidental nomenclature that she noticed, for a total of five that day, so far, and it was so early; she was rich, in her mind, at least a five-shekel-an-hour earner, easy to keep track of, multiples of five, one short of half-a-dozen, her making that much at this rate, five-shekels-an-hour, though she knew it wasn't about money, but enumeration, about *things that add up to something that matter*, *things you can believe in*, and she had had so little to believe in in her life, and while, just as well, she had been privileged and close to money, she had never had any herself, the family symbol, though, for the financial and social, total fall for this family in this Southern gentry town, an old aristocratic town that needed scapegoats, and Itragene

represented everything that went wrong in town, everything the fault of people like her, people who never stood a chance.

"John, Jennifer, I'll see y'all later," Itragene said to the mortician and teacher.

"Bye, *Eunice*," she also said to the preacher's wife, coldly, while also silently but passionately filling in Ginsburg on who that bitch was.

"I've gotta go find Maddie; she was picked up last night and I gotta make sure my babygirl is OK," Itragene said.

Itragene's last statement was met by an eye roll that was, of course, on the part of Mrs. Eunice, Mrs. Sister Jackson, who did not hide it at all as she committed retinal acrobatics, shamelessly.

Itragene walked away from the north side county square lawn, Itragene, leaving her can, Bounty paper towel coaster and bandage on the ground, Mrs. Sister Jackson livid as hell looking at the refuse, and Maddie, then, came up on her while Itragene was walking around in front of the First Baptist Church just past the square on the east side (the Sister Jackson congregation), right before you get to Carrollton Food Mart.

The medicine man had begun blasting Aerosmith's 1993 "Crazy."

> Crazy...
> Crazy...

Maddie and Itragene were just finally about to link up at last in Carrollton to head back to the house in Gordo, and after a good while of looking for one another, each passing right by the other twice but not noticing, even though they were looking for one another. Itragene was high on Phen-Phen Alabama diet pills and Maddie had not fully sobered up her few hours she'd been laying there in the cell at the jailhouse.

Itragene hadn't slept in near a week and had gone to Carrollton to pick up Maddie that morning, encountering a bunch of Lavender Pest Control trucks on her way and collecting her shekels (she had three by

the time she hit Carrollton, according to the math "Ruth Bader Ginsburg" had led her through on the drive, applied Shekel Math). Maddie had just been released from the county jailhouse after yet another night where she got picked up on disorderly conduct, an average evening; Itragene had known to pick her up because she had heard that morning on the police scanner in the wee hours that her Maddie had been picked up by the County Sheriff. Itragene had been standing on the square talking to Mrs. Sister Jackson, Mrs. Plethora Sandres and John Henry—the preacher's wife, the science teacher and singer, and the local mortician and funeral home director, respectively.

Itragene had said her goodbye and left the square and was wandering up Court Street, looking for Maddie, who had seen the Lincoln Town Car in the Carrollton Unit School student parking lot and hopped in and started driving around looking for her mama, figuring it'd be quicker than any search and rescue operation her mama would head up, who she already knew would know to be there to pick her up because her mama was addicted to the police scanner and had been staying up all night lately, no need in calling her.

Maddie had hopped in the car and set off up Commerce Avenue moments earlier.

9:15am.

She then went around the courthouse square roundabout, exiting off Court Street, when she saw her mama looking like a chicken with half its feathers missing that fell of a truck on Highway 82, just looking pathetic walking down the street in her slippers and muumuu; she was risking another DUI, Maddie, still a little drunk, not having all her feathers, either. She burped and thought about how she should enter her mama into an ugly dog competition at the upcoming Mule Day festival in Gordo and giggled. She was a fun person.

Maddie turned left off the square roundabout and headed down Court Street, where she saw her mama walking down the road.

Maddie honked at Itragene, Itragene jumping and taking the honk as a sixth shekel for the morning because it lined up with the music

Maddie was blasting, at least in her head, the "sign" being the horn she heard—"*I saw the sign*"; *toot*.

This is how it had gone for her at once, a synchronicity in her mind, a sign, significantly and meaningfully so—"the sign" was one of the hits that year, 1994, "The Sign" by Ace of Base, music so full of meaning only she could decode in her manic mind

I saw the *sign*.

Itragene hopped in and fell right asleep, her warm biscuit breakfast sandwich having made her a bit drowsy, at last, the chorus carrying her off into the first slice of sleep that she had had in days, feeling comforted by her new Shekel Math skills and how rich she was going to be if things kept going as well as they had that morning, by her eye, her having a one a half-a-dozen shekels—and it was the first day, it almost or seemingly adding up to something significant, a non-zero number greater than or equal to six and less than twelve. You had a dozen, half-a-dozen of things or nothing to show at the end of the day, and, knowing this all so deeply, she rubbed her shekels together in her mind, her half-a-dozen shekels.

Maddie sped home, heading toward the house over in Gordo on Highway 82.

The family Town Car radio went on repeat, Maddie starting the tape over and over:

I saw the *sign*...

The radio on the highway with the windows down was loud and fun for Maddie:

... it opened up my eyes
I saw the sign...

Maddie bopped her head, her messy hair, singing along, "*I saw the sign*."

Itragene was asleep in the passenger seat, and, in her head, she sang to Henry Wells in a dark, smoke-filled pub, "*Je vois la vieeee ennnnn rose. Il me dit des mots d'amour...*," internally parroting with her neurons one of her favorite singers with uncanny skill and likeness —she had a high fidelity memory for behavior, memes—her memory of song one in high fidelity, an incredible and reflective memory Itragene had, her with those neurons of hers, Itragene just built different, her hearing the French "little sparrow," as she was known, Edith Piaf, a tortured woman like herself who released her international hit "*La Vie en Rose*" 1948, the year of Itragene's failed attempt at art school in Tuscaloosa, the year she had last truly lost her mind that time before..

The bump woke her when they hit the bridge halfway home, the bridge covering the creek, the Lurleen B. Wallace bridge, this bridge just on the outside of Reform, right past Jack's before you start getting into Gordo, all of this, like a lot of stuff in Pickens was situated, along Highway 82 between the towns of Gordo and Reform; the jump of the car at the bridge stirred her sleep, her thoughts rapidly sifting through things that happened in 1948, associating shit in her head with that year the Piaf song debuted and that year that was so significant for her —"Founding of Israel, *Baruch HaHeshua Yashauahei*...Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Marshall Plan, Gandhi's assassination, division of the Korean Peninsula, Harry S. Truman elected President...the Berlin Blockade...that class, that professor..." and she passed out, then, again, until they got home in downtown Gordo.

She knew everything about anything and was too smart for her own crazy ass's good, our Itragene. She usually lived by one motto that kept her safe, given her disposition and inclination towards "enthusiasms," as she called her spurts of pointed and manic activity: "*If you're trying to be great, you're probably up to no good, and that's*

why you should only try to be good."

She had forgotten that motto last days and was trying to be *great*, which included trying to know everything about everything all at once, everything now happening then at all times.

Once home, after they pulled up in the car port covered in ivy and leaves, next to the big pear tree, Itragene immediately went to the sun room, putting on her favorite Hebrew record, one of a half-a-dozen she had accumulated over the years—she put on a collection of Ashkenazi tunes specific and exclusive to rural Pennsylvania that she had found at a flea market, a record containing Hebrew lyrics that all observant Jews knew, but with a melody particular to the isolated, rural Jewish population of a particular part of Pennsylvania.

She put that on and danced, and she interpreted the lyrics in a magical way as she danced with vigor, doing in her head what she called "Alabama Kabbalah." Who knows what that was.

Itragene danced, danced with sincere rejoice and a genuine intensity nobody else in Pickens County had ever known no matter how ecstatic their fundamentalist take on Christianity, moved by some holy ghost or many ghosts, really, the ghost of Henry Wells, so many ghosts, her singing "*Ha-va...nagila, Ha-va...nagila, hava nagila ve-nis*mech*aaaaaa*," her dancing "hand-in-hand" with Ruth Bader Ginsburg, likely the only person from Pickens County ever, by that time, the first to do that in Pickens County—what she was doing, this Jewish shit—much less Gordo, a real, real white town, white as hell, a town where nobody had really met any Jews, unless they travelled, and most people never really went anywhere, and if they did, they never came back; it was a town where there were no Jews but they were always talked about, rarely by name, usually just called "*them*," — "*them*," "they"—they'd say, they'd talk about how "*they* killed Jesus," as they so endlessly said from behind the pulpit, whisper in the pews, it so common, this idea that the Jews killed God himself, deicide, it accepted as fact.

This was something Itragene rejected outright, her seeing that it

was clearly the Romans who had killed that man, “a Jewish man who loved the poor, hung out with prostitutes, and a guy who had a lot of love to give, him with many boyfriends, twelve, in fact, and he had a thing for feet,” Itragene would think all the time.

Stuff like this about the biography of her Lord, all of it so plausible and relevant to her, and it was moral in its counterintuitive implications as to for whom heaven was, the downtrodden, the “eunuchs” of the book of Matthew, polyamorous gay guys like Jesus, of course—and most importantly, she thought it was hilarious.

It'd just all be the best test—one big test and here comes THE JUDGEMENT and it’s a Jewish faggot who listens to Nina Somone and then the idiots will see they fucked up, ignored the Word.

Jesus would be the last one laughing—and she thought, good for that poor man... deserves whatever he *wonts*.

She danced and sang until Maddie made her shut up as she went to her bedroom in the back near the carport on the other side of the house, her bedroom where she had covered the windows with aluminum foil so she could sleep no matter the time of day.

Maddie ate her aluminum foil biscuit she had gotten, ate it before light sleep prior to her daily light shift down at the Piggly Wiggly, her putting in enough hours to act like she had a job—her “hoe hours” as she’d say, laughing, was where the money really came from that supported the two of them, herself and Itragene

Itragene kept silently dancing, dancing and doing “Alabama Kabbalah” in her head, what she called “Alabama Kabbalah”—which was, by all functions, something that could really be called “Alabama Kabbalah”—she then passed out on her sun room couch for some time, around noon, Maddie leaving around 1pm, Thaddeus’ snoring from the crib waking Itragene up, a snore only she could hear, her dead daddy snoring in that crib, where he fit because he didn’t have no legs, at least in Itragene’s head, because she was crazy; Maddie could feel it, somehow, though, too, the presence of Thaddeus, his rhythm presented in her memory—Maddie was on the shoulder of the highway of sane,

so, still on the road but riding those bumps on the shoulder and it's a rough ride and she's too drunk to drive.

Maddie pulled onto Highway 82 from Main Street, downtown Gordo, going right towards the Piggly Wiggly, bopping her head to the '94 hit "100% Pure Love" by Crystal Waters.

Had she heard her mama whisper something about some "shekel math"? Maddie wondered this while driving, tired as hell—"*My fuckkk,* I hope not, hope it's not some new thing like that fucking goddamn 'Lots Logic' she tortured us with growing up," she worried.

By that weekend, the weekend that the Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre comes to pass (the meme about Jane Ellen's murder), there was another arrival in town from Tulane, a new force in town, somebody beyond the zoologist Keven van de Tuffin.

Incidentally and recently having met Dr. Kevin van de Tuffin, the zoologist, the two of them meeting while dealing with some shared university logistics down at Tulane, a well-known scholar and polymath eccentric, Dr. Katherine Mann, moved to Pickens County to conduct some research for her new book project. A Tulane social sciences professor, a sociologist, she first arrived just prior to this weekend for a planned extended stay in Pickens County this spring weekend of 1994, arriving this third eventful week of the month of March, the same week Itragene is losing her mind totally and completely.

Dr. Mann is a woman who is in her forties, residing in New Orleans. She is originally from rural Pennsylvania, Chambersburg, growing up in a small Ashkenazi Jewish community. Her birthname name is a very Jewish one—she was called Rachel Rivka.

She is called Dr. Katherine Mann—this is her alias, the girl called Rivka by her mother, and her alias is "Katherine Mann."

Not only is Katherine a fine and top-ranked American sociologist: she is former intelligence. FBI.

A full professor, she's also a retired FBI agent.

Before arriving, Dr. Katherine Mann has had no idea how things could ultimately go, and there was no way she could've, even with her training in intelligence for precisely the sort of criminal activity going on around the place where she has been set to arrive. Pickens County is indecipherable—too many wild notions and wild-minded people with no shame who do just about anything and in a way that is not predictable. There are, in fact, by this time in '94, eyes on Pickens County—there have been since 1989. The McShan Mafia had been running around unabated since the 1940s, undetected, until the recent point of '89, when what they had been running around doing came under scrutiny. Intelligence first noticed the criminal operation due to their monitoring of the Gulf Cartel's presence in the US South. The FBI watching Pickens County, they have, so far, found the place indecipherable; they do not have near enough human intelligence (HUMINT) on the ground.

Katherine is a very funny woman, as funny as she is sharp; she is eccentric, too. She has long conceived of her life as performance art. She's been planning to write a book on it one day, but that is not the book she's found herself moving to Pickens County to write—that will be later, if pursued.

Rivka was her birth name and her bit has long been Katherine, the sociology professor.

She began playing Katherine Mann as a false identity after becoming an FBI agent years before she began graduate school. Her academic career had been a front for fighting white power gangs across the United States; her focus was Cascadia when she was on active duty, the Pacific Northwest. By 1994, she had left intelligence, served her time, and she simply wanted a fun, post-sabbatical book

project, finding herself in Pickens County, home of the famous Face in the Window.

She has always enjoyed being an academic. She's very smart, astute.

A well-regarded scholar across several disciplines, she's made serious academic contributions at her day job; for her other, undercover job, which was a day job as much as a night job, she fought white power domestic terrorism with her bones and blood.

She was educated as an undergraduate at Harvard, with the University of California, Berkeley, as her alma mater for her PhD in sociology. She identifies as a lesbian, though she has no plans to disclose that fact in a place like Pickens County—not that she has to say anything, because she has what she calls "a lesbian neck." She is very handsome and has always sported a haircut that would tell on her, as well—short on the sides, a bit to play with up top. Her hair is pitch black and so are her eyes; she is difficult to read because you cannot see her pupils, which is arresting.

She's gotten involved with Pickens County by such dramatic coincidence. She'll eventually publish a book about the so-called face in the widow, one would bet meeting her, her, upon arrival, clearly doggedly determined to understand the legend of the Face in the Window, and it is a project she will develop and that she had come upon by coincidence, like a lot of great academic projects start. Specifically, her involvement began as an indirect consequence of Mrs. Hadley seeking out crow expertise, in fact, downstream of Jane Ellen's nonsense. Katherine has known the zoologist for a bit, because their classes had shared the same writing center tutor at Tulane fall '93; the prior fall term, having made a trip to Pickens County and having collected some impressions of the place, Kevin van de Tuffin, on a brief visit back in New Orleans, had casually told Katherine about Pickens County, the Face in the Window, the Mennonite Bread, the Flat Sisters of Gordo, *yada yada*, telling her all of this as they were sitting in the Tulane University writing center waiting room to meet

with a writing tutor they had shared to sort out some logistical matters regarding some unfinished paperwork they'd both failed to complete from the prior term. Curious about Pickens County from what little he had told her, she befriended him as a source, somebody she was considering a source because he was so closely linked to the thing that fascinated her, which is the Face in the Window. She thought about how surreal and ugly the place sounded. She'd never heard of Pickens County. He'd be the one to introduce her to Jane Ellen, too, Kevin the zoologist.

After learning about the place, she would drive up a few times that winter and early spring, ultimately making this most recent drive of hers to Pickens County to meet him again—this time for good, for a bit, her showing up for the third time and final time for a stay this March 16, 1994, the Wednesday that the Mennonites sold bread on the county square.

Move-in day, Wednesday, March 16, 1994s—as of this weekend, she’s been in town since Wednesday.

She’s been settling in this week for research and nesting in her rental house. She is going to stay for a while, settling just off of Phoenix Avenue in the wealthy white area in downtown Carrollton, one of Mrs. Hadley's neighbors, in fact.

A force to reckon with has arrived in Pickens—a liberal dyke who’d cut her teeth fighting white power gangs in intelligence—and it never would’ve never happened was it not for Hadley's meddling in the crow business.

On Sabbatical, eyes on the Face in the Window, she has been looking for a new project, freshly tenured and needing a third book project, looking for something juicy and controversial. She has nothing much left to prove in her field, though she has always been considered too theoretical for some tastes, her second book a high-concept work of social theory, a prize-winning auto-ethnography of mental healthcare institutions—institutions she once frequented as a patient dealing with the purported trauma she had incurred completing her

first book project on white power gangs around Portland. She had actually been fine, a tough Jew—even though most of nobody ever knows this, her playing a gentile who needed some help at the hospital —she didn't need to go to the hospital. It was pretty funny to her to do that, really, because it was and is all a big *bit* for her; she has long considered herself an amateur performance artist; she was fine, had been fine, and she hadn't needed a hospital stay, didn't need it, doing it for the ethnographic data, going to the hospital. In her private thoughts of comfort, she often giggles, likening herself to being the Andy Kaufman of Southern, American sociology; she has made the joke at cocktail parties, confounding her interlocutors, "I am the Andy Kaufman of American sociology, hah!"

She is loving it, still, this life, her life as her just doing a bit, and the bit has always worked, and it still works, her second book based upon her times in the hospital a major contribution to sociological, historical and broad theoretical discourse across many fields, a fusion of post-Marxist historical materialist discourse analysis and evolutionary theory, a synthesis she would continue elaborating in her study of Henry Wells and that window.

The Face in the Window, in her academic understanding from the outset is a *meme*, a coin termed by evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins in 1976 in his book *The Selfish Gene*, a book our Itragene Sr. has a copy of, heavily marked with her marginalia. A meme is, per Dawkin's definition, "a unit of culture." They just had repeated it so much and have kept on doing it, and, so, it has evolved, the Face in the Window meme, this their culture, like their genes, their memes too; this is the heritage of the legend in the legacy. Itragene knew about gardening and she knew about this stuff, memetic evolutionary theory. People pass memes around. Memes are replicators that carry information and, as replicators, replicate and evolve, just as the Face in the Window has evolved so much by this point.

Katherine had found herself utterly fascinated by this town with its ghost stories, its Mennonite Bread the reputation of which preceded its

carbohydrate manifestation and the private lives of this sordid place of which she is wanting more than a whiff. She's eager to learn anything, in her plenary discovery stage of research. At this time, she is weighing options for approaches to this bizarre topic of the Face in the Window, themes and hypotheses, gaps in the sociological literature, any contribution she could make beyond sociology, as well, especially history, her beloved other-field that she fetishized in her interdisciplinary efforts, that and literature, and none of that mattered in her final decision to move to Pickens.

She had already been hooked for a good bit, and has only gotten more hooked; she found herself, on a prior trip, buying a notebook, her first trip to Pickens County, a cheap Memo notebook that she got at a dollar store in Aliceville, the "Black town," which she was advised on not visiting, advised on it as such by Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley with an expectant and punitive look, looking at Katherine like *"You ain't a* [you-know-what]*-lover, are you*?"

She has been hooked for a bit.

She has moved there just this last Wednesday, and now she is learning about something that is the most amusing shit in the world, she feels, this Saturday evening, learning about the thing that is amusing her so. Though already committed to the book project about Pickens County, she has just become more hooked, hooked for good.

Somebody has just told her something really funny and she's holding in what would surely be wild laughter if she let it out.

Jane Ellen has just sealed the deal, hooked her like a fish; Jane Ellen Hadley, her unfortunate tour guide and key Carrollton informant, has just told her something that stuns her, amused as hell.

It's Saturday night, March 19, the night before Jane Ellen is murdered.

Jane Ellen, the so-called local historian, is hosting the two Tulane professors for a at her downtown Carrollton home at the Hadley supper table.

They are sitting at the Hadley supper table.

"Nobody-*uhhh* knows her name-*uhhh*, but everybody calls-*uhhh* her '*Ugly*.'"

Jane Ellen said that.

At that, Jane Ellen, having put forth this locution at her house over the supper table to her supper guests, Drs. van de Tuffin and Mann, is looking at her guests like what she's said such a banal and trivial thing, swiveling her crooked neck to each side. Jane Ellen is sitting at the head of the table and Kevin is to her left, Katherine her right; due to the left-leaning nature of her crooked neck, Jane Ellen has to swivel to her right to see Katherine.

The line near murders Katherine, a comment so outlandish, unforeseen, and, in a way, totally intuitive given what she already knows by this rate about this horrible place on the Alabama-Mississippi border,

The funny, the funny way it sounds—*they call her Ugly*—corresponds to how odd and crazy Pickens County seems to be to Katherine in all actuality.

"People call her ugly?"

Katherine asked for clarification.

Katherine, the sociologist's sociologist, sees operationalized discourse everywhere she turns, discourse and *power*, a rare poststructuralist in the stuffy field of sociology as it existed at the time in the US academy broadly, but particularly the conservative US South. She sees power at play in such a notion of whatever Mrs. Hadley is getting at here with this locution, "they call her Ugly."

Containing her laugher, Katherine is nearly choking on her too salty but delightfully buttery mashed potatoes.

Funny to her out the gate, on its face—just the way it sounds, not even its meaning, "they call her Ugly"—it is just so funny sounding and she's got so many questions about the woman called Ugly, like: "Why does a whole town call a person '*ugly*' and use that word in particular, rather than some synonym? How does power manifest in the word '*ugly*' versus, say, 'unattractive'? *Does the whole town literally*

call her ugly, just an adjective, or 'Ugly,' rather, like a proper name? Is it like that, could it truly be that way, as in: 'Hey there, Ugly, how're you?' Is she, in fact, ugly?"

She is absolutely stunned by the place, finding herself quickly and silently beyond herself, this particular Saturday night at the Hadley supper table conversation, in this hilarious moment, immediately suspecting it to be the latter, indeed, that it is a matter of nomenclature, her goddamn *actual name* around town, that they literally go around calling this person "Ugly."

She has been thinking, in these early days, and has since her initial visits prior to moving there, that, if everybody were to visit Carrollton, Alabama, the surrealists in the art industry would be under mighty threat, as there would be no need for them, her thinking it was a riff on a Salvador Dalí quote about Mexico City and surrealism, but she can never find that original quote.

"People call her ugly, as in saying she's ugly, describing her, or do they actually call her 'Ugly,' like a name?"

Katherine asked that question.

Katherine is near losing it laughing.

Katherine has asked this, hearing what she's hearing, hearing what Jane Ellen has just said—that everybody properly calls some woman by the name Ugly.

There is no yes/no question posed to her, but Jane Ellen is answering as such, indicative of the ways in which Jane Ellen's conversational comprehension always askance of a full grasp.

"*Mhmm-uhhh*," Jane Ellen said.

Silence hangs above the table for a moment.

Katherine's sternum is bouncing a bit in silent laughter. Beyond the "they call her Ugly" line, Katherine is asking a question in her head that she's been asking since she met Mrs. Hadley—"Why the fuck does she talk like that?"

Then, Jane Ellen, having just gotten her aberrant "mhmm" in, is taking a prolonged, sick and satisfied sip of sweet iced tea from a glass

as thick as Tennessee.

"Mhmm-*uhhh*."

She did it again—just *mhmm*.

She's talking while adding nothing new, but, in any case, goes about re-invoking the comedic sound of those particular words in that distinct sequence as a declarative sentence.

"Everybody calls her Ugly," Jane Ellen repeated.

It is a hoot of a line.

Hearing it again, Katherine feels the pressure in her chest get tighter as she is so desperately wanting to laugh.

Kevin starts to go off about something or another.

And this is how it goes for the rest of the meal, this evening.

Thinking about the way that Mrs. Sister Jackson looked at Itragene when she walked away, John Henry thought, "She near about had... she almost was knockin' over a stand of Mennonite Bread she rolled her eyes so hard," John Henry had noticed, suppressing a laugh, wondering what the preacher's wife would look like in one of the powder blue mortuary makeup eyeshadows he had just gotten in the mail at the funeral home, wonder what her Moon Pie face would look like if he could close her Little Debbie-huffing mouth and her ugly link sausage-sniffing nose, too, her nosy and judgmental eyes and sniffing, bloodhound up-nosed, sniffin' nose.

She was ugly.

Inevitably, John Henry would do everybody's funeral in Pickens, every white person, at least, makeup and all, and sometimes he'd look around the room and pre-plan funerals (he'd planned at least a hundred times already for Itragene's death, whom he kept finding himself bumping on his business agenda to his surprise, his mighty surprise that she were still alive; he hated to ponder it, but, the way she looked,

this might be the time...); he'd think about how he'd make so-and-so look before their expiration date, sometimes far in advance, sometimes accurately, bullseye-style and right before that person's personal doomsday, having a sense for Death, John Henry, his nose and eyes trained for signs of the body beginning its ultimate betrayal, considering a person more in his mind business-wise when he noticed something like jaundiced eyes or rapid weight loss unfollowed by return weight gains, the Phen-Phen and fenfluramine epidemic breakout first truly throwing him, at the time him having found himself that spring it took off preparing for at least fifty cancer deaths, finding himself in an inventory pickle—just too many caskets, cheap ones, too and unfortunately enough, hard to sell to anybody other than the demographic that he noticed was losing a bunch of weight out of nowhere; he eventually sold the caskets for cheap at a flea market, most people using them for firewood, one couple using their casket as a flower bed, of which John Henry had a photo hanging in his office—so he had found himself in a true inventory pickle when they all gained the weight back, seemingly a miracle. Beyond the diet pill curveball, this looking across and about the place and preparing people's tombstones in his eyes was just smart planning and project management for a funeral home director and practicing mortician, business forecasting, the thinking of a Southern Baptist obsessed with death by profession and passion, the funeral home the family business and his inheritance as well as legacy, though he was childless and without a wife or anything as such, a bachelor's bachelor, or, as some of the people said in town, “a faggot.”

They were all so damn ugly and hateful.

He was, indeed, what they'd call a gentleman's faggot, so to speak, and that was a faggot who the fine people in town, upstanding folks, could rely on, as long as he didn't mention or do anything faggy beyond throwing decadent, truly ridiculous and over-the-top funerals. They loved his funerals, far and wide, across the South, him famous in his profession, admired wide and far, indeed.

That's what a gentleman's faggot was—useful and knowing his place, his trade, and happy to help maintain legacy.

“That fag’ed’zhure’ken doll an’ol’ bitch up, though,” had said somebody that prior summer, June 1993, somebody smoking a cigarette outside the funeral parlor for the proceedings for the Johnson sisters—an open casket funeral, and, in fact, they had been smashed flat by a transfer truck in their flower bed just days prior, Mule Day and a chicken truck, of all coincidences for a dramatic Gordo death.

Gentleman's faggot and mortician John Henry had actually helped the EMS scoop them up off the flower bed, them having to peel off those flat sisters from those poor pretty hostess plants that came from the nursery off of Highway 82, between Reform and Gordo, plants they had just started planting, only a few transferred from their little green and plastic containers to the flower bed soil that they had lining their yard and driveway next to the mailbox, not even finishing the job before the life was ran over and out of them, the sisters and the flowers, all of it such a shame, a flat out shame.

“A little mashed in, but they looked like pretty dolls,” a woman had also remarked leaving John Henry's family funeral parlor off Highway 82 between Reform and Gordo, where another mortuary makeup miracle had wowed all of Pickens County and beyond, visitors from all over Alabama and Mississippi, the wealthy Johnson sisters known wide and far, far and wide, part of the legacy.

“I wonder what it is about queers that helps them be so damn good at that kind of shit,” John Henry, almost stepping out of the door and into the conversation, had overheard somebody else also observe to others about his work on the Johnson sisters funeral.

John Henry was proud of his work more than he was afraid of being a victim of a hate crime, a term he didn't know and concept he didn't grasp anyhow, internalizing the homophobia around him. John Henry figured that he had proven himself essential to the county, securing his lot in life, leading a respectable life as a Southern gentleman's faggot, his saving grace, as he was a man with a

congenitally effeminate gait, were his decadent funerals that his community oh so loved.

The Johnson sisters funeral was, actually and amazingly, such a success that open-casket visitation was extended by a week, people traveling from all over to see "the Flat Sisters of Gordo," Henry Wells-level momentum building, lore potential—the *13 Ghosts and Jeffrey* lady, the poltergeist Alabama storyteller lady, the lady with her poltergeist she named Jeffrey? Kathryn Tucker Windham? She came on through to the funeral parlor between Gordo and Reform off of Highway 82, too—she "just had to see it"—saying stuff aloud above the twin caskets at the sight of "them two flat out sisters for life, from cradle to flower bed to casket," that Kathryn Tucker Windham said, and she declared, too: "these are the sisters whose faces would not stay smashed, no matter what they did to them—run them ov*ah*, a sixteen wheel*ah* with a bunch of chickens in its carrier comp*ah*tment, well I'll be, a horrible June in Gordo and Pickens County, Alabama, too."

The *Pickens County Herald* put the Johnson sisters' open casket on the front page with the headline, "*The Sisters Whose Heads Held: The Flat Sisters of Gordo*." And, so, the meme was born—the Flat Sisters of Gordo.

John Henry was then, also, toying with taking out a local WBC 4 television commercial involving flat mannequins, like he were a mattress salesman, Pickens County—mostly active idiot community member and local historian Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley orchestrations—really giving a go at trying to make this thing a damn thing, a story, a tale, another reason to go to Pickens County, Alabama, tourism stuff. They were lost without the leadership of Thaddeus; Jane Ellen, who he left in charge of the legacy of the county on paper, she had no idea what she was doing.

Gordo high school jointly awarded the Johnson sisters homecoming queen that fall. The football team saluted a large printout of a photo of the two sisters that, at least, wasn't the open casket photo. They put a crown upon two mannequins, which were both positioned

facing the audience backside-wise, for they were turned away from the home game crowd “sitting” in chairs, silhouettes; Gordo High School's student body had these two dead figure model homecoming queens, “I'm Proud to Be an American” sang loudly by Mrs. Sanders, not a dry eye in sight that Friday fall night in Gordo at the football stadium at the top of the big Gordo hill, the night Pickens County paid their final pageantry of respect to the Flat Sisters of Gordo, Emetrice and Ambrosia Johnson, Lord rest their souls, after all them funerals.

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“Ugly... I would proffer, at minimum, given the hegemonic manner at which these things meet meaning,” Dr. Kevin van de Tuffin was saying, at the Hadley supper table that Saturday night before her murder, saying nonsense with cornbread and such supper bits all over his beard, mimicking and parroting academia per his imagination, mocking the buzzwords that “his” colleagues—”his” in his mind and his mind only—in the humanities and social sciences used, his supposed colleagues, him having none of those, colleagues, nor did he have nary a clue that “hegemonic” in the manner he was aping was a term popularized by the Italian communist and Marxist Antonio Gramsci, his “joke” not making much sense but belying his idiocy, a frequency he shared with Jane Ellen, a blatant racist whom he adored.

Kevin van de Tuffin was an adjunct Tulane zoologist who would be soon unemployed, his contract almost up at Tulane and nothing so much as printing paper in his department was thrown his way, the whole department ready for him to go, there not even the pedagogical courtesy of department paper for his classes; tenure was so far from possible that the word had lost meaning for Kevin.

This was his sad life, but he, nonetheless, continued there at the supper table, ignorant and full of air, buoyant.

“I would proffer, and this is based upon a quick cultural reading

and not any thorough sampling, qualitative, all qualitative, a statement of a type I hate to make, an empiricist myself, a scientist, one of that type—I prefer the facts, the numbers, quantitative, no offense, Katie—you mind if I call you Katie? Kat?"

He addressed her as such, and he said it while putting a fourth of a stick of butter on his cornbread and making a friendly gesture of the busy butter knife to Dr. Mann, going on, "as I know *you love your Derrida*."

Katherine had recently turned down a position at UC Berkeley, where she earned her PhD in sociology; she had just re-negotiated her very fine salary at Tulane; she had many publications and awards to her name, and this cornbread butter bump said this to her, spoke to her this this way in an attempt at mocking her, some woman.

"I don't indulge the crazed rants of Gramsci from prison. I am no vulgar Marxist. Foucault, Kevin, Foucault is who you're thinking of in your little joke you're attempting to make. I love my Foucault. If you're going to mock me for my theoretical hybridity and epistemological commitments as repartee, you, you should at least get the obligatorily French thinker correct for 'the joke,' as it were, in your eyes—I am a post-Marxist, Kevin, a historian in a sociology department, really, if you look at my work and the impact it's had," she continued, "and I do *not* believe in 'hegemony' in any vulgar Marxist sense as your commentary suggests, but rather normative power as a bio-politics of discourse—nothing to get into here now, but I am not a vapid, and, dare I say, *over-signified* literary critic posing as a philosopher."

She ended it all with a sincere smile, all of it above both her supper compatriots' heads, but Katherine said it anyhow, always loving a dismissal of Jacques Derrida, the one thinker of his type about whom she agreed needed a good bullying, herself a poststructuralist, though, in any case, as Derrida was widely considered to be, her pretty much only disliking Derrida in terms of the big players in that intellectual movement with which she strongly identified, where she grounded her

materialism and progressive politics, her historical sense of things, time and space and the way our bodies navigate through space as more slices of time are created, power itself where legacy and revolution manifest.

Katherine was very used to defending herself in the US South's academic environment, what they called a "poststructuralist," something just above Jane Ellen's head, Kevin's as well, and something most Southern professors also thought to mean that she "liked Derrida," that she "loved Derrida," the French poststructuralist theorist of language, sometimes called a Continental philosopher.

"I bet you like Derrida, bet you love him," they'd say to her.

"Foucault, sure, yes, yeah, of course," Kevin said, mouth full of cornbread.

"My-*uhhh* pardon?" Jane Ellen asked, sipping more tea from her glass cup that must've been two inches thick, her certain that she had heard a vulgarity, her thinking she had heard a curse word multiple times, by now, then, and there at the Hadley supper table.

"Michel Foucault, a French philosopher, historian of ideas—"

Katherine was explaining, cut short by Kevin snorting his tea and soaking corn bread in his throat with the sweet liquid in a manner that somehow accommodated air passing his vocal cords and articulating words.

And it would be the fusion of Dawkins and Foucault through which this professional sociologist and intelligence agent would understand the legacy of the pride in their heritage.

"An unwell gentleman, a pervert," Kevin aspirated, asserted, near needing medical assistance he was eating and tea-sipping so vigorously, precariously watching the table with only his left eye regarding his food, and swiveling his head, like a bald and rude owl, to face his supper company with his right eye, a move he made constantly talking and eating that looked like it could give him whiplash. His left eye was his food eye and he had his eyes on the conversation with the left other side of his flounder face.

"My-*uhhh* word, *that* word in French is a name—in French French, such as France French? Europe-*uhhh*? Surely not," Jane Ellen said. She had been set off.

Jane Ellen was stunned, stumbling over her words, the famed local historian stunned at what she was misunderstanding, amazed at the world and how surprising it could be, her thinking in that moment that "Fuck" was a surname in French, lost and smiling, making a face you'd see a lot on lot like her, a snobby ignorance as a mask, the Bless-Your-Heart Mask. These upper crust Pickens Countians wouldn't have two plates to serve potatoes on if they hadn't had everything, they had given to them, them having so many heirlooms and more. They often looked lost in this particular and popular, perfected way, effecting a brand of ignorance that took its pride in the power to dismiss.

Most of them, the rich and white local lot—Jane Ellen a prime example—they were bluntly dumb, handed everything and given so much power in a place such as Pickens County, where legacy was the matter of most concern, competency widely absent and even reviled, a problem that only avalanched over time as the generations got dumber as history rolled on. It messed with their heads, so much power handed to them in their ignorance, power they could wield effectively given their social standing; they never believed themselves to be wrong about anything, and that messes with your head, such hubris.

They were so dull; they were actual idiots, and this is where their evil bloomed, in their idiocy. It was delicate and upsetting to consider, Katherine had been observing to herself, but it was just like that, was the case, sadly—this is how they got away with it for so long, the Face in the Window, their blind idiocy.

They'd believe anything if it suited them.

This face Jane Ellen was making was a Carrollton classic, aloof but politely smiling, no care for what any interlocutor was saying.

These Pickens County *crème du cracker* upper crusters would be lost in conversation, always, always "lost" as in confused, not "lost" as in carried away, the *salon* caste of Pickens too dumb to engage in

substantive conversation, just misunderstanding each other and everything, making this dull face, unable to get their words right because their thoughts were rancid and confused and hateful, ugly. If anybody smart or kind at all came around and said something above their pretty ugly little big airheads, or something with which they merely disagreed, they'd just stare at the other party with an empty smile pasted on; they'd stare at any such educated person with this area's signature, vacant smile, this empty smile pasted on their faces, a vacant stare that was a mask worn atop a downright hateful inner monologue where they situated themselves as, ultimately, better than anybody who thought they were so smart, barely hearing what was said to them, anyhow, as it was.

Jane Ellen and people like her were sure that they had keys to the kingdom of heaven, but probably not people like this "*female professor*"; Kevin, perhaps, was fine with Jesus. She liked Kevin more, though she had grown impatient with his zoological efforts, but, in any case, she found Katherine a perfectly suitable guest for just a while, though not too long.

"'Michel?' Yeah, it's a guy's name in French," Kevin supplied, adding that Foucault was also a "flamer," "not much of a guy, if you follow, Mrs. Hadley."

"I-*uhhh* did *nottttt* know-*uhhh* that 'Michel,' Jane Ellen politely repeated but mispronounced as "*M*ay-*ee-uhhh--shayle*," "I-*uhhh* did not know-*uhhh*, not at all, that that was a man's name-*uhhh* in French. This is why I *do* love-*uhhh* meeting you educated typ*e-uhhh* of folk and hosting you here in Carrollton. I-*uhhh* do, I-*uhhh* do, I *jus*' s*ure* d*o-uhhh*—so happy to have y'all here-*uhhh*. It's just too rare-*uhhh* that I-*uhhh* meet others who can hold such intellectual conversation such-*uhhh* as this-*uhhh*."

She had a lot of professor acquaintances, that Jane Ellen. She was *obsessed* with meeting professors from all over the region, telling them about Henry Wells and all that she knew, putting her old newspapers in their faces, professors all of whom with if she had spoken just at least

once she called her "profess*ah* friends," a woman with whom most people with advanced degrees minted after 1861 and the outbreak of the American Civil War would find themselves not only annoyed but actively disgusted, Mrs. Hadley being an overt racist who did not hide it for long if you were white and you had exchanged more than five friendly words.

"Anyway, so they all call her ugly? People call this person ugly? But… in what sense, though?" Katherine tried recentering the conversation on this intriguing, stupidly funny-to-her and absurd-sounding Pickens County trivia.

"A-*uhhh* girl's name-*uhhh* and a vulgarity for a-*uhhh* name, too, '*M*ay-*ee-shayle F-word*,' my word." Faggots would just do anything, Jane Ellen thought.

"What, Mrs. Hadley?" Katherine asked, legitimately confused.

"His name was *Mee-shell Foo*-koh," Kevin faux-phonetically assisted both Katherine and Jane Ellen, going on nonsensically, "like 'Coke' but without the 'k,' well with a 'k' sound…" he said, and, though as stupid as he were himself, he was also acutely worried that he'd lose this simple woman with his effort at assisting understanding in conversation, worried he'd lose that Mrs. Hadley, Jane Ellen a woman dumber than his ex—and he chose dumb purposefully—dumb, that Jane Ellen, "local historian": "forget the 'k sound' comment—it's like 'Coke' without the 'k' and 'e,' so '*Mee-shell Foo-Co*,' he went on, "like 'Hadley & Co.,' if you had a company with your kids or something," said this excited man grabbing more cornbread from the center of the table that had a giant white doily as the tablecloth. He loved Jane Ellen, loved her racist ass, loved her for that reason and more, got off on how he and Jane Ellen toed the line in front of Katherine, him busting, near saying it aloud: "look at that little *[you-know-what]* in the window!"

He said this aloud and Hadley was like, "Oh-*uhhh*, my daughter-*uhhh*, Elisa-*uhhh*, she'd-*uhhh* never go into business with me, her mother, my word, no," she giggled, responding to Kevin. "She doesn't

even have employees over at the Pizza Doctor," Jane Ellen continued, "always an independent one, my babygirl. She owns the franchise, *both* restaurants, *mhmm, mhmm*. I'm so proud of her, *mhmm*. Her husband was hit by a train a few years ago, you know, really sad, though I was no fan of Steven—Steven was her husband. He got hit by the train, like I said, ran over in his sedan; he was drunk, so…well…" she ended, pursing her lips and nodding her head forward to indicate that drunk Steven deserved to be flattened by a train.

Kevin loved it when he met people who made him feel smarter than he were, and Jane Ellen made him feel like he were a magic carpet in the Arabian sky he were so full of unearned flight with the unbelievable air under him, flying too high, too close to the Face in the Window.

Katherine suppressed laughter, about losing it and had been for a good bit, now, then, there at the Hadley supper table—*almost* losing it, all about a woman whom everybody called "Ugly," seemingly a matter of nomenclature, and this racist nut job obsessed and consumed with this lynching ghost story window, just wholly fixated with her face-in-the-window nonsense, she had no fucking idea about anything at all, like *anything*, it seemed, no idea at all what was going on half the time when they spoke, the county calling her a "local historian" because she had learned how to use a microfilm machine and had looke at some old newspaper articles about Henry Wells, articles she likely misunderstood, Katherine figured, articles that she misunderstood, surely, as well as consciously also then misrepresenting what she had, foundationally, already gotten wrong, her contribution to the face-in-the-window business doing the legacy the favor of basically telling on itself, though this would be under wraps for a good bit of time, her murdered before she had a chance to tell the whole town the whole story.

She would also call it a "white lynch mob." They used to just say it was "a white mob," that bad enough, but passable, but she flat out said it—it was a "*h-w*hite *lynch mob*(!)"—true, sort of, but not actually at

the end of the day, given that Wells died of a gunshot wound. Even without that part, she just really, really told on them in more ways than one, that dumb, dumb Jane Ellen, just in how she went about it all and acted.

She was so clearly in love with that window because it involved a murdered Black man. She was sick.

She loved, loved, loved, *loved* this lynching ghost story window—*loved* that it were all a lynching story, that it were a ghost story that was also a lynching story, that an old building with a legacy was involved, Civil War trivia, a dead slave, even, oh, how fun—all of it, couldn't get any better, she felt.

This brazen nut job, Katherine was observing and nearly losing it on her face about it all, poker face-wise, her thinking, "this fucking cunt thought 'Michel Foucault' was a vulgarity in *quite literal truth*... ahahaha, *oh fuck*... Ahahah, a*hahahahahahah!*"

Katherine wiped a tear from her left eye and her lips almost buckled, but she kept saving face.

"Michel Foucault, yes, an intellectual giant," Katherine said. "It's not the 'f-word, Mrs. Hadley,' that last part politely added.

She was sincerely stumped by Mrs. Hadley, sincerely lost as to how to speak to a person like Jane Ellen who was as simultaneously hateful and bigoted under the veneer of being a nice old widow, somebody who was, at once, evidently as stupid as she were and also, somehow, high-ranked socially in her local, bizarre culture, even apparently respected as a local intellectual of sorts. Katherine knew ignorance to be the mother of bigotry and projection its father, but she found herself completely overwhelmed by these Pickens people; she had never considered that medical idiocy, *passé* by the early 1990s, was actually gesturing towards something, an insight into humankind that hurt her to ponder, the idea that some people are born rotten because they are dumb, nasty and ugly, hateful as obdurate logs in a river. These were difficult questions she wanted to wrestle, a sociologist on-site, in the field, living for a bit in Pickens County,

Alabama, home of the Face in the Window. She was about to bust out laughing thinking about how Pickens County made a case for bringing back medical idiocy.

"He died of AIDS," Kevin said, it apparent he thought he had made a point.

"*Ma*rh*zzy*," Jane Ellen, ignoring Kevin, rejoined with thanks Katherine's clarification that the French thinker wasn't literally a French "Fuck," a rare moment of mutual understanding in the experience of their exchange through speech acts, Jane Ellen throwing her voice for some reason and sounding like a crow—"*Mawrhcy*," it sort of was—intoning an approximation of "thanks" in her version of French: "Marhzzy," she said again, truly grateful, continuing, thanking Katherine a third time to show off her supposed French skills, "*Marzhzzy*, *marzhzzy, marzhzzy,* thank *yew*—if I-*uhhh* remember-*uhhh* wha*w*ht little French I learned at the University-*uhhh*... " she trailed off, no point made.

"Thank y*ew,"* she was continuing again; she was then saying, "I thought his name was Meh-*ah*-ay-*uhhh-ee*shayle-*uhhh-uh-uhhh* F-word! I was like, I had been like, I-*uhhh* was like, and I was like, 'I don't believe it!' The one thing I-*uhhh* do rememb*ah-uhhh* is the schwa e—very important for the *pronunz-ee-azian*."

"Sure, no problem; you're welcome," Katherine said. "So, Ugly, assuming that's what they call her, is she actually ugly or did everybody just nickname her 'Ugly?'

Katherine had to piss so badly by that point, so much sweet iced tea consumed by that point in the evening, and she'd been silently giggling at so much over the day, dying by damn dinner, "supper," but she wasn't leaving the table until she had a better grip on this ugly situation.

"Oh, oh: she's ugly," Jane Ellen started laughing, a fleck of butter bean meat stuck in the right corner of her mouth.

Ugly's disdain for Jane Ellen was mutual; Jane Ellen really didn't like looking at her nose hole, and the ugly whistle her face made gave

Jane Ellen the heebie-jeebies, and it really seemed to her like Ugly looked the way she did and made the noises she did just to bother you, that all she was wanting was attention, negative attention, just how that Ugly and most people were, Jane Ellen thought of the world. Jane Ellen and people like her, perverse hams, hated attention seeking. "Just doing that for attention," they'd say about anything.

"But how ugly is she?" Kevin asked, drowning in iced tea and the sog of cornbread stuffing his esophagus.

"Oh, *oh*, my good*ness*, see-*uhhh*, well, she is *so* ugly," Jane Ellen said, raising her eyebrows and widening her eyes, slightly nodding in the direction of the two of them, panning her head back and forth for effect, looking at them like, *you-should-see-her*: "she is so ugly, trust me," the way she looked at them, beyond speech acts in the experience of the exchange, *talking without speaking*.

"Oh, this is awful, but I can't help but laugh some. What kind of ugly? Is something wrong with her or is she just an unfortunate sight?" Katherine asked, almost immediately regretting it but, nonetheless, pushing aside the ethical concern in favor of amusing herself foremost, figuring, "*when in Carrollton as in Rome*." She wouldn't usually mock a person's looks, but this was different: she was in a strange place and they had so many stories and particular ways of talking, and now she had learned that the townspeople had a person whom they called "Ugly."

"She ain't got a nose." Jane Ellen announced this stunning statement. "The poor thing ain't got a nose to speak of," Jane Ellen kept on, and abruptly so, the nose thing a curveball for all involved and it took a minute to settle at the table amongst the three of them.

"She doesn't... *have* a nose, at all? No nose at all, and so they call her Ugly? That's horrible."

Katherine almost spit as she spoke, definitely would've spit had she had any liquid in her mouth at that moment. Fortunately, she didn't have any tea in her mouth. Katherine was bad about spitting drinks out amidst laughter, a woman who loved to have a hearty laugh, had a

sense of humor about her.

"Oh, she sounds ugly, then," Kevin affirmed the Pickens Countians and their aesthetic assessment. "No nose? What are we talking here, like... surely there's some nose there; it's misshapen or big on one side or something, right?"

"Kevin, no"—Katherine fucking *hated* Kevin and his stupid ass—" she *explicitly* said that she *doesn't have* a nose, *no nose*—is it a congenital condition, no nose at all, Mrs. Hadley?"

At this point, Jane Ellen was certain that, even if they hadn't said "fuck" a moment ago at the table, Katherine had just *absolutely* said to her some variety of "cunt genital," then, now, there, there at the Hadley supper table!

Katherine was actually and so seriously about to bust out laughing, it all so ridiculous, it not even being what was being literally said but how it all sounded, just the phonetics of it, the way the language flowed: "*They call her Ugly*," Mrs. Hadley had said something that sounded like that—they call her Ugly, and Ugly didn't have no nose. Fucking *Christ*, that was funny as shit, Katherine felt.

"She wears sunglasses all the time, and nobody is sure how they stay on."

At that, Katherine then screamed quite loudly. She screamed and then quickly apologized.

Ugly, the sound of it, "they call her Ugly," sunglasses that mysteriously are attached to her face—all of it just amused the shit out of Katherine.

"No nose at all?" Katherine desperately sought elaboration.

It was all so funny to her.

"She couldn't smell a dirty dog's hind-end if you put a mutt's rear-end in her face," Jane Ellen said, trying to be creative and expressive in her speech, trying to impress these *scholahs*, her graphic hyperbole about putting Ugly's face nose hole-first in a dog's ass, however, haranguing what little meaning she could convey as a matter of both cognition and dexterity in speech, her saying the opposite of what she

meant, and graphically so—if Ugly didn't have a nose, she could probably smell well, maybe better than other people, is what Jane Ellen meant to say, even though she said the opposite and, in fact, was correct in her misspoken statement, something that happened to her all the time, this being right by '*naccident*; characteristic of upper crust Pickens speech, she was right in what she said but she didn't mean to say it; this happened a lot to that lot beyond Jane Ellen, Pickens upper crust being mistakenly correct, lost.

Katherine agreed with the ghastly assessment at its face and its truthful surface. "Yes, I believe that olfactory senses are in the *nose* nose, not the nasal cavity deeper in the face…"

"Who knows, not having the exterior and just possessing a smell hole," Jane Ellen followed up. "You should see it—it's just a big hole in her face!"

"Like a nasal mouth," Kevin observed.

This type of expressive speech that undercuts the point intended to be made by talking about *x*, *y*, *z*, this happening all the time in Pickens County, was something chronic, endemic, nobody able to articulate themselves and nobody understanding one another, all lacking the necessary dexterity for agile verbal communication.

"Oh my god, thinking on it... she doesn't have the sense of smell, not if even the cartilage is gone. How awful—congenital? It's so sad, really, wow… She doesn't know the smell of spring or the ocean. Is it a congenital condition?" Katherine asked twice and again if Ugly were born that way.

"Oh, she can smell—I do apologize if I gave another impression with my analogy," by which she meant "metaphor," going on, "I was more talking about her not having a nose to put into the stank of a canine's rear side"—truly, Jane Ellen's imagination was vile—"It's just one hole between her eyes, the nostrils not distinguished of themselves from one another, no possible way, missing the trunk and all."

Everybody correctly followed Jane Ellen's wrought way of wording things and they understood that the "trunk" was the nose part

of the nose, the cartilage and flesh atop the skull bone, *nose* nose, what should've been poking out there saying "hello" to the world from the face of this ugly person had she a nose, and so this was the *nose* nose, the *town* town of noses.

She didn't have a nose at all in this postmodern world, Katherine was thinking, just lacked a nose as material face fact and you could tell that was reality because she sure did not have a nose of which to speak, she was beginning to imagine, her nose just not there, *no nose*, no high theory offering any subversion of the facts, the master narrative being true, verifiable, easily seen that she had no nose.

"Can the subaltern *smell*?" Katherine wondered and giggled to herself, gulping sweet tea.

"Noses are trunks, Mrs. Hadley, that is correct," Kevin said for no purpose other than to ingratiate himself with Mrs. Hadley. When it came to this zoologist, Mrs. Hadley had just gone and found another idiot like herself, as if Pickens County needed another one.

"I have got to know if this is congenital," Katherine sternly insisted, full poker face, dying hysterically within.

Jane Ellen—judging so harshly and from a place of ignorance—she grew visibly annoyed at Katherine, finally. "L*anguage*!" She almost yelled this, and she did not mishear this time, dead certainly, she was so sure: "*She said 'cunt genitals at my table*!"

She kept thinking it, furious, "Cunt genitals!!!"

She was this close to saying something, this close.

She had let it slide some because she thought it was Katherine trying to be funny, a woman with manners different than her own, that Katherine, a sailor's mouth she had, Jane Ellen assumed, given who she was and what she was, how she was, and it was to that sailor's mouth which she was giving expression by saying "cunt genitals" at the Hadley supper table, Jane Ellen assumed, for reasons beyond reason, cul-de-sacs of thought in her mind leading her in circles of nonsense. She wanted to say "not at my table," she really did, but she was going to give this lady another shot, deciding she'd tell her to cut it

out if she said three vulgar things, a liberal hall pass, she thought, given and considering that she also was certain that this lady professor thought she were so much better than everybody else, thought she was so smart. She thought she was so smart and, already, she was on strike with that and that was atop half a strike with this French faggot philosopher business, as it was, AIDS so disgusting to Jane Ellen.

"I bet it was something horrific and so Alabama, something involving a tractor!" went Kevin.

"Was it congenital or a something awful like tractor misfortune?" Katherine laughed lightly and asked this, thinking about how much she could not stand Kevin but had needed this "in" on this weird county with this bizarre lynching ghost story window in the courthouse they all loved so damn much.

"Why and how on earth would her *moochie* get run over, run over by a tractor? She'd have to have been laying down in a field with her legs spread up over her head, or something; Ugly walks with a bit of a limp and has a neck hump, you must know. Ugly ain't no gymnast or cheerleader who can do the splits, as Ugly as she is."

It was unclear to Katherine what being attractive had to do with flexibility, but alas.

Jane Ellen had raised her voice saying all this.

She was also not making a lick of sense, basically was speaking in Pickens County gibberish, saying something or another about Ugly and her vagina and a tractor, whatever she was on about—that's what a "moochie" was, a pussy.

Kevin and Katherine, this time, were the lost ones, them jointly confused, Hadley going on, in her own world, "I'm sorry, Professah Let*orn*u*h*, but I do not un*dahs*tand the question, I'm mighty embarrassed to admit."

"I asked if her thing with the nose were congenital or not, that's all," Katherine said and thought that she had clearly clarified.

Kevin had went and said something quickly before Jane Ellen, then and finally, got mad enough that she had really and truly, and directly,

had to say something, had to.

That equally dumb, stupid, gormless Kevin van de Tuffin understood the conversation a bit better, and he said, “I highly doubt she was born that way—sounds like an accident, if not a tractor then, maybe, it was an accident with a cotton gin,” him opting for a cotton-themed “joke” with racist intent, looking expectantly at Jane Ellen Hadley. He looked so jolly as he said the phrase “cotton gin.”

Beside herself, a lost moron, an idiot, Mrs. Hadley, in her foolishness, didn't even notice Kevin's racist easter egg in what he said, this nasty racist nugget, a hate cherry that Kevin had buried in English speech, something she always loved sniffing out and putting out there herself, testing the waters and seeing which white folk whom she could trust. She was beside herself in misunderstanding over her empty supper plate with the professors, confused and incorrect but mad as hell about what she erroneously concluded, her in furious Judgment of others, consequent and otherwise correlated cognitive distortions cascading and diffracting her fractured understanding of what was going on.

She was out of her mind, in other words, crazy as a bess bug.

With almost every substantial social interaction in her life, Jane Ellen grew dumber; communication compounded her idiocy; she was such an idiot that, in her chronic misunderstanding of what was happening around her, actual retardation in the technical sense truly characterized her path as a creature bound to the rules of human development, but she was of a class and race where nobody dare call her “retarded” (though she used the term liberally to refer to the mentally handicapped)—she was literally retarded, as retarded as contaminants flowing through porous media, retarded, slowed down in development, simply retarded in a chemical sense, in terms of her brain chemistry, her neurotransmitters and what they tended to in her attention, retarded, hindered in thought and born on that path, a path cemented by her status as, over her life, she became more retarded the more information she had, “local historian” Jane Ellen Hadley. She

was as dumb as she'd ever been, and she'd read so much, it all just making her more of an idiot because she misunderstood what she looked at and internalized these mistaken notions. She was also crazy and she was shameful as shit, as mean as misinformed—like a lot of upper crust Pickens Countians, that sort of localized power and wealth messing with your head, driving these rich white people who didn't work but kept incredibly busy absolutely mad, them all loony, nuts and deranged, lunatics. Insane and always in a fit of Judgment if not also demonstrated misunderstanding.

Jane Ellen didn't have *eyes to see* or *ears to hear*, as the good Lord says. She was a not a blessed an innocent handicapped person. She was fine, just retarded.

Jane Ellen went, "I said she was ugly, not that she was born a man. They did *nawt* take her male member off with a tractor! I don't know why you keep insisting such. What do *you know* about farm equipment living in a city like New Orleans? *Pfft*. Take off…her moochie…with a tractor?! Which I don't even know how they'd do it—a plough? That ain't even something I want to imagine, Dr. Mann—*my* mind is not in the gutt*ah*. She wasn't even born with a weenie! She did not have a *worm*. Vulgar and indecent to consid*ah*—and, and! And, and, I'd really, really *much* prefer to take the route that it be that it was that that, in Jesus' name, we steered clear of speaking about god-awful stuff like *private parts* at the Hadley supper table, I'm sorry to have to insist. I'm sorry, but enough is enough! We're through with this."

Hadley was going berserk, having had enough of the things which she imagined, had had enough of a figment of her damn imagination, a lunatic, a mean old white woman in Carrollton, Alabama. Indeed, the much mistaken speech censor, Jane Ellen, she was barely fluent in her native language, English.

At that, astute Katherine reverse engineered how they'd landed in such confusion and escalating aggression at the table. At this sideways and extended admission from Jane Ellen that she thought Katherine had said some variation of, or a phrase involving, the words "*genital*"

and, even funnier, "*cunt*," when she had said "congenital," Katherine lost it, spitting sweet tea straight into Mrs. Hadley's face and all over the dishes cabinet behind Mrs. Hadley's table-head dining room chair, where she kept her fine china, just spit tea all over the glass of the cabinet but mostly Mrs. Hadley's face.

"Oh my god, I am so sorry, Mrs. Hadley."

Jane Ellen was wiping her face already with a washcloth napkin that had Henry Well's wailing face slapped on it, and she said, "It's fine, and I suspect your apology is sincere. We have different customs down here, though I know you do live in the South... "

She finished her last statement distantly, trailing off in her speech as a speech act, doing so with choreographed intent, a dramatic punctuation of the air that was a silent *harumph;* dismissively and disdainfully, she finished her words off, her evidently not thinking of New Orleans as really the South so much as a swamp with too many Black people and *sinners*.

"I'm sorry, what, Mrs. Hadley? I mean for spitting on you—I'm so sorry for the unexpected shower, Mrs. Hadley," Katherine said, giggling overtly. "Forgive me, but I'm not sure what that has to do with how I was raised, with all due respect."

"Well, *ir*regardless of who taught you table manners and knowing that was '*naccident*, I think you should also show some more respect in my home, as well, and mind your language," Jane Ellen said in a fit of dim- and dull-as-fuck misunderstanding and mean-spirited misapprehension, her having had finally gotten so hot, just worked herself up not listening and judging others, not paying attention, assuming always the best of herself and the worst of others in the act of interlocution.

"It's your home, Mrs. Jane Ellen," Kevin said, for some reason, going off and asking for Mrs. Hadley's pardon for a fiction of her imagination, her bending reality and him contorting to provide the matrix of the experience, apologizing for something that had not occurred and the secondary and misinformed description of which he

didn't fully grasp, not understanding what Jane Ellen was talking about, him, then—amidst all of this collective not-understanding reality—grabbing a slice of red velvet cake from the center of the table, grabbing it fast and hungrily so, like a wild person from a jungle who'd never seen a supper table, his second huge slice, him having started with big hunks of homemade confection sugar-full divinity pecan candies and the cake before abundant rounds of mac'n'cheese, eating each individual food independently like a big child; a lot like Jane Ellen, the local historian, the wannabe zoologist, well, he was only ever experiencing twenty-five percent of a room, a three-quarters of everything lost on him, him only noticing a third-of-a-dozen of things when there were a dozen of them, him so inattentive. As such, he often volunteered statements that were of this same dull nature.

"It's fine, Dr. van de Tuffin."

Kevin had not said anything based in reality, but Jane Ellen was grateful for it.

An insincere, entitled and crazy Jane Ellen then stared at Katherine expectedly, waiting for her apology, too, for "saying 'cunt' and 'genital' at the Hadley supper table one too many times, once enough, and in her home, as Kevin had testified, which meant two people and Jesus agreed with her, in Jane Ellen's mind—so, three and one was God, and, so, that was that.

She moved forward in her self-righteous anger born from a fit of misunderstanding and Judgment of others. She began to speak but was cut off by Katherine.

"Wait, I didn't say 'genital,' Mrs. Hadley," Katherine said as it finally, fully settled that Mrs. Hadley had truly taken that to be what she said, truly had taken that away from Katherine's interjections, dawned on her how truly and profoundly stupid this woman was, how her ears seemed wired purely for the inability to navigate the sound in her environs.

At that, Mrs. Hadley stood up and threw her Henry Wells embroidered napkin on the table.

"Not at my table. We are through! That's *it!*"

"Mrs. Hadley, I'm sorry, I mean... I didn't say that at all, the g-word."

An adult woman with a doctorate and a grip, Katherine *hated* anti-"cussing" culture in the South, hated grown-ass adults using proxy words that invoke within the conversation's imagination the very word being tiptoed around—slurs the only exception for her—she hated resorting to invoking words by pointing at the word's starting letter with a hyphenated "-word" attached, following that initial letter, a way of speaking that was so childish, her view.

"We say '*God*' all day."

"Seriously, *the fuck* is she on about?" Katherine barely had a clue, wondering this, the miscommunications avalanching.

"Sure, no, not that g-word—and, no, no, don't worry, I won't 'use the Lord's name in vain,' the esteemed sociologist compulsively felt the need to preemptively reassure Jane Ellen of that as she spoke about "g-words" and such—"I didn't mean, um, '*generous*,' but without the 'er-us,' but an 'i-tail,' so "gen-'i"-tail,' or 'the g-word.' Anyway, and more importantly, the word I used means 'born with,' basically —'*congenital*,' she cautiously uttered the word about human pathology at birth and development again, the consonance of "congenital" starting to sound vulgar to her ear, too, which only made her want to laugh more.

Finally, everybody at the Hadley supper table was on the same page, sort of, Jane Ellen recognizing what had happened, kind of, and becoming so embarrassed, thinking it seemed like *her* mind was the one in the gutter: "I am so sorry, Dr. Mann, I had thought you asked if she were born with her *moochie* or not."

"What... what is a moo—" Kevin started.

"Oh my god, do people in Pickens County call female genitalia 'moochies?'

Indeed, "moochy" in the singular, "moochies" the plural, it was a disgusting, ugly word that they did, in fact, use as reference to a girl's

hoo-hoo. It had the worst consonance, gross assonance: *moo-cheese*.

"That is the fourth time you have used the *g-tail word—the g-word*!" Kevin ripped joyously, as if they'd been drinking all night, him rising from his seat and spitting foodstuff all over as he said it, truly acting like he were drunk, though all they were was extremely sugared and caffeinated up on sweet tea.

Jane Ellen was *so* embarrassed, *so embarrassed* that she didn't catch Katherine's easily-scorned-for-vulgarity comment, that Jane Ellen feeling like she had drawn a graphic image of a vulva, a moochie, and shown them with a pornographic intention in the middle of Sunday school and she had a math test that she forgot about, it a full nightmare.

And that was that. She'd be dead soon—The Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre.

Part II: Heritage Idiot True Crimes

IV. Pickens County Lots Logic

She wants another cigarette. She's been wanting another cigarette and she was lighting another cigarette. She was sitting there, thinking and smoking. She is thinking about time, smoking a long Virginia Slim. She'll want another cigarette after this one, too; she always does.

It was then Friday and she had been saying to herself, "It's Friday." She's been having a difficult time telling which day it is.

It was that Friday morning in the wee hours. Itragene was blasting "Land Down Under" by Men at Work on the cassette tape player, sitting in her sunroom over at the house in Gordo. It was a bit after midnight on that week's Friday. It was technically Friday, though it was functioning as Thursday night in a way, and would until dawn.

> ... I met a strange lady...
> ...breakfast...
>
> ...and she said,
> ... land down undah...

Itragene had slept some and this sleep left her disoriented in the days and nights.

Beyond the music and the refrain of "*land down undah*," the police scanner was also loudly creating a familiar noise in the surround, the entire room, the sunroom a sonic wormhole into our Itragene's madness.

Ddld—Prrrrk...
"10-4."

... land down undah...

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"Heading home—we got a 10-20 to handover—transferring to Unit 3. Suspect white female, 5'9, 5'10, blonde, husky build—Carrollton Food Mart; suspect broke in intoxicated and went and knocked over the spaghetti aisle shelves."

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"10-4; 10-9—you mean the pasta aisle?"

Take cover...
Land down undah...

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"Hah, no sirree—they only sell spaghetti. *Eye-tal-ee-an*! Thah' only pastah they got. All good? I gah'tta 10-42 and get my ass to sleep. All good?"

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"Suspect is still at the Food Mart? And what—no SpaghettiOs?"

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"10-4; Yes, they have SpaghettiOs and other fine Chef Boyardee products as well as Hamburger Helper. Suspect is on location, unconscious under the spaghetti shelf—looks like the damn wicked witch of the west."

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"10-40—10-52, this is Unit 3. We need an ambulance at the Carrollton Food Mart."

...hear the thunder...

"Good luck. It ain't the McDaniel girl—the Calloway girl. It's that Blevins clan youngest, Porridge. 10-42, folks."

Ddld—Prrrrk...

"Porridge Blevins—mama must've hated her. 10-40"

... take cover.
...land down un*dah*.

It was 1am, Friday morning, over at the house in Gordo. Here Itragene was in her sunroom, seated at her police scanner table in the big bay window facing downtown Gordo.

Sandra Bernhard is here, as well, her present company.

She has found herself talking to Sandra Bernhard in her head, the latest Assembly of Israel member—our Itragene is trying to teach Sandra Bernhard something significant in this life, in fact, something she calls "*Lots Logic*."

Sandra Bernhard—the Bernhard-in-her-head—has just up and popped up this Friday morning in these early hours.

Pops up, that Bernhard does.

Yes? Itragene goes at this popping up.

'How's it going, Itragene? Sandra, a real pleasure.' She pops up and says this, "Sandra Bernhard."

It was already Friday. Sandra Bernhard had popped up around midnight.

Since waking up, she has had to keep repeating it in her head that it is Friday; she is a bit disoriented.

"It's Friday," she muttered a few times as she sat there after having started talking to Sandra Bernhard. It's Friday... *one must*... no—*one mus'nt*.... *no*! No! We don't say no more '*one must*...' I just promised Ruth Bader Ginsburg I'd cut it with that intrusive shit, just an intrusive thought!

She has been taking mental health advice from a hallucination of a Supreme Court justice. Ruth Bader Ginsburg told her that her internal verbal tic of "one must" is an intrusive thought—and that it is and always has been. It's something she had always thought—this "one must" stuff—because she's never knows what to do with herself, down

to how to move her body, because they'll look at her and mock her no matter what she does.

"So that was Wednesday," Itragene said to the Bernhard-in-her-head as well as aloud. She was just talking to herself, going to town. She was just sitting there talking about it that Friday, all she was up to in her behaviors, sitting mostly stolidly at her police scanner table while thinking in hyperspace, staring off yonder through the bay window.

She was getting started teaching Sandra Bernhard "Lots Logic."

Lots Logic! She exclaims this in her head at Bernhard without talking with her mouth, talking without speaking.

Lots Logic was one of her notions. She had called it "Lots Logic" at a decisive point in the 1950s when, under the influence of a lot of Benzedrine, she launched a campaign for Alabama governor and her slogan was "Lots and Lots for all Lots and Lots!"—the run for governor didn't go very far but, in the land of Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr. theorizing and pontificating, she has been perfecting the notion ever since. When she has an enthusiasm, these are the kinds of things she thinks through, sitting and working at her little police scanner table in the bay window. Lots Logic, Shekel Math—these things, for our Itragene, they are her memes.

'Lots Logic?' A bemused Sandra is asking her this after she says what she does.

Yes, a proper noun—LOTS LOGIC! She screams this inside her head at the Bernhard-in-her-head.

She then raised her hands in the air like Oprah Winfrey and she was yelling, audible from the street: "LOTS LOGIC!!!"

"Mama what in the FUCK are... sorry, mama—can you please turn that shit down? Why're you in here screaming?"

Maddie had just entered the sunroom and Itragene looked like she was a teenaged boy hiding a porno magazine after mom had walked in. She almost fell out of her seat.

"Sorry, baby, yes. Yes, yes... How's'did your day go at the register

t'day?"

"Same old shit and everybody's getting older and uglier by the day."

'Oh, she's a funny one'—the legendary Jewish comedian Jacky Mason chimes in, a new voice in her head—again, just another entity popping up.

Itragene batted at her left eye like a gnat was in it.

"Do you want some catfish, mama? You ate anything today or yesterday? Didju getchu some sleep finally? You gotta lay off those Phen-Phen pills mama. I know, I love them too—but you can go too fast, you know, mama. You been a lil' too fast this past week. I'm worried. Catfish? Columbus went to a fish fry with John Henry and brough' me some to the Piggly Wiggly. You should've seen the dang grin on that man's face carryin' all that catfish across the parking lot—it's a ton, mama, like a week's worth of fried catfish and hush puppies—they got onions in them, though."

She was talking about her best friend, Columbus Chulahoma, known around the county as the Little Indian in the McShan Meadow. He was a white man who lived in a field in McShan, not a meadow, but everybody called it that and also him Columbus Chulahoma, called him Columbus Chulahoma.

'The Piggly Wiggly parhkin' laht?" Jackie Mason is saying such. "Is this broad for real right now?"

Itragene went "*Shhh!*" She enunciated this out loud.

"Mama? Are you seeing granddidy again sittin' up in the crib?"

"No, no, no, thank you, baby... I'm glad y'all still do that."

"You ain't got the wheelchair out again, did you?"

Maddie was referencing the couple of occasions she'd found Itragene pushing their old wheelchair around the house talking to it because she thought her dead daddy, Thaddeus Jr., was in it.

Maddie waited for an answer that didn't come and then spoke again.

"Do what? Share food? John Henry spoils that man—there's

plenty. He's got plenty."

"No, do y'all still have your drinks in the parking lot after your shift—you still doin' that ain't you baby?"

Itragene is in five worlds at once; on her insides in the moments before anything kinetic in her nervous system activates, she's getting ready to stand up in the same reality as Maddie, and it is a mighty effort.

At a point she achieved air, and she was getting up and had entered this world to prove how perfectly fine she was. She fell over immediately after she got up.

"Mama, Jesus!"

One must get up, Itragene's thoughts go.

She fell over on the table, fell flat on her face on the police scanner table; she immediately recovered and madly screamed at Maddie, like she was on the other side of the house, "THE BLEVINS GIRL IS STUCK UNDER A SPAGHETTI SHELF!"

"Mama, what are you—"

"Baby!" She grabbed Maddie by the shoulders—"They don't know if she'll make it; it's Porridge, the baby Blevins. The spaghetti shelf fell on her."

She was near tears, but they didn't surface. She wasn't crying but was about to.

Maddie ignored whatever this was about a spaghetti shelf.

"You sure you don't wont some catfish? It's from the McShan pond place."

"No, no, I just had a Snickers bar, baby, I'm fine. I'm fine... "

Maddie walked away at the sound of her catfish being done in the microwave, it beeping—*dt*, *dt*.

Maddie was audibly taking out her catfish, saying "shit" after burning her finger on the grease transferring it from one plate and to another covered in paper towels to wipe it down to make it edible.

Itragene started crying a bit, and for reasons mysterious to her, her emotions labile and often inexplicable. She wiped her eyes with her

muumuu.

She is hallucinating so much.

She's already getting back to it, her conversation she's been having in her head with Sandra Bernhard and the hallucinated Assembly of Israel more broadly, *talking without speaking, hearing without listening*.

She had gotten her muumuu soaked wiping her confused tears away on the dancing chickens printed on it.

She's motivated by equality as a basic right for civilized society. She did things in her life that indicated such, her notions becoming actions and those actions events in history. She surely lived in part for her notions, but, unlike, for instance, Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley, friend of the famed and legendary poltergeist Jeffrey, she has always taken breaks. She was not really on about such things when she wasn't suffering acute psychotic symptoms from not sleeping—she didn't have the schizzies like Jane Ellen; Itragene was a bit of a mad genius and she was touched in the head as well, but it was the bipolar and not the schizzies.

After having been taught the ropes of Shekel Math Wednesday morning by Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, or, at least, the Ginsburg-in-her-head, Itragene, having slept a bit after, found herself feeling pedagogical again, but, this time, she was the teacher, not the cricket.

She was the master of a language game she'd play called "Lots Logic," and she was determined to teach it to the people in her head, the rotating cast of hallucinated people she was calling the Assembly of Israel, which had, until then, that Friday morning a bit after midnight, had been just the ghost of Henry Wells and the telepathic presence of Ruth Bader Ginsburg.

At that point, when it was truly Friday, our Itragene was no longer the pupil but the teacher—it was her turn.

She had notions. She had to show them!

Sandra Bernhard had just been there when she woke and cleared

the gunky sleep from her eyes. Itragene, of course, accepted this as everyday business.

She bopped about the house, made her coffee, got set up at the police scanner table, all the while talking to the voices in her head, but mainly Sandra Bernhard, to whom she was introducing Pickens County, introduced her to Henry, and the like.

So, there she was and she was teaching Sandra Bernhard something significant, doing so, in her mind, so that they could make progress on substantial things in the world as important people, the Assembly of Israel being constituted by important people accomplishing significant things in the world, all with their "own" wisdom that was wholly the proprietary technology that was Itragene's mind.

Itragene was listening to "Dear Prudence," a 1983 cover put out by Siouxsie & the Banshees; she loved that song, that version, no idea who did the original, maybe the Beatles:

> ... won't you come out to play?
> ... greet the brand new day.

That song played in the background, sonic activity that alloyed with the lurching voices and beeping and static coming from her police scanner.

That Friday, March 18, 1994, Itragene was there, there and nowhere, everywhere, too, correct but very wrong, her in such a bad way, near dead, honestly, bipolar manic psychosis ravaging her mind and body; there she was, though, and she was explaining something to the Jewish comedian and frequent late-night talk show guest Sandra Bernhard—the latest Assembly of Israel member.

Itragene was going on about it to Sandra, this "Lots Logic" an idea she had had in the 1950s and never really shook, "perfecting it" every time she got manic and psychotic; Itragene was going on and carrying about regarding this idea that she called "*Lots Logic*."

She would recursively go on and on about this Lots Logic, never

resolving into any one point; this was built into Lots Logic, in fact, a feature and not a flaw, this recursion—and type ambiguity, too—she would show Bernhard.

Itragene was out of her mind, and Maddie, that Friday, doing her little light afternoon shift at the Gordo Piggly Wiggly, she found herself at the cashier aisle nearest to the front door, where she worked on lane three, thinking about her mama, Maddie starting to get concerned, the predecessor of its more pointed partner in attention, worry.

Yeah, there ain't no denying it: she had, indeed, noticed tiny sums of a change in Itragene, picked up that something was off with her mama, but she was mostly ignorant of these things, severe mental illness; she understood enough, though, and she had definitely—and worryingly— heard her mother mutter something about "shekel math" earlier that week, the morning she picked her up from the county square, having, indeed, grown up with Itragene going on about "Lots Logic," out of her mind, and this "shekel math" business seemed *soooo* similar to "Lots Logic" ('cos it was). She had thought she heard Itragene say something so odd and foreign, "shekel math" and it just—and immediately, her knowing her damn mother—struck her as crazy, something about which "shekel math" as a concept immediately seemed pertinent.

It was an insane idea, truly, this renewed psychotic notion she had of "Lots Logic."

"I have called it 'Lots Logic,' this morphological game with the lexemes 'a lot,' 'lot(s),' and 'allot.'"

Lots Logic is, like Shekel Math, a psychotic recursive system she had made up and has been elaborating. She's elaborated it so much that, by now, in a way, it makes in her head as well as made some sense once she's externalized it. She has executed Lots Logic in natural, human language; it's a recursive word games for her—shehad another, that latest one she had been calling "the formula of idiocy," and she was on about some recursion and permutations of the words

"idiocy," "pride", "heritage," "legend," "history," and "legacy." She was actually at the time working on an essay as of that week called "The Idiocy in the Pride in the Heritage of the Legend as the History of the Legacy."

She was muttering to herself sitting in the sunroom bay window at her little table with its police scanner.

Lots Logic is a manner of speaking, she tells Sandra Bernhnard without speaking.

'Let me tell you something, Itragene!'

Berhard screams this at Itragene from within her, and she is throwing her hands around in the air.

Bernhard is going, 'Don't tell me you're not going in circles, honey, because this seems to make sense but not add up to much, and, in showbusiness, you need to know what is what. Let them sweat it out! Don't tell them a lot. They'll try to know everything, honey. It's about street smarts.'

It was an old idea of hers, reignited, her renewed notion and novel ideas all literally and medically the byproducts of her language centers malfunctioning in severe bipolar manic psychosis; she had a thoroughly bad case of hypergraphia (medically speaking, she could not shut up, there being always language in her, her words or those of the creations in her mind in the Assembly of Israel.

"Lots Logic" was truly just an idiosyncratic way of recognizing the legacy of the Confederacy, Lots Logic just being a bizarre and hyper-agile, stenographic way of talking about segregation of lots in life—life chances—across Pickens County; this Lots Logic stuff was one of our Itragene's *modes,* an instance of her encrypted ways, her bits that she did and to which she truly committed as if she were a Gordo, Alabama Andy Kaufman; Lots Logic was batshit and brilliant, was one of her coo-coo theoretical frameworks for understanding what she knew to be *legacy*, a manner of talking and thinking through something with which she occupied herself, occupied, she was, busy, *busy busy busy* with doing things in her manners and ways.

This Lots Logic was an example of her *being onto something*, a true understanding in wisdom. Itragene liked to say this about herself when she got on a thing—that she was "onto something"—particularly when it were a wild idea or notion that kept her busy, laughing and offered occasions to be a ham, if only performing for herself and her god and no live, true audience, though she loved to entertain anybody who'd buy a ticket to the show.

She was excited to share what she felt she knew with Sandra Bernhard in their initial acquaintance. Lots Logic, "*here we gooooo*," she felt, our Itragene; Bernhard, an intelligent woman, she would surely understand.

"A lot of people," Itragene carried on to the Bernhard in her head, "a lot of people who live in haunted Carrollton, the place so haunted, Carrollton, Alabama, the County of Pickens, well, well, a lot of people around here, they live outside of town in a place called McShan."

In fact, a lot of people did live outside of town in this town, McShan, a town that wasn't a town, really, but was, rather, just a place called McShan, not legally recognized; McShan was a place that wasn't really real in legal terms, a big place in Pickens County, and one that everybody called "*Mac-Shan*," though it was spelled "McShan."

"It is just a place, McShan—and it has a lot of land, allotted in lots, which adds up to lots of land, in some cases—much, not little, lots, that is—and not a lot in other cases but nonetheless still a lot, if not in amount then type, a lot, a parcel and portion—*etc*. *Type ambiguity is key here*."

Itragene carried on about it all to Bernhard and she was gonna teach her how to find the "*etc*." for her Lots Logic, teaching her how to think in this bizarre morphology that she called Lots Logic, it just a language game, teaching her how it was all held together, the illusion of McShan, by supposed Itragene Bell McDaniel, Sr.-minted Lots Logic, our Itragene going about making sure Bernhard had the full context of the county explained to her as much as Itragene was

describing to herself what she found, at the moment, to be true, her assessing reality, her in a never-ending recursive coil of explaining to herself what's real, her so long gone and psychotic. She'd go on and on about things in recursion, medically unable to find resolve in a final word on any matter—this was an ecstatic way to think, a never-ending story, and Itragene liked it.

She felt lucky. She was crazy.

As it was, Itragene carried on and on about it all to the Bernhard in her head" "It's this, THIS IS LOTS LOGIC RIGHT HERE by way of example of McShan: it's that there's a lot of lots of land in the land of McShan, a lot, a whole lot, some lots a whole lot—see, here, *lots* to take in? I know it's a lot but I also know a lot, more than you'd think."

'Slow down, honey—you're spiralling," went Bernhard.

"Lots Logic"—she inaheld deeply to demonstrate her good faith in attempting to slow down—"You use the lexemes "lot," "a lot," "alott" in all sorts of type ambiguous permutations."

'So, it's bullshitting but it's a word game?'

"Yes, and it's also about reality—just look at McShan!"

"Let's be abstract a moment and come back to McShan. In general, it goes like this, not unlike beatboxing, forrrrr instance... "

She cleared her throat, continuing the logic silently, not muttering for a bit.

So, some lots allot just lots, you see? She's going on in her head to Bernhard.

It's not much, just a lot, in such cases, lots and for some lot, but not many lot; there were lots, too much for so few a lot; the whole lot of Pickens deserved a lot, but not a lot of that was going on. *See? Lots Logic*. You can go on *forever about it*, lots—lots in life, you can, indeed. See how this here is a homonymic—"a lot allot," as in, say, "lotting lots lot *allot a lot* of lots a lot," the "allot a lot" part, that lot of it?

'I think I see what you mean, Iddy. And, hey, word to the wise, sister: You really have to be able to accept the fact that part of your job

is to be laughed at by strangers.'

Sure, I've been laughed at lots—strangers, intimates, everybody, Itragene, slightly sidetracked by Bernhard, admitted in her head.

'I'm not a comedian,' Sandra said again, interrupting in a brief slowing in Itragene's cadence regarding Lots Logic, continuing, 'I'm an entertainer, a performer. I'm a personality.'

"Anyway," said, Itragene got cranked up and started muttering again.

"Sandra, lots—everybody, the whole lot, really—who stay in McShan are white, see? The Lots Logic makes this possible; stay with me. It's a specific lot on the McShan lot, where these white people live apart from any Black people. They live there on their lots. Funny story: that all goes the same, too, for one joker, even though people think he's an Indian—he's white, too, though, truly, his story a whole lot, him being a whole lot, too, faking being a half-Choctaw and quarter-Cherokee, that white man in McShan; I know him, friends with my Maddie."

'Isn't that the fake Indian named "Columbus"?' Sandra died laughing, saying, 'Maybe comedy is the only hope for humanity.'

"Lots Logic is kinda funny, you know," Itragene quickly quipped. Our Itragene was starting to go to *town* in her damn head and out loud under her breath, smokin' so many cigarettes, "talking to 'Sandra Bernhard.'"

Our Itragene was internally speaking faster than any human had strung together speech ever, she felt—just a "Jewish genius" from Gordo, Alabama, she was so convinced, by that point in her manic psychosis—that had emerged the last days, that notion, that she were a Jewish genius. She was just convinced she were a "Jewish genius," like Einstein, one surely soon to be discovered for her mere verbal dexterity and tenacity, discovered because she was too funny to go unnoticed, a ham and gift to the world, an entertaining—just what she was, a "Jewish genius," she so knew.

She was a Jewish genius, of course, Itragene thought and couldn't

doubt. A Jewish genius—that's why she could talk so fast in her head and to people who weren't there, to boot. She had skills, in her psychotic mind. Not telepathic? That's a skill issue, she felt.

"Everybody who lives in McShan is white," she was carrying on: "No Black people be staying there, ever, not ever, including this one man who everybody calls 'the little Indian in the meadow'—he goes by the name 'Columbus Chulahoma,' like I said; he's an Indian, they say, but, really, he's white; he's pretending to be an Indian, like I just said, pretending to not be white, but, nonetheless, he has a really big lot, now that I think of it...anyway...interesting lot in life, that one, Chulahoma."

She was getting distracted by the curio that was the Indian in the McShan Meadow—she needed to focus more on the lots lot of stuff in her head she was allotting.

Itragene was determined to give this here Sandra Bernard "the full download," as she saw it, going on in her head really fast, staring out her bay window all the while moving her mouth, there in her sun room at her feature bay window, down at the end of the main downtown strip of Gordo, carrying on, visible to all, no shit given.

She tried starting again—no Chulahoma nonsense tangents, this time, all of that something to save for later.

"OK and anyway: everybody in McShan is white—even the so-called Native American man, that little Indian in the meadow (that meadow ain't even a meadow, by the way, just a damn field, a lot of land)—and some of them own some land, some lots—lots of land, lots, parcels, some lots and others not much, not a lot. *I'm onto something*: there's a logic that goes into the assignment and passage through the generati*ahn*s of these lots of land, a logic of sorts to preserve legacy—I call it 'Lots Logic.'"

'I love *National Geographic*. Just when you think you've seen the last lost native tribe, *National Geographic* will find a new one—lot logic at work, my Godddd, Itragene! You might be right,' an amazed Bernhard said.

"See, understand, here? You're getting it. It looks like Lisp (short for LISt Processing)...do you know about computers? Lots Logic has type ambiguity and dynamic typing...in your head of course, the lot of it...I think it was John McCarthy, MIT...1958, yes! Wait, no—not relevant, not a lot. We must stick to the local lots."

Indeed, Itragene had near formalized this "logic" in her writings on her legal pads and musings in her little crazy head, some of it typed on her Underwood 315, a Spanish model manual typewriter; she was really interested in how computer programming languages and natural language might meet at the nexus of Lots Logic morphology, a modern woman ready for the future; she knew about e-mail; she didn't have a computer, had never touched one.

She had gotten started on her latest project, which was an experiment in type ambiguity with syntax.

> Lots (a lot [lots lot lots a lot]) allot lots of lots that lot lots. Lots (lots [a lot {lots that lot a lot}]) lot lots of lots, lots. Lots (a lot [lots that lots {allot lots}]) lot lots that lot, lots. Lots ([lots] {a lot [lots (lots of lots)]}) lot lots a lot. Lots (lots {a lot [lots {lots that lot lots}]}) allot lots, lots. A lot (lots [lots {a lot of lots that lot lots}]) lots lots, lots. Lots (a lot {allot lots [lots (lots of lots that lot)]}) lot lots, lots. Allot lots (a lot [lots that lot lots]) lots lots, lots. Lots (lots {lots [a lot of lots {lots that lot a lot}]}) lot lots, lots. A lot (lots [lots {lots (a lot of lots)}]) lots a lot, lots. Lots? Lot: Allot lots lot lots; lots lot lots, lots. Lots? Lot (lot): Allot lots lot lots; lots lot lots, lots. Lots ("lots")?

Bernard silently took it all in.

Typical of the voices in her head—her own rendition, the memes she had absorbed from these fuckers from popular culture who lived in her head, now, at that point. The people in her head were Itragene's version of them, how she held them in her memory by virtue of memorizing their memes, those tiny bits of culture that are replicated as people imitate one another, a term from evolutionary biology, meme, one she knew well from the work of evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins.

Pretty much, Lots Logic was Itragene being *onto something*, you could say, if you consider it, there truly something there—nonsensical in form, sure, but nothing she was saying was untrue at all, at the fuck at all. It was just a game. Lots of people treat life like a game—her turn. She was simply correct, crazy as it was, and, so, maybe the packaging of the products of her mind were odd, but, she was right in a sideways way: for instance, if you're thinking in terms of ambiguous "lots," you'll quickly realize that some, a few—well, *a lot* that wasn't a lot, just some monied lot—they, that said lot, they indeed *did truly* own lots, a ton as in size well as lots in terms of parcels, portions of land, lots of lots allotted to some lot, following the rhythm of Lots Logic; it was some mysterious lot of people who owned all the town, every lot in life assigned to each person in Pickens County in what Itragene Belle McDaniel, Sr., of Gordo, Alabama, said was Lots Logic.

Lots Logic applied to McShan and elsewhere, as it were, further, beyond McShan, it applied to all the other eleventy-seven other smaller towns, villages, communities, little places to live, the eleventy-seven of the real and fake towns in Pickens, the smaller towns with their wooded lots, some of them not even towns, technically, just lots, such as McShan, those lots being the thing about it, it all just lots of land.

That place, Pickens County, that tiny and rural county, with it having a whole *fifty-five* recognized legal entities in it—*fifty-five places in* Pickens were you could live—it was all segregated as hell, and so, it just was that this morphology of the English word "lots" and its linguistic cousins made sense in fantastical, wise ways, even if none of it sounded like it added up to anything significant; "lots" was just the unit to figure it all out in, anaphora in thought, for our Itragene—it was like a bit, or a gene or meme, a bit, a sequence of memes recursively enacted.

This Lots Logic stuff was particular to English, too, Itragene had proven in her studies of the sensation. She had thought that element up and down, and it only worked in English, she was sure. She had tried

to formulate this in Spanish and French, at least, but "Lots Logic" seemed to be an English-specific recursive quirk in morphology, syntax and symbolic recursion, or at least it wasn't a thing in Romance languages, her unsure. There had to be a mathematics to it, the way you could endlessly go on in an odd and poetic manner about "lots in life" she was so sure.

"So, Lots Logic. *What's it about?* Got any questions, doll—can I call you doll? I like how you call people 'honey' and 'doll,' Sandra."

Itragene was gleeful, having gained momentum on this day describing what she called "Lots Logic" to the hallucinated Sandra Bernhard in her head.

This is when the famous Jewish comedian Jackie Mason piped in out of nowhere: "'People say there's "a lot," huh, what do *ya* know? Gentiles—they're so busy, they're *schvitzing*, they're *noshing*.'

Jackie Mason made a weird face that was like, "*ya* know what I mean?"

Itragene did feel that she did know what he meant, though all of it was contextless nonsense, her manic mind blaring like a speaker switching channels on the FM dial; her head was the radio, so any aberrant signal was perfectly in place and she could contextualize it all.

"Jackie, you too, you need to learn this," Itragene gladly said to the comedian who had just popped up, happy to have a new Assembly member, another Jewish comedian—great, she felt.

Totally off-topic, legendary Jewish comedian Jackie Mason started going in on to "everybody present" about how Itragene's house was drafty, which was true, an old house though a nice one.

"'It's March: it's cold and it's hot, *cold*, hot—*cold*, hot—*hot*, *cold*, cold, just too drafty! I *hate* a draft in the air. We hate a draft, don't we, folks, ladies and gents?"

He was pacing back and forth in a suit, smirking, wielding a microphone loosely in his hand, in Itragene's mental visage.

"Don't set me next to the door at a *restorahnt,"* he said. "I hate the

draft, I hate a draft—I'm my own grandmo*thah*—bubbie hated a draft, HaShem rest her soul. You ever seen a Jew walk into a restaurant? Like a *partner*, "Hello!!!" Gentiles are nervous in a good restaurant, always so nervous. No good Jew likes a draft—put me here, put there, put me nowhere near the door; the gentiles don't even look at the menu! Don't put me next to the door...oh, oh, *ho*, oh!'"

Sandra Bernhard has grown beyond just visibly annoyed with Jackie Mason.

"'With all due respect, Jackie, *looooook*, hon, look: you're a legend, babe, and we all love you, but let her continue. Fuck a cold and unpleasant draft, sure...nobody reasonable likes one; we all hate a draft and you're very funny and *etc*. *etc*., the Roman *yada yada*...We get it, Jackie,'" Bernhard addressed Mason, who was carrying on frantically about drafts and uncomfortable weather.

Rather violently, a comedian of Irish heritage was coming around, then, and this was gentile Rosie O'Donnell showing up, then, and she bitch slapped Mason.

"'He's a misogynist, Itragene,'" Rosie said.

"'Jackie is very funny, great timing and expressiveness, but his politics aren't always great, true,'" Bernhard agreed. "'We love you, though, Jackie: you're a legend, doll."

"But," Itragene was protesting, "he was talking about the draft, and it's true—there's a draft, this time of year."

"'*Come*, go; come, *go—up*, down, *the air is hot* but it's cold, *what they call a draft*,'" Jackie Mason was still carrying on.

"'Oy *veyyy*, shut up, Jackie, please. Why are you always like this? This is gender-based discrimination,'" Ruth Bader Ginsburg interrupted.

"'I'm a real woman, honey!'" Bernhard said her famous line, and then went into a vortex of her catchphrases, spinning out of control.

"Don't even try it, sweetheart!

"'I adore you, but I don't have time for this.

"'Let me tell you something...*Dahling*!

"'My family wasn't the Brady Bunch. They were the Broody Bunch...I mean, I'm saying...let me tell you!'"

Itragene's switchboard was glitching a bit, devolving into catchphrases, then, too, for Joan Rivers, who was vaguely in the background as of then, catchphrases totally for her, Joan Rivers, and, for a moment, with Bernhard.

The pace picked back up and got more coherent, conversational.

"'Who *the hell* are all these white people, girl?'" Henry Wells had then piped up.

A whole bunch of them said: "Hey, be careful—we aren't just some whites. We're Jewish."

"We won't be so white if they build the camps, oh no, not *awl*," our Itragene said that last part with a Brooklyn Jewish accent randomly, going on, back to Gordo girl.

"Even paternal Jews will be on a list, Henry; it's a unique and ancient bigotry, the oldest in the world, actually," Itragene gave further context to Henry about the issue of whiteness and Jewish identity.

"'Oh, my apologies, my apologies—oh, I do see, *yesssss* I do, do enough,'" Henry said, continuing, "'Let my people go. I loveeeeee Exodus. The Israelites were slaves and hell-raisers for a mighty god!'"

"'I'm Joan,'" Joan Rivers said directly to Henry, her having just popped up a moment ago, too, Itragene's mental vista fucking crowded as hell.

Joan Rivers went, "'This isn't Sally Jesse Raphael's bullshit, hah. This is Itragene's world! More after the break.'"

"'Sandra, a real pleasure, Henry. Let me tell you something...'" Sandra was happy to meet him, truly, and so annoyed with Jackie, who was *still* ranting and raving about how he hated a draft.

The voices in her head were all occupying the same space in that moment, meeting one another; how lovely, she was like and thinking at the hallucinated sight and sound of them all carrying on in her crazy head.

"'And I'm Justice Ginsburg. We are going to re-litigate your case,

Henry—discrimination, to say the least in that reg*arhd*,'" Ginsburg assured Wells.

"'Is it cold or hot up there in the garret room?'" Jackie Mason asked Henry this.

"'Oh, that ain't me up there in that window, but I do be staying in that garret room so no crac*kah* will bother me; I go about, I do, I do, sir. Ohhhh, *whewwwwwww* it hot as hell, though up there, sir! But it do be cold, too. Hot air go up—I learned that a long time ago, a long time ago, whewwww *wee*,'" Henry Wells the hallucinated ghost of a formerly enslaved man who was allegedly lynched in the nineteen century said, continuing, "That ain't' even my face up there, sirs and madams, that ain't even my pretty face! *Y'all best know!*'"

"Horrible," Bernhard said, her OK with Henry taking up space, unlike with Mason, who *still* was carrying on in the barely audible background about the draft in the Gordo house at the end of the main strip where Itragene lived.

"'Well, I ain't got no shoes on my pretty feet, so it do get a lil' cold, but we OK, we OK, sir.'"

"'I bet they lynched you and then followed up :"Because I'm a nice person!"'" Joan Rivers asserted that, once again using one of her catchphrases that Itragene knew about, her only vaguely familiar with Rivers, though a nominal fan and thought she were a hoot, just not very familiar, limited sound bites for the hallucination.

"'EVERYBODY SHUT THE FUCK UP AND LET HER SPEAK," Sandra Bernhard said so loudly that Itragene thought the house vibrated.

Itragene then happily continued, picked back up with the lot she had allotted her to allot to this lot in her head.

"And so, so there are lots *à la* town of different kinds, lots *à la* Aliceville and Gordo, and more, lots of lots *al* town, like here, *à la carte* Gordo, the buffet of life where I myself live with my daughter, I do (daddy's here, too, but that's another story, him stuck, here, in Jewish hell-lite, *Gehinnom,* גֵיהִנּוֹם, you know...let me tell you

something—"

She was cut off by Mason, our Itragene.

"'She likes to talk, huh? *Hoo*, what a number she's got—hah!'" Jackie Mason went, briefly piercing Itragene's authentic inner voice.

"There's no comprehensive"—Itragene continued, also getting annoyed with Mason, who, in fact, seemed to like to talk more than her and that was pretty misogynist! Rosie was right, harsh but right in calling him a misogynist; "don't meet your heroes," she thought atop her other thoughts, layering them—"lesson plan, no way of giving a total account of the recursive loops of Lots Logic, this informal Pickens way of pecking about, a local county cognitive template for assigning lots in life, sacred work, sacred work, sacred, deciding matters of life, death, blood and bone, food, shelter and appropriate coverings for human bodies, some of them little babies—Lots Logic might sound like a joke at first, but it's *dead serious* in understanding the *dissimulation* that is the face in the window story that has been replicating for over a century around here," she was breathlessly muttering inside her head, conducting fresh analyses of Pickens as much as she was "updating" "Sandra Bernhard" *et al*., those motherfuckers that she was hallucinating in her head, updating Bernhard as well as Henry Wells, Jackie Mason, Joan Rivers and also Rosie O'Donnell and the Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, a rapt audience, the go*t*damn Assembly of Israel.

Suddenly, *even more* Jewish comedians appeared, and she looked up, eyes ajar, staring agape at the so-called portico, the brightly shining architectural meeting place in her mind for the Assembly of Israel. The Assembly was growing immensely and in a favored demographic direction, the tribe—Jews.

Itragene was so glad, filled with light and ecstasy, felt at home with the Tribe of Israel insofar as she was affiliated by way of the hallucinated people in her head.

That's when the deadly laughter began.

First, Judy Gold popped up, talking about her mother: "My mother

always sits in the passenger seat—she likes the legroom, you know. Hah!"

That "hah" compounded, started to echo as others emerged "on stage," so to speak, on the portico in her mind that she called "The Assembly of Israel," laugher all around.

Andy Kaufman—performance artist and comedian where you never knew where the bit began and ended, famously—then slid into view, slowly, him wearing a loud red blazer and he had his hair plastered down. He said, in a Spaniard accent, "And, now, I will like to imitate, a..."

Kaufman then paused mid-sentence, seemingly for effect, and the whole Assembly howled laughing, it not clear to Itragene as to why, but she howled, too.

Kaufman continued, "I forget. You *vant* see me dance?" He then clogged and sang "la, la, *lah*."

At this bit, they screamed, Ginsburg admitting without shame that she were about to piss herself, she was laughing so hard. Nobody had any idea what he was on about, but they loved it, all these voices in her head.

"You just never know where the bit begins and ends with him," observed the obvious, Bernhard. "They say he faked his own death—is that true, Andy, doll?"

Kaufman grinned at being asked that question but did not verbally affirm.

"Love is the only shocking act left on the face of the earth, you know," Bernhard told Andy.

Indeed, more known and relevant Jewish comedians appeared, also early vaudeville characters like Milton Berle, George Burns, Jack Benny and the Marx Brothers. Among the later comedians like Gold and Kaufman, Bernhard, Rivers and Mason, popping up also so quickly were Jewish comedians like Lenny Bruce, with his loud glasses; Billy Crystal, with his smirk; Jerry Stiller, with his yelling; Gilda Radner, with her throwing her shoulders up; Don Rickles with

his yelling, too.

Finally, that Jackie Mason, who *kept* muttering about the draft in the house, was cut off, finally and totally, for a bit, at least, when Jewish actor Gene Wilder popped up, and, *yes*—he was dressed as Willy Wonka.

At this rate, they were all talking over her and each other, too, like bunch of Jews would do, per Itragene's imagination in her somewhat culturally fluent mind, this woman loving the shit out of Jews—two Jews, three opinions, *yada yada*, but on steroids, over a dozen hallucinated Jews, conversational collaborative overlapping gone haywire.

Gene Wilder stared at her wildly from within her imagination, and a weird *jingle jingle*-like glockenspiel started filling the sound of her sun room, her hearing voices and music like they were really sound waves in the air, and Wilder began to sing, the entire assembly joining him, a sweet set of glissando violins filling that sun room as they all sang in the cinematic glow:

Come with me and you'll be in a world of pure imagination.
Reach out, touch what was once just in your imagination.

Don't be shy, it's alright if you feel a little trepidation.
Sometimes these things don't need explanation.

If you want to view paradise simply look at them and view it.
Somebody to hold on to, it's all we really need.

Nothing else to it.

"Nothing else to it" really rang lyrically for our Itragene, and the glockenspiel filled the drafty air in her house: *duh, dun, duh-duh-duh, dun, duh, duhn-duhn-duhn, dun*.

The collective, Gene Wilder-led singing continued: "'Come with

me and you'll be in a world of pure imagination. *Take a look and you'll see into your imagination…*'"

They all kept singing; the music, then, whimsically went along with a series of statements made by Wilder, who had stopped singing and started talking, absurdly dressed as Willy Wonka, spitting Wonka lines and aphorisms: "Candy is dandy, but liquor is quicker."

"'Very true—you got PROBLEMS if you're in Bel Air and that happens—no candy, no liquor. I was in MALIBU, wow, Hollywood—I was there, so what! Anyway...'" Don Rickles was screaming about something or another, nobody no idea what he was on about. "That's the show!"

Wilder dramatically messed up his hair, going about it all like an exaggerated costume change, and, then, he ducked down, shimmied, and prepared for a dramatic performance of the next line.

"'You get nothing! You lose! Good day, sir, good day."

Henry Wells replied.

"'Me, sir? I done been lost, sir, you ain't gotta tell me no nothin' of that matt*ah*!'" that Henry Wells in her head gleefully went, responding to Wilder.

Henry was somewhat confused, Itragene thought, and she saw that Mason was bemused, Bernhard annoyed, Rivers momentarily missing, Ginsburg oblivious because she was reading a law book while everybody carried on. O'Donnell held everybody else back, saying, "'Shut up, and let her speak.'"

The other many virtual people busied about, coming in and out of Itragene's visual field and aural field.

Itragene went, "'*We are the music makers, and we are the dreamers dreams...'* Can we continue now with Lots Logic, my people?"

They all started briefly singing the tune from *Willy Wonka & the Chocolate Factory*, "Cheer Up, Charlie."

They wanted her to shut up, it seemed, and they kept playing music over her thoughts so she couldn't get going on again about Lots Logic

—they got it, the point made; she was being redundant, in their eyes, views and vantage points from the multiverse of Itragene's mind.

As they sang "Cheer Up, Charlie" softly, Rivers, who had been absent amidst the collective laughter fit, suddenly said, "'Can we talk?'"

Jackie Mason goes, "'Joan! Joan, my girl, do you feel the draft?'"

"Rivers, dismayed, "'Oh, grow up!'"

"'Just talk, girl, talk over them. They'll never shut up of their own accord, hon; it's awful but it's our people, awfully funny, not truly awful. You have to learn to poke your neck out and talk over others, with this crew. Let me tell you something! You don't need to be famous to live a life as an artist. You know what I'm saying?" Bernhard urged Itragene, supportively, shaking her head characteristically and throwing her hands up in hyperbolic expression upon the last question she asked.

Itragene picked up again with the Lots Logic account of McShan. "McShan is, indeed, an essential corner of Henry's Garden, Henry a scarecrow not only in Carrollton but a broader warning to Black people all over Pickens County, Black people in a garden tended to and maintained by legacy and nourished in blood, a garden with a *strange fruit* at its center, those *bulging eyes* and *wailing* and *twisted mouth* in that goddamn window; Henry's Garden spanned the entirety of Pickens County, one big fallen, sinful garden that needed repairing, a place that desperately needed the grace of repentance."

Itragene was going off again, "Bernhard" most prominently and patiently listening with the most attention, nodding, in fact, nodding every so often in moments of apparent deep understanding that Itragene perceived.

"Anybody from anywhere who speaks enough English can learn Lots Logic *à la* Pickens, and you only have to know one thing: how to get the rhythm right, all of it about morphology and the English words and phrasings as follows: 'lot,' 'lots,' 'a lot,' 'allot," and *etc*. I have not found any similar structure of thought in any other language, and I've

looked, Sandra, oh, I've looked; I've had many a dark night of the soul...The closest I've gotten outside of the Anglosphere is some Spanish prepositions sequenced like this, *'La manera en que ocurrió es lo que ocurrió...en el caso de español hay cosas así sino que no son mismos como Lots Logic en inglés...*חֶבֶל... אֲנִי לֹא יוֹדֵעַת. One does dwell on the difference between the British and Spanish crowns in their conquests of the Americas...what a lot, the Americas..."

Bernhard seemed to speak Spanish and Hebrew; she seemed to understood the last comment, repeating the Spanish part back in English: "'What occurred in what happened is what happened'...Yeah, I agree—the Spanish doesn't have the same flare as saying 'lots' all kinds—lots of—ways; there's no type ambiguity," she said, also thanking Itragene in Hebrew and going on in words that were some of the few modern Hebrew words Itragene knew: "'*Toda*! *Ken, ken*. *Ani m'dbert kazat ybrit v'sfardit*.'"

The Rebbe appeared—*the goddamn Rebbe, that Rebbe, the Rebbe*, and who on earth knows how this crazy white woman in Gordo, Alabama even knew about the goddamn Rebbe—and everybody around in her head was amazed and honored, the legendary Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, the last of the Chabad-Lubavitch Hasidic dynasty.

Mason went, "*Moschiach* is here!"

Joan Rivers, on repeat like a looping soundboard: "Oh, grow up!"

The Rebbe, with his Orthodox clothing—that dark and faithful fashion that emerged beginning the sixteenth-century nearabouts, in Poland and Lithuania—the Rebbe indeed appeared, in his signature clothes and with his wiry old snow white Ashkenazi Jewish man beard loudly present in Itragene's visual field.

The Rebbe had appeared; he extended a finger in the air with so much apparent and noticed deliberation, a twinkle in his eye, and he said, "'Let her speak. *Are we getting settled into getting unsettled?* Did we have a fun Purim? Let us not forget the *Megillah*. *Let us read Psalm 121,* "Song of the Accents," *shir la'maalot…'"* he said.

In her ecstatic visual field, Itragene—and all present with her in her head—she and them apparently all saw manifest in the air the Hebrew letters for that Psalm, as well as the English, things that Itragene simply *knew* off the top of her head, her so dang smart and knowledgeable, this all—all content put forth by all personages present, all hallucinations of a singular mind, all their apparent cogitating her intellectual substrate supporting—projected in her psychotic conjecturing.

Parts of the Psalm appeared in the air, the first bits.

Hebrew and the English words floated in the air like firework sparklers, trails in her visual field.

Before returning to the Lots Logic lesson, she paid her respects to the Rebbe and engaged Psalm 121 further, known as "The Song of Ascents," engaged as the Rebbe had highlighted, her reciting from memory aloud in her house, "*Shir lama'alot esa einai el heharim. Me'ayin yavo ezri. Ezri me'im HaShem ose shamayim va'aretz. Al yiten lamot ragleicha…"*

"OLAHM" the Rebbe yelled and slammed his palm on the police scanner table.

He was just yelling the Hebrew word for "universe" and "world" all of a sudden.

"'You know,'" the Rebbe went, signature eye twinkle ablaze, "'this, too, is Torah, this Lots Logic. This, too, is Torah; may we remember this. Let us not forget the Megillah. The Good Book promises in covenant a land for your children and theirs, a lot in life...the gentiles will be pleasantly surprised. And what will we all say? You're welcome. The Jewish context, my friends, is inevitable, a blessing for the world over.'"

Itragene nonverbally agreed with the Rebbe; she was, at once, a sort of genius and out of her fucking mind, observant, as she conceived it, askance of astute, not dumb, but damn crazy, loony; she, in fact, knew a shit ton about Hasidism, loved Kabbalah.

She was full of חִכְמָה, felt it in her right arm, this *chokma* her

erratic and hard-earned wisdom.

"So, Lots Logic—" Itragene started again.

"'Baby girl, please stop, please stop talking,'" Henry Wells pleaded that Itragene shut the fuck.

Itragene, in a true medical sense, couldn't shut up, a condition called hypergraphia. It was not possible for her to shut up, simply put.

She carried on and Henry pleaded for her to hush.

McShan was a community—one of the biggest places in Pickens County but not legally recognized in any manner—McShan was named after the McShan Lumber Company, which was established in 1844 just off the beaten path where Highway 82 would one day be. The big, white McShan Lumber Company mansion was still standing on Highway 82, situated between Columbus, Mississippi, and Reform, Alabama, set just before you took a right-hand turn off of Highway 82 and found your way into an area of Pickens County called McShan.

Pickens County was a place where folks lived and so was Itragene's mind, it just only that the creatures living in her mind were hallucinations, so the difference was that actual people lived in Pickens County while mere personages lived in Itragene's mind. McShan itself, similarly, was a relatively specific location in Pickens County where people lived—white people and white people only—but its boundaries were less clear than Pickens County county lines or the colorfully populated brain in our Itragene's skull. In the unique and peculiar case of McShan, it was the biggest place in Pickens County, yet, and yet, though the biggest place, the largest lot around, it wasn't legally recognized at all. It wasn't a legal entity, just an agreed-upon place.

Named after the important local lumber mill, McShan was part of the legacy of Pickens County, sure enough, but it was not a real, legal

place, as important as it was. McShan was nowhere at all—yet, too, it was all over the place, a huge area.

The geometry of McShan was our Itragene's Lots Logic in recursive action: McShan was some lot with type ambiguity as to its allotment.

McShan needed to be fuzzy.

These white people needed plausible deniability.

McShan's instantiation was a local geopolitical form of policing race and place, after all, like everything that were a matter of collective consensus in that county, that window with Henry Wells' wailing face looking down over it all. McShan was a historical illusion, sure, but it was all too real, everything about it. It was just a fact that Black people weren't allowed in McShan.

All of this is to say that it wasn't real until it was, McShan, all too real, so real they denied it in law. So, that was big the thing about McShan, "McShan"—it was one of the biggest towns that wasn't a town.

It was outside of town, McShan, they'd say.

But that wasn't really true, either, though, even if it felt true, given how there was barely anything or anybody in McShan, McShan, a bunch of woods, truly having an outside-of-town feeling, but it was actually as split between towns as it were outside of the many towns surrounding the McShan area.

McShan, specifically and technically, on one hand, was McShan, *Ethelsville*, Pickens County, Alabama, United States of America, McShan the finest, smallest nesting doll in this toponymic serialization, a little list of places in their order of governance pinpointing that McShan was inside of Ethelsville, technically. So, McShan was in Ethelsville, you could truly say. Sure enough, people in McShan—a lot of them, some lot—they did have an Ethelsville Zip Code, McShan truly in Ethelsville, you could say.

That wasn't all that McShan was, however. McShan as part of Ethelsville wasn't the total vision, not all that to which it could be

reduced, that McShan, Ethelsville. McShan being part of Ethelsville but also right outside of town was only part of the story of McShan, technically and specifically, because McShan, Ethelsville, was also, on the other hand, part of McShan, *Carrollton*, Pickens County, Alabama, United States of America, some folks—a lot of them, some lot—having a Carrollton Zip Code rather than an Ethelsville one, McShan truly in Carrollton, you could say.

People were born, they lived and died; they played the game of life in Pickens County, some lots in life in McShan, wherever that was, but it was a position on the board.

McShan's lots of land looked nothing like a checkerboard, not even a Chinese one. These lots were cut up in all sorts of irregular ways, McShan lots, cut up lots, a lot cut up in lots of McShan lots, this lot of a lot of land rhythmically assigned by history when it lies, hatred hiding in the rhythm of the recursive maintenance of racial segregation.

This was Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr., "Lots Logic" in action, a goddamn savant of sorts, she was, just correct though also insane. This was mostly due to the type ambiguity of this sideways way of talking they had in Pickens County about "lots."

So, due to these ambiguities, it was a little confusing and not all that informative when somebody said they had a lot of land in McShan. First, there's no telling how much a lot is, the acreage, a lot a quantity without a distinction. Just as well, secondly, geopolitically speaking on local matters, "a lot" in McShan could be in McShan, Ethelsville, or McShan, Carrollton, a good nine miles or so between those two places' ass-ends, those towns, Ethelsville barely enough to blow off your finger if you collected it up and tried to blow it off your finger, but nonetheless a town, had a post office and a small bank, a lady called Linda who had a cigarette smoke- and gossip-filled hair salon in her house where old chickens clucked and got their hair permed, Ethelsville also a random gift shop called "Ethels*yes*" that sold Snoopy helium balloons and Precious Moments figurines,

University of Alabama snow globes with elephants in them.

There were a good nine miles between Ethelsville and Carrollton as far as the crow flies on a day the Devil's beating his wife, as they'd say, and the crows flew, indeed, they flew over the McShan Woods, these crows, barely nobody there to see them.

In any case, in Pickens County Lots Logic, a lot of the town of McShan was inside the town of Ethelsville, on its Mississippi back-end, so part of Ethelsville but outside of town, but also it was the case that McShan was a town inside the town of Carrollton, just outside of town, again, and so, then, given all this, most people understood "McShan" to reference a bunch of woods roughly split between Carrollton and Ethelsville, the McShan Woods, Pickens County's sundown-town-outside-of-town dark forest.

Further, also and additionally, McShan being a place outside of town yet part of two towns, McShan, in a sense, was just a bunch of woods. This was true, McShan truly a bunch of woods, mostly, barely anybody living there.

McShan, it wasn't even a town, existing across and between other towns, but it also had something else going on. This place that didn't exist? It had two downtowns. It had two downtowns, somehow, in Pickens County minds; they were so creative.

So, McShan was, also, a town that was a little strip-of-a-little-road "downtown" area off of Highway 82 and the driveway of Henry's Garden, Phoenix Avenue, this "downtown McShan"—let's call it Downtown McShan No. 1—just a grown-over, no-longer-used playground that had a dead school bus in it, a gas station slash general store and the giant, oddly nice house that the gas station slash general store owner lived in.

Just as well, "downtown McShan" was a couplet of words that referenced somewhere else, "downtown McShan" also being somewhere else in people's minds, as far as the crow flies from this downtown strip of one store, a defunct park and a big nice house—about one and a half miles down McShan Road, also known as

Phoenix Avenue and also County Road 35, there a dirt road, there was a place in McShan, and when people meant *McShan* McShan, "downtown McShan," really meant the "town" of this fake town between towns, McShan was also commonly understood to mean this point in Pickens where there was a dirt road that was one of many entry points into the McShan Woods, Dew Perrigin Road, a dirt road off of Phoenix Avenue, a right-hand turn coming from downtown McShan No. 1, a turn you made across from the bass fish farm ponds that had a fried fish and hush puppies restaurant and a setup where you could go fishing for a cheap few dollars, a cheap thrill in two ponds that had more catfish than water.

And there you'd be in downtown McShan No. 2., saying you went.

Lots Logic sure did hold on the race front when it came to McShan: you just literally didn't see any Black people around there, McShan, not downtown, not between the two downtowns, not in McShan, Ethelsville, nor McShan, Carrollton—not on those school busses, *nuh-uh*, nope. Those McShan busses had no Black kids and, also, they probably were at the most risk in all of Pickens of a scalp getting ripped off one of its passengers, the many white trash girls and their tangled, white-girl nappy hair blowing in the wind from the open bus windows.

So, it was all-white, McShan—or, rather, "McShan"—but there was this "little Indian" in the "McShan Meadow." This man wasn't an Indian nor did he live in a proper meadow. He was a white man posing as a Native American and he lived in what they all called around there the "McShan Meadow," which was just a field situated next to a creek that flooded all the time. Most of everybody thought that he were half-Choctaw and a quarter-Cherokee, given that's what he told everybody.

This was crazy *ole*' Chulahoma, Maddie's best friend and boyfriend of the local mortician, John Henry.

"Columbus Chulahoma" was his supposed name, "the little Indian" in the "McShan Meadow," indeed, Columbus Chulahoma, the man who lived in McShan who was white but sort of not, at least in most

people's eyes and often including his own, all of these deranged people in McShan believing all sorts of stuff, talking to Jesus in their heads, calling this clearly white man a damn Indian, out of their goddamn minds.

Chulahoma lived near Downtown McShan No. 2.

If you went far down Dew Perrigin Road in downtown McShan No. 2 and turned left on Moorehead Road, kept on down that dirt road until the woods cleared, you'd then—suddenly, out of the thick—find yourself in a little "meadow," what they all called a meadow, nobody technically sure—definitely wrong, not correct. The thick woods cleared up here along this road except for giant old trees that lined both sides of the thin road, a road that flooded nonstop, these magical trees mostly obscuring from the road what they all called a "meadow."

So, there was "a little Indian," Columbus, and he lived in this "meadow" in McShan—sort of, it like most Pickens County facts, true but only kinda. He was a real man with an actual life, though, in any case; he was a self-proclaimed "Indian outlaw," him playing that Tim McGraw track "Indian Outlaw" all the goddamn time once it debuted in '94, dancing with barely any clothes on for his lover, driving around fast on meth in the woods, playing it in a Piggly Wiggly parking lot having a drink with a friend, his bestie, Maddie, Itragene's daughter.

A caucasian Mississippi native, in fact, he claimed to be a quarter-Cherokee and half-Choctaw in Alabama upon his arrival in Pickens County, moving there in the late '70s, him only initially saying it a few times to select people upon arriving in Pickens County and letting that nomenclature myth spread, also letting and watching it spread through the grapevine the meaning of his supposed surname, "Chulahoma," which means "red fox" in Choctaw. Once enough people knew all of this—or thought they knew—"Chulahoma" went along with it, started selling his "'Native American' art" on the Carrollton county square, festivals across Pickens and as far as flea markets in Hoover.

He was so white, so, so white, in fact, just in the simple terms of discussing what color his skin was; he was so white and so pale, but

had this jet black hair and eyes, too, black eyes, eyebrows and other body hair, a black and white man, a fake Native American and a white guy. He was also extremely attractive, this white guy faking his life who lived in a fake meadow in the McShan woods, a forest in a made-up and pretend but agreed-upon and enforced town outside of town between about half-a-dozen other towns in this county of full of segregated towns, fifty-five of them, amazingly, so many towns and such a small place, a big tiny place.

This was Columbus Chulahoma. This was McShan. This was Pickens County, Alabama, and its felicitous discontents.

He claimed that his daddy was an all-Choctaw Mississippian and that his mama was a self-hating half-Cherokee woman from Kentucky, a proud and high-strung woman, he'd say, "proud and high-strung," and he'd say that she had named him "Columbus" to curse his life, "white people dark magic," he'd say, and he'd say that his mama birthed him in Amory, Mississippi, him "growing up in Tupelo a little Indian boy named 'Columbus,'" the same name as the big state-border town nearby on the Mississippi side in Lowndes County and the same name as Christopher Columbus, "the explorer," as Chulahoma was taught in his verily Southern, Mississippi education—an "explorer," like he was a globe-trotting, fifteenth-century toddler with a big, fun boat on a childish adventure, and Chulahoma's supposed mama called him an "explorer," too, that Christopher Columbus as well as that Columbus Chulahoma, he'd claim, "calling me, her baby boy, an explorer, too," he'd say with a fully worked out and perfected whimsy in his eye, say that his self-hating, half-Cherokee, Kentucky-born mama would say stuff like this; he claimed to people that he was an "Indian named Columbus" because his mama wanted to make sure no Native Americans wanted to cavort with him, and, so, she named him after the Italian colonialist responsible for the genocide of Native peoples of the US South and beyond in the Americas, and that's why he had "no little Indian friends," he'd claim, throwing his hands up in apparent upset at his unfortunate social circumstance as a Native

American man in Pickens County with no tribe affiliation but a strong connection to his Native roots.

He was convincing and charming, a looker, too, sexy—crazy, too. Only a crazy person would commit to a bit as hard as he had, a regular Pickens County Andy Kaufman.

And, so, he would say that his mama's people were from the Appalachian Mountains, Cherokee territory, finding themselves with a sedan pulling a "rickety wagon with truck tires on it" and towing it all the way to Choctaw territory in Mississippi in and around Columbus, where they supposedly settled.

There, near and around the *town* town of Columbus, there, "despite herself, never accepting who she was as a Cherokee woman," his "white-passing, half-Cherokee mama" married "a full-blooded Choctaw," he'd say, "'a full-blooded Choctaw' with the name 'Chulahoma' and the rest is history. I was born in 1958 over in Amory, near where my mama and daddy moved to from Columbus for a minute before we moved over to Tupelo, Tupelo, where we lived, and my daddy, he worked in Starkville and dealt with a lot of discrimination, as a dark-complected Indian," he'd tell people, lying his face off; he claimed to know some people in Moundville, too, the eerie Alabama town famous for its the mounds the Mississippian Native people built before they mysteriously disappeared, Moundville, a bunch of earth bumps, little pyramids on some lots, nobody sure what they were, maybe burial grounds, who knows, the Lord knows.

According to him, he got his pasty skin from his mama, the mama about whom he said was half-white, and, in turn, as well, his dark features from his paternal Choctaw side, he'd insist, proffering this all given the preponderance of evidently evident evidence.

"Look *a'dem* eyes," he'd say staring with great intensity at somebody, and his eyes were pitch black, no way at all to gauge the size of his pupils or the full scope of his gaze, which had a disarming effect on people, disconcerting but oddly thrilling, given how good-looking he was. "Look a'dem eyes, them ain't no white man's eyes;

my people's suffering is all in the eyes, all in the eyes, man; it's all in the eyes, man," he'd rattle on, lying his face off, high on meth at times, people not always able to tell when, though, because you couldn't gauge the dilation of his pupils in them pretty black eyes of his.

The truth was that he never knew his parents. He was an orphan.

He grew up with no parents in Columbus, Mississippi, grew up in an orphanage. He was, in fact and truth, the little white child of born Mennonites, white like his white parents, his parents falling out of their native faith and then re-converting to Mennonitism far after he was born, both originally from Indiana Mennonite communities, them leaving the faith before they re-committed while living in Mississippi after attending a Mennonite revival, re-committing themselves to this Anabaptist movement, Mennonitism. German and English stock by way of Indiana Mennonite communities, Columbus was an orphan who had moved to Pickens decades ago at the age of eighteen, 1976, the first time he experienced meth and made a lot of rash life decisions, just up and deciding to spend the next leg of life seeking to find his birth family, people who he knew to live in Pickens and that was it.

Well, he thought he knew his parents were in Pickens, it all a bizarre affair.

Upon his official departure from the orphanage in 1976, off into adulthood, a staff member at the orphanage, Patricia, she told him something that wouldn't be true until the 1990s, and it fucked him up, fucked him up for life, truly. She said his parents were in Pickens, then, 1976. Columbus was pretty messed up, and this was one of the main things, beyond his genetics, that messed him up. What Patricia, the orphanage staff member, had told him—it all functioning like a prophecy in Columbus' life—at the time of his departure from the orphanage, it was something that was just not yet true but would be true, one day, not yet true as of his getting out of the orphanage upon coming of age, and that was that his mother and father were living in a nearby county in Alabama called Pickens, no idea which town, a county with many towns, but it was Pickens where they lived, Patricia

had told him; they were not not too far from the orphanage in Columbus, according to the story Columbus was told.

His parents, again, were originally from a Mennonite community in Indiana, moving to Mississippi around the time Columbus was born in the '50s. That was all true, and, eventually, they did live in Alabama, but they didn't make their way to Pickens County as residents until 1990, in fact, lived relatively well in that poor place; despite what Patricia had told him, setting him off on a journey and mission in the late 1970s that could not be fulfilled.

He was living in the same county with his parents, by the early 1990s, long having given up the search, when they both passed away, relatively close to one another, their deaths. His father died in a tractor misfortune in '92 and his mother died from a mostly Piggly Wiggly penny steak-induced heart attack in '93.

Patricia, this orphanage staff member, had told him that they were in Pickens, though, and she wasn't trying to lie to Columbus in saying it, though it weren't true; Patricia had been lied to and she passed along the false information, saying this with no ill will towards the poor boy; she had relayed this information in good faith, thinking she were helping him. A mysterious woman posing as Columbus' birth mother had called the orphanage years ago, in 1973, when he was fifteen, this mysterious woman on the phone relaying this false information to Patricia, the strange caller having, apparently, enough information about Columbus that the staff member believed it to be true that this was his mother on the phone, the woman knowing details like his name, Peter, his birth name, Peter Zook.

Columbus' parents hadn't even lived in Pickens in the 1970s, as it were, the late-1970s the time of Columbus' release from the orphanage and his move to Pickens to find them.

Ultimately, Chulahoma discovered his parents' full identity with the unwanted but nonetheless productive and conclusive help of local amateur historian Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley. He had given up, by that point, and he didn't want her help, actually, it just another instance of

her criminally harassing people and getting away with hit, her and her goddamn old newspapers.

His parents were dead. By the time he had certainty regarding their identity, they had passed way.

Upon learning their identities and that there was no contact information because they were deceased, this discovery happening in early 1994, Columbus was understandably confused as to why an orphanage staff member had told him that his parents lived in Pickens in 1976 when they were apparently from Indiana but lived in Mississippi until the 1990s, when they finally moved to Pickens County, him wondering if, ultimately, his mother moved to Pickens to find him, it all a mystery, him feeling his life to be part of something big—like Itragene felt hers to be—sometimes, when the enthusiastic moods to which he was prone would strike him, organically or through a meth pipe, he'd wonder if it were something messianic, his life, this apparent lie about his parents, him having a messiah complex just like poor *ole*' Itragene, like a lot of people with untreated mood disorders.

Among those few who did know about his secret identity, beyond Maddie, his best friend, there was local mortician Mr. John Henry and, again, Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley, the nosey old woman who most everybody in Pickens all called a "local historian"; it was these two townspeople, and Maddie and her mama, Itragene, who did know, who knew Columbus the Peter's secret about "Columbus Chulahoma" being fiction, none of these particular white people caring all too terribly about him pretending to be "a little Indian," at least Jane Ellen, Maddie caring less and John moreover saddened by his plight as a one-man pseudo-powwow but not bothered by the lie itself and its racist nature—Jane Ellen, though, she just found it more funny than immoral, and that's because she thought any joke or happenstance with humor about race in any regard was funny as hell—the more race the better, "*har*, *har*, har, *hah*," away, she'd go.

Jane Ellen kept his secret identity under wraps after discovering the stuff about his parents. Columbus didn't want her involved, and he

had long given up the search, but she had violently insisted——and this was because he were actually white, and she felt a pity upon him, though she thought he had betrayed his race, as she pretty much told him she knew that last January in 1993, told him one day while looking at the purses he had been selling on the county square.

"You look white to me and I talked to a *professah friend of mine,* over at the University—he said all the patterns are fake. Secret's safe with me. Do you know the love of Jesus Christ? You *do* know the Lord is a white man, I *do* hope. The only real bible is the New King James Version."

He had been caught; caught and notified, that's what he had had happen, at least—nothing more, he was glad. Mrs. Hadley was barking only and precisely because she was agitated that she could only bark, barking and muzzled, unable to bite, her lips sewn shut, her hands tied on the matter of the little Indian from the McShan Meadow and other matters of concern around town, as well, forces from Tuscaloosa operating in the shadows of Pickens County governance.

In addition to secretly being a white man, this little McShan Meadow Indian, Columbus Chulahoma, he was a faggot, too. He was very much in love with gentleman's faggot John Henry, the mortician whose funeral parlor was off Highway 82 between Gordo and Reform.

Outside of Pickens, in Tuscaloosa, Big Iddy, Itragene's daughter and Maddie's sister, as it were, she, also, knew about the fake Indian shit, her too, in fact, and knew pretty much everything else, actually, her having her ways: so, she knew he were gay, actually, as well, all stuff of concern, both things, that she kept in her back pocket, her having something on just about every person in Pickens County, and she had "a lot on that damn closeted, fake-ass Indian chump and his cock-sucking, funeral-home-faggot *mariposa* of a boyfriend."

Though a white racist, a loyal adherent to the twentieth-century white power movement in the USA, in fact and criminally so, she could make it by in Mexican Spanish and often peppered her speech with it; she was braggin', boasting of sorts and in contradictory ways,

making people think she was so smart. She had her ways. She loved calling faggots "*mariposa,*" literally meaning "butterfly," but also a Latin American slur for faggots.

So, poor *ole*' Columbus Chulahoma was truly from Mississippi, the backdrop of his lies that gave him cover in Alabama, him having grown up in an orphanage in Columbus, after which he named himself, claiming it was his self-hating, half-Cherokee mama, regarding whom, as he regaled people with this information, he even had the gall to claim, "my mama passed as a white woman and she treated me like a little gypsy Injun, with my dark hair and black eyes and all," even crying, at times, during the performance, depending on the audience. Men don't cry, of course, so that'd be too faggy, in some company.

He was deranged and messed up in an unhinged place.

Columbus Chulahoma, the white guy from Mississippi whomst most of everybody thought were a Native American, he lived in his meadow, his fake meadow, saying he was an Indian, living out his false but real lot in life. He lived in a small, silver trailer in the McShan Woods that was shaped like half a bullet, an older-model mobile home, a mid-century model with imitation teak, built-in features, and it was set in the middle of a pasture of sorts that everybody called a meadow and, though it wasn't tended to as such nor used for agriculture, it had been, that history evident in the landscape, abandoned farmland next to a creek that flooded all the time, Coal Fire Creek, right where Moorehead Road and Will Jones Road met at a fork in the road on Will Jones; the trailer was set upon tall stilts made of wood and cement brick, the silver trailer reflective and magical from the road through the giant trees lining that road, looking otherworldly during a big flood, a flying saucer or like it was a weird houseboat, even though it was just a trailer in the middle of a field in the woods up on some sticks and bricks, his bizarre, Hindenburg houseboat, just a trailer, anything else an optical illusion of the floodwaters as they glisten in the Alabama sun in this so-called meadow deep in the woods of so-called McShan.

Next to the trailer, there was a ramp and a concrete platform where he parked his Beetle and also changed its oil, safe from the floodwaters up that high, all of this on a lot of land he rented, but all the handiwork —such as the platform—of his own hand and with the caring assistance of the funeral home director, John Henry—they were really in love, so close, long-term boyfriends, as a few knew. These two lovers loved working together on projects in Chulahoma's big-ass lot in McShan. Columbus and John had just finished rebuilding another "car platform," they called it, on the edge of the floodplain above where the water would rise, another platform he would reach by boat when necessary, a little canoe he built out of an oak that lightning struck down on some property near his giant yard lot that he rented from Maw Maw Pascale, a Pentecostal woman who was as mean-looking, ugly and sparsely furred as an 'possum caught by the tail with a flashlight being shined in its tiny, black-ball eyes—another large Pickens Pentecostal woman, who lived nearby in the woods of McShan but somewhat of a drive away, though walkable with a some parcel of time invested.

Columbus Chulahoma, the Pickens County fake Native American arts and crafts merchant, and John Henry, the only mortician in the county—respected across the region for his work, these death-obsessed people in the region having famous morticians in their midst, funeral home directors with adorers and fans, morticians as skilled as John Henry signing autographs for people who travelled from afar to attend his decadent, Southern gentleman's faggot-planned-and-executed funerals, every open casket a show-stopper, people from all over attending sometimes and not even knowing the deceased or their loved ones, especially if they heard a particularly gruesome story and had seen an announcement about the funeral, wanting to see the mortuary makeup magician mesmerize, John Henry with his corpse magic, John Henry bringing in much money from surrounding counties into Pickens, a main reason the handful of motels in Pickens County had guests his renowned funerals, these big and major events

second only to tourists coming to see the infamous *strange fruit* at the middle of Henry's Garden, or what they call called "the face in the window," at least according to the books in the county, the accounting, him honored regularly by the local Chamber of Commerce and Freemasons, the latter in interesting ways that often angered Chulahoma, who wasn't even supposed to be told about it anyhow, what they did down at the Freemason Lodge House, the county menfolk—the two of them had been boyfriends for nearly five years, and secretly so, Henry in his early fifties and Chulahoma his mid-thirties, the two of them deeply in meaningful love in a rough place for that kind of love, truly a sorry place in so many ways, a swamp county where a few decent if imperfect people would wade rivers of gator people carrying crosses, mean as a river gator most of these people were, and they'd sneak up on you, too, like a damn river reptile, just mean.

John Henry knew all of Columbus' secrets, including his real name, Peter, calling him his pet name when they were alone, "Pecker Peter," calling him that because Peter was always ready to go, often high on meth but almost always manic and stimulated organically anyhow, aroused as shit, horny as hell for his beloved mortician boyfriend, so animated, nothing like the corpses John spent his days trying to look alive though they were dead.

As it was, our Itragene's Maddie knew about the love between the mortician and the fake Mennonite Indian, the only other person in Pickens County who was supposed to know, and that was because they were the best of friends; Maddie treated Columbus like a trade-in twin, a substitute sibling to salve the wound that was the disappointing and

at most times actively abusive relationship she had with Big Iddy, and Columbus told her everything, everything except his real name, pretty much, knowing better because she ran her mouth when she got fucked up, which was often, but nonetheless telling her most other stuff, Columbus, including all the stuff about pretending to be a Native American. Itragene, then and of course, knew because Maddie told her drunk on several occasions about the gay and fake Indian thing, forgetting later that she had said anything at all, drunk and xaned out.

Her mama's daughter, that girl loved benzos so much that she almost forgot to take them, so blitzed so often, buying them in Tuscaloosa in the parking lot of a chicken wing place, where she sometimes got lunch with the dealer, a handsome guy who was always polite to her during their drug deals and when they'd get wings on occasion, a casual relationship they had, the getting wings happening more than several times, her thinking he maybe had potential, that he was potential boyfriend material; he worked for Big Iddy, the benzo guy who enjoyed wings with Maddie, just a dealer low on the totem pole. He was from northern Mexico and so hot to her. She liked Latino guys—the only ones of whom she knew in Tuscaloosa and Birmingham, Pickens strictly Black and white, no brown folks and one Asian family—she basically couldn't stand white men, dating only Black guys and Latinos only to any serious degree, nothing lasting longer than a week with a white guy. White men were her mere customers, and she despised them, mostly.

She was almost over men, frankly, sick of their shit.

Columbus Maddie's only local pal, Maddie and Columbus were best friends, a lot alike, having complicated relationships with men and their mamas, though distinct in each of their ways and histories, and, true, too, they were both just like their mamas—out of their minds and good-spirited, awful, terrible individuals who were good people who got fucked with their lot in life. They responded in kind, to extents and in ways both excusable and downright lowdown, imperfect and fucked up people navigating rough waters, breathing air and finding their way,

as crooked as following the way through with it all was, living, that is, finding enough grace to continue with their lots in life.

Columbus and Maddie loved doing drugs together. They were Alabama deadheads, potheads; they each had their special habits, too, Columbus a meth head and Maddie a drunk.

So, there they were, and it was Friday night, March 18, 1994, and Maddie was over at Columbus' fake meadow trailer in the sky deep in the McShan Woods, and they were a little tipsy, not too drunk, wanting to be relatively sharp for the experience they had planned for this special evening. They were best friends on a Friday night getting settled into getting up to some good trouble, summer already starting, it getting warmer already, mornings cold, days warm, evenings a slow pitter into chilliness. They had plans to do what's called a "candy flip," which is mixing LSD and MDMA, ecstasy, or "egg*ck*st*ucksy*," as they said around there; it was the mid-1990s in Pickens County, Alabama, and these two were a hell of a time and two nut jobs who loved playing with fire.

They were shamans, truly, like our Itragene, shamans without a clue.

Those days, he'd always put that song on, that Tim McGraw 1994 hit, the "Indian Outlaw" song, together with Maddie or John Henry or when he were alone, and he put it on while Maddie was there that evening and they drank the most modest amount of beer as their LSD kicked in, them getting gigglier and gigglier as the Alabama acid took effect.

I remember the medicine man.
He caught running water in my hands.
Druuug me around by my headband…

Columbus danced in dramatic circles for Maddie, both of them laughing so hard, him wearing a headband he had made himself, a headband with plastic feathers.

You can find me in my wigwam.
I'll be beatin' on my tom-tom.
Pull out the pipe and smoke you so-ome…

It had rained hard about a week ago, rained really hard, poured, that meadow Columbus's personal Mediterranean for a time, diffractive water ripples reflecting on the ceiling in the trailer he lived in suspended above the floodwaters, had rained and flood creek water ripples glistened on his ceiling, amplitudes diffracting one another, delicate, intersecting white patterns on the baby blue ceiling of his trailer, and he was there, making his art under this liquid constellation on his ceiling, taking frequent breaks jerking off, touching himself on meth on the built-in couch, tugging at and pulling on his chicken so fast, fervently and so often it a wonder that that that trailer didn't tip over into the flooded creek water in that field where he lived, just tipped over and right off its stilts.

The trailer shook a lot due to all the jerking and humping, Chulahoma a damn horndog. John Henry didn't mind when Peter took meth, enjoying it himself, Alabama street meth on occasion, him a fan of dexedrine, a very high dose of prescribed dexedrine fueling many a fine detail in his craft, him sometimes high on meth with his baby boy Columbus, Peter, fucking that counterfeit Chulahoma with love and care, that trailer rocking back and forth, near crashing into that creek overflow Mediterranean Sea in the McShan Meadow.

By the special Friday when Maddie was over, it was muddy but dried up out over at Columbus' place, no longer flooded, as it just had been; flourishing in and around the massive rented yard in the flood plain, its brim and woods upland, all of this lot in life that was his own, in a way, per his generous lease, which included a trailer and a lot of Pickens land, there were grasses, weeds of varieties, flood plain plants like switchgrass, wild indigo plants that time of year—flora like this

filled the meadow where his raised-up trailer house was; the field was surrounded by big and ancient willow trees and majestic red maples, every side, including along the road, too, these old trees like a majestic picket fence.

Earlier that day, Columbus had going to town, as they said in Pickens County, going to town, scoring them egg*ck*st*uck*sy and LSD.

He had been going to town, had to go to town, Columbus, where he was meeting up with a guy he knew, "over in town in Tuscaloosa," who had gone to school with somebody in Hoover, near Birmingham, and "that guy has a cousin whose sister makes and sells all sorts of drugs, including ones that don't turn a profit like LSD," Columbus had been explaining to Maddie the day prior, Thursday, describing this psychedelic labor of love, the work of an Alabama deadhead like himself; they already had a guy they regularly used for LSD but hadn't had an ecstasy hookup until recently, as their other plug had been arrested a while ago, the empathogen, egg*ck*st*uck*sy, a drug that they'd had plenty of, just never mixed with a psychedelic like LSD.

So, Columbus had been heading to town at a point early that Friday afternoon, heading to town, hightailing it in his Beetle through the McShan Woods on the way to Tuscaloosa, smoking a joint, pulling out from his driveway and heading right on Moorehead Road.

Columbus Chulahoma, smoking his expertly rolled joint of cannabis that he grew, going up the hillside and taking a right onto Lowell Hanks, crossing onto and around the edge of a big and mighty field, he had been overlooked from within an out-of-sight corner of a third-floor window from the big white, wooden panel house that overlooked this mighty filed that lined Lowell Hanks Road, him driving, entering Maw Maw Pascale's land, an island of Pentecostal influence deep in Southern Baptist land that he had had to pass through.

The onlooker peered a glance of Chulahoma from this grand but dilapidated house with peeling paint; the person snapped a quick photo, too, adding the instant Polaroid to a collection of photos of

Chulahoma the figure possessed already—this person in the McShan woods was stalking Chulahoma, unbeknownst to him. This hidden and mysterious figure was in that big white house, one of its windows on the third floor, nobody living there in recent generational memory, all its windows missing, that house empty though always rumors would abound that" somebody was *fixin' to move into that house*."

This dark figure in the window frame of the big white house with no window, Columbus didn't see this figure, this particular face in the window, not at all, focused on heading to town to buy his fancy drugs.

This figure was dressed in all black.

Though the Mennonites didn't own land here as far as most folks knew, the last couple of years, people would say that the Mennonites also monitored that area of the McShan Woods, unseen, walking around the woods dressed in black. They said so everywhere in Pickens County since Mennonites started popping up a few years go, settling in Reform. People said this about supposed Mennonite watchmen, just something said in the same place where they believed in the face in the window, the girl who got her scalp ripped off on the school bus and that Black people ate red clay because they needed the nutrients. They also said Black people walked around the woods at night, shit they'd been saying since the Emancipation Proclamation.

So, on his way to Tuscaloosa, he had turned right off of Lowell Hanks at the fork in the road next to that big house nobody lived in, somebody inside seeing him from within the house but Chulahoma not getting a glimpse, not noticing that, passing it, it on his right, and up Rocky Ridge Road he had gone, right straight into and through the ass crack of Maw Maw Pascale's land, her owning land on both sides of Rocky Ridge, which started at the bottom of a mighty steep hill on the side with the trees opposing the giant field on Lowell Hanks, so much land she owned—a lot of a lot, lots—and so many Pentecostals lived on this tall hillside set of lots on Rocky Ridge Road, there three broad driveways with multiple houses, each drive wrapping around the hillside as tributaries of the road that wrapped a way too, the road's

way heading up and around the hillside finally passing by Maw Maw Pascale's house, her big and dipped yard rounded by Rocky Ridge Road, the Pennsylvania Avenue of Pascale Mountain.

Maw Maw Pascale, seeing him go whipping by that afternoon, she called everybody on the hillside to let them know that she had seen "that little meadow boy go by, flying through here," calling people—or, rather, getting on the hillside party line at a scheduled time—her issuing her daily afternoon report to all the hillside who were her kinfolk. She had been sat up on a kitchen chair and pouring over from each side, a wide and nearly immobile woman, kitchen phone with the cord in her hand, sitting like a Pentecostal high priestess, issuing her decrees and observances to her hillside by the time Chulahoma made it into Gordo before he got into Tuscaloosa, had told all Pascale Mountain that he had had gone by, her, who, to pull from Tim McGraw's 1994 "Indian Outlaw," she would make Pascale Mountain "walk the line."

The Southern Baptists viewed this influx of Pentecostalism into their Southern Baptist woods as a major loss, her lot of land so big, too, lots she had.

Maw Maw Pascale was from Louisiana lineage-wise, though her people hadn't been in the bayou or anything like that in a few generations, but they came to the area with money, bought the land a Southern Baptist family and then promptly left the church for the ecstasy of Alabama Pentecostalism, and she was one of the matriarchs, the alpha matriarch, but not the oldest, a woman married to her stepbrother, but it wasn't anything near incest except it was close: they only became step-brother and -sister after they had already gotten married when, then, their parents married, his daddy a widower and her mama a widow, and once their parents got married, between the two of them, Maw Maw and Paw Paw Pascale, their brothers and sisters, each of them having two siblings, her two sisters and him two brothers, well, marriage it was for them, too, too, like a bunch of dirty shoelaces getting laced and tightened up on a giant boot that they

would all live in that was the area known as Pascale Mountain, which wasn't a town, just a family, just a big hill that they lived on and their woods, a huge lot of land, a quasi-incestuous, but technically Alabama kosher set of goats among a bunch of hills that Maw Maw Pascale owned in McShan, Maw Maw Pascale the boss of Rocky Ridge Road, chief head-butter, meanest goat on the hillside. Nobody drove through without it duly noted by the whole hillside, McShan Woods old biddy intelligence

The fact was, she was literally a federal intelligence asset, an undercover FBI informant in Pickens, specifically. Barely a soul in Pickens had any idea, not even her kinfolk. Big Iddy didn't even know, and she thought she knew everything about Pickens people.

By that Friday night, when they had their big plans for the evening, doing "fancy drugs," and together, in combination— eggckstucksy and LSD—Maddie was actually excited about it at that point, having been nervous and not wanting to prior, convinced by Columbus. Columbus originally posed Mule day.

Mule Day was s festival in Gordo, Gordo famous in the region for its annual town festival that they called Mule Day. It was very funny and didn't make sense, like so much around there, this "Mule Day": Mule Day was a celebration of the town's local poultry industry but called Mule Day; despite the equine nomenclature, Gordo's biggest day of the year, Mule Day, was about chickens, the chickens around town, the chickens around town that made them money, fueled their economy, and, so, eventually, they also came to call it "Chickenfest," just better marketing, more direct, the festival—despite the greatest efforts of the people trying to rebrand Mule Day with the more on-the-nose title "Chickenfest"—just ending up with two names, bafflingly,

both “Mule Day” and “Chickenfest,” this dual nomenclature confounding out-of-towners from outside of Pickens when they drove through on Highway 82 on and around festival day in June, seemingly competing signs for both “Chickenfest” and “Mule Day” stuck along the highway on little metal spikes, and it looked like two different farm animal-themed festivals were going on on the same day and in the same town, in this fat, white town, Gordo, Alabama; the women at the bank in downtown Gordo would give children plush little chick toys and lollipops that time of year, Mule Day/Chickenfest, the first Saturday of June every year, telling their sweaty mamas through the teller window, “Y’all take care, now.”

After being convinced to do it at all, she had then expedited it all, expedited on the calendar upon the idea that she wanted to being in her head, her impulsively wanting to do it right then and there upon the suggestion when it took with her, them, the day prior, Thursday, originally agreeing to early June, Mule Day/Chickenfest, specifically, before she insisted on the very next day.

“Fuck Mule Day; I wanna do it now, tonight if I could,” she had said, and she meant it, a nut job and reckless, her already out of her mind a good amount, never having stood a chance, that poor ole’ Itragene’s poor ole’ Charlice, Maddie.

It was at last that Friday night, a Friday to which they’d been looking forward since just yesterday’s Thursday of the same week; it was that Friday night, that fun and, then, fateful, it’d turn out, Friday night, back at the Chulahoma trailer, them already about an hour and a half into the time after they had each put three tabs of Alabama LSD under their tongues, around 300 micrograms, a strong trip, one where you might lose touch with your visual fields on the LSD alone, and they were laughing their fucking faces off over the Chulahoma kitchen table, Maddie spilling a white crystalline and dust substance everywhere out of a little baggie that she paid for, per usual, her not minding using what she called proudly called her “hoe money” on drugs.

They were both pros at acid and ecstasy, but always within the safe confines of Columbus' boat house-like trailer—and always just LSD, or just ecstasy, purists, sometimes psilocybin mushrooms, but both of them historically purists on the matter, in contrast to their general recklessness, but they had heard a story from a friend who spent a weekend in Birmingham and they had done acid in some basement but with ecstasy, too, and it sounded like a next-level sort of thing, and that's what Columbus kept calling it, "a next-level experience," the day prior, convincing Maddie all day that Thursday.

"This is like a next-level kinda experience," he had been telling her Thursday, the day prior—at home, her mama, unbeknownst to Maddie, Itragene talking-to a bunch of people in her head—those attached-at-the-hip two walking with their coffee that they had just had gotten downtown at the place where they sold decent coffee and assistive-living devices like stool chairs for the bath tub and bedpans, nasty commode pans and decent coffee, Maddie setting her coffee upon a grip bar display case to stir in her creamer, as they universally called half-and-half around there, "creamer," "kinda gross," Maddie always thought—From Cup to Commode, what they honest to God called the place, Columbus and Maddie walking out of the establishment with its holistic approach to the diuretic coffee and the appropriate seating, somebody driving by blasting "Sweet Home Alabama," that fucking song constantly blasting all over that county and state.

"Yeah, it's also a high-dollar experience," she had said while also holding her arm out, stopping him from walking out in front of a car, something he often narrowly avoided, barely paying attention and spun up.

"Are you trying to live in Pickens County or live in Pickens County, Maddie?"

He had asked her all eager-eyed, looking at her with them black eyes that were more Rorschach tests for his interlocutor than windows into his soul, him jumping and spilling coffee, him hopping around her in a circle amidst and animating the rhythm in their moving along in a

straight line up Main Street towards the stolen house she lived in with her mama and a bunch of people she couldn't see but her mama could.

Not high on meth at the time walking up the main street of Gordo with their Cup to Commode coffees, Columbus, he had been up nonetheless, up, caught in an enthusiasm; he would almost always be up, a manic depressive himself with some schizotypal features, in fact, also undiagnosed and untreated, his mama having given him up due to her own illness, an illness she passed to her child, her giving him up, though not by choice, her spending her psychotic life scheming as to how she'd reunite with her child, talking in hushed whispers amongst the rabble in the rural Reform Mennonite where she lived out her last several years before the penny steak heart attack got her, giving the look to people, her knowing with everything in her that her baby was the return of Christ; she would give people the look that she knew her mother gave her and that she had been cursed with when the dark moods would engulf her; her Mennonite clan in Indiana thought she was a witch, like her mama had been suspected of being, her grandmother, too, all the women in her family who passed down generations of trauma from their severe and untreated bipolar disorder with psychotic features with which they lived in a misogynist religious fundamentalist context. In the context of Pickens County, this was the small and secluded Mennonite community in Reform that all lived on the other side of downtown, past the huge Pentecostal area just off downtown, the only town, Reform, with a store with an overtly and exclusively Pentecostal and Mennonite clientele, a modest clothing and general store, Tent Revival Tablestand & Family.

"Come on, Maddie, come on; I don't wanna do it alone," he had been keeping on during their Thursday Cup to Commode run, keeping on, not letting it drop, bouncing, bouncing around her in a way that was familiar, felt like home, like her mama, what he reminded her of, what this always excited butterfly of a man that reminded her of her mama on her better days.

"I ain't doing no eggckstucksy while I am on LSD; it ain't

happening, Columbus."No matter how hard she tried to say it correctly, "ecstasy" was just one of those words this Gordo girl wasn't going to get a grip on pronunciation-wise, that and "espresso," also having said "'naccident" her entire life before correcting that shit after a lot of work and LSD. "An accident, an...accident," she had said aloud and high-fived Columbus when she finally stopped mispronouncing it "'*naccident*."

Talked into it by the time they reached her house in downtown Gordo at the end of the main street there, talked into doing it on Mule Day, Maddie was, Mule Day Columbus' originally suggested venue where they had might've been able to later do it in and in about two months, goddamn Mule Day, Chickenfest, the deal they made, her at first wanting to wait some time, because, if she were being honest with herself, the diet pills had gotten her feeling "too fast," as she'd come to call it, "too fast"—her personal code language for keeping control as an undiagnosed and untreated bipolar 1 person—"*I'm goin' too damn fast and need to slowwww down*."

Maddie was like her mama and slowly losing her mind, just at that age where it all compounded, her fake Indian friend, as well, losing it, just losing it, putting on the table the insane idea that they do it not only on Mule Day but at the damn festival, the damn Chickenfest itself, and in that fucking surveilled county, everything under the apparent reign of terror of the Pickens County Sheriff's Office, him so manic and brimming with novel ideas, manic and brimming with novel ideas, scared of no situation and a Mule Day rave sounded like quite the novel Chickenfest, he figured.

V. The Screen Doors of Perception

It was that Friday night, finally, finally that Friday. It was drug time. Maddie and Columbus were laughing their asses off, on an LSD come-up, 4 Non Blondes playing on the Columbus McShan Meadow sky trailer tape player, a mixtape Maddie had made for the occasion, their candy flipping trip in the McShan Woods. Only Maddie and Columbus could hear that ole' Linda Perry and her skyscraper pipes, hear her hit that she had with her band, 4 Non-Blondes, "What's Up?" That talented dyke's voice blasted out the trailer windows, nobody nowhere near enough to appreciate it, wouldn't in any case, everybody around there hating that song—"annoyin'," they'd say.

Maddie was weighing their egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* on a little drug gram scale; they weighed it and then put the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* in capsules, out of which they had emptied fiber supplement.

They took the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y,* waited. They giggled, listened to music.

It kicked in about 20 minutes later, the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* come-up meeting their already-reached LSD plateau; they were ready to roll.

"Do you wanna watch the crows come through?" Columbus asked Maddie this at this milestone point in their drug journey.

Suddenly and loudly, Maddie went off amidst the lavender mood. "I'm afraid I'll disappear completely if I smoke any weed, ahaha," dying laughing as she said it, etching a shape of a joint with a bulbous end in the air with her left index finger.

Both of them were lying on their backs upon his queen size bed, nice and made, neat, like all of the trailer was, a very clean meth user, Columbus was.

They had both decided weed, by that inebriated point, would be a

bad idea. Columbus had an idea for an activity, though.

"*Waw*nna, d'you...wanna—do you wanna watch the crows come through?" Columbus repeated this question to Maddie.

Columbus asked his question again as he turned over and lifted himself slightly, laying on his stomach and arching his back on the right side of the bed, next to a dim lamp with a dark pink shade, the Christmas lights he had strung everywhere off, the only dull and further lampshade-dampened light on in the room this dim pink-shade bedside lamp, the room basically the whole trailer but for the bathroom and an oddly large closet where he grew his cannabis plants.

"Do you want to watch the crows come through?" Columbus asked again.

"Beetlejuice," Maddie riposted, playing around.

"Huh?"

"You done already asked me that three times," she said, hoisting herself up and quickly whirling to the music on the mixtape she had happily made for the occasion; playing was Bangles' 1985 "Walk like an Egyptian," a song Maddie she loved.

She was dancing to the end of the song, her hands and legs positioned "like an Egyptian," like they do it in the music video; she was spinning in the living room, doing both at the same time, the hands and legs positioning while also twirling in a circle, looking like a pretty redneck ballerina or a trashy gyroscope, depending on the angle when she was spinning in hazy, dim light that cast deep shadows on her sharp facial features and bones, her body bones, bones she could feel dancing there, dancing in the living room and kitchen area, there, where the pullout mattress was.

She mucked about, spinning and dancing, and, then, she picked up her empty beer bottle and improvised, using it as a microphone, and she began singing along with what had come up next on the mixtape, Mazzy Star's 1994 "Fade into You."

"*1994, what a year for music*," she astutely observed. Columbus smiled as a sort of agreement, him liking music but not to the

obsessive extent as Maddie.

Maddie sang along with pleasant mimicry, able to sing and do impressions like her mama, "*Fade into you,"* she so softly parroted, *"Straaaaange you never knew. Fade into you. I think it's strange you never knew*."

"That song's pretty," Columbus said from the bed.

"I love it. It's been such a good year for music," she said again.

She stopped for a moment with the spinning and singing, her eye caught by a small beetle on the screen door, thinking "Beetlejuice," then kept spinning and dancing. "Do you ever mishear song lyrics? Like, do you get the words wrong to a song and you're dead certain it's what you're thinking it is, but it's not?"

Maddie asked Columbus this and was moving around the room like Shiva, arms everywhere, asking Columbus that while setting aside with hands, on the raggedy turquoise, peeling laminate counter, her microphone-beer bottle, putting her shoes on with ease, also, all these motions so fluid though she was so fucked up, a pro-acid head, the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* truly hitting.

"Huh?" Columbus was out of it, ascending on the candy flip.

"That song's gonna come on again," she said with this funny grin on her face, going, further, "I just fuck*in*' *love* th*at* s*ong*, the idea of people having to move a certain kinda way, you know...like a certain way...walk like an Egyptian."

"'Walk like an Egyptian'? Goddamn obsessed with that shit, Maddie."

"My mama wouldn't shut up about pyramids growing up, so blame her."

Columbus, then: "The song's fine but you just—" Maddie cut him off.

"She said Pharaoh in Exodus was the first Hitler, says it's a type." She stared at him sternly and said "Columbus, I asked if you ever hear song lyrics wrong, sometimes."

"That's a malapropism," Columbus correctly defined it.

"What?"

"That's what it's called—a malapropism—it's when you get words on something wrong. Malapropism. For some reason I remember that from high school. Anyway, I have a ton of them," Columbus said and smiled real big, seemed to boast that he got words wrong a lot, but he was just high as a kite on LSD and happy about anything, getting all the happier as the egg*ck*st*uck*sy kicked in.

"Malapropism," Maddie repeated with her vocal chords, this discrete unit of information, a word, "malapropisms," she said, too, following the first parrot.

They were each in their own worlds, in their heads, their bodies, there, for just a moment, forever, as psychedelic trips tend to go.

"I know some things wrong, I've done wrong," Columbus said, directing it at himself and the air immediately about his person, Maddie, too, who didn't hear, and his smile gave way to a sudden quivering lip, three quivers and no more, a nanosecond of a little twitch. "And, Maddie, I'm sick and tired of not knowing—" She wasn't paying a lick of attention to his moody switchboard of a face or what he was semi-coherently prattling on about. Unseen by Maddie, he gathered himself because he was about to cry, cleared his throat—*Chhmph*.

"Matter of fact," Columbus said, rejoining the room with Maddie, "I got a malapropism. In that song. I had one about that one for a long time," he said pointing at the radio still playing the same song by Mazzy Star.

"How, Columbus? It's a pretty plainly sang song…" Maddie was incredulous.

"You might think that, but I thought that that, that it said like forever 'fade into "you'd."'"

Maddie had finished tying her shoes. She stood there in her spaghetti strap top, black with white drug dust all over it, and tight black faded jeans, wearing rather stylish brown boots she got in Birmingham at the Riverchase Galleria mall.

She felt her past and so did he, them, them both having a transformative, metaphysics-laden, good Pickens County time in Chulahoma's trailer in the sky, which was neither a standard "single-wide"—a long skinny trailer, railroad-style except but for an obligatory and architecturally sacrificial long-ass hallway running on one side of it, doors there to a bunch of bedrooms and a bathroom, usually—nor "double-wide" trailer—lots of possibilities, being two skinny trailers tied up together as a pair, all kinds of layouts, people getting real haughty attitudes, thinking they lived in a house, the Pickens County double-wide community. Columbus's trailer looked more like a camper than a trailer.

It was a tiny place for two people to be tripping balls and rolling hard.

Maddie looked at the air and in the air, and, again, a double take that felt electric. She was having her first hallucination of the trip. She started hallucinating a bunch of trailers.

She was hallucinating trailers that had more presence than being images of trailers. She saw them not just in the air, but in her mind, seeing these mobile homes eyes open and closed, both, seeing these hallucinated trailers of various kinds; it wouldn't stop and it just was, over and again, in the air, before and about her, her eyes, her own self, she was having these tessellations about her—in, before, within, simply about her eyes, all about her eyes, but in a vision that regards beyond the retinal, visionary experience.

With her tipping glacier-colored, blue-white eyes, but also beyond her eyes, she was witnessing the most drastic disruption to her visual field so far on the Friday night trip and roll, their first-time candy flip, the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* definitely changing the nature of the experience.

She laughed and stared at these tessellations that had appeared in the air before her, most of them tessellations of the Chulahoma sky trailer, this aluminum foil-looking shiny trailer, and it was all endless in her visual field, a beautiful psychedelic hallucination of so many trailers arranged in complex and 4D fractal geometries, Mandelbrot

mobile homes, trailers stacked atop and next to trailers, spinning trailers, rotating trailers, so many trailers inside of trailers, billowing, curving, folding-in-on-themselves, meandering and sinuous rows and waves of spinning trailers, galaxies of trailers, Mazzy Star's "Fade into You" the soothing tambourine- and guitar-led soundtrack and rhythm of her psychedelic vision of all these trailers in her eyes.

For a moment, a long one, she started to laugh again, forgetting immediately what she was laughing at and, then, started laughing at her laugh in a loop of laughing, a lot of laughing.

She regained her focus and asked Columbus what that could possibly mean, what he had just told her, going, "'Fade into you'd?' What the fuck does that even mean, Columbus? Ahaha!"

She could barely see him, but she could talk to him, the two of them having been in such a psychedelic situation many a time before, them practiced walking through the other side of the doors of perception, unable to see each other, lost in tunnels of fractal lights and kaleidoscopic vistas of memories, and, though blind to one another, they'd carry on in full conversations, these two motherfucking crazy people knowing what they were doing in that state more than the average person, built different, simple McShan shamans, complicated people who could only exaggerate as their way of living, nothing less.

Columbus explained his malapropism with the song, or tried. "Whatever you get into you'd disappear into it, that's what I thought it meant. Flow state, man. I saw a guy on Donahue and he was talking about 'flow states.'"

He was really doing yoga at this point on the bed, truly, the way his back was so arched and how he had his legs and arms—redneck, made-up yoga, him onto something and having no idea.

"That is such meth head shit," Maddie laughed.

"Stoner shit, excuse you!"

He threw a pillow at her, which grazed her left ear as she grappled about, the pillow landing on the floor with a plop.

"Ready—I'm ready," Maddie said, already grabbing the front

screen door latch that resembled something you'd see in a vehicle and not a permanent home, her ready and in her nice boots.

"Ready for what?" Columbus asked this with breathy alarm that was not born out of frustration, but just another way of laughing at the cosmic joke that he felt part of in that moment, and so viscerally so. "The cosmic joke" was something he was always on about: "Man, it's the cosmic joke," he'd say about anything to anybody, such a character.

"I wanna go see the crows come in, whatever the fuck you said about some crows."

"Oh, you really wanna go to do it? I ain't think I'd be able to*ah* get you outside the house," he said hopping up with expediency and grabbing his rubber boots.A moment passed, him getting ready.

"I highly suggest you wear those," he said and was barely able too ay it, putting on his tall rubber boots covered in mud and pointing to an identical but slightly smaller pair that John Henry used when he was over. "It's just muddy outside in some places and there's—it's just a bunch of mud," he stuttered as reassuringly as he could manage in the cognitive state he was in.

Maddie was stubborn and wore her nice boots, which she was excited about wearing, the night a big event in her mind, her wanting to look nice for no apparent reason; she wasn't wearing no mud boots while she did what she considered to be a *fancy thing*—mixing an expensive and otherwise "weird" drug like egg*ck*st*uck*sy with LSD, not just alcohol and pot—"*while wearing nasty mud boots, no way,*" she thought—it was bad enough she had to do it in Pickens County, a place she couldn't seem to escape, and she was going to wear her nice boots like she was in Tuscaloosa, *town* town.

They were just two crazy people in McShan doing drugs.

Both of them booted up, they walked outside together. The moon was barely out, and it was cloudy—atop it being the dark portion of the lunar cycle. It was pretty dark, really dark, it was, outside, and they became part of it, the darkness, walking into the black night, carefully

going down his long backdoor staircase, one of two rickety, slender and steep staircases tacked onto the trailer.

Both lit a cigarette immediately upon passing through the screen doors of the trailer.

Slowdive's ethereal electronic music, by then, this band's haunting electronic music was blasting from the open windows of the trailer of Chulahoma's that sat on its stilts in the McShan Meadow. The music played as from an aluminum foil speaker in the air, blasting music of a genre called "shoe gaze" because the bands were known to stare at their shoes while they played their synths and keyboards, gaze at their shoes, often on ecstasy, lost in the ecstasy-shaped genre of electronic music that is shoe gaze, Maddie and Columbus seemingly the only people in Pickens who knew about such bands at such a time as the mid-1990s in such an isolated place. They loved shoe gaze bands' lacy synths that blanket its listener in the light oscillations between microtones from which it weaves solid walls of sound, the genre known for solid walls of evolving sounds, a rather psychedelic electronic music genre, and it was beautiful echoing in these woods whose trees were innocent.

Those innocent trees muttered in the breeze, as music touched them in waves of the air, Pickens trees, innocent and listening, talking, giant witnesses.

They sat down behind the trailer in some lawn chairs that were about an inch deep in mud already with nobody sitting on them, sinking at least seven or nine inches more under the weight of their sit, the seat of their rumps too low to the ground, causing them to have to fold their legs oddly, crossed and hunched-like.

It was a windy night and the clouds were quickly clearing.

"I feel like a crow doing a little crow-sit on the courthouse, ahahaha," Maddie said, pointing at her legs and then making wing motions with her hands locked in her bare armpits, having the best time she had had in a very long time, very fucked up but nothing like the way alcohol made her feel, alcohol lately almost always making

her cry by the end of the night, often after doing something very self-destructive; they did not even bring beer outside with them.

Acknowledging Maddie's odd positioning and theatrics on her lawn chair, he laughed a little and said, "Yeah, I need'*tah* lay a block'*ah* cement or something out here, sorry."

He was looking up at the quickly clearing sky when he said it. They sank another couple of inches further into the mud, waiting for the crows to start coming through or whatever he was on about.

Maddie was giggling. "You ain't never, ever mentioned this to me before. You ain't said shit to me about it! I don't know—it's so funny to me because of that. So random, ahah." She took a puff from her cigarette and exhaled. "You ain't mentioned nothing like this to me, and, all of a sudden, in the voice of a sage you're like let's go 'watch the crows come through,'" she parroted in an oafish way, asking, "Did you do meth before I got here? Did you get some, some fast tweaker's head start? Ahaha!"

"Shut up, I ain't touched anything in a few days." He smiled at her with a glimmer in his eye. "I already feel a little up, if you know what I mean? Just too up, restless, agitated."

Maddie knew what he meant about being "too up." With a loving series of laughs, she kept on aping Columbus, mimicking his voice and drawl. "'W*aitin*' on the crows to come through, oh look at me, I'm must "Bear Claw"'," or whatever, *ahaha, ahahahahaha*!"

"I'm an Indian outlaw," Columbus mumble sang, feeling freshly present with Maddie and increasingly less lost in his mind, laughing at his own ridiculousness, him knowing he was some form of ultimate camp, the little fake Indian with his kitsch aesthetics, just having no notion of camp, but self-aware that he were unique and funny, a hoot.

The clouds had noticeably opened above the so-called McShan Meadow.

They each felt visionary, like they could see beyond what they could see.

In these two individual people's eyes, their human eyes—places

where stuff appeared as retinal activations, real places acknowledged where they had visual cones,—you could kindly see the Milky Way.

If you were there and looked just right, stared at these two human beings in the face, surely seeing yourself and our galaxy, the universe, too; you'd see the galaxy in the universe where we're at, our home in our spinning galaxy, us stuck atop the surface of our axis-revolving, sun-orbiting planet; you'd yourself and our cosmic situation; as surely you'd see yourself and the human situation, condition, in their eyes, you'd see that we are here, their eyes reflecting back at you this fair truth that every life is a world.

Itragene had taught Maddie growing up that every life a world and every world a universe, which she took from Jewish theology and the Hebrew word for world/universe, *Olahm*.

Every human being is a universe wrought from the cosmic lattice that is love—that was the sort of upbringing that Maddie had had, her mother often making this metaphysical equation between the individual and the entire universe, her mama insane but hell-bent on righteous justice. She tried her best to instill the same values in Maddie—these Jewish values in Pickens County, Alabama. Maddie had values, but those values did not take for Iddy. Maddie was thinking about it all and her sister, how she had no morals and how she, and how she, Maddie, tried her best but, also, fucked up a lot.

Maddie thought about how her sister wouldn't even like this kind of drug experience, at least not for the right reasons, her not having an aesthetic bone in her body, everything was ugly to her, Big Iddy, nothing beautiful, just how people like that are.

Columbus and Maddie were staring off and talking, at a point.

"You know, Columbus, people like my sister are awful people you'd pity if they weren't grabbing you by the ankles and throwing you into hell itself while maniacally laughing," Maddie observed.

"You mean your brother?" Columbus joked about Maddie's husky fraternal twin.

"Did I tell you about the last time she came by the house?" Maddie

was staring off.

"Nope." Columbus was staring off.

They were staring off and talking.

"She told mama that if she kept pissing people off and sitting in her window, she was gonna end up dead?"

"Jesus."

"Right? I mean, she's said cruel things but, but… this? It felt like a threat. I swear...I swear I'm not crazy—it felt like a threat."

"Man."

"She said it was advice."

"Wow. I don't know, Maddie."

"What does she mean even, 'pissing people off,' do you think Columbus?"

"*Pfffft*, Maddie, I…I don't know, especially with your crazy mama."

Columbus, he trailed off; Maddie she had a psychedelic eureka moment.

"Oh, I guess one thing is like, like how she how she went and told Roy Yoder's wife that she 'had it on good word'—mine, Columbus, ahaha; I'm the one who told mama—that he was sleeping with whores. His wife actually straight left him the next day after. The crazy part, or funny, I guess, not too wild: Roy's wife, Elizabeth, ran into mama at the Pizza Doctor and that's when she told her. I can just see mama with garlic sticks and a giant Diet Coke telling her this, ahahah. FUCK Roy, I swear."

Maddie was laughing and Columbus observed, "You're just like your mama, my fucking god, Maddie. Why did you tell your big-mouth mother that? Legit dangerous and stupid, sorry! I think it's stupid, sorry!"

"Oh, I hate Roy. You know that. I don't care. Remember when he kept tailing me? Come on, you're not so fried from drugs that you don't remember that...it was a pretty big deal and scary."

"Oh, right, right. Sorry, yes. But that's also my point—it's

dangerous to tell your mama some shit because you *know* she'll go off in some way about it, like telling somebody gossip that can break up a marriage…ahahaaha, she is fucking funny though, your mama."

"I think he works for Iddy," Maddie said for the first time ever aloud. "Roy."

"Roy?"

"Yeah. I don't know. It was like two weeks ago when Iddy came by without calling ahead. That's when she said that, that mama better mind her own. The only thing in recent memory I know of mama doing of any nature that was serious enough that she better 'watch out' as Iddy told her is her telling Roy's wife about his *multiple* affairs, and all paid-for sex—ugly motherfucker, ahahah."

"Maybe, *Ionno*." He shrugged his shoulders and then asked a question. "Do you think grace is the capacity to see beauty?"

Maddie didn't really hear him.

She said, "I hate when Iddy is around, or if we have to go to her house. I swear she gets meaner by the day....sorry, agh...I know I'm always talking about my family. Tell me about your crows, Columbus. Please."

"Yeah, fuck Iddy. OK, I don't know—the crows? I watch the crows come through. They come through, Maddie, they do." Columbus, his speech patterns altered to solemn and serious, teetered into a strange languidness, more languid than his already elongated way of carrying on and talking, and he began spinning a tale about some crows he saw sometimes, high, tripping and rolling, seeing great significance in the crows and how they went about the place, McShan, seeing in the crows so much for the first time in this altered state of consciousness he had never experienced, this hybridization of a trip and a roll, the combination of LSD and egg*ck*st*uck*sy. "And these crows appear up and around different corners of the meadow, at least a dozen, a dozen fat murders with three-dozen—every one of the them, at least three-dozen, there and over yonder thereabouts, dozens of little groups dozens of'em."

They were both really high, the egg*ck*st*ucksy* starting to truly kick in alongside their already plateauing Alabama Lysergic acid diethylamide, (Alabama LSD), everything feeling safe to say, both of them experiencing an explosion of oxytocin and serotonin, guided pointedly by dopamine, too, this cocktail an all-hands-on-deck affair, the whole brain and all its neurotransmitters, a feeling of steady, secure and trustworthy love, unfamiliarly and sturdily secure attachment in intimacy the perception of which was razor-sharp and focused, a flood of dopamine powered by the 3,4-Methylenedioxymethamphetamine (MDMA, egg*ck*st*uck*sy), the empathogenic substance they took with their psychedelic Alabama LSD, egg*ck*st*ucksy* and acid, candy flipping they called it, two acid heads and their Tuscaloosa *à la* Hoover-area, Birmingham-ish egg*ck*st*ucksy* in Pickens County.

"Well…" Maddie had struggled to say but did pull off, fucked up. "Where do you think they're off to, them crows?"

"*Ionno* where the crows go, Maddie; I ain't got no idea—you… have you noticed how much worse it is in Carrollton this year? Outta control, crows fuck*in' ev*e*ry*wh*ere*."

They were like a production of *Waiting for Godot*, but instead of an urban bench and an absent god, they sat upon lawn chairs in a muddy fake meadow, speaking in solemn tones, the cosmos in their eyes as they leaned back and looked through this big hole in the clouds, a clearing in the mist suspended in the sky, this hole in the clouds their peephole to the face of a god, something, the evolving sky—it this big windshield view from the chariot of never-ending creation and perception on this planet. They were the drivers of their own little cars in this life, parking their cars in their lots in life.

"I think we should follow them," she said resolutely.

Maddie became sidetracked, her making that point leading to a fascination with the sound of speech as the substrate for the experience of the exchange between the two of them; she felt the air of the "f" in "follow" leave her lips like like a sphere, and she could see this sphere, too, her words synesthetic images.

She muttered, additionally, "follow, follow, follow…"

More spheres appeared in the air before Maddie, shiny and golden spheres, these Baroque spheres that broke her heart to see, her grateful for the heartbreaking, these rich golden spheres that were words. Everything felt amazing and everything was amazing, every thought truly stunning to have, every moment a miracle, healing sentiments she needed in her rough life, Columbus too, them needing the true medicinal qualities of these "*fancy drugs*"; she thought about the fact that she could say words like "follow" and found speech to be a miracle.

"Impossible," Columbus said, unable to believe the incredulous suggestion he had just heard Maddie make about following the crows. "Nobody knows as the crow flies, Maddie, but the crows do pass through; they meet here; they don't roost here, not here, no, no, no—I'd know."

He pointed at himself with his right thumb, saying it again, "Trust me, I'd know."

"It might be a straight line as the crow flies but nothin' is straight when I'm with you," Maddie said and scrunched up her face in a smile at him in a way she only looked at one man, Columbus.

Their eyes had adjusted to the dark, each seeing one another's face glowing slightly in the dim moonlight.

Suddenly and without hesitation—in a psychedelic flash of insight—Columbus decided they were to follow the crows, something he that had viewed as impossible moments before.

"Let's go follow them crows," he enthusiastically and suddenly said.

"Really? Yes! Yay!!!" Maddie was stupidly excited about the crows mission.

"Let's see, hmmm," Columbus said.

"I'm so excited, and I just can't hide it! *I will survive, Long as I know how to love, I know I'll stay alive*," Maddie was singing with a weird frog whisper, horsing around high off her ass.Columbus stood

there for a second deciding which direction they should walk. "Sometimes, they don't come this way until later, but I've seen them over on the other side of the creek and you've gotta see it, Maddie—so many of'em. It's so many of them, hmmm.""Well? Let's get going, no? *I, I, I will survive…*"

"Let's walk that way," he pointed south towards Maw Maw Pascale's land, a right-hand turn on the road he lived on, him grappling with his proprioception, getting up and turning on a flashlight, going on, "They ain't been out tonight here. Hmmm."

"*Hmmm*," Maddie mocked Columbus with a face that looked like she were constipated. "Hmmm," she said and then laughed hysterically.

They had started walking along the edge of the dirt road.

Columbus said, "It's so many *of'em*, them damn crows sometimes…it's so many of'em that I don't even know how many to say even just guestimating, even—just a bunch of crows. It's—it's not, but it's not their roosting spot, just a pitstop, like a crow carpool! They meet up, all of them. They get up again as a bigger group, an even bigger murder of crows...it's just too many crows to count; they go off off to somewhere else."

The dirt road crunched under their feet as they strolled south, towards where Thaxton Road meets Lowell Hanks.

"Wait, so you *do* know where the crows go?"

"No, maybe. *Ionno*. Maddie, I'm on drugs a lot, so be nicer ahahah."

Maddie died laughing at this.

Columbus continued, "I just see so many crows I couldn't tell you how many a dozen there are or how many a bushel they could pick, to be honest—with you, honest with you...fuck, I'm fucked up, ahahaha, hahah, *ah*-ah-oh my *god*, fuck, *ahahah*."

He guided them in the dark.

Columbus just had this huge, black, metal flashlight with one button, one clicker, the one that everybody in the area seemed to have

that looked like a weapons-grade baton; Maddie had brought the smokes, two lighters just in case, that, and, the drugs, some weed and the rest of the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y*.

They walked along dirt roads in McShan.They walked and walked.They walked, that it, all that it was for a while on their trip, just what occurred, this walking of theirs.

The Earth was still up there in the heavens and everything was spinning appropriately, these two creatures with their little ambulatory leg-having selves an intricate, particular, local expression of the general truth that it was all there.

They were walking and being.They walked and walked at Columbus' suggestion and under his guidance. Maddie walked, had obliged without comment or objection, following him, her having had been enjoying not talking for a change, chain smoking, them throwing their butts willy nilly, nearly catching the woods afire but were for the fact that it was damp.

They loved to walk and smoke together, and this was a novel stroll, time and space itself up for question; certain, though, was their companionship and loyalty to one another—idiosyncratic molds of loyalty—their kinship as sure as gravity, given all the cosmic spinning that guarantees that our asses are stuck here on this planet's surface, all of this on Maddie and Columbus' minds.

They were silent and thinking about life itself, thinking how their lives touched one another, the memory of the other always with each, strolling and thinking about all of this stuff that had to do with life, death and rebirth—grace and painful legacies—it was all on their minds in a big way.

The dirt roads and their mud were under their boots. The mud smelled sweet, like the sight of amber.

"I brought a joint," Maddie said after a good while, them having long passed Coal Fire creek, the body of water that frequently filled Chulahoma's yard and Moorehead Road.

They found themselves damn near the field with the white house

over the field where nobody lives. They were looking out over the giant field off Lowell Hanks, right up against the butt of Maw Maw Pascale's property.

"Wow," Columbus went.

"It's so pretty," Maddie said, truly stunned.They were taking it all in, this big wide view above the field, the cloudy night having cleared up a lot, the moon barely a candle, but the whole galaxy clearly visible in the Alabama night sky, unpolluted by city lights.

Maddie had her hands on her hips, joint in a small steel case poking out of her back right pocket with her Virginia slims, a "joint" that was really a Virginia Slim cigarette with the tobacco taken out and her having skillfully supplanted the original plant matter with cannabis, a joint she was itching to have with that view, aesthetics a trigger for this girl who loved her drugs oh so much.

Columbus stood there, incredibly terrified that he were Jesus; it was that springtime messianic worry he had.

○ ✦ ○

Some masculine woman goes, over in Tuscaloosa, talking to Ugly, "She's-*uh*... she is *still* mess*in*' around with that goddamn Tulane professor about them crows, ain't she? What's the does the crow say? When the hell does that faggot teach? Doez'*ee ev*en *tay*-ch-*uh*? He done been there for months."

A big dyke who was a short dye, a plump legacy girl who looked like a tree stump poking out of creek water. She was asking another woman this about Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley's adventures about the Pickens County Square with all of them crows with Dr. Kevin van de

Tuffin.

These two women were talking and sitting outside on the back deck of a big house off of Lake Tuscaloosa, about midnight, almost nothing visible but the moon from above except everything was lit up and you could see it all, the whole surround, the moon bouncing off the minor waves diffracting on the lake, the moon's shine their only light on their dark and twisted conversation.

The woman who posed the question about the Tulane zoologist was in a uniform she wore all year-long, most of which she got at big box stores despite her wealth and access. She was "hot-natured." Didn't matter, hot or cold: t-shirt and real short, faded denim shorts, dressed like this even though she was probably the richest person in Tuscaloosa County and could've been really styled out. This gay woman was a masculine person, a grimy butch, the kind at the pool table at the dyke bar you know is an abuser's top just by the way she plays pool, and she was wearing a loud pink t-shirt from Wal*Mart that screamed in big letters about another color near pink on the visible light spectrum, crimson, the University of Alabama SEC football color, crimson. Her shirt had a boisterous elephant printed on it too, and this elephant was touting pom poms in the air, holding them within its trunk, red and white plastic strings on a stick, and the elephant was waving them in the air like a cheerleader. Her shirt said "Rollllll Tide! Go Crimson Tide!" She wore her short denim shorts too that, on another person, might indicate sexual availability, but, on her thick, manly frame in the manners she had—she was a kind of girl that they called around there "big-boned"—all it did was scrunch up her cellulite and impress upon the world a camel toe for the record books, a yard long and several feet wide, it would seem. She had blue-white eyes—Calloway eyes—her only physical feature that was honestly stunning, getting them from her mother. Her hair was naturally sandy blonde, and she had faded highlights that began an inch-and-a-half from her scalp, "frosted," they called that hairstyle innovation in Alabama. She had done it herself, cap and peroxide and everything,

got the kit at Sally's Beauty Supply and did a horrible job; Michelle, her girlfriend, was still lying to her saying it looked good. She wore a loose and messy ponytail and her hair reached the nape of her neck at the back of her round head; she had stray, dry, craggy hairs going every whichaway out the front of her head. She looked pretty rough for a woman of such wealth and influence as she was, a torchbearer of the legacy for the whole region who was of the heritage of that was in their collective pride.

Beyond her pink shirt and blue shorts, she wore nothing but beige things. This was another signature of hers, beige accessories.

She loved the color beige, its blank nature, its alienating underratedness, a color not too intimate with itself or vested in itself, a color that gave up, and that was also the color of much biology, too, *bones*ssssss, in particular. She loved some bones.

Give her a bone, that legacy girl, another necromancy freak.

She was big-boned and loved bones like some ill kids playing "Hide the Bone" with a chicken wing, what fun.

She always said "beige, my favorite color," but she was talking about bones—human remains, horrifically enough.

She was a dog with a bone, a dirty and lowdown dog chewing on her bones. She was a murderer and a criminal otherwise and in a broader sense. She had killed and she had others kill for her. She didn't dress goth-like, but her sartorial inspiration was super spooky in a clandestine manner: bone, beige, same thing. Beige shoes, bone shoes; she had giant beige rings of questionable origin on her right thumb and left index finger, a beige scrunchy atop her angry head, a beige watch, she had, even, beige socks too—they weren't white like most socks out of a Wal*Mart bag, but a special purchase, not white but an eggshell color that was distinctly beige, which she had ordered specially at a boutique sock store for sportsmen in Birmingham—she had on New Balance shoes that were beige, pink accent color for the shoestrings and their holes in the shoes through which they were laced, and she had a beige necklace on that and it looked like it was made of shark

bone from the Gulf just reaching her sternum, which she wore out side of her clothes, looking like a legacy girl that just got back from a trip to the Amazon for some unknown and assuredly ungodly reason. It wasn't shark sourvenir stuff, though, as it the necklace was actually something more horrific and criminal.

She was wearing human remains.

She always had her beige purse on her. She had a big beige purse, and it was sitting on a black patio table up next to her on the deck, which was painted black and shiny with lacquer, and the big purse she had, in it was a giant beige wallet and also a snub-nosed revolver, her reliable Smith & Wesson Model 36 pistol. The purse, it was snakeskin dyed beige. She had painted her gun beige, too, did it with an airbrush. She had a beige cigar case, cigarette case, both, and a hair clip she'd use when her big and muted but flamboyant scrunchy fell out (again, beige, one of those big scrunchies that outsized any ponytail, goofy fabric on her head)—satellite phone leather case, beige, Alabama football keychain with a beige elephant that she had bleached the color out of and soaked in some chemicals to make it beige.

She was obsessed with beige accessories because they made a statement that was barely hiding: I like bone. Woof. Grrr. She was barely domesticated.

Beig power, white power, bones that rattle with the legacy in the pride of history in the heritage. This woman was a vile racist, a Southern gangster, in fact, one to find herself affiliated with white power groups all over the place, and she ran an operation that had been well-hidden for many decades. She was in the closet only insofar as nobody discussed her apparent lesbianism, though everybody knew that she swam in the lady pond. People were afraid of her; they could hold back their homophobia when it came to her.

She was a kingpin, inheritor of the family business, an operation that was born like many like it. Many Southern gangs were born from prohibition and hardened by Jim Crow, like the family business was in her case.

This mean and ugly lesbian was, in fact, Itragene Jr., our Itragene Sr.'s daughter, known in her reputation as “Big Iddy.”

Big Iddy.

Iddy was discomfited, displeased with Jane Ellen. She was mad; she was drunk; she was always violently drunk, and, as well, usually pissed off, piss drunk and mad as hell, just like she was in that unremarkable, characteristic moment.

Big Iddy was talking to a woman she knows, her company—and they call her *Ugly*.

Big Iddy was talking to one of her hands, her goo’ ole’ reliable Ugly, a scoundrel in the heritage, an employee of hers who worked for her over in and around Pickens County, an employee who was loyal and who she trusted, a woman who lived in McShan, that town that wasn't really a town in Pickens County, though it was the largest place in Pickens that had a name, dead center of the county and mostly a bunch of woods. It wasn't real, like a lot in that county, but it was the material wireframe for their lives, the scaffolding for knowing where they were, the chicken mesh that kept it all together.

McShan was also the headquarters of her criminal enterprise, which she ran from Tuscaloosa, Iddy, the granddaughter and kinfolk of Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr. through and through as much as he was Klan all the way down.

This was her kind name, understand, Ugly. She was simply the woman called Ugly, just as there is an idiot woman called Jane Ellen. This is her name.

They call her Ugly.

Phew, you didn’t want Ugly to give you the Look. Men have died, truth told.

That was her name and, in fact, she wasn't pleasant to look at, this Ugly. That's what they called her and they called her that because she didn't have a nose, which was a bit of Pickens County ugliness on the local population's part as much as the matter of her not having a nose was not a mere matter of aesthetic ugliness, but a matter of attitude,

beyond looks—nastiness, ugly, this woman, her name related to but in some ways having nothing to do with looks. She was ugly inside, her soul a black hole where tar melts and toilet screw bolt grease oils her notions; that's how she was ugly, ugly from childhood, never standing a chance, unfairly, but and likewise, her not wanting anybody else to stand a chance, a pure sadist raised in the mud.

Ugly, not having a nose, had to have something there in its lace, and that was a big hole that she had in her face.

She wasn't born that way and, in fact, did it to herself, this defining, ugly disfigurement that was her local characterization and radical nomenclature. Perhaps the disfigured deserve pity, but she was a special case in her nastiness and ugliness, despicable and no angel to waste tears on, doing it to herself, amazingly but not astonishingly, as it was Pickens County. Ugly was par for the course.

She always wore big, wraparound, reflective granny sunglasses and nobody was sure how they stayed on her face, not having a nose and all. She always wore sunglasses after she cut her nose off, as defining a feature as her nose hole, her shades. She whistled through her nose hole. She knew it freaked people out and was tickled to death about that, and this was precisely why she cut her nose off to begin with; she didn't cut her nose off to spite her face, but to bother you, to fuck with other people with her apparent ugliness, her aesthetic and moral code.

There they were talking, Big Iddy and Ugly.

It was late at night on the deck outside Iddy's house, the moon reflected in Ugly's sunglasses, which she was wearing as she always did, no matter the time of day. She thought it made her nose hole distinguished, her sunglasses like a woman's rouge to accentuate bone structure, Ugly's fashion statement a direct view into her human skull, a view she accentuated with all them pairs of sunglasses that she had that she mostly got at Sears, had been doing so for as long back as the seventies, when she had that one friend, Elizabeth Sally, and they’d talk about their sunglasses, Elizabeth Sally missing an eye on one hand, on the other, her also pretending the good eye that she had didn’t

work, and so the sunglasses aided in her pretending to be totally blind.. People are complicated, are they not? And everybody is unique and special, too.

You could see straight into her whistling nose hole, her sinuses in public view, her insides an external organ.

Big Iddy and Ugly were drinking, Iddy her expensive amaretto, like her granddaddy Thaddeus Jr. loved, and Ugly a Budweiser. They had been drinking for a few hours out on Iddy's lakeside, Alabama ritz wraparound deck of hers. Iddy had been delaying inquiring about Jane Ellen because the whole situation made her so mad; she wanted to be drunker when they got to business. She liked her females submissive bitches, her amaretto ice cold and her Judgment inebriated, the best headspace for decisions, she had decided drunk so many times that it had accreted into a business principle of hers, a management philosophy, a messy way to play the game in what they call “the life,” sometimes. She was out here, y’all, as people’d say about Big Iddy, grateful to her for her pride in the heritage in the legacy.

They had just been hanging out and shooting the shit, Big Iddy and Ugly. To the extent either were capable of intimacy, they were good friends since young adulthood, when Iddy hired Ugly on behalf of her grandfather, in fact, which was shortly after she cut her nose off, her nose hole like a job interview portfolio to prove her nastiness that she'd need for the job.

This deck of hers wrapped around several corners on the backside of the giant house where Big Iddy lived, Michelle, her main bitch who lived with her, coming in and out of the sliding door off of the great room, refreshing their drinks, laughing at Iddy's jokes so she wouldn't beat her later, avoiding looking at Ugly's nose hole like she were an offensive killer whale on their property she had to avoid looking at so she wouldn't splash her with remnants of sinus from her blowhole. Ugly was very skinny, it should be noted, nothing like a whale beyond respiration commonalities in piping. Michelle would laugh, screeches she faked that echoed in the night; Iddy fancied herself a comedian,

but all of her jokes were ugly and nasty, mean, not funny. There wasn't anything humorous about her beyond her bizarre uniform of t-shirts, short denim shorts, and beige accessories. This bone lover didn't have a funny bone to speak of.

This was her lot in life, Iddy, the bed he made in the name of legacy.

Her house was immense and so was she widthwise, a double-wide trailer of a person, and she was talking to that woman named Ugly, who lived with her large family, the Blevins clan, in a bunch of single-wide trailers that were welded together at various points and tacked onto one another, her vast trailer home having wings and wheels, the Blevins clan about eight people, including her uncle who was frequently in and out of Bryce State Hospital, the insane asylum in Tuscaloosa, where he was sent often due to his habit of indecently exposing himself to whomever drove by their big yard that was bordered by a creek that flooded all the time, a family member everybody knew to be Ugly's uncle, who they all called “Beef Jerky” for clear and upsetting reasons. Iddy was set up in her big, black-painted wicker chair, out there on her colossal and decadent, wrap-around, high-dollar Tuscaloosa lifestyle back deck tacked onto her enormous house on Lake Tuscaloosa. This woman was rarely inside, ever, always out there on that deck with its grand view she didn't even appreciate, not having an aesthetic bone in her monstrous body. The back of her big house, with giant windows that spanned three floors, grander than even floor-to-ceiling windows which were so envied in the region by rich trash, it faced the lake on her lot, her pricey property. On the lake side of this wraparound, Alabama ritz deck of hers, you could see far and across the lake and, to the left, you could see the Lake Tuscaloosa Dam waterfall, its faint roar audible from the deck, Iddy living in a prominent black house that everybody knew the sight of in Tuscaloosa from just passing by if not by Iddy's reputation —all black, exterior walls made from black materials or otherwise painted a matte black, curtains clearly black from behind the many

huge windows, blackout curtains, at that, the doors black, too, window frames, the roof, chimneys, all of it black and accented with the color of bone, such as on the doorknobs and sconces—her house was an abode that you could see atop the mighty, rocky, tree-covered hill you'd see on your right if you were driving through on the bridge over Lake Tuscaloosa on New Watermelon Road, going towards Northport and the Tuscaloosa County border with Pickens—heading west, you'd see it and people knew about it even if they didn't know who lived there, a noted home in T-town, the Classic City.

"MMMM*hmm*. He ain't no faggot beyond his constitution, but he's still around. All I ever seen him doing was hang out at the Pizza Doctor," she grunted, ugly ole' Ugly.

"What was that motherfucker's name?" Iddy was always lost when it came to the details.

Big Iddy was pissed about this crow investigation. Unnecessary attention.

Her memory was always shot and she had shit pattern recognition, which, interfacing with her bipolar disorder and schizoid tendencies, meant that Iddy was always confused and fit to be tied because she didn't understand half of what she encountered and, in the process of thinking, would get agitated (also, she'd get hot; she was always so hot), bothered by what she saw in her mind, understood or not, it all pissing her off, any mental contents beyond lust and gluttony, this insanity all due to the noticeable cognitive effort she had to expend to understand anything. She wasn't bright like her mama or sister Maddie, but she was not only *as* crazy as our Itragene, but crazier. She was dangerous, too. To compensate for her sheer idiocy, and disorienting alcoholism, she mostly followed Ugly's notes, but not in a way where Ugly was in charge or the real boss, nothing like that, her nowhere even being a right-hand woman. She was just a very trusted source of information and Iddy turned to her for brainstorming and planning their evil deeds, their crimes.

"Kevin van de Tuffin, 'Dr.'—Ugly let out a sick chuckle at

enunciating that honorific—"I don't know what kinda name that is... But yeah, he ain't made no progress. Jane Ellen's beside herself," Ugly said.

"But yeah, she is still cavortin' with that man," she elaborated, pausing for a bit and looking off at a point that was only clear to her as to what was the precise spot where she was looking because nobody knew where she was looking exactly with her sunglasses covering any clues.

"That professor ain't one of our boys," Ugly added.

By "one of our boys," she meant "*white people who are racist, know it, proud of it and act accordingly in terroristic, criminal ways*." He was a racist, van de Tuffin, a European mutt from everywhere and nowhere, was racist indeed, loved Jane Ellen's racist ass; he, an empty man, was a standard-issue Southern loser who licked his wounds by repeating the n-word as fast as he could in certain company to feel a moment of superiority which was in his white, crippled imagination. He was mildly like them but just wasn't doing anything about it like Iddy and Ugly did as their profession, not one of their boys.

Iddy and her hands like Ugly laundered millions a year through the Face in the Window enterprise. Her family had been moving around massive funds like this since 1940 over in Pickens County, her granddaddy handling it for about four decades as county commissioner until his retirement in 1989, doing it since the 1940s, 1989 the year he came back from Mexico with most of his legs cut off, knee-down missing.

"She ain't took'em to the woods, right? I swear to *fuck-Jesus*! If that old bitch done took him to McShan, *phewwww*-wee."

Big Iddy exhaled with the same sound effect her mother did, "*phewwwww-wee*," a winded vibrato of a sound, one of the few traits she inherited from our Itragene. She swigged her amaretto about in the air, wondering a bit where Ugly was looking exactly and entertained by this riddle that never had an answer, amused by Ugly, but getting madder by the minute the more she thought about Jane Ellen's never-

ending meddling in Pickens County affairs that nobody told her to tend to, the crows just the latest bullshit of hers. Jane Ellen was Iddy's least favorite employee to the same intense degree that Ugly was her most prized. She also worked closely with her, as she did with Ugly, given the whole Window Watchers setup; this was Thaddeus's stroke of brilliance, him appointing her prior to his death, a useful idiot who, if necessary, could be a fall guy if Big Iddy stumbled, his granddaughter babygirl, his favorite family member who was just as sick and hateful as he had been.

She had lots of employees, Big Iddy, “big” not just in her person but renown. She was known from Mexico City to Atlanta, Miami to New Orleans, Matamoros and Brownsville.

More than half of the upper crust Pickens County denizens, see, worked for Big Iddy, just as they had worked for her grandfather, Itragene's father, Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr. It would seem that all of them rich white people living on the slave money passed down through their families had worked for the Calloway family since 1940, the year Thaddeus established the McShan Mafia with some of his Klan pals in business.

The headquarters of the McShan Mafia was in McShan, deep in the woods. It wasn't the cabin where Hadley worked, even more secret than that, Hadley no idea where the HQ was though she thoughts he had a key to it.

So it was that Big Iddy was a Southern kingpin, and it was one of the only things that Itragene should've noticed but didn't, given her nose for patterns that didn't add up, but she didn't, our Itragene blinded by her love for her daughter and tangled in denial, at a cognitive distance due to their quasi-estrangement, almost never speaking much less seeing one another. Maddie knew her twin sister were a drug dealer of sorts, but she had no idea of the magnitude. The realization would have terrified them both and wouldn't have been actionable. Life does present you with truths delayed for your own good, your safety.

Ugly was staring off—she was looking at a dead moth strung up in a spider web next to the unlit bone-colored sconce on the wall that vaguely resembled a hand holding a lightbulb, hand bone.

The moon was bright.

Ugly was rearing to tell Iddy something more about Jane Ellen, whom Ugly did not only hate just as much as Iddy, but enjoyed hating and in a perverse manner that was too much fun for her. She observed her like a zoo animal. Iddy wasn't entertained by Hadley's antics, but Ugly sure was. She loved to egg Jane Ellen on and see her step in shit, step on rakes and hit her stupid face, "local historian," a phrase that made Ugly croak when she contemplated it. Nobody made Ugly laugh as much as that thick blockhead Jane Ellen.

Ugly was fixin' to tell Iddy about Jane Ellen's newspaper discoveries, which she knew about from closely spying on Jane Ellen, who talked to herself a lot. Ugly had a bug in the cabin, and she had bugged Hadley's house, too. She's eat copious amounts of bologna sandwiches and listen to her tapes and laugh.

Ugly knew and Iddy did not yet.

Finally, at last, Ugly just knew, once she had told her what Jane Ellen went and did with them newspapers, which she was just about to do, Iddy was gonna ask her to do what she had looked forward to for as long as Jane Ellen had been the director of the Window Watchers: murder her in cold blood.

"Thank you, toots," Iddy said to Michelle, who had just refreshed her ice in her amaretto.

Ugly was lost in thought, thinking about her last ultimate act of gruesome violence, which she had never been able to top. She hoped the manslaughter she was gonna advocate for regarding Jane Ellen would provide the stage for a new and dramatic act of violence. She sought to outdo herself, to top her acts carried out the the day she cut off her nose. Whatever she was going to do to Hadley was going to be a big opportunity for her to show Iddy and the Devil exactly how ugly she could truly be.

Yes, the Devil. Satan with a capital “S.”

Caricatures, Iddy and Ugly were. Absurdly, in fact, they were neo-Nazi Devil worshippers, theological Satanists. This was their faith.

Ugly's whole bit, her big thing that she did, was be ugly. She served Satan.

She was thinking about the day she cut her nose off, thinking about cutting her nose off again, something she returned to in her mind so often, so mighty proud.

It was a Carrollton Unit School wood shop class act. There they were, the year 1978, her and her classmates, there in the wood shop class and they were building lunch trays for mother's day; the class was doing that, and Ugly, about a straight-F student who eventually graduated only because she threatened to kill the principal of CUS, she was sitting there whittling with her pocket knife a wooden figure, what looked like a Pine Tree voodoo doll of some enemy. She had sap on her hands. Her eyes were piercing gray, eyes she had not yet hidden behind her signature sunglasses.

Ugly was then known by her Christian name, which was Dixie. Sweet Dixie Blevin.

It was an ordinary day at the k-12 unit school over in Carrollton, up the street from the Face in the Window, a two-block hop. An ordinary day, and somebody called her crazy, making fun of her voodoo doll. They taunted her all the time because of her family.

Ugly had had it and she was about to get real ugly, become the woman she'd become, it the day she became a woman more than when she got her menses: Ugly, she was to become Ugly, her stage name.

The class laughed, they roared and took turns making fun of her, little Dixie Blevin.

The teacher, Mr. Williams, let it go on unabated, consumed with checking out the tits of the cheerleaders who were in the class with the boys because the home economics teacher Mrs. Williams had ran her car off a the Lurleen Wallace Bridge on Highway 82 between Reform and Gordo and they hadn't replaced her yet.

Dixie had just been called crazy for the last time. She was actually ugly, not just crazy, she had then proceeded to show them.

As a direct response to the verbal taunts, not taking it lightly at all being called crazy yet again—this was offensive and not enough of a compliment, adjacent to what she were going for, ugliness that was feral—she grabbed a woodworking tool, a wood gouge, specifically. She seized the wood gouge, took hold of it from the hands of the ginger kid with buck teeth who was laughing at her sitting next to her, a boy who was lucky she didn't hit him in the face while she wrestled it from him, which he gingerly let go. She then proceeded to violently remove her nose, she was fondly recalling staring at that dead moth, wishing it had been recorded, her nasal trepanation, daydreaming on Iddy's deck while Iddy was consumed by her own demons, there a lull in the conversation.

She was applying the wood gouge to her face. She made the initial incision in a nanosecond, Dixie a strong girl, thin but strong.

She was ripping her nose off by pulling it out of itself.

She began to tear it from her face, blood spraying everywhere and splashing off the surface of her classmates' faces, desks and lunch trays for their mamas, their big 1970s glasses. All her classmates were screaming, nobody exactly sure what was going on or stopping her, not fully aware of what the act was about until she threw her detached nose at Mr. Williams.

She cut the nose off that the Lord hath given her, and was screaming in a real ugly way.

"I'MMMM *Ugly*. I AM SO DAMN UGLY, MOTHERFUCKERS! I AM UGLY, NOT JUST CRAZY. I AM *UGLY*—DON'T MESS WITH ME *AND DON'T LOOK AT ME, BITCHES! Y'ALL* ARE A BUNCH OF SHIT STAINS, FAGGOTS! *AND ME? I'M JUST UGLY, HAH! Ugly and more, UGLY AND MORE...*

Several of her classmates were crying by that point. A cheerleader with bouncy tits ran from the room, followed by her hunky football player boyfriend and Mr. Williams gaze, who had not fully processed

that a student's nose was in his nasty old horny lap. The boyfriend was laughing at Dixie, newly crowned Ugly, as much as he were chasing with vigor his distraught belle.

Ugly kept on screaming and bleeding all over the place.

"AND I'M MEANER THAN A MANGEY DOG SHITTIN' ON YOUR FACE! I'M UGLIER THAN A CAT'S MISCARRIAGE ON THE FRONT PORCH! I'LL *KILL YOU, I'M SO UGLY!!!!!*"

She had filleted the tip and extracted the root of her nose, pulling the cartilage through her nostrils, flipping her nose inside-out, gouging her olfactory organ completely out of her cranium and with a rusty wood gouge, of all things, leaving no cartilage, cutting so terribly and efficiently deep. She had dug a hole in her face and was beaming and bleeding profusely through her maniacal laughter.

Nobody messed with Ugly after that and they obliged her, called her Ugly as a matter of deference and avoidance of violence. As nicely as she could, she did ask them to call her by her new name, after all. As crazy as that shit was, they didn't even threaten her with Bryce, the loony bin. They were scared in regards to what she'd do once she got out.

And that was her nasal trepanation, a fond memory that was never too distant, replaying in her head like a film reel about victory after the Great War. Nobody messed with Ugly after that and, shortly thereafter, she got her job offer to work for the McShan Mafia.

The last thing she ever smelled was the metallic element of the gouge, and she kept that smell with her for years, her last olfactory act, smelled that metallic and coarse sheen, the surface of a rusty shop metal tool. She imagined it were how guns smelled, knives too, shovels and garden hoes, things that were by design or could be be used a weapon, but she would eventually forget this smell and its associations, forget all the scents of her ugly life. Always wearing black Levi's, sometimes, after she got rid of her schnoz, she'd piss herself a little bit just to stench a room, literally just to fuck with people, gaslighting them with her urine, denying that she had pissed

even though her seat was wet, her unable to smell it and it not visible as a mess in her pants since her jeans were black. The degree to which she sought to fuck with people was base.

Iddy loved Ugly because she was so ugly. It was funny as fuck to her.

“You can just hear it on the phone without even seeing her. Tickles me to shit,” she'd told Michelle at a point.

Ugly almost laughed aloud, which she did often, recalling that glorious day.

She took a big gulp of her beer and she said, “Iddy, I gots something to tell you about Jane Ellen. She's been up to something besides them crows.” She resisted smiling. She was totally in control of herself, loving this moment, the moment of revelation she had been waiting on.

Iddy was quiet. She finished her amaretto, yelled at Michelle in the house to refill it, and she walked over to the railing of the balcony and rested her heavy and thick head in her meaty hands.

“Ok, what is it... “ Iddy said in a resigned manner, barely a question.

“Well, and it was news to me and maybe it'll be to you too... you know her and her fuckin' newspapers?”

“Yes, yes. Oh god, what is it?”

“Henry Wells wasn't lynched at all, turns out.”

“Huh?” Iddy, a girl who was indoctrinated into the legend from infancy, she was completely confused by this.

“Also, the window has to be fake.”

“What the fuck are you talking about, Ugly?”

Ugly then began to explain.

Dumb and as incapable as she was, Jane Ellen, nonetheless, was the historian who actually went and uncovered the mystery, found evidence that Henry Wells wasn't lynched at all, but shot by police amidst his arrest instead, Wells later dying of a gunshot wound in jail, succumbing to an infection of the wound. In this version of events,

Henry Wells actually never even stepped foot on the onto the squares north side lawn by any oak tree stuck by lightning nor had he found himself in the then under-construction third courthouse, which, as Jane Ellen *also* had uncovered amazingly enough didn't even have a damn window when he was said to have passed.

"She's hiding the papers in her house, talked Nancy at the library into letting her take them home."

Big Iddy let out a roar that echoed across Lake Tuscaloosa. Birds were disturbed and flew away from a nearby tree. A bat was circling, one with which, when she was hearing voices, Iddy would speak. His name was Arnold.

"SHE WHAT?!"

"I don't think she really knows what she did, did it on 'naccident."

"Satan himself protect me, give me your dark strength!" Iddy belted like a big man burping. And it was so corny, her Satan shit.

Ugly was near snickering, but effected a face of concern, something she was decent at as she only had to make mouth movements in her psychopathic mirroring of a normal person, it the only visible mode of expression on her ugly face.

Jane Ellen had done told on herself and everybody else in her findings, and she could not be allowed to tell anybody, in Iddy's estimation, which was pretty obvious of a conclusion. It was all bullshit, literally all of it, from the smudge that they called a face to every damn element of the legend besides him burning down the courthouse, which, he did do, laughing while he did it. It was funny, after all, as they'd just built that damn courthouse and were mighty proud of it, the first one after the Civil War. He burned it down, most likely with his buddy William "Bill" Buckhalter, the sources Jane Ellen had found also indicated, that part at least true, him burning down the courthouse, one element that provided some foundation of fact to the whole egregious matter that was ironically very funny.

Ugly explained all of this.

"I mean, he did burn he courthouse, but Iddy, clearly somebody

made up the window part and stuck that image up there. I'm sorry."

An end to a mighty long era had just begun.

Iddy yelled at Michelle to get the record player. She had to drink and think, which she preferred to do to music.

"Gimme a minute, Ugly. I need a minute." Her growing anxiety and new desperation were so palatable, visible to an extent that edged Ugly into some humanity, sought to comfort her. She gave her a bizarre hug, standing up and Iddy motionless, fully dissociated in her big wicker chair. She was staring straight ahead and looked disturbed, touched.

"Imma get outta here, I need to feed Beef Jerky."

"We have to kill her before she tells anybody," Iddy said and she was crying like a big baby. She was crying. She was scared shitless, felt like a child. Where was granpappy?! Dead and useless to her. She had to figure this out all on her own.

She was gathering her shit, but she had one more thing to say.

"Iddy, mind if I put something on the table in reg*ahdsz-uhhh* to the job? I gots me an idear," Ugly said, leaning closer and near stamping her feet in animalistic excitement.

"What?"

"I wanna stuff her whole, full and entire body with them Ruby Red grapefruits she loves so much that she gets from Tom," Tom being the medicine man who had the van with DIY paintings of cows feeding baby piglets with milk bottles, all smiling. Tom trafficked the grapefruits once they got to the area, transported all the way from Mexico, just one of the many products on offer by Southern gangs working with the Gulf Cartel out of Matamoros, Tamaulipas, Mexico. They also had *queso menonita*, "Mennonite cheese," produced in the state of Chihuahua.

A crow landed on the deck and Ugly went and got in her pickup truck and went home. Iddy told Michelle to leave her alone for the rest of the night. A raven called Ezekiel listens and stands by in observation.

Both Maddie and Columbus were experiencing the deep, mind-manifesting trance of psychedelia—"from the Greek, 'mind-manifesting'," they both thought every trip, Alabama acid heads familiar with the civilizational meme of tripping—deep in the McShan Woods.

They re-dosed the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* right there, on the dirt of Lowell Hanks Road, overlooking the mighty big field, re-dosed, as they agreed they'd do on the peak of the egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* meeting the peak of the LSD, and boy did they take too much by mistake.

They overdosed.

"How much was that?" Columbus asked Maddie, who had gotten it out of a gold case in her left back pocket, opposite hip as her joint, memorably so for her. It was so bitter. Both of them were spitting and spatting, the terribly, just hyperbolically bitter taste of egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* in their mouths. They just raw-dogged the powder, no measured-out capsules as the original manner in which they dosed, and they had not brought water or anything with which to wash the taste out of their mouths—egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* mouth, nobody wanted that.

"The rest of it," she simply said, just dutifully and honestly reported, just answering the question.

They hadn't weighed the re-doses earlier, expecting to be near or inside the trailer, their usual elevated lair when fucked up like this, by the time of the second dose, not all the way over near Maw Maw Pascale's land, as they had found themselves.

"You have *got* to be *fuck*ing *ki*dding me, Maddie—*the fuck*?! All that, that was extra extra, two initial doses for another two rounds, another night, another day, some other night...Mads, two initial doses for two people and the second dose is supposed to be half of the initial

dose. Jesus fucking Christ, Maddie."

He was, now, walking back and forth with his palms on his face, his Charmin toilet paper-white face in his little fake Indian hands, his hands a window into his acute torment upon learning he had taken that much egg*ck*st*uck*sy, the trip and roll, the to-be life course-altering trip taking a bad turn and quickly for him, but him snapping out of it, able to snap out of it and correct course—a pro, this would just be something he'd have to settle into and accept as his destiny that night.

Maddie was laughing about it all and didn't give a shit. They had overdosed, and it was a time.

Overall, between their first and second doses, they'd had about 300mg of egg*ck*st*uck*sy each, which is a shit ton.

"Ahahahaha*hahaha*, I'm so sorry, Columbus; I swear I heard you say you wanted the rest, that we should split the rest; I swear I heard you say that, hahaha, *ahahah*!"

She was truly such a loud mouth in general, but she was in a torn up fit out those there quiet woods, out here acting like what Mrs. Sister Jackson would call "a shame on her race," cutting up and being too much like her mama, loud as hell she was being, out here over there where some hornet hive people lived in their hives like mean, racist bees, their houses and trailers situated on the hillside, renters on the underbelly of Maw Maw Pascale's land.

"At least it was half," she added, "*ahahah*."

Maddie was hollering out here where a few houses indeed were, trailers, too, gravel driveways poking out of the woods the side of the road opposite the field and people asleep, old-ass people, mean-ass old white people who live in the McShan Woods, old grumpy sleeping river gators, inhumane people truly afraid of the Black people whom they denigrated and hated, did violence unto and discriminated against, and who, these people, who also feared revenge, feared brutal revenge in their sleep and them Black people literally creeping up on them in them woods where only white people lived, as was always the case since they booted the Original Peoples (guilty conscience and

projective identification, what so much of this is all about, knowing they were guilty as hell in so many ways, unable to see the monsters in the mirror, river gators), saying things to each other with a straight face and making shit the fuck up on the spot, shit like, "I saw a *[you-know-what]* in the woods last night—*you could only see the whites of his eyes!*"

So many lies they told about the Black folk.

Henry Wells probably the most outrageous example, perhaps the South's most outrageous example of dehumanizing obfuscation by way of a lie told about a Black individual—ever, the biggest lie ever, one they believed so much they hugged it as they fell asleep in the fetal position, sleeping with their *13 Alabama Ghosts & Jeffrey* books, this biggest whopper of a falsehood ever about a man whose life was like that of Henry Wells, the severity of the situation absolutely surreal, over a hundred years of telling this *cleary* bullshit and obviously *insane* and *morbid* tale, this disrespectful-to-the-dead story, an outrage in the case of this murder, this offensive-to-the-living story —white people made up shit all day about about Black people, made up shit and believed it to be true, out of their minds, McShan and Pickens, overall, a seriously and so profoundly delusional a place, idiosyncratic to each person and nowhere a cultural argument to be made to account for it beyond individual lunacy *en masse*. It wasn't just people with mood disorders around there who were nuts. These fucking insane white people would believe themselves and tell each other shit like this, all the goddamn time, all of them driving each other increasingly insane, in permanent hysterics, telling each other and themselves about "Black people in the woods at night," saying, when they heard a bobcat screaming at night, an eerie sound, upon hearing that, as you do in the Alabama woods around those parts, going "*I just hope it ain't no white women getting—oh, I can't even say it*," dead-ass would say these things and mean them, them implying Black men were raping white women in the McShan Woods despite the fact that no Black people set foot in McShan, never had since the

Emancipation Proclamation, knowing better—raping white women, so absurd, white women, fucking white Pickens County women and their ways, them and and their rapist husbands—it no wonder they all believed in the face in the window bullshit, an isolated people in Alabama who'd believe anything if it suited them, hateful and ignorant river gators carrying crosses that they sometimes burned.

Maddie fell down laughing and, then, a BOOM: a gunshot fired, cracking the air, a shotgun, rifle, some big and long, loud gun.

A Southern Baptist had fired a warning shot in the air for whomever the hell that was out there making all that noise to hear and take note real quick-like, scared as hell and shaking as he lifted his rifle up and shot, nearly falling, terrified, never having heard nothing like that around there. The man who shot in the air played the piano at one of the local churches, whose front porch they were not too much a ways from.

They immediately ran and grabbed the other by the hand, pulling one another, running directly up the road into Maw Maw Pascale's land, up Rocky Ridge Road, stopping halfway up the hill out of breath and laughing, not wanting to go further, because they were terrified of getting caught up on the Pascale hillside in the state they were not only in but were about to be in, having finished off the egg*ck*st*uck*sy, purchased for use over multiple occasions by Columbus, Maddie having no sense of price and amount, just always wanting to do the most she could when she did drugs as a general rule. Not going to last as long as Itragene had, the rate Maddie was going.

They were standing on the right side of this steep hill of a road, standing next to the woods, the thick and dark woods.

Talking without speaking, Columbus turned the flashlight on his face and made a funny face, a mischievous face, gesturing with his face, her seeing his face multiply in a visionary experience as he turned and dove directly into the thick brush on the side of the road, diving into the McShan Woods like a dark pool, violating the surface tension of trees and brush, a tension kept by those slick patches of

woods with no detectable entry, just diving in head-first.

He just fucking went into the goddamn woods and didn't say shit, just making a face, a face that Maddie saw frozen in solid frames across the darkness, tripping balls and rolling hard, seeing slices of time in space, seeing multiples of Columbus's face filling out the surface of a bejeweled set of magisterial doors that were manifesting in an architecture as real as the surface upon which her mind was projecting the portal imagery, gigantic, French medieval castle walls of wood on hinges, magisterial doors that were the surface of the woods in her mind's eye, the wall of thick and intertwined plants and trees without an actual entry point of the McShan deep woods off the road; she saw Columbus' face all over the surface of the woods, a magical door and Columbus sculpture relief-covered entry into a secret way, the passing through of which was to discover a mighty secret, she felt, unable to move, trying to follow her friend who had just walked through *the doors of perception*.

○ ✦ ○

"'There's a cult in town,'" "Henry Wells" whispered calmly and solemnly to Itragene, him happily eating a piece of Ruby Red grapefruit and sitting right next to her in a chair that she had started pulling up at her little police scanner table just for the ghost of Henry Wells, who was alive in her mind but also a ghost, none of it making sense, Henry supposedly resurrected at the End of Time, which was "just the beginning," in Itragene's mind.

It was near 4am and she was her on her third cup of coffee and

tenth cigarette of the new day. It was Friday morning, seeming like Thursday evening for her, it the same morning in which she explained to all the members of the Assembly of Israel how Lots Logic worked.

"...בְּרֵאשִׁית," Itragene replied to Henry absently, that word the Hebrew for "Genesis," literally translated as "in the beginning."

"'…'"—Henry didn't speak no Hebrew.

"'*B'reshit,* Genesis in Hebrew, a word that begins with a preposition—ב—'in the beginning' the whole universe was already in motion from the very start, indicated by the preposition, "in," "ב," "*b*'."

This stuff about Hebrew she said to Henry and she also frequently thought it in some form, obsessed with the Book of Genesis and its eschatological meaning.

"There is a garden," she would say such to the hallucinations who were her company, thinking about their eternal lot in life, a garden the context. She loved the second Hebrew letter, bet, ב, her thinking it looked like a little bird and it stunned her that tacking the letter to another word made it a preposition. Hebrew was so different than English; you could say different things in each language, she knew.

"They call such prefixation with words that are letters 'clitics…'" Itragene taught the voices in her head this. "You can also add letters as suffixes, mostly to show possession..." she would just go on and on.

"Henry"—or Itragene's version of him in her mind, rather—he apparently had no idea what the hell when she ranted internally about some things that interested her, esoteric things like Biblical Hebrew; Henry had no idea what she was on about nor was he even there at all.

In any case, Itragene was talking a lot to the voices in her head, and she was also falling in love, too.

Itragene was simply *in love* with "Henry Wells," a famously dead man, a ghost, a ghost that wasn't even a ghost, but a material projection of her psychosis. She was very sick, battling a progressive and often terminal illness—bipolar disorder, bipolar I specifically—a true tragedy was unfolding that only she knew about, this love story

that would never deliver a single embrace, a romance that only she knew about, so far, her and the hallucinated people inside of her head, her cursed with the dramatic irony that she was the only actual person aware of all of this going on, the tragedy that it were all delusional missed on her, her believing herself to be the main character in a love story beyond the parameters of time and space, something *Biblical,* something *hyper-spatial* and *holy*, a love story the theme of which was metaphysics and resurrection of the dead at the End of Time through the power of love and the commitment and audacity of the Tribe of Israel to their Lord God. She thought it had to do something with particle physics, string theory in particular, and the memes that mattered.

She just thought that he were alive somewhere else at that point, Henry, unable to believe he were dead. She thought it was the end of the world and the beginning, all at once, life mimicking Torah, the Five Books of Moses—*Torah*, *Torah* something that is read by Jews ritualistically, a cyclical ritual where, upon the death of Moses in Deuteronomy, Jews return to Genesis and start all over again, this ritual called *simchat Torah,* Itragene knew and practiced.

"'This, too, is *Torah*,'" said the Rebbe; the Rebbe would start saying this—"This, too, is *Torah*"—upon his appearance he had just made earlier that Friday morning just past midnight, him starting to say this every so often in the sound that was her surround, her hearing voices.

Everything, for Itragene, everything in her life and life itself, everything was *Torah*.

"'Look, girl. I tell you: there's a cult in town and it be who you might think if you be pay attention to the garden more than the window of that *ole'* courthouse,'" Henry seemed to have continued, repeating himself, sitting there at the table with his Ruby Red grapefruit that was also a projection of Itragene's imagination.

It was so odd, but Itragene felt Henry's face in her face when she perceived him, feeling "his" facial expressions in her own face, like he

was delicately stroking her, him her lover, a visage she wore as a mask in intimate love.

She felt these unconventional and scientifically impossible embraces and caresses. This was the odd and peculiar metaphysics of their love in her mind.

He'd stroke her lovingly, in a sense, but stroking her face with his own *face,* instead of a hand, "stroking" not even the appropriate word, perhaps. Instead of a finger across her cheek, she felt a caress of sorts from Henry, "her Henry," felt "his" cheek in her own, "his" wry smile in her own mouth, "his" form becoming her form, felt it all as a love in a demented but deeply meaningful way—somatic and cognitive and visual and auditory, totally encompassing her—her taking on her interpretation of "his" facial expressions in her own face, becoming one with her ephemeral lover, all of it a type of love Itragene thought was not only real, but meme-based—scientific, it having to do with human evolution, in fact, Darwin and *Torah* her concerns. Itragene thought this type of love and its phenomenology were real and rare, sacred and available to only a select few "who could handle it," she'd think, "who are built for it, built different," "who had the right stuff," in her mind. When she was thinking about "'*the right stuff*,'" she was thinking about that Tom Wolfe book about NASA astronaut culture—*The Right Stuff,* a 1979 gonzo book she loved—she was thinking about how astronauts in training go about having "the right stuff," just the mojo, something hard to quantify, "the right stuff"; they had to have "the right stuff" to go to outer space, as it's said, as Wolfe wrote about, this all happening and her unravelling like this in her stolen house in Gordo and around and about Pickens. She had the right stuff, she was so sure.

Her understanding of *Torah* and evolution was the context for her tinkering under the hood of her consciousness; she tinkered with an intent that felt scientific to her. She conceptualized what was going on in terms of evolutionary theory and Torah, Miss Little Unique Cookie of Gordo, Alabama, her crown and hers only. She had an evolutionary

mindset and loved a god; she had delusions of grandeur; she was hearing voices and seeing things.

So, there was Itragene in the wee hours of the morning, there, gazing at and talking to Henry in her head at her little police scanner bay window table when Madonna, the controversial pop star and sex icon, chimed in out of the literal blue behind Itragene's eyelids, her always seeing this muted, matte, but glowing blue, matte and glowing blue when she closed her eyes, the "electric blue," she called it.

Madonna, *the material girl*, just up and popped up, and she was just *a material girl in a material world*—no drama, no big to-do, no grand curtain reveal nor drawing open of any kind of curtain, just there she was, damn Madonna, and Itragene accepted this like nothing had happened, as if speaking to the Queen of Pop were perfectly normal.Jackie Mason started to pipe up, but didn't get a word out, Sandra Bernhard appearing prominently, looking at him like "*don't you fucking dare*."

Madonna was just there, out of the blue, and said something intriguing to Itragene, and a few folks who were in company, Mason and Bernard included, and Ginsburg, a few others, and "everybody else," as it were too. Madonna said without a prompt: "'Fuck *these Southern Baptist* bastards. *There really is a cult in town...Henry's a very right Black man, and he gets no respect. He's right*.'"

The whole crowd, the Assembly of Israel, they all cheered, and it was loud, the approval of Madonna's random comment—approved and cheered by all but Thaddeus, who was less a member of the Assembly than a memory that was a curse, the opposite of his memory being a blessing, but a memory she had committed to Jewish hell, so to speak, him a little monkey in her head, unlike the lovely people she hallucinated and of whom she'd never made a single, actual acquaintance—and so this was, in that moment, Henry Wells and also Sandra Bernhard, as well as Ruth Bader Ginsburg and, the latest, then, suddenly, Madonna, even Jackie Mason, who was hard to please—and also Judy Gold, Andy Kaufman, Milton Berle, George Burns, Lenny

Bruce, Joan Rivers, Billy Crystal, Jerry Stiller, Gilda Radner, Gene Wilder, Don Rickles, Jack Benny, the Marx Brothers and gentiles Rosie O'Donnell and Phyllis Diller—all of them was who it was who cheered in her Gordo, Alabama, head. They cheered her own words, Itragene's her insight about a cult in town, just dressed up as Madonna delivering the message; the gap in Madonna's front teeth glistened in Itragene's mind and she could feel it touch the inside of her lip as if it were her own two front, gappy teeth, her lost in an ocean of empathy to the depth of her own skin, barely an idea where or who she was.

Itragene took a moment to put "La Isla Bonita" on the record player, Madonna's ridiculous 1986 single, Madonna like our Columbus Chulahoma, herself when it came to *latinidad*, and the room became newly animated with the pop song influenced by Puerto Rico or wherever Madonna was drawing her "Latin" or "Spanish" influence.

The drums pit pattered— *tid-tid-tid pit tdd-tdd-tdd, id-tid-tid pit tdd-tdd-tdd*. The shy synth went next, rejoining the drums—*dun, dun, duh duh, dun, dun, duh duh*. Next, the glissando pickup phrase, the synthetic sax sample went "*wow, bam*," and, then, that Italian-American celebrity, that white girl, Madonna, she started singing in that middle range she's famously got of hers, acting like a Puerto Rican with liberty, or a Dominican, something "Latin," something "Spanish," and she sang, that Madonna on the record player, and Madonna, the hallucinated person, danced to her own beat in Itragene's mental vista, up on the portico with a glass of wine, Madonna, dancing, lip syncing.

The Assembly members were all present, Itragene included. They started moving in a motion in a coordinated way in Itragene's mind, all of them lip-syncing and moving in highly coordinated ways, like they were starring in the famous dinner table scene in the 1988 film *Beetlejuice,* them all coordinated and bopping and moving their hands and shoulders about, like they were there at the table in that movie with "Day-O" by Harry Belafonte playing, and ghosts moving them, but it was Madonna's 1986 hit "*La Isla Bonita*" and it was just this

little crew of friends in her head dancing and lip-syncing, having a good time:

> ¿Cómo puede ser verdad?
> Last night I dreamt of San Pedro, just like I'd never gone.
> I knew the song, a young girl with eyes like the desert.
> It all seems like yesterday, not far away.

It wasn't immediately obvious to Itragene why Madonna had randomly appeared and brought the Southern Baptist Convention into it, her talking about something or another having to do with a cult or something or another, and this was after Henry had already mentioned a cult in town. It wasn't obvious to Itragene herself, but the collective inside of her knew what it was about, the Assembly of Israel knowing on her behalf, seemed knowing—it was that, for things she couldn't handle, these internal people took on the cognitive and emotional burden, a dissociative identity matrix doing this for her until she could process things happening to and around her that she noticed and picked up on in Pickens, noticed but simply couldn't handle directly, be it emotionally, cognitively or otherwise, her noticing shit the source of their lobotomized, Hollywood Squares-style compartmentalization of the so-called Assembly of Israel in her Alabama noggin', her personal knowledge the database for this interface of these virtual personages, these little people in her head that she called the Assembly of Israel, a crazy lady in Gordo, Alabama, the year 1994.

Rhythmic drums kept on—fake-Spanish Madonna, carrying on like she was actin' Mexican, or Puerto Rican, who knows. The Lord knows and it was all in Itragene's imagination; Madonna did a lot of weird shit, in fact, and Itragene noticed—especially when it came to race in the '80s and beyond.

The beat continued, the song went on, the vinyl record was spinning; generic Latin American-style drums sounded like they were

really in the room.

Tropical the island breeze, all of nature wild and free:
this is where I long to be, La isla bonita.

And when the samba played, the sun would set so high.
Ring through my ears and sting my eyes, your Spanish lullaby.

And, then, it was at that "'Justice Ginsburg' 'said'" something in our Itragene's head, both bopping their heads to the music.

Ginsburg next said, "'I laugh, I laugh; I laugh when I imagine it, when I think on it, *all of it a wonder*—you know who runs the cult, the one that Henry just mentioned; it's not the Southern Baptists, Madonna,'" a correction which Madonna acknowledged with an *ay-ay* captain salute, gesturing silently, gulping red wine with long, buttery legs on the glass.

"'It wouldn't be the Southern Baptists,'" Ginsburg was going on, "'because that's too easy for our Lord God—too obvious and not funny enough to be true,'" Ginsburg said, Itragene seeing her in her own mind's eye plucking her eyebrows in a mirror, bopping to the Madonna song, as she casually said this to Itragene *& co*., laughing mildly, Itragene's mental visage so multidimensional that it accommodated the Assembly doing whatever they were doing "live," so to speak, in addition to talking with Itragene and other "Assembly members,"too.

Then, Ginsburg was, by that point, beyond herself laughing, putting the tweezers aside and keeling over: "'Take a guess—it's a group in town, so-called, and this is *very* important so-called—*so-called*—so-called Christians; I've said enough and I'm, *oy vey,* my side hurts, but this is important in this reg*ahrd*—I was noshing earlier and I had this grapefruit you can only get in Mexico that Henry recommended, a type of grapefruit, I forget the name—oh, a Ruby Red, and you can get it more places than Mexico, but they have the

best, and—oh my *gawdddddd*, take a guess, Itragene. Here's another hint: they have't lived here all that long, this cult.'"

Itragene pondered it for a minute, bopping her head to "La Isla Bonita," still playing.

I fell in love with San Pedro, warm wind carried on the sea, he called to me. Te dijo: 'te amo.' I prayed that the days would last, they went so fast.

All-of-an-Alabama-sudden, with the sounds of fake Puerto Rico pop popping in the air with the Madonna song on the record player, Itragene's pupils widened, got so big, expanded off her face like solar flares and she immediately knew.

She screamed it aloud, "alone" at home, what she had realized: "It's the goddamn Mennonites—*and they're working with the crows*," and she started thinking on it, carrying on inside: "It's all so obvious...*Isn't it all so obvious*(?)...They're all over the place all the time, the crows, but only in the morning, and OH MY GOD, my HaShem! They don't bother people on the third Wednesday of the month, when the Mennonites sell their bread, and they'll peck at you if you sit for too long in the morning, but only the morning, almost like they're reasonable or have reasons for being early birds there doing a crow-sit in the morning—but they do seem like a plague that could be working with a *Mennonite cult...It's all so obvious and goddamn funny*, ahahah ahahaha hahahahahahah. AHAHAHAHAHAHAHA!"

Itragene paused for a moment, thought, and then yelled out loud: "ENTER THE FROGS! Do not tempt us, Pharaoh. My god is a mighty one!"

She had gotten up and screamed that, two passersby outside on the sidewalk seeing and also hearing her, she was so loud, them walking by, one commenting to the other, "poor *ole*' Itragene."

Itragene was onto her next thing, crazy as a bess bug. She was, as she famously was to do: she *was onto something*.

By that moment, she then thought that there were a Mennonite cult in town on some lot...and that they had something to do with the crows that won't leave Carrollton alone in the morning except mornings when the Mennonites sold bread on the square, and, so, it was a Mennonite face in the window crow cult.

"I mean, my God! These crows must roost in a lot—the question is where," she acutely observed and excitedly, going on: "We have to find this lot."

"'Oh, grow up!" Joan Rivers said, no apparent reason.

Jerry Stiller was there, fighting with Joan Rivers, for who knows what reason, it just shit happening in her.

"You want a piece of me?!" Stiller repeated his famous *Seinfeld* line.

"Oh, grow up! Oh, please," Rivers, once again, asserted.

Phyllis Diller, about whom Itragene wasn't positive as to what her faith nor ethnicity were—she was a Jewy gentile, like Rosie, she surmised—but, in any case, here came Phyllis with her characteristic HAH HAH, her cackle of a staccato beating of a laugh.

"'HAH HAH," went Phyllis Diller, "you should see my husband, Fang, you should talk to him—you should see his mother, *bigger than any Pentecostal in Pickens—'"* the delivery of that line made Jackie Mason and Don Rickles laugh really hard—"'Fang's mother is so fat they push her through the Holland Tunnel to clean it! HAH HAH. *Hahhh*!'"

"Because I'm nice!" Rivers was yelling at Mason. Who knows why.

Sandra then said, "'It's so loud in here. I can barely fucking think. Also, why is Madonna here? I should've been notified first. I hate that cunt, my best friend.'"

Judy Gold then started it again, as she was prone to do, started a cascade of cacophonous laughter: hysterical laughter that was near

deadly. It all started with her, the roar of laughter that would've broken an eardrum or fine crystal were it real.

Judy Gold went, "*ghrah*-hah-hah. *Hah*..."She was quiet about it initially, that Judy Gold, and, then, she was very, very Judy Gold-loud: :"hAHA HAHAH bbwahah ahahahahah hahahah ahhhhh hahhhh hacgchhchhhh. ahahahAHHA HHAHHAHahahahHAHAHHhaha ahhaah," out of control, wild, Judy Gold laughing so go*t*damn hard that Itragene, once again, thought the house shook.

Itragene, Judy Gold and all of them dying laughing inside of her mind and she fell down laughing so hard and very much out loud about the notion of a Mennonite crow cult, fell laughing so hard that she could barely breathe and was about to piss her leg, the laughs so hard that they were silent; she worried she were at risk of literally dying from laughing, hysterical laughter, not the first time in her life.

She was on the shag carpet sun room floor laughing at this idea her mind had concocted as a bizarre diffraction of things she truly knew, this notion of a Mennonite crow cult—so funny she thought it had to be true, which is how her mind worked in manic psychosis: the funnier it were, whatever the matter, the truer it all probably was. This was a fat and fucking funny so-called Itragene Bell McDaniel Sr.-minted *shekel*, if there ever was one, she hooted on about.

Her laughing, the crowd also laughing, it was a form of hysterical cheering inside of her head that *was so LOUD*.

"That's right, hon. It's the Mennonites," Ruth Badger Ginsburg affirmed and hugged her in a warm squeeze that Itragene felt throughout her body and she clung to it, this perceivably received love, of which she had known so little in her life, her receiving what seemed to be profound love from Ginsburg similarly as she did from Henry, but platonically, nonetheless intimately.

She had figured out something big that she could believe, there being a Mennonite crow cult, her new foundational belief rapidly canalizing; she had half-a-dozen shekels plus one more, lucky seven, now, at this rate, with this "discovery"; she had that that she could

count on, feeling she had something at last, an island and beautiful world of her own making.

This was objectively hilarious, but she shared it with nobody.

It was time for business.

"*There's something about the Mennonite bread, too*," she found herself thinking staring in the bathroom mirror as she downed three diet pills around 6am, fresh off the commode, the toilet imprinted on her ass in red welts, following an hour-long toilet conversation with the Assembly, official batshit proceedings where she sat on her toilet throne, where, in the bathroom, at least, nobody could see her looking insane and talking to herself.

Big Iddy had no moral scruples—nor had Thaddeus had any.

Big Iddy and Thaddeus were and had been sick in the head, the heart, too.

Big Iddy had, and Thaddeus had had, a thought and mood disorder, schizophrenia, namely, which interfaced her bipolar; both had had that going on as well as the notorious Calloway bipolar that nobody knew they had or at least wouldn't admit to—like and different than her mother, taking after her grandfather and Itragene Sr.'s father, Thaddeus, with his a schizophrenia in addition to his bipolar nature and disposition, all of it undiagnosed and not even something with which had been conceptually grappled by anybody, not understood in any form or to any degree by anybody who were relevant to the matters at hand.

Big Iddy, like Thaddeus, had these thought and mood disorders as well as a sixth-of-a-dozen personality disorders—a couple, a handful of personality disorders—truly crazy and dangerous and in a way that had to do with character and was not episodic in presentation, unlike

our Itragene's issues, trials and tribulations, who only had severe PTSD and her bipolar, but no borderline personality disorder (BPD) or anything like that, Iddy's rage. Neither Big Iddy nor Thaddeus BPD, both of those ghouls too mean to even have a plight like the tortured borderline, but they were both definitely malignant psychopaths who had anti-social personality disorder (ASPD) as well as narcissistic personality disorder (NPD) going on, and clearly so; Iddy was, and Thaddeus had been, fucking crazy-ass people with no moral scruples between them. Both so delusional and grandiose, too, and awfully so, dangerously enough, criminality a family trait shared between them.

Thaddeus and his babygirl, Big Iddy, the two of them were messy, hubristic, and both were surprisingly—and too—powerful. It was odd, really, odd how dumb the two were; it was odd how, overall, parochial and unintelligent they were. Thaddeus was well-travelled, him just never developing anything similar to a cosmopolitan understanding of things like modern statecraft and transnational criminal syndication, but he was oddly "good at business"—good at business but understood nothing of political economy, the transnational crime of with which he was deeply involved at the international level and at the highest levels, best friends with Mexican presidents, in fact. Thaddeus had been a floating upper crust Pickens cracker who had no idea and his white skin granted him undue luck; Big Iddy was a Gordo girl and always would be, too, no matter if she lived in a big town—that she called a city, as did others "The Classic City"—would always be a Gordo girl and unsophisticated, as she didn't go anywhere, at least not anymore—not what after happened to her in 1989 down in Matamoros, Tamaulipas, Mexico, which is a whole long story having to do with her and her damn Satanism, and perversity and literal blood sacrifice, drug trafficking, all of that and more, it truly incredible she weren't in prison.

She stayed where she was a big fish in a small pond, stayed in Tuscaloosa, T-Town for her an aquarium that she dominated like a mean betta fish except she was ugly and not beautiful like the Siamese

fighting fish of the *Osphronemidae* family that they sold at Alabama and Mississippi Wal*Marts in cruelly tiny cups, mean fish, they were, had to be kept separate from others, fish that were also known to head butt themselves to death in aquariums against their own reflection, not smart, these five-inch, blue and red fish.

She didn't go anywhere any longer, not after what happened in Tamaulipas in 1989, nope.

Around the time Maddie and Columbus were making their way through the McShan woods, Big Iddy was out on her Alabama ritz, wraparound deck overlooking Lake Tuscaloosa. She always had her record player out there on the deck, and a song came on, in fact. Bells were ringing and a very 1980s-like electronic organ synth sound punctuated the leering bells; there was loud static and it was part of the song's mix, part of the composition.

Dark synths were hit, bleating.

It was cold, a February evening, and she was wearing her trademark outfit—funny looking, this dyke, her of short statue and of a round build Like a cartoon character, she always wore short and faded denim shorts, New Balance-from-Payless tennis shoes and exclusively neon pink shirts, from tees to blouses, her loving an outlet mall and a flea market, always on the lookout for a new pink t-shirt, these loud shirts she'd wear with her blue jean shorts and white New Balance dad shoes and all-beige accessories, so weird, obsessed with beige accessories, and also she was "hot-natured" (read, obese and "thick-boned"), wearing the same outfit all year, only really comfortable in the dead of winter, always "hot as fuck," she'd say.

More creepy bells rang like the goddang *Exorcist* were coming on, creepy-ass bells and ambiguous percussive sounds, all vaguely Medieval Europe-like, these percussive sounds, too, the bells, all of it ringing with the mean hollering and spitting you could hear out there above Lake Tuscaloosa in the Alabama night—hateful bells, a reverie of eerie intonations, all of it designed to be scary, intimidating and fanged.

Literally.

Iddy was listening to some little "s" satanic music, a hermit with a profane life. There was some meant-to-be-scary, ominous music playing, a damn scene. It was "spooky" and it was farcical, childish.

Big Iddy clanked her ice in her glass full of expensive, sweet amaretto. She took a golf of a gulp—just how she swallowed when she drank.

A song called "The Trinity" was playing, and the musicians responsible for the cursed sounds were a bunch of real, practicing and literal satanists (with a little "s," as they weren't literal Devil worshippers). A false wind blew in the audio and through the total sound of the moment; it was part of the song's mix, part of the composition and the overall sound.

Some sort of darkness was arising, one of some sort, out there on Big Iddy's deck—a true darkness though puerile and juvenile in attitude.

The song was a single from Radio Werewolf's 1991 *Songs for the End of the World*. That's what was playing: an underground and esoteric self-proclaimed satanic musical group associated with the "official" Church of Satan, the non-theological one founded by Anton LaVey in 1966—basically a bunch of atheists and neo-Nazis otherwise, if not also, a movement made up of people who were all hedonistic and Machiavellian Ayn Rand fans, most often, also, pointedly embracing white power movement aesthetics and ideals throughout the 1980s and into the 1990s. This was the "official" Church of Satan. They didn't worship Satan, the mythic entity in some cosmologies. They were still satanic, just with a little "s."

There was Big Iddy, listening to her mean music, thinking she were so scary, but her aesthetics were so awful, knew no grace in form.

Iddy had ties to Radio Werewolf, a group or band or whatever which broke up due to Big Iddy's meddling and maladroitness, actually and in fact, a music collective that split that prior year, 1993—a long, different story about a time a very manic Big Iddy tried to add

to her professional repertoire the title of band manager. Anton LaVey's daughter, Zeena Schreck, and her husband, Nikolas Schreck, were both integral members of this group, Nikolas a founding member, the group a a changing collective, a band, basically, really, all the "collective" talk pretension, and, and in any case, Iddy had been friendly with them all. This was a band she felt sorry about, given her role in their demise, but there she was, Big Iddy, the record playing was one of her favorite "more mainstream" albums, as she'd say, her view of mainstream was warped.

A light and bleach-blonde and Aryan-looking-by-aesthetic white woman who was on the album cover, Zeena Schreck, she was whisper singing in the wind this creepy "The Trinity" song: "*In Trinity...Ill omens ignored, then one soundless flash in Trinity. Deaths are doorways blasted apart. In Trinity.*"

Ominous drums went *dun dun*.

Satanists who were also white supremacists were singing.

"In Trinity," they sang, "Now we are all going West. In Trinity."

In the mid-1990s, in the land of chattel slavery and its ghosts were roaming white power gangs who worship the Devil; some loved the Devil and sang.

"*Now we are all going West. Now we are all going West,*" sings Zeena Schreck, daughter of Anton LaVey, founder of the Church of Satan and the author of *The Satanic Bible*.

Heading west, the music said, understand?

גבורה

VI. The Trailer Castle down at Maw Maw Pascale Lot Bottom

○ ✦ ○

There he was.

Here was Columbus. This was the McShan Woods.

He was somewhere in Pickens County and he stepped into the woods on that steep hill on Rocky Ridge Road.

Once properly lost in the woods, he persisted, he still walked, continued, extending the evening's theme amidst his and Maddie's doing fancy drugs in the McShan Woods and then chasing the crows, which they hadn't found, only instead just nearly missing being shot—walking was the theme.

Columbus walked, carried on, shining his giant flashlight.

On this stroll, at a point, the ground finally flattened, earth beneath his feet leveling out after a good while's fair amount of repeatedly climbing uphill and downhill.

Columbus felt sweat on his clothes and also the dynamic change in pertinent elements of altitude at his feet, a change that was consistent and not momentary. The ground was flat beneath his feet and flat as far as he could tell for a good distance. Until that point of hitting a clear bottom of many hills, it had otherwise been quite a steep up-and-down, up-and-down, up-and-down journey for him after he hopped into woods on the right-hand side of a very dark Rocky Ridge Road, that strip of a dirt road that wound up and around Pascale Mountain, which he and Maddie had ended up running up at the sound of the gunshot warning that had just filled the night air; Columbus had indeed made his intoxicated way further into the McShan Woods, quite deep,

stumbling further into the territory known as Pascale Mountain, specifically, ultimately making the latter part of his steep descent with some increased ease without too much obstacle, taking a cleared-out trail that he had encountered while making his way down a large hill.

He had taken that trail and walked.

Not only had the ground flattened for a good distance, but, as well, the brush had cleared, and, also, there were no more tightly packed trees. Beyond the tessellations and hallucinations otherwise filling his psychedelic visual field, by that point in the walk, Columbus could clearly see the sky and he knew that he was in a clearing, one that was enveloped by an oblong circle of trees. He rubbed his eyes and could see that detail, the arboreal frontier which he had crossed. He was in a field of sorts, he somewhat registered in his body, comporting himself a bit differently now that he didn't have to fight the briar patches, loose limbs and dead ends of jumbled sticks, tightly packed trees and unknowable heaps of foliage, the obstacles of the wild McShan Woods off the trail he had found.

Here was Columbus. The whole, entire way he made it there had been a dangerous path, there bobcats and bears and snakes, coyotes, but also more than dangerous animals, and this same way was the only way out, the way he came in. He hadn't had a destination in mind, but he had been walking briskly and found one, and, so, there he was, and he was out of his mind, tripping and rolling on LSD and MDMA, ambling here about in the middle of the woods, hallucinating and feeling the love of a god that was there in that night with him, Columbus unbothered by the dark or his being a bit lost, full of ecstasy.

There he was, and he did not pass unseen.

He wasn't alone.

He felt Maddie just behind him.

There was Columbus, and, as well, *there were also watchers*, McShan Woods watchers, people in the woods whom he hadn't seen but who had seen him. Over the course of the walk, at least twenty

unseen people were passed by, and these unseen people were all men, all wearing black and all had on them various kinds of guns, hand pistols, hunting rifles, illegal guns of war, too. Hidden, they intently watched on at all the drug-fueled commotion from dark pockets in these woods near the cleared trail Columbus had come upon in his intoxicated stumbling. Some of these watchers were up in deer hunting stands, Bass Pro Shops hunting gear repurposed, these stands everywhere across Pascale Mountain, set up as a sort of fortress protection in their arrangement, metal stands attached and nailed to thick tree trunks about thirty feet off the ground, all over the place, about halfway up the trees from which they guarded the way, sitting in their little seats, peering through night-vision scopes fitted on their many kinds of guns. The whole area was, in fact, guarded from up in these stands, beyond the bit of a trail where Columbus made his way downhill. More darkly clothed men were flat on their bellies, others leaning back onto trees, guns drawn and ready.

Watched the entire way as he made it, he had been steadily going downhill when he hit what folks around there called "the bottom," by which was meant in this particular case the underside of the many coalescing hills that all made up Maw Maw Pascale's giant personal property, a vast area in the McShan Woods that everybody in Pickens County who knew about it being there called Pascale Mountain.

So, this was the Pascale Mountain bottom.

Columbus was down at the bottom, but only insofar as his person had coordinates on earth and he was physically where he was at, him having barely a clue as to where he was and his psyche not up to the task of figuring it, him lost physically but also mentally, somewhere in psychedelic hyperspace, him cogitating in the human senses far beyond the 3D world and any humble walking trails in the woods. Hitting the bottom, sensing a difference in the tilt of the soil, he slowed his pace, having before been making an aggressive walk on his part; he carefully put a foot forward, his right, and his left followed, him carefully walking until it finally registered with him as to where

he was at, and, then, he knew that he had walked so far into the woods that he had gone over the hills and down the hills come up on "the bottom," as such topographical features as the one he had stumbled upon were known around Pickens County—"the bottom," a popular meme people said all the time, and it was quite literal, what they meant by "the bottom," "the bottom" a colloquial reference to land that was at the bottom of land that was of a higher altitude; simply, "the bottom" referenced the little valleys down at the bottom of multiple hills, a flat spot where hills converge from all sides, there plenty of these "bottoms" around, Pickens County a hilly place, situated in the Appalachian foothills. Though there were many bottoms in Pickens, people used the definite article "the" and always meant to reference only their bottom when they said "the" bottom; it was sort of like saying, "I'm going to the house," which meant a person's house personally, not that there was just one house. A lot of people who had lots of property in McShan, they had bottoms, and they called it that, saying stuff like, "I tilled the soil at the bottom and put new salt out for deer season."

The bottom was guarded, but, even so, passage had been allowed by the watchmen on this March 1994 night.

There Maddie was, there was Maddie, too, and she had no idea where she was, had far less of a notion of where she was located in space and time than Columbus; by the time that Columbus realized he was in a field at the bottom of the McShan Woods, Maddie had long smoked the joint that she brought with them on their gallivant down those McShan dirt roads, and, then, there she was, truly lost, out of it, more so than Columbus, far more so—she couldn't see at all. And here was Columbus, having his own time on these fancy drugs, a good time but it was also somber, him having a different experience than Maddie, nonetheless, just somewhere else than her on the trip, him seeing stars and ghostly figures reaching out from a vortex of his mind, stars and snow in his eyes, so high on LSD and MDMA, but no marijuana amplifying the effects even more for him, as was the case for Maddie.

Columbus could see more of the actual, physical world, much better than Maddie, could somewhat see his surroundings, make out that he was, then, out here in an open field, the bottom.

At a point after this recognition, Columbus, carefully navigating the environment, he vulnerably eased out into the open field like a deer about to get shot, slowly departed the seeming relative safety of the trees that hid him, stepping out into the clearing as deliberately as he could in that state of consciousness, nakedly revealing himself there, at the Maw Maw Pascale bottom, where, unbeknownst to him, he was surrounded by mysterious gunmen who had allowed him to take this walk unencumbered, gunmen whom Columbus had not seen and still could not, though they were everywhere around there.

Here was Columbus, and he was uncertain of where he was, there, or what he was in the sense of who he had become in his here and now, then. He was having a psychedelic identity crisis. This walk to Maw Maw Pascale's land had manifested by accident after they had passed through the screen doors of perception and out of the familiar safety of Chulahoma's trailer and walked in silence smoking cigarettes while they tried to find where the crows come through in the evening in McShan, the two of them eventually arriving at Lowell Hanks Road and staring in awe at the sky above the mighty field there. A breakthrough was happening, a splendor's disruption of what was known was occurring. Both Maddie and Columbus were deep in the McShan Woods, neither knowing much about the whereabouts of each of themselves, much less the other one, though they felt they were together, as they always did, attached at the hip and the most best of friends. They could barely tell who they were, much less who the other was, which rendered them knowing where the other one was comically impossible. They were Alabama blitzed in the McShan Woods. Columbus, at least, would emerge from this experience with a new understanding of himself and the world, and where he fit in all, his purpose in life.

This walk into the liminal space of the Pascale Mountain bottom

sent Chulahoma's identity into crisis—he'd had time to reflect in the psychedelic state on his life, and he kept thinking about how he'd never met his Mennonite family, but had been told by the orphanage woman, Patricia, the woman who also told him his mother was in Pickens that they were Mennonite, and this swelled up in him and he cried over it all, standing there in the field, the trauma of being an orphan, the burden of the fake little Indian who lived in the fake McShan Meadow welling up in him.

He wiped his tears. He clarified some things in his mind. He became activated by his external world. His retinas began picking up clues from the environment, actual feedback from reality and the physical world.

Columbus Chulahoma said his birth name, "Peter," saying so after he had sensed a pointed question from Maddie, her asking him his real name, something, the one thing, he had never told her.

"Peter," he said again, and a few times more, "Peter, it's Peter," a bottom admission from Chulahoma the Peter, the inauthentic Indian in the fake McShan Meadow, a white man who told all around that he were a half-Choctaw and quarter-Cherokee, a man in love with a renowned funeral home director and mortician. He was a Peter but went about the world a Columbus and this had had effects on his psyche, had injured him.

A strange purple light had been emanating all about the bottom the entire time, and this finally registered with Columbus, like the air were filled with fish that glowed a royal purple. He saw it, tuning in; he had made it to the bottom and the bottom was, oddly, glowing, a faint purple that, for a moment, he chalked up just to his being on drugs. He then was able to visually register that there was a big crow nearby and it was on a perch, and then there was another crow, and another, more perches and so many crows, too-many-dozens of crows to count. The bottom was glowing purple because there were so many crows that the moonlight emitted this bold purple in reflecting on the surface of the bodies of so many crows.

"Wait," Columbus the bottom Peter then said, "Do you see that? It's so many crows, at least twenty-one dozen crows."

Per usual with the crows and their enumeration in Pickens County, the math couldn't be done, exceeding the egg unit calculus, countless crows, too-many-dozens, just too-many-dozens to count, and *etc*.

Here was Columbus and he was starting to see more, seeing that there were also these little structures, what he was seeing, structures built into the canopies of all the trees around the bottom, but he could not quite make out what it all was, not just yet, just arriving to the Pascale Mountain bottom. The details were loading. This was a video game. As the pixels loaded in his mind's eye, he could then see something that stunned him, the first stun of many shocks he were about to feel: there, here also was a giant, giant hole in the bottom, Columbus was seeing, approaching its brim. Ignoring Maddie, this was when Columbus started realizing that he wasn't alone otherwise, not at all, here in the liminal space of the Pascale Mountain bottom.

There were so many crows glowing like an iridescent black and purple blanket in this patch of the woods that was the Pascale bottom, the Pascale's little patch at the bottom of these woods where they hunted deer and planted fine grasses like everybody else pampered and used their bottom, or, at least, that's what everybody had assumed about Maw Maw Pascale and them's care for the land—there was more here than a salt patch to attract deer, though, even beyond the crows. The bottom had this huge hole, first of all, a *huge* hole in the middle of it. This bottom's hole was like a huge asteroid crater—huge—and even more incredibly, there was a lot jammed in there, a lot of stuff, and this stuff was actually and apparently a built structure, a megastructure of sorts, and there were people in this hole all about the megastructure that Columbus had yet to make out architecturally beyond sensing a building were in a giant hole and that some people were there, too.

There were motherfuckers coming out of nowhere, coming out of nowhere, all of a sudden appearing, coming out of doors that were all

over the structure, the structure that was jammed up inside the bottom hole, them emerging from doors of a strange megastructure that took up most of the hole, seemed to be custom-made architecturally fit to the hole.

They were all dressed in black, men and woman, children, too. The women and girls were wearing bonnets. Columbus realized that this was a bunch of Mennonites, at least in appearance.

He wasn't sure if he were hallucinating or what.

There he was and he was surrounded, he was realizing, though he had yet to see the gunmen. The company he had there was aplenty, though. There were *so many* damn people in and about this here building that was somehow and for some reason down in this hole, and some of them were rushing out of some doors down there, and others were hanging out windows and leaning over off the many roughshod rails of the many porches that were tacked onto this confounding and Escher-like structure.

A multitude was down there in this outrageous hole he had just found, Maw Maw Pascale's bottom hole, all at the bottom of Pascale Mountain, this Pentecostal McShan outpost in Southern Baptist territory where some Mennonites, apparently, had built themselves a castle of sorts in a well of sorts, some type of a big building in a big hole, and they were dangling and were dangling on its features, looking like a barrel of monkeys.

There was, actually and in fact, and amazingly so, quite the crowd, quite the crowd in this giant hole in the McShan Woods—*inside* the hole, inside of it, a hole that went very deep, room for plenty, a crowd inside this bizarre, humongous and supernatural-seeming hole that seemed to be the defining feature of the Pascale Mountain bottom. They were spilling out of the megastructure of a gargantuan architectural structure, spilling out from multiple points, running around the hole, some up on the very high roof that was about flush with the ground outside the hole. Columbus couldn't believe his eyes —too many crows to count and, as it seemed, too many Mennonites to

count, too.

The megastructure was constituted by smaller units of architecture. It was a bunch of trailers tacked together, width-wise and vertically up into the air, near flush with the radius of the bottom hole.

This was a trailer castle, the only way to describe it, Columbus was seeing and barely believing it, but there it was, just a whole bunch of trailers stacked atop one another and down in a hole. Columbus was fully realizing that the Pascale Mountain bottom was a place in Pickens County were there was a trailer castle.

Everything lit up in the bottom. It was very sudden. It all became so bright, much brighter than the hazy purple glow that Columbus had just noticed that was engulfing the bottom due to the crows' iridescence.

Columbus threw out his hands before him and shielded his face, his eyes suddenly burning, everything becoming violently luminous. It struck like lightning, but there was no thunder. Very startled, it seemed to him that some sort of explosion had happened, a great and bright conflagration. This retinal sting he initially thought to be a giant, combustible blast, it was so violent in force, though it were nothing but photons, however, stuff in the air that was somewhere between a particle and a wave; there was no detonation nor boom, though Columbus thought so, no debris.

There was only unpleasantly bright commercial lighting.

It was that some fluorescent flood lights had turned on, he could then tell that that was what was happening, and it all glowed so searingly, all of it, the entire grassy field surrounded by trees that in their mutual constitution made up the perimeter of the bottom, as well as the totality of Columbus' vision, it all lit up, all out of nowhere, all of a sudden, the bottom abruptly lighting up, this jolting light emanating from this ample hole before him, the hole the source, the light blooming out into the night like an upside-down UFO, light beaming into the sky, blooming from this enormous cavity in the earth that had this giant trailer castle in it, and this was all deep in the

McShan woods, and it was hard for Columbus to believe all of this, even though he was as high as a kite and he'd believe anything.

The lights were an awful florescent that penetrated the air like sharp, piercing fingers with jagged, electric nails. The light hurt Columbus' eyes but his gaze began to adjust, his pupils as large as Jupiter's biggest moons. He recognized the frequency of this here light; it looked like the sort of cheap, blinking lights you'd see in fellowship halls around the area's churches.

Squinting his eyes, Columbus walked toward the fluorescent portal and peered into a Mennonite world in the hole that he hadn't known to exist prior, him approaching the rim of the hole and then leaning over and staring into it, beholding the incredible sight while steadily maintaining his balance despite the incapacitated state he was in. He kept his balance, very afraid of falling in. He wanted to get on his knees and stare, observe from closer at it all, but he could only stand there in bewildered awe, awe, couldn't really feel his knees, standing agape and haphazardlly at the mouth, stuck between amazement and fear. He didn't know what to do.

In his gazing, it fully registered, and he knew he hadn't seen something that wasn't there, knew he wasn't hallucinating the fact that there was this trailer castle, plain and simple.

It wasn't so odd in those parts for people to fuse pieces of buildings together to derive larger redneck structures; novel combinatorial arrangements of mobile homes were not alien at all to Pickens County, many people and families living in two single-wide trailers welded together lengthwise, in that fashion, side-by-side, though, as in Carrollton's Pentecostal area about a mile off downtown and the county square, the Pentecostal areas of certain towns had more elaborate designs, a few arranged more creatively, but always totally horizontal and limited to one story, the favored shape an "H" outline, with common areas set in the middle trailer and wings for these large families' bedrooms at the extremities. Columbus had never seen a structure where the trailers were stacked atop one another like this,

never seen a multi-story trailer-based structure; this was something wholly different. It was a trailer castle.

It was actually five single-wide trailers total, three on the bottom and three stacked atop one on the bottom in the middle. There was this middle trailer at "ground level," down at the bottom of this bottom hole, and onto that middle trailer were tacked two other trailers, joined at their middles to its ends at both its ends, a three-trailer ground level of the structure that looked, from above, like the letter "T" but both sides, top and bottom, having a horizontal line—better known as "H," but Columbus was processing it as two Ts, could only see two Ts superimposed, couldn't keep the full structure in focus.

Even more bizarre than it even being there in the McShan Woods in some giant hole, all of the windows seemed to be retrofit for underwater navigation. Strangely enough, these windows on these sutured trailers looked like they were built for submarines, maritime-seeming doors, as well, exiting onto the wet stairs covered in algae that all connected to it at a number of points and floor levels. It was apparent to Columbus that this hole might at times be filled with water, looking like an ordinary McShan woods pond.

On the bottom level, he could discern in the light, there were two wings that jutted out on each side of the middle part of the structure, as was typical of some trailer hybrids, and those wings jutted out very, very far from the middle portion at those outer wings' outermost architectural extremities, arranged like the letter "H," in the middle some skinny, rectangular building structure, at once a familiar and alien sight, a single-wide trailer. This was a castle, however, a tower, and the handiwork wasn't just wide and big, the built structure filling out the whole perimeter of this huge hole, the whole hole. It was more than an H because it it was also tall, but only in the middle.

It looked like it was made of tin weenies, all lined up across one another, Linkin' Logs but rusty metal. It was a tall and rusty structure in its middle, and tall in this middle part only, only that middle aspect towering near the mouth of the hole, the utmost portion of the building

just short of flush with the brim of the hole. The structure was in various forms of disrepair, with shiny spots here and there but mostly coarse and rusting surfaces, most the edifice or whatever was not reflecting the extremely bright light that had just come on in some elaborate and weird yard in the bottom's giant hole for some odd building that treated crows like hummingbirds, in fact, Columbus was also then recognizing, crows everywhere on and around the structure, roosting, all of it in the in the middle of Pentecostal territory in the McShan Woods.

At least one mystery was solved: the crows roosted, it seemed, at the bottom of Pascale Mountain in the McShan Woods. The crows roosted in the bottom, the bottom of Pascale Mountain, deep in the McShan Woods.

It was so bright and there were so many black crows glowing in the light, diffracting the light, that a purple, radiant haze emanated from this big hole in the bottom. Crows were all over the structure, down in the hole, gathered around the bottom, roosting.

Each there, in their places, each and both as they were, Maddie and Columbus, in their distinct visions, adjusted their gazes and understood better all that was about each of them, could see with their eyes and hear with their ears that the good Lord had given them a bit better and with a renewed clarity, but their vision was still also full of stars, light, sacred geometries and cartoons that weren't really there, high off their asses, hallucinating and them unable to believe what could be seen. *By such a point, they are, in fact, together, together, near the bottom hole, there they were, living the exchange of the experience, peak states of consciousness ablaze in them*. There was so much light in them, like there is in most people, most people living in the light. Most people aren't ugly.

These trailers that were all tacked together, a sort of trailer castle, these trailers were all welded together.

At the bottom, those ones that were welded together, the three trailers welded together, they were raised just up off the ground inside

of the hole, at bottom of which there was a glowing clear water, the bottom's true bottom, water in the hole that one could barely see with all them crows perched down there above it all, this trailer building seemingly actually in a well, a giant well of sorts, this hole, this hole with a crater shape, a deep, wet bottom—it had tastelessly wrought and severely rusting, decorative metal lattice bordering its bottom to hide the structures the trailers rested upon, some invisible sort of stilts in this mysterious water, and it was hard to see the handiwork because there were so many crows gathered, especially near the bottom of that bottom's hole, so many a dozen it's Pickens County too-many-a-dozen of crows-levels of crows; and there were perches on these trailers, too, welded to them, and also in the yard surrounding the trailers, in hole and up above it, too, perches all over the bottom hole, perches all around the bottom, perches for the crows who were, apparently, roosting at the bottom.

"McShan," "too many crows to count," "the face in the window," "Columbus Chulahoma"—things they believed.

"Yeah," Peter said, "it seems like it's more than gerbils in this hole—I've watched *911*, not my imagination!—but a bunch of dozens and dozens of crows roosting in this bottom hole."

Maddie didn't hear him, not in earshot.Walking closer, unafraid, he was not sure if it were real and not fully aware that the other were experiencing the same thing, the Chulahoma Peter called Columbus.

The sudden light had already startled Columbus, but a sudden explosion of music then cut the night, and this frightened him so much that he almost fell in the hole. He shook near that cavity, jumped, scared as hell as, suddenly, blasting in the air was, of all things, Cher's "Gypsies, Tramps and Thieves."

He didn't know where the speakers were and he wouldn't have been surprised to have seen Cher herself down in the bottom on Maw Maw Pascale's land, had she appeared, but Cher did not appear, though her familiar and round voice rattled the bottom, and Columbus couldn't help but feel the groove in his trippy state.

The fuck *who* kn*ows*z what was going on.

The signature bell descending of this classic song and beat of the drum and bass, Cher starting, the song really began.

I was born in the wagon of a traveling show...

Maddie had in fact been tranquilized by one of the individuals who lived in the bottom hole, as tranquilized as she could be, so damn high on a drug with stimulant properties, *eggstucky*.

…my mama used to dance for the money they'd throw
papa would do whatever he coulddd
preach a little gospel…

All of these people appearing and they were fucking Mennonites, these moles in this hole, somewhere between and in, as well as at, McShan, McShan, Ethelsville, McShan, Carrollton, "McShan," off Highway 82 and Henry Well's driveway, Phoenix Avenue, County Road 35; those trailers' stairs were filling up with these people, these Mennonite creatures, and they were running around like hamsters, in fact, also, *eager*, looking up outside from their depth underground with outstretched arms, desperate and *truly ecstatic*; they were all apparent Mennonites, all wearing black, but they weren't acting like Mennonites, more like a bunch of Pentecostals or something, and they were carrying Mennonite bread as an offering of sorts, but they were eating it really fast, it maybe just for them and only held up like an offering, no idea had, Columbus lost without a thought worth stringing words together to push out or work through, fast, so rapidly, madly, frothing like mad hell hounds, rabies-ridden hole raccoons ritualistically eating Jesus, some dead Jew on a stick, murdered, a lot of lies told, similar to poor *ole*' Henry Wells, that poor *ole*' Jesus, getting what he asked for, a lot of attention, but nobody deserving

what he got—they were frantically *transubstantiating*, in fact, them eating bread and drinking wine—and verily as hell, not cranberry juice, a fine Malbec from Baja California—wine quickly drank, so fast, in a total fever and mass hysteria, this hole looking like a bright, Wal*Mart-like lit pit of hell, demons roaming this fluorescent trailer megastructure like freshly disturbed ants in an ant hill but, instead, seemingly trapped in a big hole, it being *like* Columbus and Maddie had bothered an ant hill and the tunnels were exposed, the once-hidden fungus of the hive walls exposed and ants running everywhere in this vista that looked like a subterranean big box store in its lighting aesthetic, not a subtle sconce people, this sect of Mennonites—they were not mad ants, though, but creatures happy to be disturbed, not out to bite anything other than the Mennonite bread that they carried like eusocial ants carry their tunnel fungus, bread they were rapidly transubstantiating in this bright florescent lighting, like a fellowship hall from Southern hell; Columbus didn't have a clue as to what they were doing, but they, sure enough, they were transubstantiating like a bunch of drunk Catholics, these Mennonites who seemed to have forgotten why they split off from the Anabaptists during a time of high drama in Europe, the Great Reformation, it seeming that they didn't literally believe in eating and drinking Jesus' body parts forgotten, them eating the body of Christ, some Jesus hole eating.

The scene was twisting in a vortex in Columbus' mind, this feeling like a trip from hell where he confronted his Mennonite identity, not even sure if what he was seeing were real.

A further circle of lights lit up, up outside the hole and around the bottom. A line of lights that circled the bottom's perimeter came, a much gentler sort of light, incandescent, large bulbs that looked industrial in their design. One by one and in a series, the path lit up the whole bottom.

This revealed more.

There were a lot more crow perches than Columbus had originally thought, as he could see in this new stadium of light at ground-level,

crows sitting up on perches on the ground around and in the hole, as well as on perches that were nailed to these little tree houses that surrounded the bottom, also, he was seeing come into his focus, these residential units there, also and in addition to the trailer castle. These little residences were to be made up from cut-up pieces of single-wide trailers, themselves. There were these pieces-of-trailer treehouses, these cut-up and sutured pieces of single-wide trailers, a whole village suspended in the old oaks and maples around the bottom, cut up and rearranged pieces of trailers that seemed wired for electricity, one light after another popping on. These odd homes had big bay windows that had a signature pre-fabricated aesthetic. There were Mennonites in those windows, too.

It was a bottom hole with a whole trailer castle village that had been stumbled upon, it'd seem, something like that, pretty crazy stuff.

The chaos began to abate. The stir in the hole stir calmed, the butt of matters, at least, the hole, it all eased up, the hole lulling into a state of less chaos, the running around and transubstantiating dissipating, these McShan Mennonites finishing the last of the bread which they already had in their mouths, which they had been rapidly and madly transubstantiating to the soundtrack of Cher's 1971 "Gypsies, Tramps & Thieves," the bread which they consumed paired with a fine, buttery wine, its quality apparent in the long legs running down their chins. They were quiet, at this point, madly looking up towards heaven from the hole. They looked expectant.

Cher was still singing—

Picked up a boy just south of Mobile
Gave him a ride, filled him with a hot meal
I was sixteen, he was twenty-one
Rode with us to Memphis
And papa woulda shot him if he knew what he'd done

—the music played, but the ecstatic ritual was over, or had hit a new calm point in the ritual, it all unclear, and it got really serious and quiet but for the music, blasting from who knows where.

This all seemed to be finely choreographed.

A woman suddenly appeared prominently, and she wasn't Cher, which Columbus half expected. This woman showed up in a prominent spot and the light at the bottom of the hole in the bottom, and the bottom light, it refocused, as if in a theater or stadium, refocusing upon her, the light pinpointing her and the rest of the vista going back to black and iridescent crow purple, this light from the inner walls of the hole, a Mennonite megachurch of sorts amazingly built in this bottom hole.

The music was so loud.

Gypsies, tramps, and thieves,
We'd hear it from the people of the town...

The woman who had appeared was wearing a black dress and a bonnet. She held the rest of the crew back, and they slunk into the shadows; she held them back by merely gesturing, standing on a main landing where so many of these Escher-like stairs connected with one another, a long platform at the third floor that ran all around the trailer of the top of this haphazard building built out of five trailers, standing like a pop star on a mega stage platform that was set to hydraulically lift up soon, revealing the star to the world. It was the McShan Pascale Mountain bottom, it was the Super Bowl halftime show, it was Broadway, a Vegas show, who knows.

It was a big production.

They'd call us gypsies, tramps, and thieves
But every night all the men would come around
And lay their money down.

She called out to Columbus in an aged but vigorous voice, called above out Columbus, "You're the egg who came back. We've been waiting for you—you ain't no Indian. You're one of us."

And then it all began to rise, indeed, the sound of water rushing filling bottom air that was already so loud with Cher singing, belting, still, water showering down with the sound of the grinding of giant machinery, this trailer megastructure from the ground hydraulically lifted until the bottom level was flush with the bottom at its top, grounded. Stairs that connected to various points at different levels in the depths of the whole when submerged were all in the air, staircases to nowhere, dripping with algae and other aquatic plant matter.

The lights had stayed focused upon the woman the entire time as this structure lifted, lights from the hole replaced by new ones coming from the roofs of the trailer-piece treehouses, and she had begun to move, this woman, moving and gesturing that the increasing number of Mennonite men and were to remain on the stairs, stairs that didn't only run along the surface of the three trailer-tall structure connecting the floors externally, but stairs that also jutted out and twisted around one another, draped, goopy entrances all around the hole as if nut job Spaniard Antonio Gaudí designed it, the craftsmanship of the stairs, though tacky, so intricate on these structures around these shit trailers, *La Familia Sagrada* but tin or something and wood and down in a hole and then had had had itself lifted up god knows how, so intricate, little carvings of Mennonites, *oddly*, ecstatically dancing, *which they're not known to do*.

It was all so odd, to say more than the least but not enough about it; Columbus was sure he saw little Mennonites dancing in the woodwork.

The woman who was commanding the space for everybody slowly descended to a second-floor landing, and with much drama, a landing that ran across just the front of the second floor but further out from

the building and she approached the front railing of the balcony like a Hellenistic representative of a polity; this second level of woodwork was a massive second-floor deck the floor of which served as the roof for a first floor patio full of endless whicker chairs, Cher's voice, round and deep, carrying on in the background, still—

…smooth Southern style
Three months later and I'm a gal in trouble.

—the Mennonite woman stood in the obscene fluorescent flood; the woman called out a name: "Ezekiel."

Cher continued.

And I haven't seem him for a whiiiiile, uh-huhhhhh...
I haven't seen hiiim for a whillle, uh-ohh-uhhhh...

A raven flew to her that had been somewhere in the bottom, a raven hidden among the crows, fucking Ezekiel this goddamn bird's prophetic name, and this raven named Ezekiel landed on her shoulder, the music slowly turning down until it was only the sound of the McShan Woods insects and these excited whispering Mennonites like bizarre elves in a Dalí-designed forest from fellowship hall hell in the dead center of Pickens County, it all a big production, no escape.

The Mennonite Pascale Mountain bottom hole trailer castle woman whispered to the raven; she gestured to Peter to indicate he should hold out his hand, and he did, and so Ezekiel took off from her shoulder, wings wide and aflutter, and landed on Columbus' hand. Ezekiel looked at him dead in the eye, this bird's head rotating in Columbus' inebriated mental visage, rotating as a cube with the face of the bird on all sides of the cube, like some biblically accurate beast, Columbus the

bottom explorer Peter tripping out of his mind, this bird's head cubed and rotating, and the raven said to Columbus, "*Attah Yeshua HaMoschiach*—you are the messiah, Peter Zook."

Columbus didn't know a lick of Hebrew and that crazy Christian, heretical in her denomination, acting like a Christian, sure, but Catholic, also doing that thing that a lot of weird Christians do with Hebrew, using it, not knowing it at all, Christian, at least what could be sized up looking at this hole picture; that supposed Christian put that that in that bird's mouth, filled its beaky mouth with poorly pronounced Hebrew and English that wasn't much better—distinctly Pickens County upper crust class English with a distinct mid-century lilt, like she was an extra in *The Maltese Falcon*, but Southahn.

This apparent leader of the hole, in fact, was Itragene Sr.'s mama. She wasn't dead, and when she ran off, she didn't go far. There she was, as she had been the last fifty-four years.

For ritualistic purposes, since 1940, so for fifty-three years, Hellen was supposed to be completely isolated beyond the few who came and went from the Maw Maw Pascale Bottom hole trailer castle in the bottom hole; Iddy and Thaddeus, and others, crazy and powerful, inheritors of local legacy, they thought that Hellen were the Whore of Babylon from the Book of Revelations, that she were to be separate from civilization, in desolation, the "wilderness" (Revelation 17:3), as it were, per the New King James Version of the Christian Bible in Revelations, and that she were to "sit on many waters" (Revelation 17:15), water they ritualistically of which kept the bottom hole covered, giving it the appearance of a too-perfectly-round pond—hence the maritime retrofitting of the trailers in the bottom hole, but, indeed, the appearance typically that of an ordinary pond in the McShan Woods, of which there were plenty, this being perfect camouflage. Also, she was walled in with people who had machine guns, those working at Big Iddy's behest making it impossible to enter or leave HQ.

Promptly, the raven positioned its left claw in such a way that a

needle coated with tranquilizer attached to its right claw pierced Columbus' skin and he immediately fell to the ground.

The Mennonites, at that point, finally and truly gathered Columbus and Maddie and set them both in two whicker chairs on the first floor patio on the front side of the trailer castle they had at the bottom of Maw Maw Pascale's land.

The initial darting and needle-pricking contained an incapacitant dose of ketamine, a dissociative tranquilizer, a powerful horse tranquilizer, specifically, in fact. Two Mennonite women then administered to them more ketamine. The darts had delivered an initial dose to stun, and these further injections were meant for a subsequent, heftier sedating. These two women had these doses each in their hands and they injected Maddie and Columbus, further tranquilizing them with the intention of knocking them unconscious for a good while, about thirty to forty-five minutes. Though they didn't look conscious, they were. They had each had had about 300mg of Alabama street egg*ck*st*uck*s*y*, enough that could've killed them alone, with its stimulant properties, and due to that egg*ck*st*uck*s*y*'s stimulant properties, Maddie and Columbus were paralyzed, but conscious, even if they were tripping balls, rolling and, now, they were in a k-hole, too, all while fully conscious.

They were not as sedated as these Mennonite medicine women assumed, clumsy so early in the operation, one that had been in the works for nearly a century.

Four Mennonite men put them on homemade medical stretchers, two men per stretcher, and they took a journey up a hill and down a hill, and they were eventually laid in beds in a house somewhere.

This particular Mennonite sect was a bit syncretic, not even Mennonite in their practices, obsessed with eating Christ, they were, in fact; it was perverse. They had long diverged from their Great Reformation Anabaptist ancestors. This was a sect active between Indiana and Mexico over the course of the nineteenth century, continuing on in the twentieth, them at a point taking a keen interest in

Pickens County, Alabama, which was on their way to Mexico, and they passed through every so often, long before Highway 82 was paved. Spring 1878, passing through, they got wind that there was a "spirit photograph" in Carrollton, and that it was up in the courthouse garret window, a "spirit photograph," as images like the so-called face in the window were known in the era, a time of religious experimentation that involved talking to the dead, a trans-Atlantic religious movement usually called Spiritualism. By 1994, they had only been living in Pickens County for a few years as far as Pickens County was concerned, everybody knowing the Mennonites who made the bread had settled off downtown Reform, starting in 1990, a move they made late, a move they made then even though they had been selling that bread there for a long time, since the late nineteenth century. This sect had been in Pickens County for so long, under their noses, laying their trap. As it turned out and unbeknownst to most around Pickens County, some of this sect had lived there since the Civil War, deep in the McShan Woods.

This was how Columbus Chulahoma discovered that there was a trailer castle deep in the McShan Woods and that this trailer castle was where some of the Pickens County Mennonites lived, down there at Maw Maw Pascale's bottom, there over in the McShan Woods.

By this time, 1994, these hidden people in Pickens County worked for Big Iddy, these hidden figures in the McShan Woods, just as they had since she took over for her grandaddy in 1993, them working for Thaddeus since the 1940s.

The trailer castle, in fact, was the McShan Mafia's headquarters. They called it "HQ." And the thing was, again, they weren't really Mennonites, the HQ Mennonite sect.

Music picked up again as the curtain went down on the big show.

My father married a pure Cherokee.

My mother's people were ashamed of me.

Cher's 1973 "Half-Breed" began to play, and the Mennonites busied about, calming down after the big show, cleaning up and getting ready for bed.

The Indians said that I was white by law
The White Man always called me "Indian Squaw"

Half-breed, that's all I ever heard
Half-breed, how I learned to hate the word
Half-breed, she's no good they warned
Both sides were against me since the day I was born.

Cher was like Columbus—"part-Cherokee."

Give her a feather, she's a Cherokee.

Saturday morning, which happened to be the morning after Jane Hadley and the zoologist saw one another, around 8am, Columbus stirred deep in the McShan Woods the same morning Iddy finalized her plans.

His movement effected noise, his stirring having a sound.

At his moving, there was a loud rickety sound that wasn't bones though his bones ground in his joints, too, somatic noise, the sound embodied amidst the surroundings about. It was a bed, the sound, Columbus realized, being in a bed the situation, it was dawning on him. That he was in anywhere at all was news to him, much less a bed specifically. He had been wide awake but elsewhere, not in the room

where he was, didn't know he was in a bed until he moved, though he had been in this bed for hours and fully awake, eyes dry from staring at, but beyond, the ceiling.

He was in bed and it was morning, Saturday, he believed.

He moved, moved his head for what must have been the first time in hours, a severe crick in his neck making itself apparent as he looked across the room where he found himself and saw that he was in a room with a window frame but no window panes. There was a chilly breeze.

It was the Saturday after their fateful Friday night use of LSD and egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* in the McShan Woods; they had radically altered their consciousness by their own hands, and then, also, they had been drugged and kidnapped by some people dressed like Mennonites, incapacitated with even more mind-altering substances, none of it fully knocking them out as the Mennonites supposed, them too high on stimulating egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* to go down with the ketamine dose the Mennonites administered to them before taking them each to the house where they were waking up, the ketamine dissociating them but not knocking them out.

The hours prior, after midnight and before the sun began to rise, four Mennonite men had left them in some large bedroom with two twin beds and no windows but where there were window frames. They barely had any recall of anything after Chulahoma's trailer, the stuff that came about after they walked all the way to Maw Maw Pascale's land. They did not exist yet in a present with a recallable past. They had been heavily under the influence of substances—the potent psychedelic LSD, the stimulating empathogen egg*ck*st*uck*s*y* and the tranquilizing dissociative ketamine—that dramatically alter consciousness.

Having been lost in total awareness, just lying there in this bed in an unfamiliar room and not yet speaking, too overwhelmed by the stunning silence beyond the birds chirping outside and the sound of breeze making contact with trees and wind chimes in the distance, it was coming to Columbus what had happened the prior evening. He

could remember the Mennonite men carrying them from Pascale Mountain's bottom, its bottom side, where all of its big hills met, carried them to wherever they were, neither of them remembering being taken into any building, only a long walk on a path in the woods, them on homemade medical stretchers fabricated from whicker.

Maddie, also waking, did not remember being carried from the bottom, didn't remember the hole, didn't know anything about a trailer castle nor did she know what she had done, her instead set to believe Columbus' account over her own, not trusting her mind at all as waking consciousness planted its roots in her mind and she came to life, her, over the coming days, just going along with whatever Columbus said happened.

They both had been too incapacitated to move for quite a while, the Mennonites having induced in them total paralysis but not quite actually extinguishing their consciousness as they had life, her, over the coming days, just going along with whatever Columbus said happened, each of them hours earlier having been administered 500mg of the dissociative tranquilizer ketamine, a substance introduced to their loops of consciousness, their minds having been already as bright and dynamic as the Vegas Strip, deep into an egg*ck*st*uck*sy and LSD candy flip. They had just been lying there for hours, the sun slowly coming up, cold but with old-fashioned blankets on them, deep red handiwork with blue farmhouses in the patterning, the blanket croqueted, bumpkin blankets, soft like buttermilk.

As their waking consciousness took hold, they were getting scared, had already been scare, becoming absolutely terrified and literally didn't know what was going on, the last each of them could remember clearly prior to these beds was them being deep in the McShan Woods, running from gunshots up into Pascale Mountain.

They laid there a long time, birds chirped and the sun continued to rise, the two of them afraid to move at all. It appeared to them both that they'd been kidnapped, and it had been a terrifying trip, they, at minimum, knew, knew it quite a bit, ultimately kidnapped or

something, it unclear because they had been so fucked up.

There they were, waking up having never slept, there in two twin beds in a chilly room, all wood—the floor, the walls, the ceiling, all finished wood painted a lilac color. Again, the window was missing from the room where they were, Maddie and Columbus. And that's just how their Saturday morning started; they thought they had been kidnapped and hadn't moved all morning as they watched the sun slowly rise, their systems full of so many drugs and their aftereffects—LSD, egg*ck*st*uck*s*y*, and ketamine, all different drug classes with extreme drug interactivity; Maddie also vaguely remembered having a joint, something that wasn't the case for her pal, Columbus Chulahoma.

Maddie was the first to say something, her vocal box a gravel pit, "Columbus?"

She said it at a low volume, terrified that there were somebody on the other side of the room's closed door, guarding them or preventing their exit, or something, who knows, it all so surreal; Maddie also vaguely remembered having a joint, something that wasn't the case for her pal, Columbus Chulahoma to wake from a sleep they never had.

He was near tears, but he responded to her.

"Yeah?"

Maddie did not immediately respond, getting a grip on the process of getting ready to speak, speaking some portion of a minute later, fighting tears newly forming upon her trying to use her mouth to speak.

She said, "Can you please come here?"

Coming to terms with how conversations work between human beings, with the present material reality of being a live human and not experiencing the forever of the cosmos blitzed on fancy drug—they were there, remembering what the fuck what they were both trying to do, them with their varied recollections of the evening.Columbus went across the room, slowly, so slowly, slowly walked over towards her after getting corporeal gumption, the floor creaking as loudly as a

bridge collapse, sounding like the Lurleen Wallace Bridge next to Jack's on Highway 82 had broken and fallen into the creek it covered.

He made his way slowly, standing in the middle of the room for at least a minute as he gauged if his stirring sounds were provoking any human activity or otherwise on the other side of the bedroom door; they looked at each other desperately and as only people who intimately knew one another could, chosen kin, while Columbus lingered at that halfway point, both so terrified.

Nothing happened, no sound on the other side of the door and Columbus couldn't take it anymore: he put his finger up to his mouth indicating that Maddie should remain quiet and he then opened the door—nobody there.

There was something attached to the other side of the door in a satchel, thought, a black little cloth bag with a bell on it that rang, a little satchel-shaped thing, a legal-size envelope.

"What's that?" Maddie grunted.

"I don't know," Columbus said without pausing and opening the bag's brim and peaking inside, afraid to just reach in like it was a McDonald's bag, it feeling like a trap. "There's like, documents in here," he said, pulling them out, adjusting his eyes, amazed his eyes could focus on discrete letters and words and sentences and make sense.

"Let me see," Maddie urged, also getting up, her bones hurting.

Columbus handed her what looked like a contract, on large, long legal-sized paper, and an agreement of some sorts on regular letter-sized paper, examining further what was in the bag, a broach of sorts —a crow.

"Columbus...I think this is your house, now? Is your name actually 'Peter Zook?'"

Flabbergasted, Columbus the Peter went, "Well, yeah...as a matter of fact I think you asked me last night and I told you it was Peter...I don't remember saying Zook, though."

"Oh, I don't remember that, but that's not why I'm asking."

"It's on the papers?"

"Yeah...look," she said handing him the longer contract on legal-size paper, pointing to where the document said "Peter Zook (Alias 'Columbus Chulahoma')."

"I…" Columbus said, holding the paper and looking up in the ceiling in doubt of his own eyes. "I think it's a deed? It says we're on Lowell Hanks..."

"Yup," Maddie said, them both getting their bearings again on navigating this world but having no idea what on earth was going on, her leaning out what appeared to be a westward window and it was looking out over on the intersection of Lowell Hanks and Rocky Ridge Road; they were inside the giant white house that nobody lived in that over looked the mighty field.

There was a deed and a non-disclosure agreement, an odd NDA that didn't' seem legal because it also threatened his life, an NDA he was instructed to sign and leave on the kitchen counter next to the back door in a set of instructions typed on a smaller piece of paper. The instructions said he would be shot upon exit if he did not agree to the terms of the NDA, which were simple terms: accept this house as your property, maintain it with funds that will come your way, or else.

He had been addressed, but he was not sure whom it was that had done this to him.

Columbus had just been trapped by the Window Washers, the latest victim in the scheme, a long-time pawn unbeknownst to him, it becoming clearer—giving something extravagant that could cause him a lot of heartache, next few years, this was a common tactic of Iddy's.

As it had come to be the Window Watchers was designed to bring local businesses together in public-private partnerships with the town of Carrollton and the County of Pickens to preserve and promote the face in the window, ensnaring them financially and politically further than they already were upon Thaddeus' death with the situation that they called the face in the window—as well as Thaddeus' own legacy as a preserver of the face in the window, like the great prophet of the

face in the window, getting promised a posthumous statue holding a pane of glass at some point, one they planned to also etch Henry's face into, looking up at Mr. Calloway and smiling, a Black boy and a Very Good White Man.

The Window Watchers were part of his final will and testament, one of the few parties who received money—an NDA was required and the money was laundered, very much technically and criminally, *via* Big Iddy, who was, essentially, a Pickens County mob boss and notorious Southeastern drug dealer, gun trafficker, fraudster, extortionist and blackmailer who lived in Tuscaloosa County though she was the lord of Pickens, just west; the Window Watchers money was laundered initially to Mrs. Hadley and then, as businesses signed on, those businesses all became ensnared in a posthumous blackmail plot controlled by the one family member Thaddeus trusted with his true legacy, his granddaughter Itragene Belle McDaniel, Jr., Big Iddy, her granny, Hellen Calloway helping from her trailer castle.

When they made their way outside, oddly not worried that they'd be shot regardless, they were stunned at what they saw: a mailbox had appeared overnight and it said "Chulahoma" on it—Columbus was scared for a number of reasons, but pointedly in that moment because it was one thing to be "the little Indian in the meadow," a renter, but to *own* in white McShan and in the context in which they all believed he wasn't white, but Native American. He was worried about the stir that must have already been made by that mailbox popping up there, McShanians loving a Saturday morning drive around the woods, no telling who had already seen it.

At least he wasn't Black, he thought, and he thanked his lucky stars for this, awful as it was.

VII. The Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre

Nobody loved the legend of the ghost of Henry Wells more than Jane Ellen did over her life.

Not nobody.

Nobody could compare to Jane Ellen—famed so-called local historian and illiterate child of the fine, fine and upstanding local idiot gentry—not nobody, not in passion when it came to the Face in the Window, for: *she had* *Pride in the Heritage* *of the Legend* *of* the Face in the Window *as* *the History of the Legacy*, *the legacy*, the legacy, these godforsaken people and their goddamn legacy—*the legah'say of the Ollllllld South,* and this furious Pride of hers she had inherited as the Heritage of the Legend as the History of this Legacy on the trellis of bigotry as its History in Time.

The *legah'say, the legah'say, legah'say,* on and on and on and on these godforsaken white people would go, would go on and on about their hateful legacy, *the legah'say, the legah'say*... on and on and on and on, just endless tedious and hateful bullshit—The Face in the Window, The Face in the Window, the Face in the Window they scream until Death claims their carcasses. Death—the only thing that would make them shut the fuck up finally, and at last, about Henry goddamn Wells, each and every one of them, their being dead cold and in their graves.

She loved that window more than anybody ever had, Jane Ellen, this was the truth. The tale and its role in local civic life consumed her until her death, this legend, this famous lynching ghost story window.

"My-*uhhh* word-*uhhh*, I am-*uhhh theee-uhhh* director-*uhhh-ah-uhhh!* Of-u*hhh*! Theeeeee, THE-*uhhh* Window-*uhhh*hhh Washers-*ahhh*hhh-*uhhhgh*! A big deal, a big deal, responsible for *the legh-uhhh-*

ah-say in fact and indeed! The director, in charge and leading my people! I am a thought leader and servant to the legacy, indeed! h'WHITE POWER! HAIL-*uhhh* HITLER-*uhhh*! Rollllll Tie'd-*uhhh*."

That's just a snapshot of her one night in the mirror at the end of the hallway, her and her spooks and Hitler, who she also thinks she can talk to, channeling the dead in her home littered with over one hundred unique Henry curios.

Little sweet and innocent legacy girl Jane Ellen was, in fact, a neo-Nazi, as the McShan Mafia was a neo-Nazi, white power criminal operation, indeed, a white power movement, neo-Nazi Southern gang.

It's more common than you'd think.

This here white pride was the legacy of the Confederacy, after all, the heritage of the Ollllle' South.

Shortly after Thaddeus Calloway Jr.'s death in 1993, widow Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley had gone and found herself all of the sudden the director of the newly set up non-profit called the Window Watchers, which, itself, at the end of the day, its capitalization, where they created value, was in its being a blackmail, money laundering and trafficking operation, which she knew about, all of it, was in charge of elements of it—no surprise, really,

because she'd do anything for the legacy, a product of history and the pride that was her heritage, would do it at any cost, this legacy protecting, even become what she became at the end of her ugly life, a common criminal.

She was so honored.

A real opportunity to serve the legacy—and some recognition, finally, this a dream come true, this the attention of a kind and quantity which she so craved. She was a privileged woman who had never worked a day in her life, but she had been busy, making herself available as a staunch, faithful and lifelong advocate for the window and the legacy of the legend of the ghost of Henry Wells and his fucking face—*yada yada*, the legend in the legacy and the legacy in the legend... the history of the pride in the heritage, *etc*. *etc*. The usual

bullshit in the famously recursive South.

It had been a long time coming, the recognition of her dedication to the heritage of the legend in the legacy.

They'd say it with a hateful drawl: *Tha Lehgah-see*.

The idiot woman called Jane Ellen couldn't look for *squash shit* beyond these narrow bands of her thinned attention that she had, and so she'd get overwhelmed by the information around her, understand, her condition and all. She was too aware but in a blank way, aware in an askance manner of her environment, aware in some ways, aware of so much stuff but didn't understand a lick of it, just knew it was there and that it confused her, and that figuring it all out agitated her, for she was always confused in her notions and in the thick of trying to figure out what the hell was going on.

She'd lie and say she was aware.

"Oh-*uhhh*, I'm aware," in fact, was one of her most commonly uttered phrases.

"Oh-*uhhh*, I know, trust-*uhhh* me. I am aware, *mhmm*."

"Oh-*uhhh*, I am-*uhhh*'ware-*uhhh*."

She was mixed up in some dangerous business, Jane Ellen, beyond her financial crimes at the Window Watchers, a criminal cheating other criminals, a nice little old white lady in penny loafers. She was so mixed up in this McShan Mafia business. Professor van de Tuffin had no idea. Jane Ellen sure did know—guilty as hell and she just didn't care up until that point. She'd do anything for that window and its heritage in the legacy as the legend that they were so proud of. She wasn't going to no jail, no matter; she wasn't some damn [*you-know-what*].

Not only did these people capitalize on the lynching ghost story window, with their tourism and endless yapping about it and writing about it, but they ran a criminal enterprise under the guise of the legacy and this was their true heritage. This was, in fact, the legacy: from human trafficking in the days of chattel slavery to their affairs in the modern era, transnational in criminal scope and terroristic in

domestic activities. Those Ruby Red grapefruits that were found at the scene of the crime in the Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre and that she loved to eat so much were sold by the medicine man called Tom—the one with the van with the paintings of the cows feeding baby piglets with baby bottles—but they were trafficked from Mexico. All these people were traffickers, from the days of yore and enslavement and its horrors to the present moment.

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"It's 'go time?' Huh? Th'fuck? 'Go time' 'go time'—that kinda 'go time?' The hell, Peggy? What'n'fucks'sakes are you talk'm'bout?! What're you talm'k-ahnbout, Peggay Pascale?!? Peggggy, Peggay, Peggy, Peeeeggy, Peggy—no, no, no, uhh uhh, nooope. No, it is not no damn fucking goddang gotdamn 'go time,' ain't no timeeee for anything as such, no, no no...Do you know who's watching right now? You sound so stupid. YOU'RE A FUCKING IDIOT, PEGGY PASCALE!" She spit after she said it all; she cleared a gob of smoker's snot from her throat and spit the carcinogenic refuse over the balcony edge; she was spitting.

Big Iddy was so mad, so mad, spittin' mad. She was fit to be tied, Big Iddy, the Devil himself animating her, surely enough. She was out of sorts.She was hollering and being mean and spitting and there were also ominous bells ringing in the background as she carried on.

It was late evening and Maw Maw Pascale had just given Iddy a ring. Big Iddy, for her part, she sure was fit to be tied, couldn't believe what she was hearing on the phone, mad, fuming, big mad; she was seething, she was furious, she was a raging alcoholic; she worshipped the Devil. It was same Friday night as Maddie and Columbus' adventures in the McShan Woods, and Big Iddy was out there on her

beloved deck on the back side of her giant house, and she had a record player with a big speaker out there on her deck with her, blasting some creepy song.

"I'm real sorry, Iddy," said on the phone Maw Maw Pascale, gripping her giant denim thighs with her big fat hands, gripping her own big person for dear life so that she didn't laugh, trying to sound sorry about it all when she sure as hell wasn't; she was an ornery woman, but a good woman, Peggy Pascale, chief head-butting goat of Pascale Mountain; she hated Big Iddy, her granddaddy, too, and actually liked our Itragene very much—Peggy called Itragene Sr., "Ma Iddy," like a few around town did, including Columbus Chulahoma's boyfriend, the mortician, John Henry, as well as Columbus Chulahoma, too, fondly.

"Please, don't encourage her!" Maddie would say when people called her "Ma Iddy."

A very amaretto-inebriated Big Iddy was bewildered and pissed, she was, the latter perturbed madness her default lane in life at high, raging speeds, and the former a not uncommon parking spot for her, her bewildered a lot, dumb, moving too fast, in too deep, and ignorant, no idea what she was doing, her, then, yelling into the phone, screamed it: "Also, the fuck you think you're doing calling me at this time of night? If this ain't a fucking emergency, I swear, Peggy, ooooh."

Big *ole'* Iddy was spitting mad, drunk as shit, talking that mean way that she did to Maw Maw Pascale, talking down, like she did to everybody, a person who truly did think she was better than literally everybody else ever with whom she had been in contact. This is how she treated Peggy Pascale, whom she happened to even like, insofar as her sour soul could take a liking to anybody.

Iddy did not want this phone call in the abstract and the particulars were shocking to her, so genuinely and with much derivative disorientation on her part, the next moments it all comically apparent, her desperation, her newly deepened desperation, as they would speak.

Generally, big-picture, especially since Thaddeus' death, Iddy was worried about her Gulf Cartel business associates spying on her in Tuscaloosa, her definitely being trailed, as her countersurveillance measures had indicated, and there she was that Friday evening, drunk and paranoid but confident and self-assured, cocky but also terrified, a contradictory and moody mess cognitively and emotionally, confused and emotionally labile, her asking and asserting all of this on the phone with Maw Maw Pascale, who had just called up Iddy from her kitchen phone, her sitting atop her favorite kitchen chair, spilling over its sides with her fat, her over there, Maw Maw Peggy Pascale, deep in the McShan Woods.

It was often confusing in Itragene Jr.'s head, that Big Iddy, as they all called her, Big Iddy, Big Iddy and her profound confusion, bewilderment, there she would be, similarly to but in profoundly and disturbingly different ways than those known ways of her mother, Itragene Sr; our Itragene, Ma Iddy, she said things that sometimes added up, in a way, but didn't make sense—other times, things she'd be on about, they'd be of a nature that made sense but didn't seem to add up, adding up only to Itragene, but not to others, but they did to Itragene, they did, and others just couldn't see it, but and and this was when she were righteously correct and right, our Itragene truly a Pickens County shaman who could see through the rot and redeem life as part of her magic, who could help others see and hear, too, if given the tools, room, Itragene capable of sacred work if properly nurtured and, finally, at last, truly tended to and cared for by another human being with total intimacy, something she'd never had—Itragene needed to get on meds, heal and carry on with her life's work in a more stable manner, a less self-harming manner; she needed to eat, sleep, laugh and relax a little, have true company, not be imprisoned by the hallucinated voices in her head.

Big Iddy had a few voices in her head, too, one was a poltergeist named Jeffrey and the other was a deep growl and hiss "who" she assumed to be Satan, her a little devil. Like her grandaddy, Big Iddy

was riddled with personality disorders and she was also bipolar and schizophrenic. Both Bid Iddy and her grandfather, Thaddeus, were psychopaths.

That either Thaddeus had ever had the life that he had and that Iddy had had hers were both cases of testament to the white supremacist legacy of the fallen Confederacy in the Black Belt Deep South—they got shit they didn't deserve, those two and white people broadly in Pickens County and around it; this is why most of these white people around these parts would do *anything* in their power to protect their legacy, no depraved act beneath them, the reason why they had been carrying for over a goddamn century in Pickens County and all over elsewhere around the South, carrying on and hollering and pointing and laughing and yelling and carrying on, just carrying the fuck *on* and *all the goddamn time*, carrying on for *over a century* about that *dead Black man who had been enslaved during his life under the horrors of chattel slavery and then to have been said to have been lynched*—them carrying on for over *a* remarkable *century* about the strange fruit print of Henry Wells' supposed face in that goddamn courthouse garret room window that they've got and that they're so proud of, this awful notion of a strange fruit scarecrow that they had and called "the face in the window."

Big Iddy was so confident about so much—falsely so and to extreme degrees. This idiot poise and bravado was amplified when she were inebriated on her fine liquors; daily, she had a confidence in things that were all simply not fortified for such a certainty of which hers was a type and kind, none of it certain, not at all; one such false confidence about Iddy's mind that was demonstrated in her ways was that she were sure as hell, *certain as fuck*, that nobody, nobody—neither law enforcement nor transnational criminal syndicates—nobody at all were spying on this particular call. The line that she was using, that call, she was so sure of it to be safe, Maw Maw Pascale long-trusted and her communications devices checked regularly by Ugly and other underlings, but Iddy's Pickens County hands all used

countersurveillance methods that had failed to detect the latest, remote technologies used by law enforcement and intelligence agencies of the time, the mid-1990s; she had this confidence about her, though, an anachronistic one, a confidence in her countersurveillance measures that were analogous to Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley's amateur historian work in their professional quality, her, a professional criminal, Big Iddy, a professional criminal who was too simple and self-important in a manner that was always leading to her own methods being that which chronically trapped her rather than her enemies' schemes, doing their work for them. For instance, she barely had a handle on *ole*' Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley: a pro would have murdered Hadley a long time ago, and there would be no Katherine, no damn left-wing Tulane sociologist snooping around, no animal "experts" like Kevin van der Tuffin who might also notice shit, no newspaper discoveries that revealed the whole bit and in naked ways, and not for lack of cruelty had she let Hadley live this long and carry about in ridiculous way, Big Iddy enjoying a good murder, but it was that she just didn't' know when to act, just didn't have good instincts like her granddaddy had, her unsure of herself as much as she was sure, equally, and that was a cognitive state that interfaced her rapidly oscillating moods, and, so she was confused all the time and spitting mad about it.

Big Iddy spoke freely on the phone with this Pentecostal woman, so confident that nobody was listening in on their call.

The Birmingham FBI field office was laughing as they listened in, though, laughing hard, like they did, as they did all the time, did laugh at Big Iddy, them hearing this particular and new desperation in Big Iddy's voice, the surprise. Agents in the Birmingham field office clamored to monitor and surveil Itragene McDaniel Jr., all wanting this duty, and that was because she was so stupid, clumsy, and, as they all figured, Big Iddy would never be arrested because she'd ultimately get murdered by the Gulf Cartel, her the Jane Ellen Hadley of that Matamoros, Tamaulipas, Mexico-based crime syndicate's satellite subsidiaries across the US South, the Gulf Cartel well-intreated

amongst the Deep South gentry and their white trash hands, well-integrated into Southern gangs born out of Prohibition and hardened by Jim Crow. Big Iddy was a dumbass, mean as she was dumb, a dumbness her grandfather could not see because he, himself, he were a dumbass, and, also, he couldn't see his grand-baby's medical and evident idiocy because he was so infatuated with the notion of his own legacy that he put all of his blind faith into the one family member whom he knew to have the congruent morals to carry out the evil work of preserving Pickens County legacy—the Calloway family name, and their precious Pickens County, that damn Henry Wells ghost lynching story courthouse and more—after his death and his long tenure as county commissioner.

"Hahaha," uttered a blonde woman over in Birmingham, and loudly she did, too, taking off her headphones that were connected to a big black device with knobs and dials and digital green-lit narrow screens with sound waves on them, oscilloscopes, a large panel of a device that was installed in the beige wall where the built-in, Brutalist desk where she worked was flush, her there in a rather small, fluorescent-lit, windowless room where she was currently sat with two other men who were sat at their individual desks, too, all with the same equipment, these people being FBI agents monitoring various Southern gangsters, an office space where joint FBI and DEA operations were ran in Alabama, an elite squad, just one corner in a building that contained a vast complex of many small rooms where such joint task force work took place between the FBI and other governmental agencies.

"I have got to piss so bad, fuck. I'll rewind and listen to what I miss," she said after getting up and removing her headphones, this blonde Birmingham FBI agent; she went out the door laughing her ass off, disappearing into the hallway.

"Fuck, right?" A Black guy sitting near the blonde woman said as she walked by, him high-fiving her in a casual and fun way, as they did all the time, this a tight-knit team, his headphones still on and him rapt.

"She has no fucking clue what she's doing. It's about to get so fucking messy, I am dying." The other guy, a white guy said."She's gonna end up dead, like I've been saying," the blonde woman had said right before she opened the door and ran to the restroom, laughing her ass off about it all, still.

These FBI agents were having the times of their professional lives that Friday night, a real on-duty treat, and so unexpected, and it was triply funny to them because this all involved a damn fake Native American and the target of surveillance's own fucking sibling. They knew about a lot in Pickens, such as the topics germaine to the conversation being had between Peggy Pascale and Itragene McDaniel Jr., had taken satellite images of the bottom hole at Pascale mountain, which sometimes looked like a large pond from an aerial view, and, at other times, but less frequently, the trailer castle would be exposed and be either visible down in the hole or up out of it, when it'd be raised to ground-level, raised up and outside the hole, when it would be lifted on its hydraulics-powered base—the United States of America had these intelligence agencies tending to a lot of Drug War matters, both the FBI and CIA, and nary an agent, no intelligence analyst, nobody in intelligence nor law enforcement could fully figure out what was going on at the bottom of Pascale Mountain in that clearing that was a type of land feature folks around Pickens County called a "bottom," Maw Maw Pascale, herself, not even fully aware. The government needed more human intelligence (HUMINT), and, so, like Big Iddy and the McShan Woods Mennonites, the FBI had been closing in on Peter Zook, alias "Columbus Chulahoma," and seeking to make him an asset, a risky asset, at that, but their best bet, risky as he was not very stable, but he was compromised in more than a couple of ways and thus pliable, and, indeed, he were also uniquely and well-situated to explore the trailer castle at the Pascale Mountain bottom, given his mysterious ties to those Mennonites in McShan woods and their intelligence- and surveillance-wise opaque and mysterious machinations.

The blonde woman was back, Special Federal Agent Rachelle Strickland, and quickly so was she back, hands still wet from rapidly washing them and skipping the paper towel part, her having ran back, so excited, patting her hands on her pants and putting her headphones back on, sitting, asking of the room, talking to the other agents, "Do you think we should we inform Katherine or do we think this should all, you know just play out more naturally—we have plenty of eyes on her, so she'll be good even if she steps right into the mess Iddy's about to make."

"Let's leave her in the dark, for now—she's not on active duty and this is a total coincidence that she's even in Pickens County...although, on one hand, I still can't believe nobody has not taken them, yet, taken them to task for that damn window...I'm glad it seems....does seem so that Katherine seems to be onto it, but it's all so mighty dangerous and she doesn't get that, yet; knowing her, she probably thinks it's all funny as it is dark, knowing her. She's so smart and funny, man. I do want to eventually tap her, out of respect of her work, at minimum, and, of course, for her own safety, but, way before that, before we influence her behavior, we need a better grasp on the Aryan Brotherhood of Mississippi and how closely they're still following her; she served her country well infiltrating one of the most notorious white power gangs in the country, prevented thirteen goddamn terrorist attacks, total, and I do *not* want her involved and in danger with the cartel, not if we can help it. But, I know she'll do the good work if asked. I feel lucky she's there but sick to my stomach about it, really," the Black guy said, clearly in charge, his word on it final. His name was Marvin Montgomery, Special Federal Agent Marvin Montgomery.

"Anyway, beyond Dr. Mann, man, Iddy, Iddy, Big dumb Iddy. She's playing Chinese checkers and these motherfuckers are playing Go," the Rachelle accurately observed to all, replying directly to her superior, Marvin.

"*Right under* her goddamn nose, man, right under her goddamn nose, *ahaha*, man, oh man, these jokers in Tuscaloosa, man," Marvin

was laughing and intently staring at his oscilloscope signatures.

"*Yeppp*, yep. I'm real sorry, but seems such, seems to be," Maw Maw Pascale said in the affirmative, Big Iddy having asked her some minutes before if it were truly "go time," her putting down the phone for a minute to go refill her amaretto when they got on the phone at first; Iddy, then, got back on the phone, audibly breathing hard and in actuality also sweating like a pig, and, then, Peggy had told her again that yes it's "go time," "*Yeppp*, yep," Peggy Pascale was taking a true —and rare—pleasure in how this really seemed to destabilize Iddy's sense of things, how she thought things were going in McShan, in Pickens; Iddy wasn't as smart as she thought, not as thorough as she believed, and Maw Maw Pascale could tell, and this had her all near in a fit of hysterical laughter, her hearing that truth be so congruent in the desperation she sensed in Iddy's voice, a rare desperation to which Maw Maw Pascale had never been directly privy, and it was a fun form of intimacy for her, her wanting revenge on Iddy.

There they were, on the phone, and this was that same Friday evening as the candy flip and long walk from Chulahoma's trailer in the McShan Meadow through the McShan woods over towards Pascale Mountain, Maddie and Columbus, by then, still somewhere deep in the McShan Woods experiencing the extreme edges of human experience with non-ordinary states of consciousness, having been kidnapped by an apparent group of McShan Woods Mennonites.

It was near midnight.

Our Itragene Sr.'s Itragene Jr., Big Iddy, she was holding the phone in the crook of her neck with her shoulder and pacing, smoking a cigar and drinking fine amber and shiny, sweet amaretto with ice, looking out the way beyond her house, gazing out and at the bright half-moon reflected in the ripples on the surface of Lake Tuscaloosa, a cloudless night, by then—just looking, not seeing, however, her not having *eyes to see* nor *ears to hear*, Iddy not having an aesthetic bone in her body nor giving a shit about nature and its magnificent universe in any other sense that might instill a sense of appreciation for life, nothing sacred

to her; so there she was, Iddy set up in her big, black-painted whicker chair when she wasn't pacing, sitting and ambling about on her big wrap-around, high-dollar Tuscaloosa lifestyle deck at her big house on Lake Tuscaloosa, a woman who was rarely inside, always on that damn deck, scheming, usually. The back of her big house, with giant windows spanning multiple floors, it faced the lakeside of her lot, her pricey property. On the lake side of this wraparound Alabama ritz deck of hers, you could see far and across the lake and, to the left, you could see the Lake Tuscaloosa Dam waterfall, Big Iddy living in the giant and prominent black house everybody knew from just passing by if not by Big Iddy's reputation—all black, exterior walls made from black materials or otherwise painted black, curtains clearly black from behind the many windows, blackout curtains, at that, the doors black, too, window frames, the roof, chimney, all of it black—a house that you could see atop the mighty, rocky, tree-covered hill on your right, if you're driving over lake Tuscaloosa on New Watermelon Road going towards Northport at the Tuscaloosa County border with Pickens County—heading west.

"Yup, *yup*, Iddy, sure is 'go time,' I'd say, sure do look that way... "—Maw Maw Pascale hated to say this part, truly, as much as Iddy's reaction were priceless in her eyes, as she knew violence was near, if it were "go time," but thus was the masquerade, her playing her part—"thing is here, this is the thing: I done talked to your granny. She called around ten. That Mennonite Indian boy and your sister found their way to HQ, this evening, I'm sorry to report. What do we do, now?"

"Hellen *called* you—*really*? Huh, h*m*m*ph*." Iddy's voice lilted with a form of being pissed off in a way that only somebody as fuming and turnt out as her by default could reach in vocal expression, mean and ugly, hateful people like Iddy and Ugly, those kinda people with their mean voices.

"Ye*ah*...I know, I *know,* I do...I hadn't seen her for a few days, either, so it was doubly *surprisin*'."

Big Iddy and the McShan Mafia had big plans born of convenience

that were for Chulahoma, but the McShan Woods occultist fake Mennonites had very complex plans for Chulahoma, as weird and complicated as they were big in some awful sense, eschatological, for these nut jobs who lived in a trailer castle deep in the McShan Woods on Maw Maw Pascale's property.

Chulahoma walking up on HQ? None of this had not been part of the plan set by Thaddeus before his death with the assistance of his beloved granddaughter, Itragene Jr.; though Iddy had been spying on Chulahoma in a plenary, surveillance fashion, men dressed in all black all over the McShan Woods monitoring Chulahoma, taking photographs of him, writing notes as to what he was up to, and more, and, so, Big Iddy did have big plans for him, plans that would exploit his mental fragility in regards to his untreated and apparent mood disorder's derivative messiness in life and clearly apparent messiah complex, plans she had that were based upon the fact that he was born to Mennonites, particular plans specific to Columbus Chulahoma that had been in motion since Hellen Calloway called the Columbus orphanage in 1975, talking to the staff member Patricia, the one who had informed Columbus that his parents were in Pickens County, a lie Hellen told in an effort—among others, this just being the thing that did the trick—to lure to Pickens "Columbus," a boy named then Peter Zook, to lure him to Pickens County, where they'd ensnare him in their occultist rituals; they lured his parents there, too, it a true strategic loss when his parents died, particularly his mama with her Piggly Wiggly penny steak-induced heart attack in 1993, the year prior. This complex of entrapment was Thaddeus' plan by way of Iddy and the pseudo-Mennonites, unbeknownst to Iddy, had some plans of their own, too—the code name for the project which focused on Chulahoma and his birth family was "the HQ Messiah Complex, or the HQMC.

Some of the Mennonites, like *all of those* who lived in the McShan Woods, and *a slim number of* them in downtown Reform, the rare downtown Reform Mennonite that where involved those being who were in-the-know on this need-to-know-basis stuff; they all were on

the frontlines, authentic and inauthentic Mennonites of Pickens, the lead of Iddy's McShan Mafia army. The faithful and peaceful Mennonite, though white, was one of the most abused victims in Pickens County, under Southern Baptist rule at the hands of the McShan Mafia.

Indeed, Bid Iddy, like her granddaddy Thaddeus, were Southern mafia bosses Iddy took on the leadership role when Thaddeus passed in 1993.

Iddy found them useful, these people who were Mennonite authentically or only insofar as they had a culture of reclusion and that they dressed as they did, but nothing more, the occultist ones, them not even worshiping Jesus as their god, but the Devil, akin to Big Iddy, *but*, *and* and, it was all a good cover, their innocence presumed, whichever, only appearances mattering for the crimes they did in their innocent clothing, costumes for some. The occultists in the McShan Woods were up to things that Iddy had no idea was going on, and nor had Thaddeus a clue when he were the boss; so, on the other hand, despite the apparent boot on all the Mennonites' necks, these select McShan Mennonites were from a sect that branched off from Mennonitism in a clandestine fashion, and they practiced syncretic forms of Indigenous plant medicine alongside theological Satanism, genuine Devil worshippers with magic mushrooms and the like, these "Mennonites" only pretending to be Mennonites, dissimulating, dressed in these signature black clothes from Great Reformation Europe and selling their bread on the county square, wolves among sheep. This sect believed that the Return of Christ would happen in the US South and that it would be a man of Mennonite origins who did not have parents—a so-called virgin birth, and as close as they could approximate that was an orphan, and so it was—and this Mennonite baby with no parents would be the person of the returned Jesus the Christ, the instance of creation that is this man called Jesus, in the flesh, here for a second round, his Second Coming; these ideas were central to their prophecies, their initiation rituals and oral as well as

hidden and written notions. They wanted to *crucify him*, murder him ritualistically, in fact, a ting theological Satanists are notably fixated, blood sacrifice, and they wanted to crucify him and sacrifice him under the moon, and do it deep in the McShan Woods, in fact, ushering in the one-thousand-year-reign of Christ on Earth, in their views and prophecies, a reign of one-thousand years before the final showdown between Jesus, King of the Jews, and Satan, as narrated in the the Book of Revelations, a plot and scriptural End of Time-scene where, they hoped, that Satan, all Satanic forces, the Devil himself, hoped that the Devil would beat Jesus. They viewed Jesus as the King of the Jews, indeed—so, a dirty Jew—and in a profoundly Roman and perverse way that meant they wanted to murder him, eat his body, and then claim his crown and the inheritance of his people from their god. They were sick and their understanding of Judaism and the Jewish people was nothing new, just the same shit that lead to the *Shoah* and Holocaust, the same ancient bigotry that had been the Roman and Hellenistic curse set upon the tribal people from the Levant known as the Jewish people, a curse that had been on them for over two thousand years.

Maw Maw Pascale had just told Iddy that she spoke to her grandmother, Itragene's mother and Thaddeus' wife, and Iddy was shocked—not because her grandmother was alive—that she knew—as indicated by Maw Maw Pascale referencing having spoken to Hellen Belle Calloway, but because Hellen—a truly crazed occultist, a Satanist, not a Mennonite nor Christian by any stretch, her isolated and living in an underground trailer megastructure down in the Pascale Mountain bottom, deep in the McShan Woods—she never used the phone, the thing was. Typically, Hellen would rely on walking to the edge of the woods and grabbing an ear as well as that damn Raven of hers, Ezekiel, her using it as a two-way police scanner, receiving and sending signals within the air, McShan Woods Satanic SIGNIT.

Iddy was also shocked because she had Mennonites trawling the woods with guns, these people better at reconnaissance work than

Finnish snipers in the dark forests of Europe. There was a fortification with machine guns—how the hell did this fake Indian get down there with his sister?

And so that was the truth of the matter: there was a go*t*damn Mennonite crow cult in Pickens County and it *did* have to do with Pickens County in particular and that so-called, putative face in the window. Our Itragene wasn't kinda right—she was absolutely correct about a thing that a select and situated number of Big Iddy's hands in Pickens County knew and feared.

The truth was, while Big Iddy thought she were in control of this subset of the local and apparent Mennonite population, they had other plans, plans that they had had a long time before they started working as a collective hand for the McShan Mafia, plans hatched in Mexico and nursed in Indiana.

How had the chosen one from the Columbus, Mississippi, orphanage gotten past them, the local meth head who was a fake Indian and a faggot, too? They had purposely let their guard down, simple as, allowing Peter Zook, alias "Columbus Chulahoma," to walk down to the bottom and discover what they all called "HQ." Maddie, in fact, never made it to the bottom by her own accord and with her own legs, but, indeed, she was, in fact and eventually carried to the bottom and then, with Columbus, to a house alongside Columbus, them on whicker stretchers.

"The *fuck—how, how the fuck* did they find it? And how did they get past security? I'm gonna kill my grandmama for letting this happen—bet'chu she's just did it to fuck with me and because she wanted attention, always that shit with her. Was the water let out?" Iddy demanded answers, and those were the first questions that she had, as to whether or not the bottom hole had been filled and how the fuck they got past at least one-hundred sharp shooters in the McShan Woods. The water was only typically let out early-morning the third Tuesday of the month through late-Wednesday afternoon, Tuesday there needing to be ventilation so that they could cook copious

amounts of bread in one of the five trailers tacked together at the bottom of the trailer castle megastructure.

"It's Friday of the third week of March. I think they were down there celebrating Ides of March. It sounded like a lot of commotion when she called. I think they were eating their ergot bread," Peggy said, and that was accurate, though a guess on her part.

"Ergot bread" is what Peggy and Iddy called the LSD-laced Mennonite bread that Iddy sold by way of the medicine man to knowing customers, the medicine man being the local eccentric who drove that van of his with paintings of black and white-spotted cows feeding little pink piglets milk with large baby milk bottles, selling "Ergot bread" and other things like "rattlesnake butter."

Big Iddy did, though, know about their syncretism, superficially, knew about the local Mennonites who weren't Mennonites—yet another damn instance of something not being what it looks like in Pickens, something said that wasn't true but everybody believed—but she had half of a less of an idea as to what they got up to, her knowing they worshipped the Devil like her, but she just thought she was better than them and that whatever occultism she were up to was much better and so, an elitist, she stupidly didn't' investigate further—a *real* hermeticist, she was, Big Iddy thought of herself, an expert in Ancient Egypt and the traversal of the hermetic tradition to Europe, where it was taken up by theosophers like French-Egyptian Sufi Réne Guénon and those theosophical thinkers were taken up by political fascists, such as Italian Julius Evola, who had favor at varying times with both Adolf Hitler and Benito Mussolini.

They practiced mushroom magic, adherents to a doctrine they had inherited from María Sabina. There was a cult in town, indeed, a crow-obsessed sand face-in-the-window obsessed Mennonite cult that called itself a mysterious name only the crows and the raven, Ezekiel, knew. They had no power without their being a pawn in the schemes of Thaddeus' legacy carried on by his grandchild, Big Iddy, the McShan Mafia.

"So, that cunt, my grandmother, Hellen, she picked up a phone? Livid doesn't describe it, Peggy. We're gonna have to get Ugly involved and I can't be the one to reach out to her, so you gotta figure..." Iddy was surprised and spinning, saying the first thing that came to mind, no tactical approach to strategy in sight.

At the mention of "having to get Ugly involved," the FBI agents in Birmingham howled so loud you could probably hear it from the Mississippi Golden Triangle.

"What about Roy? I mean, still stupid, but come on!"

The blonde FBI agent said that to her colleagues, hooting, and a red-headed woman was walking in, another agent fresh to her shift. "What's so damn funny?" She asked, getting settled.

The Black guy said, "Big fucking Iddy is about to open a can of whoop-ass on herself.""I thought we had another few months with that one before she broke," the red-headed lady said, drinking a Krispy Kreme coffee and putting a whole glazed donut in her mouth.

"No, get this," the blonde woman said, turning around in her swivel chair to the redhead. "She's gonna fucking murder somebody, way it sounds as of now and, get this...She's gonna use go*t*damn Ugly to do it!""No way," the redhead said choking on her doughnut and continuing with her mouth full, "She just literally used her in Palmetto for whatever that joker's name is—Clarke?—but anyway, yeah, Palmetto murder and she drove her fucking four wheeler there *with the murder weapon tied to the front of the four wheeler* and it was a garden hoe, covered in blood! She's so fucking sick, a goddamn garden hoe? My god, this state. The idiot left a trail of blood from the scene along her four wheeler path—she'

s smarter than Iddy, and I think she knows we're all watching and are not gonna touch her, for now, probably waiting to be recruited as an informant, no loyalty—her name is too true, hah. She really is so ugly! But anyway, yeah, like, the goddamn murder weapon garden hoe—it was *covered in blood*, from what I saw in the photos that the field agent sent. She went to the *goddamn Carrollton Food Mart* and *got a*

fucking biscuit and soda the morning of the murder, *with the bloody murder weapon on her damn four wheeler in the parking lot there in downtown Carrollton*. Did you know that? Did you read the report? Dying. I am dying! She is so stupid."

"*Shhh*, put your headphones on. Let's listen," the Marvin, these agents' boss, said."Can you fetch Ugly, Peggy?"

Drunk and dumb Big Iddy was asking.

Hellen, the prominent woman who was the apparent human mate of the raven called Ezekiel, usually met Maw Maw Pascale up near the edge of Pascale's giant, dipped yard that was set on a series of ridges atop the mighty hills of the lot of McShan land she owned. They had many an evening exchange, not everyday, but always at the same time, a coordinated dance, the same time it'd be when they met, them meeting at what people around there called a "scrap pit," Maw Maw Pascale's scrap pit, a form of redneck composting where you take your leftovers you won't eat and other organic kitchen refuse and throw it in a pitted area, usually off your backyard on the edge of the woods, a small pitted area on the edge of the woods that was grease-slicked and where stray cats, roaming dogs, raccoons, 'possums and more would eat up the scraps.

"I'll get my son to tell Ugly—how soon do you need her and what are we even doing? But yeah, sure did talk to her just now—just right now. She called me just a time ago, not long ago. I figured you were still busy dealing with the Hadley mess and that professor that just moved in on off Phoenix off downtown, so I wanted to go on ahead call about it now," Maw Maw Peggy Pascale said.

Iddy wasn't aware, but Maw Maw Pascale's phone line was indeed tapped by the FBI, something Maw Maw Pascale did know and it was at her will that it were done, and it amused her when she knew there was a dramatic irony to her phone calls, the other party unaware that every word was being listened to at all times by either agents in Birmingham at the FBI field office or by agents based in the Washington, D.C. offices of the Federal Bureau of Investigation,

somewhere deep in the J. Edgar Hoover Building on Pennsylvania Avenue—FBI asset Peggy Pascale, a key Pickens County informant, age seventy-two, a mildly-trained operative for the last year or so, recruited as a local in 1989 upon certain McShan Mafia affairs showing up far too often in human intelligence (HUMINT) and signals intelligence (SIGNIT) amidst their monitoring of transnational crime syndicates affiliated with the Gulf Cartel, more than they had before, the McShan Mafia long monitored, them working with the Gulf Cartel, a militarized trafficking entity based in the Mexican state of Tamaulipas, a state bordering Texas and the US border—Maw Maw Peggy Pascale had worked for Big Iddy for as long as she were in charge, so, since the mere last year, less than a year, and Peggy found that Iddy simply wasn't as smart as her grandfather, Thaddeus. As it were, upon Thaddeus' death and Iddy coming to inherit the legacy and governance of the McShan Mafia, becoming theMafia Boss, Peggy had been working for Thaddeus before—given no choice, coerced, just the way these Southern Baptist gangsters worked. Peggy was more than happy when she was recruited by the FBI in a series of bizarre instances of the Bureau trying to make safe contact to recruit her, driving back and forth on Rocky Ridge, trying to draw her attention, that and other various measures that led to a fateful Pizza Doctor meeting in Carrollton on a loud night, a CUS football game night, her agreeing to be an informant over copious garlic sticks, them, the FBI, dropping in from Birmingham to recruit her, her a patriot and a proud of American who believed in the American Experiment, a Reagan Republican but not a total bigot, to her credit, somebody already ideologically aligned with the intelligence agencies in the States, compromised, as well, and thus pliable into recruitment, given her working relationship with Big Iddy, Peggy Pascale, against her will, deeply embedded in local machinations, her family there in McShan for generations, working with the McShan Mafia since Thaddeus founded it in 1940, the year his wife disappeared and his youngest child, were born.

"Well, first thing's first—I want you to get that Nokia mobile phone and take it the fuck away from Hellen. She ain't got no fucking business using no goddamn phone. And we're going to deal with Hadley, finally at last—and the rest of Pickens better get the message: Stop fucking around and being a bunch of busybodies. I cannot believe my cunt granny called you, can't believe e it's come to this. I guess I'm glad she didn't wait to see you tomorrow. We need to act this weekend. We gotta take care of Hadley and let's go ahead and pull the trigger on setting up Peter Zook with that house. Thank you for calling, Peggy—that was good Judgment."

Peggy rolled her eyes at this artificial charm that wasn't charming at all, her truly a Pentecostal woman who loved Jesus, so she hated Iddy, and she also hated to hear such language about her "cunt granny." She hated cussin'.

"Next, get that phone away from her and then you gon' need to reach out to Iddy indirectly. She had the NDA and contract at the cabin. It's already been updated and set just in case—good thing, too, considering," Iddy said.

Peggy didn't tell Iddy that she had spoken to somebody else, too, just minutes before she called her up, holding in laughter and prepping herself first in the bathroom mirror with cold water, a slap, and a hearty laugh as well as brief prayer time with Jesus, who she assumed would find it funny, wishing she could hear her Lord God, hear the voice of a god, but she didn't, 'cuz she wasn't as crazy as a lot around here—just having hung up the phone with Hellen, she had just been at her scrap pit behind her big tin shed in her backyard at the edge of the woods, next to a path that went by ways of a long, steeply downhill walk to the Pascale Mountain bottom. She had talked to the local Mexican Mennonite midget named Jesús McCoy, a man of faith and peace like Peggy. She sure did talk to him, and she didn't mention this to Big Iddy, but she sure had, had mighty a word, in fact, had a mighty word there, at her scrap pit, a mighty word exchanged between these two allies out here in these dark parts of North-Central West Alabama

on the Mississippi border, the McShan Woods, the heart of darkness of Pickens County.

Nobody loved the face in the window as much as Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley, loved it so much it'd kill her, that lynching mob's biggest fan.

She had a very special coffee mug, a keepsake and souvenir, and it said across its brim, "Save the Face in the Window," and when you put a hot liquid in it, like coffee, well: Henry Wells' wailing face would appear on the mug, heat-activated. She had precisely two cups of black coffee everyday in her Black man mug upon waking. She had grapefruit every morning, had for years, sitting in her sun room, in Carrollton, Alabama, right near the downtown square, a delicious, Mexican Ruby Red grapefruit with Domino sugar, a huge haul of them delivered to her door every Saturday and Wednesday morning by the local traveling merchant who worked for Big Iddy who everybody called "the medicine man," known around town for his offerings, driving a conspicuous vehicle that had these goofy cartoon cows feeding baby pigs with bottles that sat on the cows' knees.

Her home was a shrine to that cherished lynching ghost story window. She collected her "Henry curios," as she called them and had all in her home, every room and the main hallway, too, and the garden was not left out, either (the Black gnome she had that she called Henry, my word, just incredible stuff), her Henry stuff, just random shit like the sticker she had on her bathroom window that was Henry's face, some baby clothes that said "A Henry by my mama's hand, a Carrollton Native by the Grace of God." There were also posters, of which she had a few copies of one print that said, "See you in the Square!" and that had Henry Dancing like a Bojangles, advertising a lunch special at a chicken place over in Gordo—a poster from Mule

Day ‘89. She had this portrait, a watercolor, and it depicted Thaddeus Sinclair Calloway Jr. standing under the window, Henry looking down upon him with clear and cartoon favor, the smile itself was a racist rendering, and nothing but projection from these slack jawed ingrates... (Truth told!) Jane Ellen, up in the attic, she had Henry curios which were out of season, too, like her Ho-Ho-Ho in the Window Henry Wells Black Santa Clause cookie jar. Her home was full of objects with Henry Wells' supposed face screen-printed on them or embroidered, these among other novel and experimental means of transferring that image to surfaces—no lightning, though, an act of God they were just never able to replicate though they repeated the story non-stop, happy and proud of it like a rain dance for their heritage, but it was a ritual and dance they’d do about a lightnin’ fireball in an all-of-an-Alabama sudden thunderstorm in 1876, no telling what they expected to get from the dancing by then, by this point in their long history of the rituals of the legend and its legacy, their repeated—and gleefully celebrated lynching over and over again of the ghost of Henrry Wells—when it all had begun to unravel around them and undid what they had tied themselves up in it in the name of legacy and as an affront to history, the legend and the legacy, as it was always with these deranged white people and the twilight of their lynching ghost story window that they loved so much and carried on about so goddamn much—the legacy, the legacy, the legacy... on and on they’d go.

Like this, for years, Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley had been eating her grapefruit, enjoying her morning joe, doing so with a pursed-wrinkly lip smile staring at her elephant ears and hostas plants, her hydrangeas and black-eyed Susans, her back yard an absolute elaborate garden, one maintained by a Black man who she called “boy.” Her house and her beautiful garden and her lovely sun room were just a hop and a skip of two blocks from the old, haunted county courthouse, a legend she was maintaining at that point, taking on the mantle after Thaddeus passed.

Mrs. Jane Ellen, her neck was crooked, like she had scoliosis but only in her neck—she got that way because she had been rubbernecking a lynching story all her life, adjusting her head just like so to see the face in the window; sometimes even meditating with her head like that, her just obsessed with this window, obsessed her whole life, finding herself all her adult life standing there in the square, crows pecking at her, injuring her sometimes, in total zen looking at her lynched ghost face that she loved so much, looking at it so long you'd think she had voices in her head, too, but she didn't, it actually mostly silent, her dumb as drywall; it was her favorite ghost story, her so proud of being behind its legacy in any regard, so proud of her work, her town, her county for having this ingenuity to create something like a heat-activated lynching mug, a brilliant way to raise money, money all that mattered, under the surface in Pickens County, a whole subterranean world the gristle of the bones that held up the place.

So it was that Big Iddy was a Southern mafia crime boss, and, too, Mrs. Hadley, Mrs. Jane Ellen-the-church lady Hadley was one of her hands, worked for her, worked for that horrible Iddy, one of her goons, dumb Jane Ellen, "local historian," a really dumb runner and, until coming into her responsibilities as director of the Window Watchers, a low-level messenger woman, doing that for many years, just like so many other rich people in Pickens, that the deal, always had been, it seemed, none of them knowing who else did the running, all coordinated by Ugly, in fact, the famous Ugly of Pickens, the woman called Ugly on the ground and Iddy from Tuscaloosa at the top. Nobody important, not a single important person making significant progress in the community on whatever it was that they were on about, none liked to see her coming; they'd be going about their business, and then there'd come that Jane Ellen, on business, and their stomach would drop, at least since she started taking more direct orders from Iddy, rising in the ranks, those in the know basically knowing, it obvious, but in a paranoid environment with few confirmation signals, the "dumbest, dumbest, stupidest fucking bitch" Iddy "had ever

known, ever." Jane Ellen made a particular face at people whom she approached on business, when she was sent by Iddy, one of nausea, dissociation and disbelief.

She hated her life and also Ugly, hated working with her.

Exploiting that Thaddeus had, as a dying final directive to the Pickens County business community, put Mrs. Hadley in charge of the legacy, at least for a time, as all of Pickens County learned, including Mrs. Hadley, when a mousy, worried looking woman had read one evening after his death in '93 at a Chamber of Commerce meeting held in a fellowship hall of a Gordo Southern Baptist congregation, read his parting wishes, expressed his parting wishes: "And to Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley of Carrollton, Alabama, the County of Pickens, I bestow the honor and responsibility to shepherd the legacy of the face in the window, the Pickens County Courthouse and, at large, the town of Carrollton, the seat of Pickens. I know that Mrs. Hadley will make us all proud as the new, inauguration of the Window Watchers, a non-profit to be set up in my name posthumously, funded by a gracious set of anonymous donors."

The "anonymous donors" were himself, with his giant inheritance to which only that monster, Iddy, had access, affiliate white power drug running gangs and the Gulf Cartel subsidiaries with which Thaddeus and the McShan Mafia had been dealing quite intensely since the 1970s, the McShan Mafia around as long as 1940, the year Thaddeus' wife ran off into the McShan Woods, never to be seen again, as the story went, but wasn't true, her and Thaddeus frequently making trips to Mexico to spend time together and conduct business, having a direct line to the Mexican President his entire criminal career, Thaddeus. Thaddeus was no widower, but the whole county and state thought he was, CIA, too; only Iddy and Ugly knew Hellen Belle Calloway was alive, well, and undercover with the local Mennonites, Thaddeus and then Iddy's embedded agent.

It was Saturday afternoon, and her morning grapefruit and pleasant garden vista seemed years ago, seemed like a dream, Mrs. Hadley felt.

She wasn't at home, but in a dark kitchen with wooden walls, floors and ceiling, a low ceiling in a rickety house, an old log cabin, nowhere near her nice home in downtown Carrollton's residential area. She was deep in the McShan Woods.

"Not that much," Jane Ellen muttered, worried, looking in the giant envelop she had again to make sure that she hadn't missed any cash.

"How much?" Ugly grumble asked.That *ole*' Ugly was eating a shiny bologna sandwich and grunting, her body making disturbing noises as gasses passed between her organs.

"$750," Jane Ellen said as she put a thick rubber band around a unit of $500 and worryingly also restrained with a rubber band the remaining $250, having to twist the band twice, the amount so thin.

They were sitting in a cabin deep in the McShan Woods, near downtown McShan No. 1, off the little strip of a road where the old, run-down school bus was. It was a basic cabin, one-bedroom, a safe house and also where the McShan Mafia kept money, some key documents, weapons and drugs as well as, sometimes, trafficked fruit that didn't sell, which Mrs. Hadley would can and preserve, giving it to Ugly who'd give it to the medicine man who would sell at county fairs and flea market the goods out the back of his cows-and-milk bottle-baby pig cartoon van.

Ugly, who had white bread sandwich particles in her teeth, her fingers dirty with mustard got up, poured another glass of sweet tea. She took a gun out of her waistband, which she had stored near her cooter and had forgotten was there until it jabbed her near her cooter hole.

"Ow, fuck, *shit*," said Ugly, real ugly-like, too, just how she talked, grunted. She said this, that to which Jane Ellen rolled her eyes. Ugly sounded like an old dog, just constant noise coming from her mouth, stomach, her whole body, including, when it was quiet, a faint whistle coming from her nose hole, her breathing through her little whale hole on her face.

She had just collected the money, Ugly, bringing it to the cabin and

meeting Mrs. Hadley, her giant Town Car parked near the lake that was next to the clandestine work cabinet when Ugly arrived on her four-wheeler, which she used as her primary mode of transportation, rain or shine, wearing her sunglasses.

One of the ways that Big Iddy laundered money through the face in-the-window—in a sense, the number of avenues within which money flowed that was somehow about the window being one way to launder money, simply put—was a photobooth of sorts that had been set up outside of the courthouse on the north side lawn. Real tourists would come through and use it, also McShan Mafia and Gulf Cartel-affiliated gang members.

Mrs. Hadley herself was usually the one with the key and who acted on behalf of the Window Watchers. She was a mule, one of the many face in the window mules across Pickens that were celebrated at the annual Mule Day in Gordo, basically every public facet of Pickens County life holding double meaning for its elites, secret code like "Mule Day" everywhere.

That day morning, Ugly had taken on the task because Jane Ellen was worried that Professor van de Tuffin, the failure "crow expert" from Tulane, might notice something, that day, it not a normal day for picking up, her having received instructions from Iddy that she was being watched, no further detail given.

Could it be Kevin, Katherine, maybe?

The sociologist had gotten increasingly nosy, after all, too, so maybe she was the watcher about whom Iddy enigmatically warned her, but she was mostly worried it were Kevin because they spent an ungodly amount of time together, her only really seeing Katherine at meals that Mrs. Hadley hosted at her home for her new *professah friends*, her home or social events.

It was ugly, actually and it was Ugly, properly, what was going on: Ugly was the one watching her.

Getting home from the McShan cabin working with Ugly, that Saturday night, Jane Ellen came inside, in from under her sun room

backdoor from the garden, walking in from the car port, two cement strips and a covering with lots of ivy and hanging plants. She came in and put her purse down on the coffee table before the couch. It was dark.

Ugly, in her sunglasses and on her back, was pretending to take a nap on the sofa in the cabin when Jane Ellen left the cabin, but she had tailed her on her four wheeler, then speeding ahead by way of another route, getting in position.

Jane Ellen put her purse on the coffee table, a moment passed, and that's when Ugly snuck up on her, hopping down from a ceiling rafter with a rifle and a little jagged grapefruit spoon.

Itragene wasn't there when Columbus dropped off Maddie that Saturday morning, around 10am. Itragene had been turning right off the downtown Reform strip, instead, around then that morning, passing the downtown Reform water fountain in front of the Dollar General, as she got headed east towards Carrollton on Highway 17, intending to stop at the produce market, for one, a farm stand called Clay's Produce between Carrollton and Reform, where she intended to buy some beans or peas, some handful of something; she intended to use these dried legumes as a tool for enumeration, for tallying her damn shekels, intending on using different legumes for different subtypes of shekels she was counting. Secondly, she was heading to Carrollton to go to the public library to do something she hadn't done in a bit, look at old newspapers on the microfilm machine—and microfiche, her knowing how to use both, Jane Ellen never able to get her spatial reasoning around centering the microfiche properly, unlike smart Itragene. Since childhood, Itragene and Jane Ellen had always been competitive, though it was no competition.

So, first, she needed to go get some beans for her evolving shekel

math practice—she needed a new abacus. When it came to the legumes as shekel enumerates, for instance, she was thinking on the drive over, she could use butter beans for synchronicities like the Lavender Pest Control incident, and she could use black-eyed peas for what felt like moments when the universe seemed to be shouting at her, in reality those moments being delusions of reference, very common in advanced bipolar disorder with psychotic features.

Here she was going to buy beans to count her shekels, the fallen daughter of this gentry family.

She had dressed nicely for the occasion—she was going to go mission to people, testify as to what she knew the Lord had shown her in the messages of the the so-called Assembly of Israel, that cast of hallucinated characters in her head. She was wearing a nice tweed jacket and a wool skirt, remnants of her prior life as a Southern Belle.

She arrived at Clay's Produce Stand and began to tell everybody in the most casual manner ever: "Did you know that there's a Mennonite crow- and face in the window-cult?

That's what she said to the bewildered and now alarmed people shopping for early spring season greens like collards, said it all sorts of ways, Itragene, acting crazy, noticeably so.

This was not, however, like other times when she was on about something aberrant and mostly not based in reality, acting crazy in public as she famously did—the business owners who worked the floor at the farm market were terrified of what she was saying, them being business owners compromised their entire tenure, opening in the 80s, compromised by Big Iddy, who had worked for Thaddeus until he left her in charge, taking on the books for her grandfather when he died.

There was actually a widely known secret amongst the power players in Pickens. It wasn't that they all secretly knew about the Mennonite cult, but they did know about whatever she was going on about, her going on about *machinations,* and these people knew you didn't go and discuss, ever, the machinations of Picklens. She was saying that, calling a shekel aligned all too well with their suspicions

of the Mennonites, and, them familiar with the actual levers of power in town, they knew Itragene was opening up a can of deep shit—for all of them,

"The two main shekels," she was telling a man who was an attorney in town, distantly related.

"I'm sorry, Itragene, you have done and gone and truly lost me. I am just a simple country lawyer.

This man was lying to her, lying his face off, scared and worried as hell, worried an order of things were unwinding, something that he couldn't help but think was going to be violent, if it came to pass.

"*Shekels*—things that count, not about money...—the two main ones I have right now I earned all on Wednesday," she was going on, beaming, sharing the Good News of Henry Wells the Black Jesus ghost story wkdnow man, explaining, as well, how "disappointing shekel hunting has been the last day, though."

She explained the two of them, explained them so much, what she considered her heftiest shekels, and that was the first three she had all earned regarding encountering the Lavender Pest Control trucks in Gordo on her way to Carrollton the other morning, her nearly crashing into one of those bug trucks, and her seventh shekel, "lucky seven," she said with a knowing glance, like everybody knew about angel numbers and the like.

"You do know that they're antisemites, the Lavender Pest Control people."

She spoke of true but abstract, hidden things that alarmed those busying about the store, busying about until they stopped in their tracks, listening to her manic ravings.

The thing was: everybody who had to launder money for Iddy found themselves, at some point, making an uncomfortable and high-stress delivery to the Lavender Pest Control trucks, which sometimes had guns in them, Ruby Red grapefruits, meth, even children—yes, Iddy not above that whatsoever.

It was all surreal and brutally violent and native to the region,

trafficking in so many forms.

Organized crime was how lots happened in Pickens and how some lots in life were assigned. She was sensing something real, a stir: there was a stir occurring in the air in Pickens County, power angered. She had no idea it was her daughter pulling the strings nor did she have any idea that her father was up to no good beyond Klan membership. She thought he was going to Montreal when he travelled, but he had only ever been there once. He owned several homes in Mexico, two expansive apartments in Mexico City, one in La Condesa and the other in Hidalgo, near the finest university in Latin America, UNAM; he owned homes in the country, like Tepotzlán, right outside of Mexico City, as well as in Northern Mexico in Matamoros, just across from Texas, a border town.

She got a bunch of different dried legumes in neat bags and high-tailed it to Carrollton proper, Clays between Reform and Carrollton.It was newspaper time.

Itragene was onto something, but it wasn't quite a "Mennonite cult" like she thought—there was a hybrid sect in town, hybridizing once it arrived, this sect of Mennonites from Indiana, but, though the Pentecostals often helped them out, this was a Mexican affair, too.

About 1am...Monday...John Henry had exhaled as he always did when he got a call from EMS like this one, knowing it was showtime and that Pickens County, Alabama, needed him—they thought he should see what they had found, and it was Mrs. Hadley's address, where they directed him to go.

Another Pickens County atrocity and it was his job to make sure all appearances in death were kept.

It was about 11pm, Saturday evening.

When John Henry arrived at Mrs. Hadley's downtown Carrollton home, police were everywhere, EMS, two ambulances, three fire trucks. All Pickens County services from all places in Pickens were there and if they weren't they were on their way, all-hands-on-deck: Mrs. Hadley had been shot in the head with a rifle, possibly over morning grapefruit, sometime between Wednesday and Saturday all they knew, when the body was discovered by Mrs. Hadley's gardener that Saturday night, our Itragene's Bessie's cousin, Garland Jones.

Not only had she been shot, as John Henry was seeing with his own eyes, but she had been stuffed with grapefruit—every cavity, as stuffed as could be with grapefruit, some cut up into slices to fit into nooks and crannies, some grapefruit meat and other material just rind, zest, some places stuffed with the whole ball, the whole fruit, whole Ruby Red grapefruits, it unclear if she were stuffed after being shot dead with a rifle or if they tortured her by Mexican Ruby Red grapefruit first—it definitely sent a message that grapefruit could be dangerous in Carrollton, most well-to-do folks knowing those delicious Ruby Reds were trafficked by Iddy.

The sight was awful to behold, one of the worst because the overall scene was so *ugly*, what an awful thing to happen, either tortured by being stuffed with Mexican grapefruits or shot first and defiled afterwards between citrus and grapefruit spoon violence; he wasn't sure how he'd pull this one off, and the EMS knew it would be a difficult funeral, and so they called him and let him in on moving the wreckage so they didn't break any more glass than necessary, and Jane Ellen's body was totaled: trigly and without flair he'd call it "putting toothpaste back in the tube," what he called these kinds of jobs, situations where somebody had blown up bigger than they were and he had to put everything back inside and make it small again and, very importantly, downstream of a good understanding of mass versus weight, make it turgid, not limp with mushed up remains merely shoved back into cavities of the body where meat with integrity had been prior, but turgid, life-life, situations like this much more difficult

than inflating somebody who was, say, flattened by a transfer truck, like his renowned work with the Johnson sisters, the flat sisters of Gordo.

John Henry had had it, at that point. He was sick of being the reliable gentleman's faggot. He was sickened by this violence, knowing exactly who was behind it—Big Iddy. This is the day John Henry changed in fundamental ways, becoming a better person, and, all the while, a little crazy. You had to be crazy to turn your back on Big Iddy if she owned you.

It was Saturday evening and she had wrapped up the latest draft of her manifesto, which she was calling "Lots and Lots for the Lot of You Lot," wrapping up about an hour ago. Satisfied, feeling accomplished, the busiest unemployed person in Alabama, there she was, sitting in her chair at her bay window table with her police scanner, as was Itragene's way, what she did and was known to do.

It was 7pm, having just gotten dark, the sun setting about thirty minutes earlier; she was rocking back and forth and Maddie came upon her, having just gotten home, popping by the house to change clothes after her shift at the Piggly Wiggly, tipsy, having had a strong beer and some vodka with Columbus in the Piggly Wiggly parking lot, coming home and seeing her mama, all the lights off in the house, like she always found her mama, seeing her mama when she got there rock back and forth in the red beam of light coming off the police scanner out the window, from the street, saw her from the street, where one of her many boyfriends had just dropped her off on the corner next to the house.

Maddie walked in the car port door, made her way to the sun room, turning on a lamp when she crossed he threshold.

"Mama, what are you doin'?"

Maddie was taking her bra off and standing in the sun room confused as hell at the sight of her mother, who was acting even weirder than usual.

She was moving in a weird way—technically called stereotypy,

common in psychosis—really rapidly, like how birds move, or a beetle. Her mama looked like a bug, siting there, just acting strange and bug-like, Maddie having no other way to put it, as she took in the scene and tried to narrate it for herself.

"I'm counting my shekels."

"You're...wha—huh?"

Communicating with intensity, being guided by the assembly of Israel, the gang of characters inside of her, all whom Maddie couldn't see, and all of whom constituted an extra layer of reality through which Itragene sieved her perception, whom she often felt in her face, their facial expressions mapping onto her facial flesh, mirror-touch synesthesia, technically, that mixed with some dissociative identity issues. She started to ask Maddie—over and over, stereotypically, clearly psychotic, something really wrong—a question, sounding like a replica of Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, a voice Maddie instantly recognized, given her mother's obsession with the Supreme Court Justice and her endless recordings of her television appearances from her nomination the year prior, 1993, Itragene going, "Are we settling into being unsettled? Are we settling into getting unsettled? Are we settling into being unsettled?"

Over and over, "Are we getting settled into being unsettled?"

She laughed maniacally between asking this question she was getting from Ginsburg's voice and also a generic character in the Assembly of Israel, some entities in her mental landscapes anonymous and shadowy, generic like this; she was emulating a rabbi from Brooklyn, roughly: "'Are we getting settled into being unsettled?'"

Maddie about had a heart attack—her mama had really lost it, finally, she was thinking.

"Mama, I—"—a statement Itragene snapped in half, inserting herself.

"Stop, bitch! Devil cunt! I'm counting my shekels; I need to count my shekels—stop, stop," Itragene was agitatedly saying.

Maddie was officially scared. She tried speaking again, cut off

again by Itragene.

"You don't know shekel math and you don't understand what you're talking about, because you don't have anything that adds up to anything at the end of the day; you don't know what's real and I do, and the Assembly of Israel is mad as hell at you, Maddie."

"Mama, you're not making any fucking sense right now and you're scaring me."

"Go to bed, bitch! Get outta here! Out of order, that's what you are, buddy, girl, sister, bitch: you're out of order; this is a court of law, out of order, time and line; we're over here trying to count our shekels and you come to me like this, you disturb us! And that's what we're doing, we're counting our shekels, and no—I know you're an antisemite, but it's not about money, wrong, that's how you've gotten it; shekel math is necessary and it's keeping track of those things that matter, all of it, all that you see out there, because you've gotta make sense out of it! If it doesn't add up to anything, then it probably didn't make sense in the first place, and, if you're up to no good trying to be great, you won't be counting your shekels, getting cocky! You count your shekels and it keeps you humble, no telling when it can be taken away and then nothing adds up anymore!"

Maddie called Iddy in the kitchen, leaving her mother rocking back and forth blathering, the cacophony of the police scanner cradling the whole scene.

Ddld—Prrrrk..."10-4."

"OK."

Ddld—Prrrrk…—it was so loud, the analog local Pickens County police scanner frequency, echoing off the Gordo windows of the Alabama sun room.

"All clear—10-42, heading to Jack's."

"We're gonna have a 10-33 if you keep getting that for supper every evening, fatass."

Ddld—Prrrrk...—several people laughed over the channels, a woman and three men.

Maddie, on the other side of the house, couldn't hear the scanner and she was glad, she was glad she couldn't' see her mother for a moment, though she was so alarmed, it just a real disturbing scene, and, of course, tending to the matter, it having boiled over.

"The FUCK are you calling me on a goddamn SATURDAY NIGHT WHEN YOU KNOW—" Iddy was yelling, spitting mad as she answered the phone and recognized Maddie's desperate voice.

Maddie immediately broke into tears, bawling, holding her yellow kitchen phone with the long cord.

"Iddy, I'm so sorry...Iddy, it's mama. Something is wrong, really wrong…"

"Is she dead?"

"No, no, nothing like that—"

"Then I don't give a shit, Maddie."

"Iddy," Maddie, softly said, softly crying, her in the kitchen with the phone with the long cord, hoping Itragene didn't pursue her to that part of the house, who was, now, barging into the kitchen quoting Phil Donahue daytime talk show episodes.

Ktherine had the "Jeffrey Recordings" that Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley had in her home—something John Henry swiped because Jane Ellen had instructed him to grab it from her bedroom if she ever died of mysterious causes—she had a kill switch, and it was John Henry. He grabbed it when the EMS had summoned him.

Katherine had listened doggedly to these tapes—tapes where she was talking to Jeffrey the Poltergeist

By this time, days after her death, Katherine already had a rudimentary analysis of the Jeffrey Recordings. Jeffrey kept calling her an idiot, to sum up. She did so with few words—pride, heritage, legend, history, legacy and idiot. In all of what he said to her, which was delivered as audible in the recording by Jane Ellen's muttering to herself, those nouns were linked together with different prepositions and they all made one basic argument: the Face in the Window is only as such because of idiots protecting their Old South legacy as the local history of this legend as their heritage.

This is what Katherine determined was "The Idiocy in the Pride in the Heritage of the Legend as the History of the Legacy," the title of an essay she was writing about Mrs. Hadley's life as a local historian, one of the first inevitable academic articles to be born, Katherine prolific and often put out multiple journal articles in peer-reviewed publications a year.

If Jane Ellen had her schwa e and our Itragene her Shekel Math and Lots Logic, and if the Mennonites, too, had their Mennonite Bread and the whole county could throw the Look and, likewise, they all loved the Face in the Window and the Flat Sisters of Gordo, then Katherine—so amused at herself and the subject matter—came up with her own meme, calling it IDIOTICS, which is the art of optimizing for idiocy as a historical aesthetic and memetics of heritage.

Katherine's notebook was full of writings, mostly just permutations of the same idea, a chain of nouns—pride, heritage, legend, history and legacy—arranged with prepositions in a manner where the endless permutations said the same thing in an equation of idiocy as an optimization of pride in the heritage of the legend as the history of the legacy.

The consistent output of this language game is the same: there is idiocy.

Her thoughts were as such, after she ironed out a first draft:

Idiocy in the following formulation is not a trait but a protocol.

It is a sequence of memes ritualized as a bit that a whole community can commit to.

I propose "The Idiocy Chain of Pickens County Memetics." A heritage epistemology made of chained familiar nouns: PRIDE ◦ HERITAGE ◦ LEGEND ◦ HISTORY ◦ LEGACY. Put them into a sentence and make the topic idiocy: PRIDE ◦ HERITAGE ◦ LEGEND ◦ HISTORY ◦ LEGACY → IDIOCY.

The result is the same. It is non-commutable; ordering matters but there is a diverse range of positive valence permutations as natural human language units such as sentences and paragraphs.

Here are a few permutations, with emphasis, listed and presented in a nice visual manner:

There is idiocy *in the pride in the heritage* of the legend as the history of the legacy.

In the pride of the legend was idiocy *as the heritage of the history* of the legend.

Of the history in the pride in the legend was an idiocy *as the legacy of their heritage*.

In the pride of heritage as the history was an *idiocy as the legacy of the legend*.

These things—heritage, legend, history, legacy—in certain combinations in their relation to one another is the ontology of an optimized idiocy that is the nature of the situation with the Face in the Window. In everyday language it is the prepositions—of / in / as / for / by—that operate on the notions as functions that retype relations.

A PARAGRAPH OF NATURAL LANGUAGE PROSE QUA IDIOTICS:

Here is the idiolect between Jane Ellen Hadley and "Jeffrey" fully executed in permutation, as prose: There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the legend as the history of the legacy. There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the legend as the legacy of the history. There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the history as the legend of the legacy. There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the history as the legacy of the legend. There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the legacy as the legend of the history. There is idiocy in the pride in the heritage of the legacy as the history of the legend. There is idiocy in the pride in the legend of the heritage as the history of the legacy. There is idiocy in the pride in the legend of the heritage as the legacy of the history. There is idiocy in the pride in the legend of the history as the heritage of the legacy. There is

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Further considerations as to retyping as the prepositional function:

in (enclose) → sets scope;
of (inherit) → confers pedigree;
as (equate) → fabricates credential;
for (aim) → directs energy to legacy;
by (author) → specifies enforcement.

"of" – possession/origin
"in" – membership/containment
"as" – equivalence/role
"for" – purpose/teleology
"by" – agency/authorship

The whole town of Carrollton had had enough when it came to the crows; Big Iddy had, just as well, had it with Mrs. Jane Ellen, who kept pissing off Big Iddy and her violent associates with shit like this crow investigation, her poking around and busy bothering just a little too much, inviting attention that Iddy did not want on Pickens County, all perceptions of Carrollton carefully put through the functions of the logic of the face in the window, a great mesmerist county affair—Dr. Mann, the Tulane sociologist, was exactly the sort of person who was not only set but capable and had enough situational awareness to accomplish blowing the lid on the face in the window, the consequential rat trap snaps of which would not stop at that window up on the third floor on the north side of the old Pickens County courthouse.

Ugly had been trailing Katherine since her second week in town at the behest of Iddy.

It had been the prior night, Maddie actually never made it to the bottom of Pascale Mountain, had never seen any trailer castle, Columbus sounding insane when he explained this to her, didn't see the giant hole that the bottom had. It was so odd, her having no recall at all of the majority of what Columbus kept trying to process with her, him trying to understand what had happened, talking about it all; himself, Columbus felt that she had been there by his side the entire time, her memory a comfort to him in a mighty terrifying moment, him so stimulated by the eggckstucksy that night that he was awake despite all the ketamine, hallucinating some stuff, such as Maddie being there, all in Columbus' little white head.

She was actually almost shot, indeed, as was Columbus, once they got to the highest poin they reached on Rocky Ridge Road prior to entering her journey ended there, for the night. But she stayed there, didn't' go to the bottom at all.

Once Columbus had hopped into the damn woods, she had actually —and this is where they got split up—smoked the goddamn joint she had had in her back pocket, the view having been too much of an aesthetic trigger and she smoked the joint and she disappeared and had had no idea what had happened when they woke up in that house, how she got there, what Columbus was talking about, her just agreeing and going along with it because this felt like more than a blackout, but something that just didn't fucking add up.

She had smoked the joint she had brought along with them when they went to watch the crows come through, that she had, and she had

lost all touch with reality staring at the face of the McShan Woods once Columbus had walked into the brush, in fact, him diving in like a toddler explorer in the McShan Woods, living up to his name, her left stuck, caught staring at all these tessellated appearances of Columbus, her coming to think outside of space and time that Columbus was Jesus, accepted him as her Lord and Savior, Columbus, and, as well, fucked up as shit, as she was high, so high, and she was speaking in tongues on Rocky Ridge Road.

"Abadalalagah minafalatarada achazsa manana!"

It was then that a Mennonite boy, or a little Mennonite man, a small figured dressed in black, it was then that this person approached her and she came to for the scantest of moments, enough too see his small form in the night.

Maddie was carrying on in the middle of that steep dirt road that ran up Pascale Mountain, Rocky Ridge Road, her speaking in tongues, moved by the Holy Ghost, she felt, and she could've been hit by a car if, oddly, one were on the road at that late hour.

The small Mennonite figure approached her, and it actually wasn't a child. It was a little person, a Mennonite midget. He was mumbling in Spanish, distinctly Mexican Spanish, "*Pinch*e *gringos*…" He muttered and grumbled.

He had an object, Maddie saw, with a little green light—a radio of sorts.

He seemed to be speaking Spanish. He *was* speaking Spanish. Something in Spanish filled the air, something Maddie didn't understand, not a speaker of it—"*Entonces, déjala a ella en la calle—no hay nada que hacer en este momento*."

Was she hearing Spanish in the air up here on Pascale Mountain?

All of the occasion then moved her; she became felicitously distraught.

She was crying, she was rejoicing, and, clearing tears from her eyes and she wound down the speaking in tongues, something that had never happened to her—she wrapped it up with a final, quiet,

"*asalamancata*, *oh*, *oh manulaha kajalmana*...A*men*n*n*."

She cleared her eyes with her hands, her throat, too, cleared her throat, and her vision began to line up, and there was this short Mennonite figure before her, standing in the middle of the road and looking like a leprechaun.

He stared at her for a moment more, realized she had come to a bit, and he ran away, running up Rocky Ridge Road, visible for Maddie to see in the faint light, his rapid little footsteps audible, too.

He stared at her and, then, quickly spirted away, and she'd just barely seen him.

She straight up didn't believe it, him looking too much like those two twin girls in *The Shinning* but this creepy child-like figure was dressed like it was a Thanksgiving horror movie in the McShan Woods, too much like something from a damn movie and she didn't believe it, but he had been real, and he had went and got somebody, in fact, and while he did that she had smoked more and began to stumbled on her feet, feeling sick, and passed out in the goddamn road in the meantime, him coming back and with company, more Mennonites but of average height, and then the Mennonites, one of them a damn dwarf, darted her with the ketamine just as she got up again, stirred by a commotion of people in the road, her collapsing fully, finally, due to the ketamine dart.

They then took her to the bottom where Columbus was, toting her and then, also, Columbus, too, toting him shortly thereafter alongside with her, taking them both, ultimately, to the white big house that overlooked the field on Lower Hanks, the big white house that was soon-to-be Chulahoma's home.

Machinations were afoot. There was a granny witch at work, as the Mennonites called their local leader in Pickens County, called her "the Granny Witch."

This was Itragene's long-lost mother, in fact, understand.

Maddie had no idea how evil her grandmother was, Hellen Belle Calloway; she did run away from the hospital the day Vonnie was

born, that day in 1940, it a true Pickens County Calloway family story, Itragene ten years old, and she ran into the McShan Woods, that's what she did, ran into the McShan Woods and never re-emerged in Pickens County or regional public life, did it over a half a century earlier.

The men carrying the limp bodies of Maddie and Columbus worked for her, the missing Calloway matriarch, those under her just following orders.Itragene was like her mama in some respects—crazy and they both loved signals intelligence (SIGNIT). Helen loved that damn bird, the raven, Ezekiel, and she'd sit up all night listening to what it had heard across the region, an aviary police scanner, old school mimicry the record of regard, it turning out Itragene had something in common with her mama, the nosiness and busibodiness. In the end, this mother and daughter, Itragene Belle and her mother, Hellen Belle, they both loved *signals intelligence*.

Hellen maintained her rule through the *look*, which she had mastered.

"As above, so below," she'd so be like and she'd say, like a damn Hermetic wench that knew noting about no damn Kabbalah, no matter how won't she were to pretend she knew anything about such a thing, not even knowing how to use a whole bunch of quotations marks from the Alabama-Kabbalah outset in a situation where you need to confound the enemy with words. Hellen didn't know shit about talking.

Hellen didn't know shit, had been sitting in the woods talking to this damn bird for forever, out of her mind.

In any case, she made them walk the line, made everybody she knew do everything she wanted and it was all by looking at them a particular way.

She was full of machinations. In fact, she was the one who had called the orphanage, finding out through her ways that there was a Mennonite child at a Columbus, Mississippi orphanage, just across the state border that was just right there on the Ethelsville side of McShan, and then she set it all up. His parents, who truly did re-commit

themselves as adults to the Mennonite faith, after his birth and their surrender of him to the State of Mississippi, re-committed themselves to Mennonitism as adults to the Anabaptist tradition and the Mennonite denomination of Protestant, Northern European Christianity, true Mennonites and peaceful people, if a little mislead and ignorant regarding stuff like women, mental illness and accusations of witchcraft, as his mother had been accused in Indiana and Mississippi, Reform, too, later; they were Mennonites, sure, but this was truly a witchy, occult and Hermetic, messing-around-with-Hebrew without proper knowledge stuff that Hellen Calloway was on about in her McShan bottom trailer castle, where she'd lived for the last fifty three years, down in the McShan Woods, first in a shed and then a trailer castle.

It was with one *look* that she forced their hand, and they were left no choice, looked at a particular way and given no choice otherwise in other ways, ways of which the *look* was a warning, the final look a face can give before before friction goes truly kinetic and violence is done and injustice served, a face that comes long after deception, the lie already revealed and the carnival barker laughing at the sucker who bought their line, the sadistic face of enjoying the precipice of human creatures taking it kinetic.

It was the face of bloodlust that was a familiar mask for white people, and it was the last thing Henry Wells saw in his blessed life—*the look*.

All that, and, too, another mystery solved: she was the resident crow sitter, Hellen Calloway. The Mennonites made them circle the county square, simple as, them to blame, doing it to fuck with the locals, nothing more.

Amazingly, there seemed to be a fucking Mennonite crow cult deep on Pentecostal land in the famed McShan Woods. Itragene Belle McDaniel, Sr., of Gordo, Alabama, was, well, correct.

Just as well, lots was happening beyond Pickens that mattered.

Helen Belle Calloway was thinking about that Mennonite boy and

her sister as they woke in a house in the McShan Woods, in fact.

By mid-March, 1994, Big Iddy had decided that Jane Ellen had to go. She finalized the on the phone in a rash manner that fateful Friday evening, talking to Peggy Pascale the Saturday morning after Maddie and Columbus candy flipped in the McShan Woods, them kidnapped eventually by Mennonites who reported to Big Iddy, in fact, Iddy knowing her mama was alive because her mama was her McShan Mafia underling, in fact, though these Mennonites did not ultimately disclose all of their activities to her, the first set of fuckers to ever trick Iddy, and, eventually, they would get her good, be her downfall.

Jane Ellen had seen too much and acted rogue one too many times, the calling the University to investigate the crows the latest, and she had to go and she had to go, also, because that would be useful to Big Iddy for other reasons, specifically that it buttered her biscuit if the Window Watchers were to find itself without a clear heir to maintain the legend of the face in the window, a major responsibility, one Iddy wanted to reassign, doing just as she had planned in the early '90s with Thaddeus before he died, the two of them scheming at her big Lake Tuscaloosa abode, smoking cigars and drinking expensive amaretto.

Big Iddy had decided it was time for the closeout sale and the managed decline of the face in the window business, the jig basically being up, it having had a good century of a run. She decided this sitting at her big lake house on Lake Tuscaloosa. It was that Jane Ellen knew who the mother was of the Mennonite boy who called himself Columbus Chulahoma, Peter Zook, too, which Iddy did not want her knowing about, that damn busybody she just couldn't' fully control, and so, she had to kill her.

That was fine and well until recent events, her knowing about Columbus and his identity, but, by that Saturday morning, that "Mennonite, fake half-Choctaw, quarter-Cherokee, or whatever the fuck, that faggot done walked up on something he wasn't supposed to see, him and that whore friend he's got, my fucking piece-of-shit sister."

After she talked to Peggy on the phone, Iddy was considering it all, the decision already made and Peggy Pascale making the arrangements by way of her son that Ugly be notified she'd been given the green light from Tuscaloosa on Hadley; Iddy was considering it all, sitting on a big whicker chair on her balcony with her bitch on her knee, who she woke up to keep her company, pulled her out of bed, disrespectful as hell of her partner, her bitch, what she called her girlfriend, her "little baby bitch," going over it all in detail with the woman who she domineered as her gender expression in their relationship, an abuser's top, going over it all, smoking a cigar, same brand as Thaddeus had smoked, with her girlfriend and also on her own with her high-dollar life on her balcony tacked on her big house on Lake Tuscaloosa.

As it were, indeed, recent events had changed the status of Mrs. Jane Ellen on Big Iddy's head from "monitoring" status to "eliminate" status. She would enjoy it, but she had no choice, also. It was time, it was fate.

What Iddy would orchestrate came to be known by the Pickens County Herald headline that covered the story of what happened eventually to Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley: "The Carrollton Grapefruit Massacre." When the 13 Ghosts & Jeffrey poltergeist lady, Kathryn Tucker Windham, got wind of it all, the gruesome Hadley murder, she didn't anything to do with it, it too gruesome even for her; she wanted nothing to do with it, her, and she had treated the funeral proceedings for the flat sisters of Gordo like it was a posthumous Elvis sighting.

This is what Iddy did for a living: scheme, connivingly plot, defraud and orchestrate, familiar with the crafts of extortion, blackmail and intimidation, "sending a message" one of her favorite business

occasions because it pushed her imagination as a violent criminal, her the big boss of a racketeering, gun, drug and produce trafficking white nationalist gang that was based out of McShan and Tuscaloosa and worked so closely with the Gulf Cartel out of Mexico that they might as well have been considered an auxiliary branch of the Matamoros, Tamaulipas, branch of the Mexican trafficking organization. She was proud of what she had thought of, how she was going to have Jane Ellen Hadley not only murdered, but made a message out of, Hadley's body to be used as a warning to other Pickens personages who were within Big Iddy's realm of orbit—every politician, many civil servants, most local businesses, they all knew who ran Pickens, the Calloways. Iddy had Pickens County on lock and nobody was sure who knew what so they never spoke of it, just knowing that's how things were in this town ran by Southern Baptists and Methodists, by practice or legacy, as was the case for Big Iddy, who wasn't a believer in that sense, herself, but worked in favor of the legacy of her Southern Baptist granddaddy, Thaddeus, his Christian dominionist take on the Christian take on the Hebrew Bible, his white supremacy, a legacy she revered in regards to race, if not theology, her Satanism a secret. You could love the Devil and hate black folks, all legacy, the so-called Christians around there demons, anyway, hellhounds.

She was going to do something so disgusting with those fucking Ruby Red grapefruits from Mexico that Jane Ellen loved so much. Iddy was sick and reveled in it, a true antisocial psychopath, born that way, mean and ugly, just like her Klansman grandfather, Thaddeus.

The mystery as to where Thaddeus' money went after his death ended with Big Iddy, in fact.

Big Iddy got every single dime Thaddeus left, all half a million, setting up shell companies and inauthentic philanthropic organizations for laundering the money, the Window Watchers being one of the fraudulent non-profits through which Iddy laundered money and exercised intimidation schemes using the symbology of the face in the window, the unseen lady man captain of the big tug boat that was the

face in the window business, the business of the face in the window, its purported value added, value that was mostly cooked books, really. Big Iddy had been doing this shit for a long time; it was also Iddy who had orchestrated the clearing out of Thaddeus' money upon his death, a big orchestration and an act of stagecraft, mesmerism, forcing her Aunt Amicille into an extortion scheme to accept cash from her to buy an ostentatious airplane and a regular allowance that was to be spent on specific items to give the impression of sudden decadent wealth, more than Amicille already had, rich already, and this worked: everybody had thought Amicille had taken Thaddeus to the bank and made him sign over the money to her, that simple, and plausible, because he was suffering kidney failure-induced dementia towards the end of his life. Just as well, although Iddy wasn't driving the truck on Mule Day the summer of '93, the truck that killed the Johnson sisters. "The Flat Sisters of Gordo" was a short story of which Big Iddy was the author, like she was the protagonist in *The Shining*, her typewriter activity questionable, a writing that was a setting-up the Calloways to inherit this prominent and giant house in downtown Gordo that belonged to the Johnson sisters; it was Big Iddy, indeed, Iddy who sure did blackmail the truck driver, who was molesting his son and Iddy had proof, and he sure did run those two sisters over on purpose, blackmailed, had been driving by their house repeatedly for no real good reason, off his route, waiting on the right moment to run them right over. He absolutely hated to do it while they were planting those pretty hostas plants.

Iddy was the boss for a Southern mafia organization that Thaddeus had founded the year his youngest was born, Vonnie, 1940, the same year his wife, Itragene and w's mother, pretended to skip town: this was the McShan Mafia. They were a white power gang working with the Gulf Cartel out of Mexico all across the Southeast. She was an abusive criminal, a murderer, in fact, personality disorder-riddled, a true psychopath. And, too, she was also a huge dyke, and, and but, everybody knew it and did not fuck with her over it because everybody

in and around Tuscaloosa knew you did not cross Big Iddy.

Big Iddy was the hidden mama daddy, the patriarchal matriarch of the Calloway family and she was set on restoring the legacy of her family name—and the white race.

She was also a practicing Satanist, something few knew but was true; she was a Devil worshipper, a proper theological Satanist, an occultist like her mama's mama, Hellen, not just LaVeyian trick-or-treat costume play.

Itragene said she was Christian, but she was secretly both Jewish and Muslim, at least in her mind—she was a woman of faith, in a way, in a really weird way.

She thought a lot about that case when she made it to the hospital, our Itragene, Sr. Big Iddy and Maddie had finally had to do it, commit their crazy mother.

At the hospital, she kept herself busy, kept herself busy for about two months, eventually to be let out Mule Day 1994. The doctors didn't know what she was talking about, usually, mostly because she was too smart for them to not only keep up, but too smart in as way where she could put things out there and it not necessarily even be true, but the doctors, not encyclopedias, couldn't, really, pin her down and call her crazy for saying—too smart, and also way too esoteric, thinking the weirdest of things in their niche. The wise alley cat she was, looking like one, too, rough, she took her meds and smiled and pretended that she was sane, pretended every delusion she ever had had vanished; she was good to go, you could let her out, she insisted in her big act.

She had worked it out, years ago, when she ran for Alabama governor: Lots Logic, and it was how she was going to save the world, starting with Pickens County, by establishing a Caliphate for the Jewish People, as she amazingly thought of it, in the middle of what she called Al-Bama—yes, as in the definite article for "the" from Arabic transliterated, the amazing product of her mind, her understanding the latter half of the Arabized "Alabama," "the "Abama" in "Al-Bama," to be the phonetic equivalent to בָּמָה, or "bamáh," which is Hebrew roughly for a "high place" or a "platform," a place of worship, her treating the "a" in "Abama" to be silent, like the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet, the Alef Bet, aleph, א. She had to set up a Caliphate for the Jewish people in the name of Jesus in Pickens County—a Caliphate in Al-Bama, McShan, Ethelsville, Pickens County, Alabama, United States of America and, given that McShan was a town that wasn't a town that had two downtowns, also a Caliphate at Al-Bama, McShan, Carrollton, Pickens County, Alabama, United States of America.

She had sat down to really write up what she meant by "Lots Logic," as she was more certain about log logic now that she had shekel math; she was going to go public with some ideas, she decided, and she needed to first flesh them out in written words.

Overall, this is what Lots Logic meant to her, and she'd narrate it with her best Brooklyn Jewish accent, a mix of Ginsburg and other sources she had heard, thinking it through to herself over and over, weighing it from every possible angle, concretizing the concept of "Lots Logic" further, Lots Logic dependent, by then, 1994, in her latest formulation, upon her newly learned skill of "shekel math," somehow, in her little head: "*Everybody, you know, finds themselves with what one can call 'a lot in life,' you know? 'That's just your lot in life,' or 'That's my lot in life,' people say, but I think we can do better*" —she was thinking to herself, sounding like a politician making a stump speech in her mind—"*everyone can not just merely be given a lot in life, just stuck with some lot in life, often without a lot, but we*

can give them a lot in life, right? Everyone, in Lots Logic, gets a lot; everybody's going to be rich, if we get our shekels right, I now understand. The thing is, right now, it's just a lot in life that a lot get—a lot more than is fair, most deserving a lot more than just a lot—because it's a whole lot if everybody gets a lot, right, even though there's plenty, and it's not a lot, just more than enough. If everybody gets a lot, that's a lot to figure out; not only is it a lot—not a ton, not a lot like that, but a lot, an allotment, just a lot, a portion—to distribute, a lot to distribute to the lot of people out there (a lot of them, all distributed about the lots about the place, lots of lots with lots, lots all the way down), but it's a lot to figure out if everybody gets a lot in life. So, for right now, it will have to do that everybody is stuck with their lot in life, some with not a lot, not much at all, but, when the promised land comes, everyone's going to have a whole lot, and a lot of it."

She arduously worked in the hospital on her addition to the Hebrew bible, a document that was manifesto-adjacent, a document about what she called "lots in life," scribbling in English phonetics with the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, writing with her left hand at a rapid pace

זֶה עֶנְד? זֶה בֵּגִנִינְג—עֶ לְוֹת עֶן לָיְף.
זֶעְת אֶס זֶה וּעֶ, עִתְז גוּדְ עִנוּף, פּעֶפֶקְתְּלִי
גוּדְ. עַבְּרִי לְוּת עֶן לָיְף בְּעֶרְזוֹנש יְתְז
גוּדְ פּאָרְטִקוּלַר טוּ בּעְבְּרִית

She wrote that and liked it, made a footnote for the English—she was figuring out stuff, but she was ready to show the world her Lots Logic, intending this document to be an addition to Bible 1.5 and read, and, so she wanted it to be accessible without losing the rigor of her Alabama Yiddish system—continuing, figuring she'd glue it all together later after getting the ideas out.

The English phonemes transliterated from their Hebrew graphemes, she wrote. This transliteration revealed that real Hebrew

was also embedded in her Alabama Yiddish, which she'd mark off in brackets:

Zeh end? Zeh beginning—a lot in life. Zat is zeh way, it'z good enough, perfectly good. Every lot in life [in the beginning | Genesis] good…particular to [Hebrew].

עֵן שְׁעֵכוּרְנְג וּר לְוֹת עֵן לָיִף, עֵנְד עֵ
לְוֹת פוֹר וּזְעֵס, וּ תֵעק כֵר וֹף וּרְסֵלף...

In securing your lot in life, and a lot for uzahs, you take care of yourself.

In English it was written, just with Hebrew letters, English sounds and Hebrew marks, and it said in her native tongue things that would be familiar to the Assembly of Israel—it was her doing her lots in life stuff, again, calling it shekel math.

She wouldn't name Henry explicitly in the text nor the shekel math she was doing on legal pads, but she was increasingly writing about Henry and their lot in life she was imagining in the world to come, where Henry would be resurrected and she would be restored to the beauty and health of her youth, and they would live as an interracial couple and example unto others for eternity.

She was no stranger to strange thoughts—she had a potent messiah complex, certain her life intersected some great messianic plot or moment, messianic machinations, and she was certain that her mundane life was a cover for a great destiny, had been convinced her entire life that it was all leading to something, something big, something huge; just as well, and oddly enough, she considered herself to be secretly Jewish and, well, also, somehow and sure enough, Muslim, too, in a way only she could understand and justify, and this was downstream of her idiosyncratic reading of world Abrahamic

religions, and this is because she thought that Jesus was the messiah but that he had never intended to start a new religion (she had a tattoo on her ass that said "Yeshua HaMoschiak," a misspelled transliteration, with a "k" instead of a "ch," but correct phonetic Hebrew in the Roman alphabet; "I put it on my ass because Jesus rode an ass into Jerusalem," she'd regale people with this story in her Southern Baptist church in her youth, right on the edge of saying what she really thought, a game she liked to play, feeling it kept her agile, walking high up to the edge of what she was allowed to say in social discourse), and so she identified with Christianity, in a way with Christianity, but thought it was "a Roman psyop *in Hellenized clothing*, too," as she'd said aloud too many times in her youth, no matter, nobody around there having a damn clue what that meant.

These identifications were based in her strongly held belief that Christianity was a "backdoor" into Islam and that Islam, in turn, was a "backdoor" into Judaism; she also figured, though this was not her path, that Christianity could be some sort of "backdoor" into Judaism; she was nuts, but her heart was in the right place, and she was offensive as hell, and she really wanted to be Jewish, but she was really antisemitic; she did love Black people and one Black man in particular, her beloved Henry who she hated to see in that window in Carrollton and on the cross in Jerusalem, in pain, thought she suspected it was all made up, the lightning stuff a bunch of bullshit; she was on her way, she kept figuring, and she'd sleep when she figured out what to do, she reasoned.

One time, a teen, she recited the Shahada at the dinner table with Thaddeus, to which he responded to her "Muhammed is his prophet" by throwing a glass of amaretto and ice right past her ear, near spitting out his ambrosia salad, the glass smashing on the wall behind her on the thick yellow, wallpaper, where, though cleaned, on the velvet, there was a faint stain of prior glasses of alcohol that had left their mark, all cleaned by Miss Bessie, who was forced to stay until Thaddeus was done with his liquor cabinet for the evening, making her wash the

glass, his single glass, that very night; Itragene had mostly kept her idiosyncratic views to herself, knowing the rules even if she was out of her mind—if she didn't play by the rules, keep her weird ideas to herself, she would be greeted with a grippy sock and a stay at Bryce Hospital, the state mental institution in Tuscaloosa. She didn't like to be told what to do, and she was determined to never do a night in a hospital, though people had tried to commit her many times before, mostly Maddie and Thaddeus, when she wouldn't sleep, times like this. People did care about her and worried, worried a lot.

On the TV in the community room in Bryce Hospital, her favorite part of the movie had just happened, her favorite part of *Death Becomes Her*, or maybe her second favorite, her not sure—Meryl Streep's character had just shot Goldie Hawn's with a giant rifle, both of them so glamorous, Hawn flying through the air and landing in the bright blue water of a Beverly Hills interior courtyard fountain. And Streep delivered her famous line, looking directly at Hawn, who now had a giant hole in her stomach, dead and alive at the same time, Itragene on a plastic, soft couch you couldn't hurt yourself on with a Diet Coke and a long extinguished Virginia Slim, her so absorbed in the movie: "I can see right through you!"

It got her every time, made her laugh every time, Meryl Streep saying "I can see right through you" to Goldie Hawn's character, right after she shot a hole in her stomach. She rocked back and forth and laughed and laughed, rewinding it similar to how Hawn's character, Hellen, in the film's opening scenes, rewinds the scene of Meryl Streep's character, Madeline, being strangled, a similarity which Hawn brought up to Itragene while she eating some popcorn and sitting next to Iragene on the couch watching the film in which she starred.

She hadn't found any shekels watching the movie, so she decided to get back to work on her Lots Logic stuff, the work continuing, no hospital stay curbing her vigilance.

An avid and broad reader her entire life, she was, actually, a great writer; she was just out of her mind. She had a way with words, and it

was stunning and confounding.

Everybody thought she was fluent in Hebrew in the hospital, though she was not, writing in her phonetic Hebrew English to encrypt her intentions and her writings, her many hospital writings that she wrote in her bed, or at a table next to where somebody was always working on a jigsaw puzzle in the main commons area or at her desk in her room, her actually quite liking her mental hospital room desk. She wasn't as fast as she'd like to be, on lithium, but she had gotten them to get her on the lowest possible lithium dose possible; she could still "talk to Henry," only now she usually referred to and thought of, called him Jesus, and she'd be able to the day they released her from the hospital. She was pretty sure Jesus was going to pick her up, that day, the day she was scheduled for release, just another daily disappointment of psychosis, Jesus not picking up crazy people from Bryce Hospital curbside, in reality.

She had a hospital gown wrapped around her face and pulled back atop her head, a makeshift *hijab*.

As crazy as she'd ever fucking been, she was, finally, as scheduled, this episode, finally, finally—finally, finally on what she liked to call, even in the throes of it, her "Muslim bullshit," too. She was sure she was about to write the most important document in major world religion since Muhammed recorded the Quran, the next major text in her idiosyncratic reading of the main global three Abrahamic faiths—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—a document that would unite the faiths and their adherents, ushering in world peace, her wanting to emerge having helped Jesus, as his Bride, craft a unified religion that was, at the end of the day, part of an "*inevitable Jewish context*," she had reasoned, the inevitability being that, in Judaism, the end is just the beginning, she figured, thinking about *Simchat Torah*, the Jewish holiday celebrating the end of the *parsha* cycle which ends with the death of Moses and then, the next day, the reading of Genesis, the beginning coming after the end ("...'Parsha' *is Hebrew for "portion," the cycle referring to the synchronized reading cycle of* Torah

throughout the year in Jewish observance and..."—she was was explaining the *parsha* to herself, as she did so often, re-explaining things to herself that she already knew, partly on a shekel hunt), and that—even if the latter two adaptations of the Hebrew Bible, the latter two, had a visceral disgust with Christianity, wasn't tolerant of it, wasn't were sort of both true, especially Islam, she felt with a visceral disgust towards Christianity and less and affinity for Islam, about which she basically knew jack shit. She had a visceral disgust for Christianity tolerant of what they did, the supercessionism, the violence in His name and their displacement of guilt upon the Jewish people—if you looked at it as she had been looking at it and considering it for decades, the end of the world would never arrive because that would break the original covenant between the Jewish people and the God of Israel.

It was all convoluted, the reasoning, or, rather, "reasoning," and, and but, heavily reliant upon scripture from all three religions' holy texts, her practice in some ways Muslim, she felt, but fundamentally Jewish, Islam just being a different presentation of Judaism, in her mind—"*one god, which was a novel and dangerous idea the Israelites had, one god but his name isn't Allah—but who cares, so, good for them, the Arabs, who lived over there, too, all over the place over there, the Holy Land, and close enough, "Allah" it is, who cares; it's Arabic, who knows, who cares, she'd throw her shoulders up in her mind thinking*—"and so that's wrong, but, in any case, we don't say the name, anyhow, not when we talk about that *ole*' Hebrew God, Adonai, HaShem, *the name*, but they're right, them Muslims, right that that Jesus was not the monotheistic god of the Israelites, and the Jews were just kidding when they said he wasn't the messiah, left no choice, it all a test, one most white Christians had failed in their racism, their antisemitism—he was a Jewish man and they killed him, the Romans, blaming the Jews, chasing them around for millennia with an effigy of a dead Jew, Yeshua, who was, surprisingly, African, violently forcing conversion to Christianity or exile, or attempts at extermination, like

the Shoah, and then later, after European colonialization, this little tribe from the Levant, the Jews, found themselves again being a tribe whose tribal religion had been adapted for a new religion, second damn time it had happened, the luck, with the rise of Islam, Muhammed and his swords, and all, just how it was, a third edition and all the drama that was involved, for everybody involved, a three-party tussle, by then, Arabic colonization, and the same shit all over again that they had dealt with with the Christians, all of this happening...it happens in a way where there are good Muslims and Christians who realize that, truly, they are Jewish, and that Jesus, the messiah, is no god, but a master magician from the Jewish tribe*," she considered it over and over, furiously looking for the truth and her ticket to heaven, psychotic and terrified. Beyond the psychiatric care risks, saying shit like that in 1990s Alabama could get you fucking killed. She was so ridiculous.

She had a hospital gown wrapped around her face and pulled back atop her head, a makeshift *hijab*.

She wrote about the death of Jane Ellen.

She wrote about Lots Logic in context.

> There are surface logics to understand—the first one is going to town as a concept (1).
>
> There was a local idiom and ideology in Pickens County, a memeplex, a bunch of memes that went together, and it was travel-themed. It was a way of life that everybody around there understood who had a vehicle and could drive somewhere: *You had to go to town*, the townspeople would say around there, around town, around the fifty-five towns legally recognized in the county by the mid-1990, as well as around and about the towns that weren't towns at all, just local places to be that they inevitably named and called something, like McShan, the biggest place in Pickens County, dead center and not even legally recognized at all in any way.
>
> "*I'm gon*' go'*head* an' head to town," they'd say."I went to town, today, and

tired, phew."

"Pick me up some milk, won't you, if you head to town."

They'd go about the place, make their way, go to here and there and places that were always "just past" another place. Their movement had an idiom, and *you had to go to town*, sometimes, they'd say.

"I'm goin' t*ah* town," they'd all say to whomever they were heading out on, hopping in their vehicles, their cars and trucks and minivans and SUVs, and there they'd go, off in either direction—west, Columbus, "*Miss'ippi*," or east, "*Tusk'loosa*," keeping their tax dollars in Alabama.

"I'm heading to town," they'd say, no idea half of the time about any of it, anything, just them heading over somewhere and finding themselves about a place and calling it something, sometimes real and at other times not, fake, and—but still—the fake places were real, anyhow, too, everybody all so confused, a miracle there weren't more traffic accidents on Highway 82 with all of them zipping back and forth between Tuscaloosa and Columbus and these tangled towns around Pickens, too.

They had this here local idiom, this notion of "going to town," a meme they all knew and replicated in history, doing stuff in the alluvial gaps of liberty and freedom as distributed according to legacy.

It didn't matter where you lived, you had to go somewhere, had to, had to go to town, as they would gleefully describe the process of getting around and announcing their plans to move about, how they were gonna go to town at any given time, and, even if you stayed in the town where you lived but nonetheless found yourself in a mode of transportation, some sort of vehicle, you'd still call it "going to town," as you had left your driveway, or parking spot, in the rare cases of people who lived in apartments (considered a "Black people thing"). One must—to understand how people bopped around this place at all and how history determined this daily matter of where you are in this world in a local sense—immerse oneself into the logic of going to town, understand that "going to town" was simply what they did, a way of life. You could say it was their lot in life, this manner of bopping about, this manner of bopping about that complemented their lots in life in terms of domiciles and the parcel of ground it was on which that you lived your life, where your house was and if it was even a house, be it a trailer or apartment.

Understand, as the hidden forces who ran Pickens County did so well, that mobility as a human right is only guaranteed by the proper management of

lots in life for everybody around in a democratic and socially just manner that bears in mind the Judgment and Equality as the rejection of the pride in the heritage of the legend as the history of the legacy, the pride in the heritage.

And, so, this is what the forces in the shadows did: make you drive a lot.

You had to go to town, *had* to.

You had to go to town, they said, and it was true, as, even if you lived in a town, as, chances were that they didn't have half of what you needed to live, didn't have the basics, people zipping about in their vehicles between the many towns in Pickens County to get what they needed, the towns in Pickens and, at the ass-ends of Highway 82 east and west, Columbus, Mississippi, and Tuscaloosa, Alabama.

You had to go to town, again, as they said and did.

There are scarcity mechanics to understand—the incentives people had were economic, commodity-based (2).

Take alcohol for instance.

A dry county, Pickens County, no legal alcohol sold, not anywhere you went, no matter where or when you went, all week, Monday-Sunday—you had to go across the state border for that, a drink, so to Columbus, Mississippi or north to Lafayette County or west to Tuscaloosa County, wasting gas money.

It wasn't just alcohol, but it was anything.

There are maps and territories to understand—the point of the maps in Pickens County weren't to orient you, but to disorient you with toponymic ambiguity and contradiction (3).

"I'm going to town," they'd say all the time, and sometimes that'd be when they really went to *town* town, *big* towns, *town*, not quite Birmingham, not a city, but big, big towns with multiple traffic lights, Columbus, Mississippi, and Tuscaloosa, Alabama—that kinda thing, you know, *town*; they simply also, if they lived outside of town in a smaller town, "would go to town," small but bigger, these kinds of towns around there, too, bigger bigger small towns with their own school districts, like Carrollton or Gordo, and so it was "town" no matter where you went, Pickens County English like damn redneck Chinese in its tone-dependency, there being "town," sometimes called "town town" with no emphasis (*e.g.*, Carrollton, Gordo, Reform, *etc.*) and "*town* town," with emphasis (*e.g.*, Tuscaloosa, Columbus, *etc.*), and it

was because every little village was also a town, the bigger and biggest towns, as well: it was towns all the way down, even the towns that weren't towns that were all right outside of town, even and in some cases, towns that were hybrids of multiple towns, towns all the way down and also across, towns all over the place, too, so many of them, a "town logic," so to speak, wherein power and legacy would frame where people were in space and time in the memory of the county's many lines in the sand, its violent historical memory of territory, what determined who got sorted into what towns and into what parts of those towns, Black, white and Black and white towns, a town memory foam and a historical, material logic that can only be learned by immersion. Some of the towns weren't even towns, to be honest. So, all the real towns and these fake places that were all too real, towns that weren't towns, towns right outside of town that were also split between and spread across other towns, and broader, general toponymic messiness abound, this tiny place so confusing, tiny, but big in a way, too, big in some ways, big in that the place compressed so much information into such a small place, mostly confused notions, so much information compacted into the place and with so little civilization.

The reason they were always going to town was because they had split the county up into so many tiny pieces due to racism and you could barely move without switching Zip Codes with your person. You could have one foot in one town, the other in another town, and your nose be in a damn third town, too, three places all at once, a perverse and mortal hopscotch of a county where nothing seemed real and everybody was always confused in their proprioception.

There was a logic that applied to a lot and it applied to a lot of people—the whole lot of Pickens, all the townspeople from every lot in life there, every town that was real and every town that was a real place but didn't exist at all in the law—and that logic is a discovery Itragene made.

She called it "Lots Logic." This was the real deal, what the town logic, say, which is the idom of going to town, hid. This was the deeper reality of the distribution of life chances in the county.

Itragene Lots Logic to recursively explain legacy to herself, when it came to the concept of town itself, the notion of town around town, and how towns organized bodies of different colors. She undertood history as a bunch of loops of behavior and the people who passed around pieces of behavior that

could be imitated, like the Look.

Itragene was crazy, but she was right about one thing: a lot in life was the most basic unit the good life required.

Pickens County was racist, evidence everywhere in every town, down to the basic, brutal facts of life chances, facts like as to where people were allowed to live, all clear as day it all being about race, or at least mostly, money also mattering, but nowhere near as much as race, everything that was all to do always all mostly according to the color of skin.

"Lots Logic," "town logic" and "redlining," all getting at the same thing: there was an informal but operating segregation logic of which the face in the window was a derivative aesthetic imprint and statement piece on the county's memory.

The town logic at play in this notion of going to town was just the surface of how the legacy used ambiguity in the English language to keep people confused and driving in circles. There was a deeper logic, and it was this Itragene Belle McDaniel Sr.-coined notion of Lots Logic. It was that the powerful lot of folks who controlled Pickens County and its lot of denizens, which wasn't much, not many folks living there, this lot a small one, but there were these different lots, disparate groups, lot in that sense of identity, as well as the divvying up of amounts of land, lot in this sense, which was two-pronged, being both the distribution as in numerable pieces of land and size as an amount, how big your literal yard was or house. The foundational logic hidden by everybody going to town and never knowing where they were could be called "Lots Logic," which is what our Itragene called the distribution of life chances according to identity in the role of legacy as a matter of history.

It's a langauge game Itragene played and she learned it from her daddy and people like him, gasalighting psychopaths who used language to manipulation people into accepting less than what they deserved, which wa usually a lot for these poor fucking people, living in shacks and trailers with hles in the floor, babies with no food or socks. It was a disgrace. They stole people's very sense of reality by confusing them as to who they were and whre they were all in relation to one antoher so that the poors and the Blacks got scraps and the hidden forces of power got everything else—a lot, too much, more than anybody deserves, as it was everything and at the expense of everybody else who wasn't them, and that was, simply a lot—the vast

majority of them, treated like dogs.

So-called Lots Logic is an exhaustive understanding of the notion of " a lot in life," a good meme, one that hinges upon type ambiguity and morphology of the words "lot," singular and plural, a noun, as well as "a lot," a modifier, and "allot," a verb regarding distribution. This deeper understanding of what the English language had done to the place in its degenerative idiocy and legacy of hate was what Itragene called "Lots Logic" and it was a real revelation.

You had to understand settler-colonialism and genocide—the place was founded on trafficking and the McShan Mafia was in this legacy (6).

But on the surface, this was what they did a lot, go to town, all they did, in a sense, if they got in a vehicle, and that is because legacy and structural recursion, over the history of this place, was essential for very existence of Pickens County, a county founded in the genocide of Native populations and the settler-colonial establishment of a slave economy. They kept hiding the ball by moving the ground around right under your feet.

Nobody stayed where they were at because the checkerboard kept moving in this hyper-segregated place.

Legacy is a recursive process and was especially so on this lot of land called Pickens County, and in a lot of ways, ways that were typical of the region and time, of a lot that went down and happened in that time and place, all of it, and this was a lot of it, a lot, all of it was typical of mid-1990s Alabama, in the heart of the Black Belt and in the Appalachian foothills.

And there is the social life of legacy to undertand, the mechanis of history itself—the texture of daily lives and how minor torment was the idiom of the gentry who controlled it all (4).

Let's take Black folks who lived in Carrollton and how, beyond the Face in the Window and it's spectacle of depravity, everything was annoying, inconvenient, unfair and needlessly a hassle.

Going to town was how it all looked on the surface—power in Pickens County. Take Carrollton and being poor and Black beyond the wealthier white residents of this old aristocratic, county seat town. A lot of poor Black people lived near downtown in Carrollton in trailers they rented from slumlords who lived mostly in Tuscaloosa, a lot of folks (as in group) who a lot of (as in amount) had grown up in Pickens County, which was most of

this lot, though some of that lot had no ties to the place, the lot of land called Pickens. They had nowhere real to buy food, these Black folks many of whom didn't' have cars as individual families, and, if they had access to a car, it was one they shared with their cousin or some other similar arrangement. There were no grocery stores in Carrollton, the county seat of all lots of land there in that place, only convenance stores that closed at 7pm and that had signs on their doors that banned sagging your pants and not wearing a shirt, just one example the little daily administrative violence of legacy, flat-faced discrimination. The middle of nowhere and a county with fifty-five whole entire towns legally recognized because the lot who ran the place kept splitting up the county due to racism, segregating the lot who lived there. It was a place that had lots of land, this was Pickens County. And that could mean a lot, about anything, really.

There are powerful, long-standing machinations to understand—and this was the foundation (5).

What really ruled your life if you were a denizen of Pickens County was simply your lot in life (in a totaliing sense), where you lived (your piece of land, that lot in life), how you lived (the way things were for you, the biblical-like sense of your fate, that lot in life) and what privileges you had as a member of any particular lot of people (the way you were sorted into groups and assigned an identity based upon immutable characteristics, that lot in life), and all of this, your lot in life, you had to take it as it was given to you, as it was allotted, divided and divvied out and in certain amounts (usually not a lot, for most lot, most not the privileged lot who got a lot more than just a mere lot in life, like the white people with sunrooms) out, to various lots, groups, and in a manner where a lot of the time most of what a lot that happened were hidden machinations on the part of some hidden lot of people.

The mechanics of deception at social scale you had to understand—the people in power were hiding or weren't even there (6).

the mysterious lot who controlled Pickens County, and, in the case of those with the absolute most power, this lot didn't even live in Pickens County, but a variety of places across the Southeastern United States, and, and in a County where no Latinos lived, as well as Northwestern and Central Mexico. From Tuscaloosa to Mexico City, a mysterious lot made a lot in Pickens

County much more difficult than it had to be by allotting lots in the name of legacy, a legacy that hinged upon the legend of the Face in the Window, but which extended far beyond the Carrollton town square.

Some of the places were real but not even legally recognized at all.

Pickens County, on which the gentry still had its grip in, particularly in the old aristocratic town of Carrollton with its ghost story lynching window, was owned by some lot of mysterious folks. The land itself, it was allotted by them, split up into lots of land. A lot could be anything—a parcel, as in a lot as a piece, a parcel, and it could also be an amount, as in a lot of material that has been allotted, an amount.

The lot who ran the county were simply a hidden lot. All you knew was that they were white and rich, but it wasn't clear who ran the show in terms of management, who reported to whom—at least to the poor lot of folks in the town who didn't know the machinations.

The lot was hidden a lot, indeed. They were not only often but almost always working in secret, hiding what they did a lot, this mysterious lot who allotted the lots of land, and, so they shielded the identities of the mysterious lot who allotted the lots of land to various lot, various groupings and distinct types of townspeople, having some to do with money, the allotment and sorting of people in the name of legacy, but almost all to do with race. The lot was hidden a lot, so, not only was the lot hidden a lot in terms of clandestine secrets and revelations of what was once hidden, but it's what they always did, what they did a lot, hiding the levers of power so often, a whole lot, that, in, in effect, the mysterious lot who allotted the lots to the various lots, those in control over which lot in life you got, but A lot of people, most of them, this unfortunate lot, the townspeople of the many towns in Pickens,

There were ways in which legacy kept people busy with busywork, needless rituals that had to be repeated over and over to survive—this was for no reason other than to keep people confused and committed to a way of being, this "going to town" idiom (7).

This hidden game determined a lot, like one of the most sacred activities a good Christian family interested in consumer choice and American capitalism could do—and that was go to Wally World, Wal*Mart.

Wal*Mart.

Not only did you have to go to town if you wanted a drink or any other basic commodity beyond basic groceries and the things they sold at

convenience stores like toilet paper and biscuit breakfast sandwiches, but you had to go to town if you wanted to do the most basic and universal activity that this lot of folks got up to, usually on the weekend, and that's go to Wal*Mart, again.

Wal*Mart, home of those low low low prices.

They had one in Alabama just east of Pickens and everybody, though mistaken, called it the Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart, and its nomenclature is a fine example of the ways in which the mysterious lot that controlled everything liked the population confused and in motion, never settling down and finding peace and stability. The friction made them.

If you wanted to go to Wal*Mart, Columbus it would be, usually, too, or, sometimes, depending which Pickens town where it was that you lived in and how far east or west you were as well as how much gas money you had, you could also go to what they called "the Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart," which just another instance of them being confused but treating something to be so true that it sort of was, a collective local hallucination, and so they'd head over that way, going to the so-called Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart, head towards T-Town, Classic City—Tuscaloosa, Alabama, home of the Alabama Roll Tide at Paul Bear Bryant's own University of Alabama. They'd be "heading to Tuscaloosa," "going to Wal*Mart in Tuscaloosa," or so they'd say, and they'd head that way, they truly would, but not get all the way, nope, Pickens Countians just only ever usually making it as far east as a place called Northport, only getting as far as a town in that was in Tuscaloosa County but outside of *town* town, near but outside of the the town of Tuscaloosa, Tuscaloosa County, Northport, Northport, Alabama—they'd make it to Northport, Pickens Countians, just far enough, where a Wal*Mart indeed was and that everybody who was just west of Tuscaloosa all erroneously called the "Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart"—people from Pickens County, "*headin*' to 'Tuscaloosa.'"—the Northport Wal*Mart, where and what these confused, mistaken people called "Tuscaloosa," greeting you when you enter Tuscaloosa County from Pickens, when you got just past Gordo, this Northport Wal*Mart was synonymous in Pickens brains with Tuscaloosa, though it wasn't really there in the place where they said the Wal*Mart was, one of many shared mirages in Pickens County, sort of like the face in the window.

These people were dumb, and in their profound and proudly optimized

idiocy grew an insidious evil.

There was a logic at play where legacy obfuscated opportunity—the very mechanics of bettering themselves as individuals and a population was denigrated (8).

"*Roll Tide*," they loved to say, "Roll Tide, Roll Tide." They'd be heading over towards Tuscaloosa, home of the Roll Tide, heading over that way, heading towards Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart Northport town, or whatever.

This uneducated county that loved Alabama college football and hated education, educated people even more, educating themselves a *bother* to *legacy*, educating themselves, in a broader sense, as well, educating themselves in a broader sense on a single thing at all, it was just a *bother*, too, *difficult*, something they *just didn't get up to*, didn't know how to as they'd never tried, and, if you tried to teach them something, it'd be obvious, their hatred of education being as severe as up to, in this hatred of the learned, it being that they simply didn't even want you to teach them anything, not nothing, either, not nothing at all, them literally saying stuff like, "I don't wanna hear it, I don't wanna know nothin' about any of that." They'd shove their fingers in their ears and close their eyes, sticking their tongues out at you, going "nuh-uh, I don't wanna hear it," the way they didn't want to learn anything—and this was because they didn't wanna know anything, ultimately, these, at the end of the day, a mostly dumb, dumb people, mostly dumb and hateful people, their bigotry a fruited evil that was downstream of ignorance, sure, but perhaps its origins were also in a profoundly proud, congenital medical idiocy that they exhibited, too, maybe something measurable, something worth studying. You better not call any of them dumb, though—when *Forrest Gump* premiered in 1994, it was an occasion and it was telling, indeed, a major Hollywood production that partly took place over in Tuscaloosa, around the University and the Classic City, and people were of two minds about that film, either loving it, or being terribly offended, going, "I am n*awh*u*t* retar*r*dtded," and they'd insist and say it and say such in their critical reviews of this film about this man with a mental handicap and his adventures in their Alabama, a man who they all liberally called "retarded," called the film itself the movie about the "retarded box of chocolates man," Tom Hanks playing the "retarded box of chocolates man," and they were of two minds about him, too, as well, the actor, Tom Hanks, given it that he had just also starred in a film that they didn't like,

which came out just the year prior, '93, *Philadelphia* the flick, a movie about "*AID*Sz," as they'd say it.

"M*yyyyyy word*dd*h*," they'd think and say, "a ret*arh*d with *AID*Sz, my word."It was all so vulgar and stupid, this place and its legacy; they were all cross-eyed stupid.

They lived in all these towns, and they'd drive, head over to town, or even further, heading to *town*, Northport Tuscaloosa Wal*Mart town and the like, some just made up places that they all believed in, and, so, it was all real.

She had finally done it, had finally gotten it written out, had finally done it, though, however and in fact, indeed, had finally formulated Lots Logic in a mathematical form, at least in the approximation of her psychotic mind, writing in English, actual, real English graphemes and phonemes, it all the only thing she wrote in English at the hospital, hiding it, as it would, she knew, make her look batshit crazy if anybody saw. She wrote out the English pattern:

Lots (a lot [lots lot lots a lot]) allot lots of lots that lot lots. Lots (lots [a lot {lots that lot a lot}]) lot lots of lots, lots. Lots (a lot [lots that lots {allot lots}]) lot lots that lot, lots. Lots ([lots] {a lot [lots (lots of lots)]}) lot lots a lot. Lots (lots {a lot [lots {lots that lot lots}]}) allot lots, lots. A lot (lots [lots {a lot of lots that lot lots}]) lots lots, lots. Lots (a lot {allot lots [lots (lots of lots that lot)]}) lot lots, lots. Allot lots (a lot [lots that lot lots]) lots lots, lots. Lots (lots {lots [a lot of lots {lots that lot a lot}]}) lot lots, lots. A lot (lots [lots {lots (a lot of lots)}]) lots a lot, lots. Lots? Lot: Allot lots lot lots; lots lot lots, lots. Lots? Lot (lot): Allot lots lot lots; lots lot lots, lots. Lots ("lots")? Lot (lot): Allot lots lot lots; lots lot lots, lots. Lots (a lot [lots (lots [a lot {lots lot lots}])]) allot lots, lots. Lots (lots [a lot {lots (lots [a lot])}]) lot lots that lot, lots. Allot (lots {a lot [lots lot lots a lot (lots [lots])]}) lots, lots. Lots (lots {lots [a lot {allot lots (lots [lots of lots])}]}) lot lots, lots. A lot? Lots (a lot [lots (lots {a lot of lots})]) lot that lot, lots. Lots ([lots] {lots [lots (a

lot)]}) allot lots a lot, lots. Allot lots (a lot [lots (a lot {lots lot lots a lot})]) lots lots, lots. Lots (lots {a lot [lots that lot a lot]}) lots the lot, lots. Lots (a lot {lots [lots (lots [lots])]}) allot that lot, lots. Lots (lots [a lot {lots ([lots {lots (a lot)}]) a lot}]) lot lots, lots. Allot (lots [lots (a lot {lots [a lot (lots of lots)]})]) lots, lots, lots. Lots? Lot ([a lot] {lots (lots [a lot])}), allot lots that lot, lots. Lots (lots {lots [a lot {lots (lots [lots])}]}) lot lots again, lots. A lot (lots [lots {lots (lots [a lot {allot lots}])}]) sees lots, lots. Allot lots (lots [a lot {lots (a lot of lots) }]) lot lots of lots, lots. Lots (a lot [lots {lots that lot lots (lots [a lot])}]) keep going, lots. Lots? (lots [lots {a lot (lots [allot lots])}]) lot lots, lots. Lots (lots {a lot [lots of lots (a lot {lots lot lots})]}) swirl, lots. Allot (lots [a lot {lots (lots) }]) lots, lots, lots. Lots ([lots] {a lot [lots (lots {lots that lot})]}) allot or lot, lots. A lot (lots [lots {lots (lots of lots [a lot])}]) concludes more lots, lots. Lots, a lot, allot, lots—lots? Lot (lots {lots [a lot (lots)]}) lot everything, lots! Lot and lots, lotting lots, lots lots of lots a lot, lotting a lot of lots that lot a lot of lots a lot, lotting lots of lots a lot (lotting lots of lots lots [lots, lots and lots alotting {lots (lots of lots)}]). Lots of lots lot lots of lots a lot, lotting lots—lots lot lots, a lot (a lot lots, lotting lots a lot, lots)—lots lots and lots lot lots, a lot, lots of lots lotting a lot of lots a lot, lotting lots. Lotting lots, lotting lots, lots lots. A lot (lots lot lots [lots a lot]) lots of lots allot (lots that lot lots). Lots that allot lots, lots that lot lots, lots allot lots of lots. A lot of lots allot lots of lots to lots that lot. Lots lot a lot, and a lot lots lots in a way that allot lots, lots. Lots, lots of lots lot [a lot {lots that lot a lot}] (lots lots). Lots lots of lots, lots a lot, lots in lots that lot a lot. A lot lots of lots, and lots of a lot lots back. Lots of lots spiral into a lot of lots that lots, a lot, lots. Lots, that lot lots [lots {lots that lots a lot}] (a lot lots). Lots lots that lot, lots lots a lot, and a lot lots lots that lot. A lot of lots that lots lots, lots lots in lots. Lots that lot a lot, spiraling back into lots, lots. A lot ([a lot lots] lots {lots of lots [lots]}) lots lot. Lots lots a lot, a lot lots lots that lots a lot, and lots a lot lots. Lots spiral a lot, lots that lot, and lots of lots that lot lots lots. A lot of lots swirl in lots that lots of lots, lots. Lots, lots allot [lots {lots that lots {a lot lots} lots}] (a lot). Lots that allot lots of lots, lots that a lot, and lots in lots that lots. A lot of lots in lots, swirling in lots of lots that lot. Lots that lots allot lots, lots that lots lots. Lots, lots [lots of a lot {lots that lot lots}] lots (a lot). A lot lots, and lots lots, and lots that lots lots in a lot. Lots of lots spiral into lots that lots a lot. Lots allot a lot of lots, a lot of lots lots in lots lots. Lots, lots [lots (lots of lots) lots allot {a lot}] (a lot

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and lots that lots lots in a lot. Lots of lots spiral into lots that lots a lot. Lots allot a lot of lots, a lot of lots lots in lots lots. Lots, lots [lots (lots of lots) lots allot {a lot}] (a lot lots). Lots of lots that lots allot, a lot lots, and lots a lot in lots of lots. Lots spiral in lots that lots lots of lots in lots that a lot. Lots that lots lots a lot lots allot lots, a lot, lots. Lots, lots [lots that lot lots (a lot)] lots allot. A lot lots lots of lots in lots that lot. Lots allot, a lot of lots lots that lot lots. Lots spiral and lots that lot back into lots lots, a lot. Lots, lots [lots of a lot {lots (a lot of lots) lots}] lots (lots). A lot of lots spiral into lots of lots. Lots that lots a lot in lots that lots lots. Lots, lots, and lots allot lots of lots that lots a lot, lots. Lots, a lot [lots of lots (lots)] {lots lots} lots (a lot). Lots lots lots, and lots lots a lot in lots that lots. Lots that lots, lots allot, and lots swirl a lot. A lot of lots lots a lot of lots that lots, lots that lots. Lots, lots; lots lot lots; lot lots allot: Lot. Lot lots, and lots lots lot. Lots a lot of lots, and lots lots allot to a lot. Lots of lots that lots spiral into lots that lots lots a lot, lots. Lots, lots; lots lot lots; lot lots allot: Lot (lot). Lots lots lot lots, a lot of lots, and lots of lots that lots lots. Lots that lots, and lots allot a lot, lots that lots lots back. Lots lots in lots that lots, lots. Lots, lots; lots lot lots; lot lots allot: Lot (lot) “lots”. Lots of lots swirl, lots lots a lot, and lots lots lots. Lots lots lots in lots of lots that lots back to lots. Lots spiral lots that lots back into a lot of lots. Lots, lots allot (lots {lots of lots [lots lot {lots a lot}]}). Lots that lots lots of lots in a lot. Lots lots that lots back into lots of lots that lots, lots. Lots, lots of lots allot lots, swirling in lots lots lots. Lots, lots [a lot (lots {lots [a lot]} lots)] lots that lot. Lots of lots lots a lot back into lots. Lots, lots lots a lot that lots in lots of lots, lots. Lots spiral back, lots that lots a lot, and lots lots, lots. Lots, lots [a lot (lots [lots lots, a lot {lots}]}) {lots} (allot). Lots of lots lots, lots, and a lot that lots lots. Lots lots back into lots of lots, a lot lots. Lots of lots spiral into lots that lots, a lot, lots...

She then had to double-check it, make sure it worked in Alabama Yiddish:

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Once she sat there and stared at her work, her final articulation of Lots Logic, she finally accepted: she knew she was crazy. She immediately summoned a doctor and got on a higher dose of lithium. She was on her way to recovery from acute manic psychosis.

Part III: Legacy & the Devil

~1994~

"Dying Confession of Henry Wells," the headline read in the January 29, print of the *Pickens County Herald*.

It was reported that a formerly enslaved man who lived in Aliceville who'd been arrested about a month prior for burning down the new Pickens County Courthouse had died in the jailhouse of a gunshot wound. His name was Henry Wells, that Henry Wells, that formerly enslaved man who would become synonymous with Carrollton, Alabama, in the lore.

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Late February 1878, a loose copy of the Pickens County Herald flew about the Carrollton town square, the seat of Pickens County. The front page was mostly about the courthouse burning down yet again, and there was an interesting profile, too, one that townspeople were enjoying reading, a profile of the famous "sleeping preacher," C.B Sanders, a Tennessee preacher man who, in his sleep, was said to tap into clairvoyant powers and could talk to the dead.

Pretty much everybody around town knew who Henry Wells and his associates were, and that Wells had recently died, all of it coming to pass after his getting arrested at his mama's house, over in Aliceville, for burning down the new courthouse. Most also knew that he died of a gunshot wound in the county jailhouse. The *Herald* had reported on it all about a month ago. People knew about Wells, and some even knew him personally, but the ghost of Henry Wells had yet to be widely known, had yet to be invented, the year still 1878, the season of Wells' perishing.

The loose local paper of record flew into the town hall when the
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Pickens County Sheriff walked in and closed the door behind him, closing the door on a windy, early-spring Alabama day. Inside, past the door, two other men were observing a pane of glass on a cedar table, a pane of glass that had a warped splash of colors on it, iridescent, sort of purple and blue, yellow halos at some angles.

"We are to be cursed with this haint that looks upon us," one of the men said, and he was laughing really hard about it. This was Thaddeus Calloway Sr., Thaddeus Calloway Jr.'s father and Itragene's grandfather. He had just gotten back from Boston, where he learned the ropes of fraudulent photography. The county had paid for his travels to and fro, the man a local photographer, a man who worked for the paper. He was sent to Boston to train with William H. Mumler, a man who'd rose to prominence with a famous image he produced, a portrait of Mary Todd Lincoln, and in that photo you could see Abraham Lincoln's ghost. Calloway Sr., had trained with this man, learned the ropes of ghost story fraud.

He was standing back and presenting this glass, his handiwork, something he did with an acid-based etching method that Mumler had taught him. He showed it to the judge, the sheriff walking in, who had come by to see the glass, too—it was a little whop-sided, but it looked sorta like a face, kinda. All present approved of this new architectural feature they'd add to the new courthouse garret room, a bit of spooky fun and it'd keep Black folks in line, too, and that was its main purpose.

"Look at that [*you-know-what*] in the window! Look at that [*you-know-wha*t] in the window! I can't wait to see people's faces. They'll be like, and they'll say, 'Look! It's that [*you-know-what*], Henry Wells! They'll be slappin' their knees and pointing yonder forever.."

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A Mississippi country lawyer, James L. Gibson, had just returned from a trip to New Orleans, where he met some Yankees involved with spiritualism, mesmerism and Theosophy, New Orleans and parts of
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Mississippi abuzz by that time, the year 1879, abuzz about these metaphysical, esoteric ideas traveling across the Atlantic world. The Siddhartha Lodge was still under construction in Vicksburg, but a small group of Mississippi hermeticists were having a meeting in Gibson's home. They had just had a meeting, mostly discussing the last construction details for their under-construction Theosophy lodge, and Gibson was talking to James, James Thompson, a dear friend of his and a fellow traveller.

"It was eerie, and they all seemed to know the story, the details about the same. The man's name was Henry Wells."

"And this was all to do with the courthouse burning down?"

"Yes, yes, like I said, but he was *on the lawn* when the mob came; it was a ball of lightning that set his face in the window."

"Every bolt of lightning ends in a fireball, they do tell you from so young."

"They said he called out to them before they finished him off, his last words was said to be 'I am innocent! If you kill me, I will haunt you for the rest of your lives!'"

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"And they said that his last words were, 'I am innocent! If you kill me, I will haunt you for the rest of your lives!'"

A wiry woman was telling a dark room all of this about Henry Wells, a dark room illuminated by scant candles, about thirty folks in the audience, them having one of the first Theosophist meetings in Birmingham, Alabama, at the newly opened Birmingham Theosophical Lodge, opened that year, 1920. This raconteur had just returned to Birmingham after a trip to East-Central Mississippi, Lowndes County, where she had met with fellow spiritualists running a "psychic circle" in the town of Columbus. They had told her about a so-called spirit photograph they'd seen in Alabama just over the state line, a "spirit photograph" the then en vogue term across the English-speaking Atlantic world of Western esotericism referring to purported
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images of ghosts and spirits on captured on various surfaces..

"It's terrifying. He's just looking down on the whole town, down from the Garret room."

1928, the Pickens County Herald reported on "a dreadful hailstorm"—it had knocked out the window, said to have been there and with that wailing face of Henry Wells since 1878. "Many explanations have been given for its presence and many are the stories that have been told about its mysterious appearance," the *Herald* read.

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The county schools had just finally started desegregating, county commissioner Thaddeus CallowayJr., overseeing much of the details, which was an effort on his part to maintain "all deliberate speed" as much as he could, though they had finally lost the legal battle, the Feds putting their feet down.

It was 1969, a December afternoon, and she was sitting in front of a classroom of some kids, both Black and white, including both Maddie and her sister, Itragene Jr., them nine years old at the time. The students were of mixed racial backgrounds, a novel sight in Pickens by that time, mixed but they were mostly white. At the front of the classroom, sitting on a chair was a woman, sitting on a chair that was built for a middle schooler and that was a bit too small for even her modest frame, and this woman was Alabama folklorist Kathryn Tucker Windam, her writing and speaking engagement career really taking off around then, the late 1960s. Her 13 Alabama Ghosts & Jeffrey had just been published that year, and she was down at Gordo Elementary School, her first stop on a long book tour she was about to launch across the US South, telling stories about ghostly things like "the hole that will not stay filled" and "the face in the window."

She had just finished telling the story of Henry Wells, a lesson about the past, as it was told by then, 1969, after the Civil Rights Movement.
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"'I am innocent! If you kill me, I will haunt you for the rest of your lives!' This was his last words, Henry Wells," she said, and she closed the book.

A good portion of the twentieth century, Thaddeus Jr., the Calloway patriarch, was county commissioner. He served for many decades and responsible for maintaining the lore regarding this putative face in the window, the guy who figured out tourism marketing and managed the upkeep of the square, commissioner stuff and also tasks that he took on as matters of personal legacy, Henry Wells central to his legacy, and, so, he was particularly and notably responsible for the legend of the face in the window, all throughout and after Jim Crow, a long tenure, the tale under his leadership and careful hand changing after the Civil Rights Movement, becoming more covert in its racial calculus and apparently raking in more tourism dollars, the new and sanitized versioning of the story, the narrative eventually refashioned as a post-Civil Rights Movement lesson, a distorted and weird pseudo-lesson, having the form but not the content for pedagogy, a condescendingly, clearly nonsensical lesson about race where the white people involved—the party guilty of Henry Wells' death by any account—come out the good guys because the sheriff supposedly tried to prevent his lynching, the new, ridiculous, gaslighting frame in almost every version of the face in the window tale reimagined in the late 1960s after the Civil Rights Movement, hinging the moral of the story completely on a likely fabricated subplot of this lynching story and one that doesn't even make sense if you admit the priors packed into this re-telling of the famed face in the window story, this lynching ghost story. You know exactly what white people in that segregated

town and county called that Black man whose screaming face was supposedly in that window that they were so obsessed with, what they hollered and laughed about as they said it, uttered the phrase that contains a "hard 'r,'" what they said right up until they finally couldn't say the n-word as freely as they wanted: that's exactly what they'd call him, that "little [you-know-what] in the windah."

All living together, Itragene and her children and Thaddeus, Itragene's kids were mostly minded by a Black woman employed by Thaddeus, Miss Bessie Jones; the kids usually only had one sock on, and they relied on Bessie, they simply did, and they thought that they did so endearingly, her "family" yet fundamentally different—in other words, as was often said by white people who thought themselves to be of good standing when it came to Black folks, and people like Thaddeus did think they were good white people.

Thaddeus would go on and on, "At the end of the day a *[you-know-what]* is a *[you-know-what]* and they'll stick together, so we have to, too."

It was a scary place and time and family, Itragene's locale and cursed lineage—family she was, Miss Bessie, and Itragene's perverse father, a cruel man, Thaddeus, would even call her, even on into the 1990s, "mammy," fucking "*mammy*," a Black woman about the same age as Itragene, a woman paid pennies by Thaddeus to tend to his home and his middle child and her children.

Though he did pay her a few pennies—*pennays*, he'd pronounce it—a few pennies more than other white people paid Black people whom they still viewed as property, despite all the that had happened, still—so goddamn stubborn and downright hateful—he was an absolute racist monster to her. Thaddeus made it clear that she should be grateful for her *pennays* and more, reminding her at every moment he could that he owned her time, owned her labor and life, torturing her, popping up behind her while she cleaned the toilet, hung laundry outside, did the dishes, whatever, popped up smoking a smelly cigar, no meditative moment of labor too holy for him to interrupt,

condescendingly, in a perversely playful tone, asking her if she was "earning them *pennays*."

She'd work, she'd hear him come around like that and she'd grit her teeth and say "Yessir, thank you, sir," weeping internally, seeing his tombstone in her eyes, asking for forgiveness from Jesus later for such a thought, but she just wanted that damn man dead and for him to leave her the hell alone and let her take care of Itragene and them babies.

"Damn these foolish people," she'd think, poor *ole*' Bessie.

Katherine took her eye mask off, one of those headache things you put in the freezer and then lay over across your eyes, her head killing her that Monday morning, March 21, 1994.

She was so hungover, had drank herself to sleep the prior night after leaving the Hadley household where she had had supper with Mrs. Jane Ellen and Kevin. The research was to start in earnest today, the plenary research, and that was mostly figuring out a list of people whom she could interview around the town about the so-called face in the window.

She rolled off the couch and found the remote, it somehow lying in the middle of the floor and too far to reach from the couch, where she had just welcome her first night as a temporary Pickens County resident. clicking the TV on and, initially confusing her, she saw scenes shot around downtown Carrollton, just up the street from her.

Carrollton was on national news, ABC

Katherine suddenly realized, and, then, she heard many helicopters outside, and she grabbed her house coat, stepped out on the front porch of the tiny house she rented near downtown off of Phoenix Avenue,

and there were media vans all down the street, news anchors and camera crews walking around like it was Woodstock for the news but it was happening in Pickens County.

She flicked through the local channels she picked up on her rabbit ears, and she was gobsmacked: Kevin van de Tuffin had been arrested, and not only that, but for the murder of Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley!

Katherine, an FBI asset since her first academic project wherein she infiltrated a white power gang weighed calling her handler, but didn't want to risk it, just not sure about communications in her new local accommodations--she hadn't checked the place, yet.

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She got dressed after she got the message on her answering machine—Kevin had called her as his one phone call. He wanted to see her, felt it urgent in his case.

She relented and got dressed, and then she went down to the jailhouse.

That's where she met Maddie, fresh from another night in jail due to her acting up drunk again.

"I'm so sorry!" Katherine said, after she whopped Maddie in the face with the front door of the jail where Kevin was housed and from whence Maddie was departing.

Maddie was still drunk, and didn't flinch.

"Oh, that's just fine, honey, don't worry. I din't feel a thing." Her makeup was all run down her face, her having obviously been crying.

Maddie looked her up and down, could tell she wasn't from these parts.

Katherine looked at her.

Maddie looked at her.

"Who the hell's dragging you down to the county jailhouse? You don't look like somebody whose cousin does meth, hah."

The light "hah" she let out was the sweetest thing, Katherine thought.

The moment Katherine saw Maddie, she knew she had found her
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wife; Maddie, who'd made out with some girls and once fingered a girl on a dare ("on a dare," her perfectly happy to dip her toe in the lady pond with a valid excuse such as a dare), had never considered a woman as her partner in life, but Maddie, herself, knew she had just been made a wife by a glance.

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Maddie, like her mother, was very good at hiding how crazy she was. She started this relationship with Katherine while out of her goddamn mind, thinking on and off that her fake Indian friend, Columbus, could be the Second Coming of Jesus, all of this happening around Katherine, astute Katherine, noted for being "astute" in particular amongst her colleagues, her a professor at a major research university falling in love with and for this Gordo girl's act, a professor at Tulane, renowned in her field, sociology, her expertise being human behavior in social contexts; she had no idea Maddie was as nuts as her mother, though she knew her mother had just received an official diagnosis of bipolar 1 and that this illness was genetic, so she had been on the lookout for it, but didn't notice Maddie acting odd unless she were really drunk—she did say some weird shit, then, but nothing that set off Katherine's alarms too much.

Katherine had been so intrigued when Maddie told her that her mother didn't believe in the general story about the face in the window.

"She doesn't believe it at all?" Katherine asked her, taking a drag on an American Spirit, turquoise.

"Nope," Maddie had said, them on a drive to nowhere, just driving around the McShan Woods to get some air, the windows down, hot Alabama may pouring in, the radio on but low and playing a mixtape, one of Maddie's creations.

Based upon what Maddie had told her about her mother, Katherine was too curious and asked her one night while they were drinking at the house in Gordo if she could see Itragene's office, the door of which
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hadn't been opened since Itragene was home, Itragene gone for so long and the house feeling like Maddie's own, delusional but overall treading well, steering through the choppy waters with the mastery of a nut job who hadn't fully lost control.

And there they were, standing in Itragene's office in the yellow light of the low-watt lightbulb in the yellow glass-encased lamp on Itragene's desk, the overhead light long gone out. Katherine was mesmerized by this heirloom of a lamp, it having belonged to Thaddeus, made in London and purchased in Mexico City in the 1950s.

"She writes all the goddamn time listening to that fucking police scanner, knowing everything from what's going on in Pickens County to who the minor players were in the French Revolution; it's a shame she didn't finish college, no telling what she would've made of herself, so smart, my mama, that I can say." Maddie never mentioned Itragene being insane, ever, only going along with it when mentioned by others, never disagreeing, but never making the case, scared people could truly see how much she was struggling and she felt she was, freaked out that her mother had been diagnosed with this very heritable disease of the mind.

"I can see that," Katherine said bewildered looking at the room. There were books in English, Spanish and French, Katherine could see, and the room was covered in legal pads that contained Hebrew script print all over it.

"Um, babe," Katherine said as her brain accepted that she was, indeed, looking at the Hebrew letters all over legal pads in this office of an old rural Alabama white woman currently in a mental hospital, Hebrew everywhere, from the floor to ceiling, also writing in English, Spanish, French and, amazingly, what appeared to the ignorant reader to be Hebrew, but it was just Itragene's personal Yiddish, English words written phonetically in Hebrew letters. Katherine could read and speak aloud Biblical Hebrew, Katherine having attended Hebrew school growing up in rural Pennsylvania in a close-knit group of

Ashkenazi Jews who found themselves there following the Holocaust, Katherine born in London, her parents making the journey by boat to the States days later, London a pit stop from their native Germany. "Has your mother ever mentioned speaking Hebrew?

""OH GOD, yes. She's not fluent but knows the letters and she can follow along with some language she told me about…"

"Yiddish?" Katherine inquired, even more bewildered at the notion of this Itragene Sr. speaking a mix of high-German and Slavic languages using the Hebrew letters.

"No," Maddie said, fully aware of Yiddish, as her mother had gone on endlessly about "needing to learn it soon," for who knows what reasons. "She said it's like Spanish but you use Hebrew letters to spell it? I don't know. I don't think Latinos speak it, some Jewish thing from Mexico or another, no idea."

"She's talking about Ladino, babe. Ladino is, basically, fifteenth-century Castillan Spanish using the Hebrew letters. Ladino sprea globally during the fifteenth century...wait," she said taking a closer look and picking up her first legal pad she'd rifle through that evening, delighted by what she saw. "This is in English, babe." Katherine was so amused—what the fuck was going on? Why did Itragene seem to be able to also speak fucking *Ladino*, a Jewish language that spread across the world, mostly the Mediterranean in Southern Europe and the Levant in the Middle East due to the great expulsion from Spain in the year 1492.

One of Katherine's favorite Ladino songs, "Sien Drachmas," was a song that was about five centuries old, a song about the expulsion and a woman selling her body to make it to the land of Palestine, the song chillingly announcing over five hundred years ago, וַאמוֹס אַ לַה פַּלַאשְׁטִינַה," or transliterated, basically Spanish, "*Vamos a la Palestina*," "we're going to Palestine, the English.

Katherine was stunned when she came upon an essay about the song, a beautiful essay written in English Hebrew with block quotes in Ladino.

"How do you mean?"

"It's just English—well-written English, I might add—but with Hebrew letters. I've said it before, just based upon stories you've told me, but babe—I think your mother is an idiot savant. I'm very good at armchair diagnosing.

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Katherine had told her about it.

When Maddie found out about it, that Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley had, in fact, disproven the entire notion of the face in the window—that it was Henry Wells' face period, that he were even lynched, that his damn wailing face was somehow transferred like a photograph to a window, all of it, none of it were true—she laughed so hard that her ribs ached, which she did a lot, a girl who loved to laugh. It was too poetic that it was Jane Ellen, of all people, given how she loved the legend and story and everything about it.

Katherine had told her one night while she was over at the house in Gordo and, for pure entertainment, and also at Maddie's request, Katherine had brought her recording of Jane Ellen's interview, which she had fortuitously conducted prior to her untimely and unseemly death.

"I don't understand how they can keep on with it, though, if she went and found out all of this and—I mean, in the first place, period, even without Jane Ellen's bullshit… over one-hundred years….which is crazy. Wait, when was it again? When was it that she figured all of it out? I ain't heard *nothin*' about this."

Maddie asked her this once she calmed down upon first learning that Hadley had gone and blown the lid by mistake, popping three Lorazepam into her mouth and swallowing it with the wine they were drinking.

"Want one?"

"Sure."

"Here you go, my queen."
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Katherine swallowed a benzo with her Gordo girl, no drink to wash it down.

"OK, you'll hear her talk about it," Katherine said. "She says it near the beginning of the interview. She's SO proud of it yet doesn't get that she disproved it? It's honestly very difficult to discern. Nothing that woman said ever made sense. It was 1993. December, by the way, when she started popping off about it."

"Did she not tell everybody? That old woman loved to toot her own horn… 'local historian,' that shit always made me fucking laugh. I'm just surprised I didn't hear anything about it. Seems like a big deal!"

"She did, and she pissed off your sister so much. But they weren't, like, gonna put it in the *Pickens County Herald*, or anything. Nobody in town who knew about it wanted this to get out. It's a house of cards."

"I still can't believe that Iddy is a damn kingpin—and that Mrs. Hadley, of all people? She worked for my insane sister?" Maddie said this abruptly.

"Believe it."

"I also can't believe I turned out gay like her, too, ahahah. Must be genetic. I wonder if mama's ever tipped her toe in the lady pond."

"I can't believe your sister can speak some Spanish, as stupid as she sounds in general. The Satanism shit is so childish. I think she thinks it makes her scary." This made Maddie laugh again.

"Maybe she got it from mama. She's fluent. I think you know that."

"Yeah."

"Did she say anything about—wait, never mind. Just play it. I don't wanna spoil it."

"OK, ready—sure? You love to run that mouth," Katherine said sweetly. "I don't know why you just took benzos before but…" Katherine had to say that; she was permissive but did worry about this Gordo girl's substance issues, which she clearly had, though Maddie

had told her, and truthfully so, that she were doing a lot better since she started dating Katherine, whom she knew were named Rachel, but it was all so weird, this false identity stuff. She preferred to call her Katherine, or "babe," felt she didn't know Rachel Rivka, a Jewish girl from a rural Pennsylvania enclave of Ashkenazi Jews who escaped Nazi Germany. She did want to meet this Jewish girl one day, though. All of this figured into their intimacy, a heavy situation.

They were on the couch in the sun and the tape recorder was on the coffee table.

It was about 9pm.

Katherine hit play, then immediately paused it—"Oh, and yeah it was a little dirty of me but—ultimately, fuck that racist, crazy bitch—OK, so, you'll hear on the recording that I'm absent initially. I left the recorder on in the room with Jane Ellen and went to the bathroom and pretended to use it. She didn't know she was being recorded. I was just sitting in the bathroom laughing at her and the weird shit she has in the bathroom—she had a fucking Henry Wells *towel*, a toilet seat cover… she was truly such a sick bitch."

"Why? Why did you leave her?"

"She talks to herself, just as I suspected. I confirmed it with this recording—and it was even better than I had imagined, as you'll see. So, I did it because I figured she talked to herself, right? I noticed this thing she does with her lips, this thing that I've seen other old Southern white women of her disposition do the same—it's like this little thing where she would purse her lips really small, and then jiggle them up and down some, and with this look of engaged intent on her face, like she was listening to the radio or something, like she was hearing voices, in other words. Anyway, I noticed it when she was washing dishes that night I had dinner with her and her maybe murderer."

"Kevin."

Katherine was positively sure that Kevin were not Jane Ellen's murderer; he had been let go about a week prior, no evidence, first of

all, and, also, though Kevin nor the local authorities had any idea, the FBI had stepped in and forced the hand of the prosecutors office. Marvin had said, "Don't touch it—a total lightning rod," at a point, kicked back in his chair at the Birmingham FBI headquarters.

Katherine suspected it was Big Iddy, and, of course, it was, Big Iddy by way of Ugly, and Marvin knew this. Though Katherine had been let in on a lot, and was in the process of onboarding again as an active agent, she had not yet been given the Top Secret information on the situation, yet, and she was eager to see those files. She just knew it was Big Iddy, in some way, her McShan Mafia machinations.

"Yeah, anyway," Katherine continued, "I noticed she was doing this thing with her lips and it was at the cadence of speech—"—she wasn't sure if Maddie knew that word—"erm, the *rhythm*, right? She had her mouth closed but was moving her gums and jaw like she was talking. She was totally talking to herself but without making noise."

"She does not fucking talk to herself at the beginning of this, does she? Ahahah."

Maddie was cracked up.

Maddie loved this exhilarating relationship with this person who could see Pickens County people for who they were—including herself, feeling valued for the first time in her life.

Katherine treated her well. They were falling in love.

"She does. I caught her! Your girlfriend is really smart, you know. I'm a professor at a major university, you know," she winked and kissed Katherine not he cheek. She was giggling herself.

Katherine accepted the kiss and laid back in Katherine's lap, looking up at her as Katherine began to stroke her hair at the nape of her neck.

"Ok, I'm ready, been ready, let's go."

"One more thing, though. I think I told you this, but we did it at her house. It was before I had the Pizza Doctor idea—just for safety because I had no idea what would come out of these interviews, a public place."

"Makes sense!"

"But yeah, anyway, we conducted the interview in her sun room. That's the location. Oh, also, some point Garland arrived and she kept calling him 'boy.' God, I don't know how you grew up here and are as sane and sweet as you are, babe."

"I don't care! Hit play. Don't matter to me where."

Katherine hit play.

There was static, the hum of the tapes spinning.

There was the sound of people shuffling, settling in, Katherine thanking Jane Ellen for her coffee, the sound of utensils, Jane Ellen cutting up a Ruby Red grapefruit."

"Oh, ahaha, ok this is horrible, but she was eating one of those grapefruits…"

"Honestly, babe, when I heard what they did to her body? I laughed."

"It's so disturbing but…"

"Yeah, that's Pickens County."

"Rewind it and I'll shut up. Please play the tape, doctor."

The sound of rewinding, that chipmunk backwards sound, and then Katherine hit play again. The cassette recorder hummed.

"I'm gonna head to the ladies' room for a moment," Katherine said on the tape, a few seconds into the tape.

"All right. There's a fresh hand towel on the counter. Just got it! I had it custom made. The girls down at Tent Revival Tablestand & Family did it for me—over in downtown Reform, it's a Pentecostal store; I'll take you and introduce you one day. It's got Henry's face on it!"

She had so much shit with Henry's mug on it, including a heat-activated mug where his face appeared when you put hot liquid in it.

"Erm, OK. Thanks, Mrs. Hadley—I'll be right back."

You could hear the bathroom door close.

Silence.

About thirty seconds went by and then there was this faint noise,

and it was Jane Ellen mumbling to herself—"*jdubt jdubt*, *mhmm, phew*."

It was quiet for a moment and then there was the sound of a spoon being put down, her grapefruit spoon."

"*Mmm*, so good, so g*ewd,*" you could then hear Hadley talking to the thin air.

She kept clearing her throat.

"Jeffrey, I don't know where this girl is or what she wants."

Maddie screamed and hit pause.

"NOOOOOO. NO. FUCKING. WAY."

"Yep," Katherine said, reading her mind.

"She talks to that damn Kathryn Tucker Windam poltergeist when she's alone? Aahhahah, stop the tape. That's enough—holy fucking shit!"

"Yes. I knew you'd love it. It's gonna take us all night to get through at this rate."

"Rewind it, sorry."

They listened to the same bit again, and then Jane Ellen continued on, "And Jesus, please give me the wisdom for this process. I do not know what this girl *wawnts*."

The night she got out of the hospital and Maddie picked her up, there was a big tornado.

She had left the house, and she had gotten some pizza down on the square, and there came through a tornado, and she stood there through it in a moo moo, eating her pizza, wind whipping all around her, and she looked up at that window and sure enough it finally broke. It was

about 1am when she saw this happen, the face in the window finally breaking. She didn't know what to do with herself, immediately running to her car to tell Maddie, who didn't believe her, and so they both drove back to Carrollton from Gordo at 1:30am and as they arrived, two men were leaving the south door of the courthouse, both Southern Baptists, and that goddamn window was there.

Itragene didn't doubt it at all that she had seen something. The same little Mennonite boy who saw Maddie up on the hillside of Rocky Ridge Road was roaming around downtown Carrollton.

With Hadley's priceless interview in her research inbox, Katherine thought the next interview would appropriately be a foil to Jane Ellen Hadley, and, so, she scheduled her second interview in the research project with Itragene, set it up to happen shortly after Itragene was released from Bryce.

"Sandra was my favorite, but I also liked Ruth Bader Ginsburg!" Itragene was at her bay window police scanner table, sitting there with Katherine. There was a cassette tape recorder in the middle of the table, the spindles of the tape slowly rotating as the device recorded these two's conversation, two people who already felt like family, given how intense their situation of acquaintance had been, them becoming close quickly, all of them people who had a difficult time trusting others, had been abandoned or otherwise hurt.

"Was Henry different, given that you had never actually seen him or heard him?"

"I try to not, but I do feel mighty bad about that, that and whatever I was calling 'shekel math. My visions of Henry feel, in hindsight, like

minstrelsy...'" The weight of this guilt was apparent as she said it; she was processing live with Katherine, still out of her mind, but slowly recovering from her massive spring episode.

It was June and Katherine's interviewing for her research was in full swing.

She created a preliminary network graph of the people she'd interview. Having laid that foundation, she found herself adding other components to her post-discursive, memetic exploration of bio-power in Pickens County *vis-à-vis* the face in the window meme, myth.

The Indiana stock from whom Columbus came had been making their journey to sell their Mennonite bread in Carrollton since 1978. His particular line had a number of women who, every generation, made their way to Mexico to learn mushroom magic.

This house was his heritage, a house that had been destined for a personage of which he met the qualities.

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July, Maddie moved in with Columbus, who had been in his new house on Lowell Hanks at the bottom of Maw Maw Pascale's land since early April.

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Katherine exchanged friendly words with Elisa Hadley at the cash register, the late Jane Ellen's daughter and proprietor of the Pizza Doctor. She ordered some garlic sticks, an extra-large order with cheese added for fifty cents extra, bopped around the counter and filled two large styrofoam cups with crushed ice and fountain soda, a Diet Coke for her and a Dr. Pepper for Mrs. Sister Jackson, Eunice, the preacher man's wife from the big, all-white church off from the county square on Court Street.

The sociologist had decided to hold all of her interviews at the Pizza Doctor, a favorite around the county and nice, neutral ground where she could meet these insane people and know that, even if she pissed them off with her lines of questioning, they wouldn't hurt her because they were in public.

By the time Pickens County finally got around to desegregating the schools, it was 1969. They all discovered something upon integration, discovered a lot, but one was that people had been playing common board games with different rules than other people in their isolation due to segregation.

The way so many families in Pickens County played checkers with different rules, everybody playing distinctly in their own manners, one of the few interracial activities of mutual enjoyment being the Black and white kids at the newly integrating schools playing checkers and comparing how their families played it, seeing how apparently there were contrasting Black styles and white styles; everybody seemed to enjoy this aspect of their humanity across the artificial, often arbitrary, yet ironclad-in-those-parts Black-white color line of racial difference;

people also played dominoes different ways across the color line, these differences the particular matters of flesh in which these human lives took form, the sanctity of life given much air in those parts and little actual, material regard, a county where hate and legacy were two poisonous, flowering plants that can and do cross-pollinate to create monstrosities, the gardening of atrocity the flowering of hate as legacy's partner in fruit. It was all strange, and it barely made any fucking sense. Funnily enough, as it all were, Black kids were generally better than white kids at chess, a game with rules, moves and expectations, fair rules white students found confusing, and it made a lot of people so mad, especially the year when there was a chess outbreak across the county, Black and white kids enrolled in Pickens County Schools the spring of 1971 playing chess every chance they had, even carrying mini magnetic chessboards and playing in class, the integrated nature of the fad horrifying white teachers who were clinging to the past and also Black teachers who worried these Black kids were moving too fast and were gonna end up hurt, race riots not unfamiliar to these newly integrated schools, everybody so scared of each other, everybody all worried a race riot was gonna start because of a chess game gone south, so many horrifyingly irrational and violent things happening in this county to certain people, especially Black and queer people—women, too.

Chess was all but banned in crackerville McShan for a bit, so much chatter going on in McShan about the "fucking integration bullshit" happening down at the CUS schoolhouse, but they all loved Chinese checkers, in any case, probably would never give it up, chess not so much officially banned as much as people refused to try and learn. "Easier than chess," they'd all say, and it was true, no lie told—Chinese checkers is easier than chess and it'd be pointless to even start explaining the ancient game of Go to these hillside warthogs, playing checkers and dominoes with alls sorts of made-up, hick "rules" that the Black people didn't know, didn't have, found hilarious, in fact, and this knowing-the-real-rules on the part of Black folks was because they

simply played by the actual rules, game imitating the lives all of these people lead in their diversity across racial difference, Black folks used to following rules, many arbitrary and hateful.

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“Wuzn’t long ago we be out there pushing that empty wheelchair after her daddy had been dead. I thought she was long gone. To me, though, the funniest thing about the Calloways? After that man lost half his legs, the put that joker in a damn baby crib in the sun room, no shame,” Ms. Bessie Jones was telling Katherine at the Pizza Doctor on her interview day.

"I had to back away, though, after one too many time pushin' around that empty wheelchair."

The police scanner would echo throughout the whole house at night.

It didn't really keep anybody up by then, though, because first of all Maddie was rarely home in the evening, out and about all the time, never sleeping herself, really, also struggling, just like her mother around that age, her early thirties, an often eventful time for manic depressives.

Itragene's father also had not been what you'd call a sleeper, so it didn't matter, the police scanner noise just fine in regards to Thaddeus just as well as Maddie.

He didn't sleep, he'd come to find, couldn't, and Itragene noticed this.

Thaddeus haunted Itragene, always there, though the police scanner didn't seem to bother him, as it had years past when he'd tell
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her to "turn that goddamn thing off."

Thaddeus was also haunted by the past, unable to rest in peace, as it were, Thaddeus. He would want to take a walk and ponder it all. He had found that he was wanting to take a literal walk all the time, walking with his legs, but he couldn't, because he didn't have any legs from the knee down, nor the upper body strength to transport himself when he tried in his wheelchair, like he was stuck in some sort of nightmare, his arms moving but no wheels turning.

Thaddeus was only taken around the neighborhood every so often in his wheelchair by Bessie.

It was a bit of a bit, this thing that Bessie and Maddie would do, them taking turns pushing Thaddeus' wheelchair—a bit, a sequence of memes, a thing they'd do repeatedly, about the same way always but with variation, evolving the ritual.

At times it was Bessie, and others it was Maddie who would take her turn, and she'd push Thaddeus around the block in his wheelchair that had an Alabama "Roll Tide" flag on a stick waving on the back of the headrest, Itragene walking along, smoking, out of breath, decades into COPD, three generations of the Calloways walking down the Main Street strip in Gordo for everyone to see how pathetic and crazy they were.

The police scanner was always on.

The thing is, Thaddeus had been dead for about a year, and when Bessie or Maddie would push around that wheelchair, it'd be empty. Bessie was out of her mind, a bit, herself, driven insane by these white people, the Calloways, her mind not what it used to be after a lifetime of bullshit, and, so she'd push that empty wheelchair around; Maddie thought her mother had dementia rather than that she was experiencing chronic psychotic symptoms, and so she was humoring her insane mother when they did this, pushing around that empty wheelchair—though she did carry on extensive conversations with her grandfather that was the ghost passenger in that empty wheelchair, a missing passenger whom she missed very much.

"Where did the money go? Where did the fuckin' money go?"

By pushing around that empty wheelchair, Bessie and Maddie were feeding Itragene's delusions, and Maddie, the Lord knows, was developing her own.

The face in the window, the ghost of Henry Wells and the grand legend of Pickens County, Alabama—the face in the window, the ghost of Herny Wells. The strangest thing was happening to Itragene. She was falling in love with Henry, it no modern romance, but there he was—the ghost of Henry Wells a presence she felt in the house at the end of the main strip of street in downtown Gordo.

Itragene would sit in her sun room bay window and look out, sitting with Henry.

~1995~

"*La tragedia en Matamoros*," as it were, it was a song, a Mexican *narcocorrido*, "The Tragedy in Matamoros," in English—this is the name of a Grupo la Migra 1990 *narcocorrido*—the Spanish label for a Mexican ballad about drug trafficking and the life about it. It was a tune dedicated to a ghoulish event, a truly Satanic event, *la tragedia en Matamoros*, as it came to be widely known in Mexican pop culture. The tragedy in Matamoros, Matamoros a town that meant in English, "kill the Moors."

Matamoros is a border town near Brownsville, Texas, a popular spring break destination for American college students living on la frontera. The tragedy in Matamoros, indeed, an appropriately and simply titled tune, given what it was about. "La Tragedia en Matamoros," this short, it played on Mexican television one night, the fabulous Juan Gabriel crying, Itragene recording it and learning the tune, singing it drunk, a Gordo, Alabama, ranchera, treating her sun room like a Mexican village zocalo, doing la cucaracha, the same room where she would do

her Alabama Kabbalah "Hava Nagila" dance with the likes of Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg. This song, oh, it was about the darkness, indeed; it was an about dark and surreal matters: it was about a Gulf Cartel-operative, a Cuban-American—literal—bisexual Devil-worshipper drug trafficker, to start with, his hand, a Mexican-American woman his right-hand woman, them known as El Padrino and La Madrina, and that's barely scratching the surface of how ridiculous this story is—a matter of concern with which Big Iddy was directly involved, something unbeknownst to law enforcement in Mexico and the States, barring corrupt Mexican officials who were in cahoots with the Gulf Cartel.

Big Iddy had gotten away with murder so many times, literally, but this was different. She was dealing with Mexico where people did not play the same game as Tuscaloosa, Alabama. A Southern Mafia boss does not take on Mexican cartels, very dumb.

It had been May 1989. The War on Drugs was in full swing, as well as what scholars would come to call "the Satanic Panic." The 1980s had been a scary time for Satanists of all stripes. It was scary for the P.T. Barnum, carnivalesque, showman's Satanism as articulated in *The Satanic Bible* in 1969 by Anton LaVey, the psychopath who established the modern "Church of Satan." LaVey's Daughter, Zeena Schreck, was a common guest on daytime television, her and her then, and verily, neo-Nazi husband Nikolas Schreck, them on a PR campaign for the Church of Satan and to defend her legacy, somewhat innocent Satanists being accused of crimes like pedophilia, the Satanic panic really doing a number on varying strains of movements that, broadly, would call themselves Satanic, including and beyond the Church of Satan most people knew about.

Iddy would come to piss off the whole underground of satanism for two reasons—one, acting as band manager for Zeena and Nikolas Schrek's band, Radio Werewolf, ended up fumbling it all and this led to a series of events which ended in the band breaking up; two, she fucked up in Mexico, making the satanic panic worse.

In this context, before Iddy went and fucked up in Matamoros, worried, just as well and already were the theological Satanists, the real Devil worshippers, occultists, hermeticists and the like.

As above, so below, as far as the border goes, as it were.

Some of them were so worried that they committed mass human sacrifices for protection—really, like the face in the window, this all truly happening, surreal as it all was.

Spring 1989, it was, when Iddy fucked up in Mexico, in part trying to impress Sara, *la mardrina,* with whom she was in a perverse love: "All-American," University of Texas at Brownsville pre-med student Mark Kilroy had been missing since March 15, 1989, kidnapped on spring break a few yards from the US-Mexico border checkpoint between Matamoros, Tamaulipas, Mexico, and the United States, Brownsville, Texas. Iddy,

Amidst this sensational story dominating headlines internationally, Mark Kilroy's parents at one point meeting President George H.W. Bush, Itragene was obsessed with it all, couldn't stop reading about it. She was delighted when she learned Oprah Winfrey was going to do a whole show on it.

It came to pass that Itragene, Iddy and Thaddeus were in the sun room watching that episode of *The Oprah Winfrey Show*. It was a May night in 1989, and our Itragene had recorded the episode earlier that week, Monday. The episode was about Mark Kilroy and Satanic drug traffickers who murdered him in a supposed blood sacrifice, these the actual details of this absurd case.

It was dark in the living room, just the light of the TV dancing on the walls and their faces, and Iddy looked worried, Itragene morbidly fascinated and Thaddeus barely paying attention, just glad to spend a little time with his babygirl, Iddy, with whom he had just made up, them having gotten into their first ever quarrel, which was downstream of Iddy having fucked up in Mexico and this leading in a series of events to the Gulf Cartel cutting off the old man's legs from the knee down after he was lured to Matamoros by one of his Gulf Cartel

associates, Thaddeus a Mexico City man, fancy, never frequenting Matamoros; he found border towns and their hybridity disgusting and enjoyed the white Mexican elite's company in the Federal District of Mexico, Mexico City.

The US and Mexican media could not get enough of this story.

Oprah was showing a montage of local news coverage about it all.

A friend who was with Mark as they crossed back into Texas after a night of drinking in Matamoros testifies: "We kinda got separated, and Bill and I kinda left Mark behind. We all came back, and he was missing."

After an arbitrary image of the Mexican flag flashed across the screen, a former classmate says, then, in footage taken from an interview outside of Mark's funeral, "He was a just, *um*, an all-around type guy. He was real nice to everybody."

All that spring, Kilroy's high school senior year portrait had saturated Mexican and US press. As investigators uncovered the macabre and near-truly unbelievable details of the case, including those associated with the murder, new faces replace Mark on the cover of Mexican magazines and newspapers—his alleged murderers'—a man named Adolfo de Jesús Constanzo and a woman named Sara Aldrete Villareal, "*el Padrino*" and "*la Madrina,*" leaders of a group working as a subsidiary for the Gulf Cartel that the Mexican press came to nickname "*los narcosatánicos*," "narco-Satanists" in English.

Constanzo, *el padrino*, was a 27-year-old, Cuban-American, bisexual, self-identified *palero* and *brujo*—in other words, good ole' Alabama terms, Adolfo, with his freak name given to him by his bizarre mother at birth, literally naming her baby "Adolf" after Hitler, he was a Devil-worshipping faggot kingpin witch from communist Cuba, as they'd say around Pickens County, presented with the facts. Sara was an ordinary chicana girl who was madly in love with Adolfo, and she'd do anything he said, one of many people under his spell, *la madrina* only in popular name, her always subservient to this demonic man with whom she was in deep love.

Iddy was so jealous of Adolfo.

One widely cited English-language text called them "*los narcoSatanistos*," which wasn't proper Spanish, but obvious as to what the English would be." The American press was besides itself, just like the Mexican press, and not prepared to cover it, either, lacking cultural sensitivity and sensationalizing over coverage of the facts, which was not even necessary, as it was all so nuts to begin with, anyhow.

The Gulf Cartel was *pissed* when this story blew up—it made them look bad.

They may have been a bunch of psychopaths who did stuff like cut limbs off of people as a matter of daily business, and torture people, but they had limits, families, legacies. The political economy of the post-1973 War on Drugs moment required extreme violence to stay competitive, but you didn't have to be fucking weird about it.

Adolfo made things weird, indeed, but he knew his place.

Leave it to Gordo girl named Itragene Belle McDaniel, Jr., Big Iddy, her grandaddy's granddaughter, for sure, to make it fucking weird, as she did, Adolfo and Sara taking the blame, Adolfo eventually shot and killed by Mexican federal forces in Mexico City, Sara to eventually serve the rest of her life behind bars, sentenced in 1990.

May 1989, it all blew up, even worse than before. The story kept evolving. Constanzo's journal was discovered by Mexican officials. The press broke the news. Full-spread pages recounted that the contents of an agenda notebook Constanzo dropped on the run, contained details which revealed that, in addition to being a drug lord, Constanzo was a spiritual consultant to the Mexican elite. Among the enumerated notable clientele are stars "*La Trigresa*" Irma Serrano, Alfredo Palacios, and Juan Gabriel. Allegedly names of some members of the national and city government in Mexico City also appear in the pages of Constanzo's journal. Artifacts of the sacrifice are found; the most horrific relic is a necklace that has been wrought by extracting Kilroy's spine and then running a wire through it.

Iddy had had possession of Constanzo's journal, which she stole. She mailed it anonymously to Mexican officials. This was an attempt to save her own skin and Sara's, as well. She wanted the authorities to think of him as the architect—all it did was provide more evidence that was held again Sara in court, however, Iddy so dumb in having done that.

Iddy, in fact, knew Constanzo, knew him well, but knew his associate, Sara Aldrete Villareal, much better, intimately, near lovers, but never fully crossing the line, but friends with an intense relationship.

Constanzo was a practitioner of an idiosyncratic, perverted form of *palo mayombe*—a Caribbean syncretic religion, considered dark magic, also known more simply as *palo*. Iddy leaned a lot from their cultural exchange.

A front-page spread framed a photo of Adolfo and Sara "*¡Más crimines satánicos!*" ["More Satanic crimes!"].

Under Constanzo, "*los narcosatánicos*" allegedly ran a bizarre drug-trafficking cult that sacrificed Mark, literally, a blood sacrifice—and fourteen Mexican nationals were also sacrificed, in fact, though they were not at the center of the constant news coverage—"for protection," it was learned, and this was true, the purpose of these blood sacrifices, these ritual crimes.

Oprah's sensational montage was playing that May 1989 night, Itragene, Sr., eating purple grapes with salt, licking her lips, totally transfixed; the montage for Oprah's American audience was prefigured by this original Mexican journalism; Iddy felt like she was going to pass out.

Oprah Winfrey narrated the a good daytime TV punchline, narrating a montage of news coverage, pre-recorded and imposed over this sensational montage: "Mark and the others," Winfrey said, "had fallen prey to this man: Adolfo, Dee-hey-*suze*, Constan*zah*." Oprah said this so self-seriously.

"They were lookin' for an Anglo," DEA agent and Kilroy family friend, Oran Neck, told Oprah and her live audience.

Oprah followed up the statement: "For a *sacrifice*, correct? Got it."

The *Priistas* were still in power, members of the long-ruling liberal Mexican PRI political party, and neoliberal economist Carlos Salinas de Gortari was the president of the Mexican Republic, a personal friend of Thaddeus'. Geopolitically speaking, in Mexico and the US, the War on Drugs had a prominent place many international conversations that spring, there many headlines, and the most recent national and international topic prior to the discovery of Mark's body was the April 8, 1989 arrest of Miguel Angel Felix Gallardo, *el Padrino* of the Guadalajara Cartel. As a result, ostensibly, at least in the terms of the Salinas administration—a vital and material link between Colombia's cocaine producers and distributors and US cocaine consumers has now been damaged—and the McShan Mafia offered their services during this transition period, Thaddeus as influential as he had ever been in Mexico or the US.

It was a context wherein seismic shifts happened, ones that Thaddeus had leapt upon. Los narcosatánicos, Adolfo and Sara, they had been moreover just friends with Iddy, meeting by way of Radio Werewolf, Zeena and Nick Schrek's satanic punk band. But there was a lot of money to be made, and Adolfo had proven himself a slick trafficker, working a route between Matamoros on the Texas border that went across the Texas, Louisiana, Mississippi and Alabama coastlines and then all the way down into Miami, where he had a residence, in addition to a safe house in Matamoros and an elegant apartment in Mexico City's La Condesa neighborhood, one of the most expensive areas in all of Latin America, a place where Thaddeus also had a residence.

This case caused a stir in a religious minority's world in Mexico, Mexican Mennonites. There was a new fear, and some northern Mexican Mennonite communities abandoning their lives in Mexico, their families there for generations. Some of them made their way to

Indian, Pennsylvania, Ohio, and the like, and they were on the run from the Juárez cartel, leaving without the permission of their bosses.

Mennonites were known drug runners in Mexico, where they settled in the north.

The Mennonites who sold their bread in Carrollton knew it was go time, time to move to Alabama, and time to work for the Cartel, as their Mexican breathren had done for so long, but on the west coast of Mexico, the US Southwest border. It was time to join the Gulf Cartel. This was a syncretic sect who engaged in mushroom magic and had a network of cultural exchange between several towns in Indiana and Cuauhtémoc, Chihuahua.

The Mennonites who sold their bread already had a network in Pickens County, the clandestine Mennonites who worked for the McShan Mafia and, by way of Thaddeus' operation, the Gulf Cartel.

It was a perfect time, too, for this move, this Mennonite sect expert as moving about and doing stuff in an unassuming way. They made their way to Alabama under the cover of an *en masse* migration of Mennonites across North America to rural locales where their kind had not lived before then—while a small community of leaders had lived in the trailer castle for quite a number of years, a bunker before that was constructed, the rest of them had been waiting to join them, their prophecies fulfilled, a set of oral prophecies about which only a few elders knew about, the knowledge derived from a series of sessions Mexican Mennonite leaders had with the famed María Sabina, a Mazatec *curandera* who, through a series of incidents by which she ended up being covered by *Life Magazine* in 1957 when ethnomycologist Gordon Wasson wrote up his journeys with "the little teachers" of María Sabina, her re-introducing the modern world to psilocybin mushroom and psychedelic planet medicine, broadly, her impact by the 1960s counterculture beyond undeniable.

The 1960s' countercultural drug movement was a Mennonite plot, in part, at least in Alabama. They laced their bread with LSD and had a time in the McShan Woods, an ecstatic time. There would be no

woodstock weren't it for the trailer castle in the McShan Woods.

A lot changed since the night the Calloway family sat there watching Oprah talk about Devil worshippers who sacrificed white kids to Satan for protection in their drug trafficking and transnational crime syndicate activity more broadly.

This stuff scared the *shit* out of people in Pickens County and the wider West-Alabama region, the whole South, the whole country, even two American countries, the United States of America and the United Mexican States.

A few months later, July 1989, the Mexican Christian right was rising to power.

In the state of Baja California Norte, having cultivated political legitimacy within the party ranks of the *Partido de Acción Nacional* (PAN) [The National Party of Action] over the course of the twentieth century, the long-clandestine Mexican clerical right, by then, stunningly garnering their first gubernatorial victory since the founding of the PAN in 1939. Correspondingly, the PRI-having staved off right side of the political spectrum in the sixty years since it came to power, the PRI was losing its hegemonic administrative and managerial grip on the nation.

"Democratization" had arrived, as neoliberals called it.

Thaddeus exploited these major geopolitical and macroeconomic shifts. He sent Iddy to Matamoros often.

It was this context in which Iddy felt the heat for the first time, Thaddeus funding PAN officials, bringing reactionary politics, a specialty in Alabama, to Mexican politic through transnational organized crime. It would be PAN officials who pursued the Kilroy case the most, earning the good graces of the Bush administration and collaborating further in the War on Drugs.

What Big Iddy knew that Itragene nor any of her other siblings knew was that, that fateful trip to Mexico, when Thaddeus lost his legs, he was being punished for Big Iddy's actions—her actions in Matamoros, her actions in conjunction with Los Narcosatánicos. Iddy,

in her canine-like pursuit of beige accessories as well as her goal to impress Sara by showing how violent she could be, well, *she* had been the one to have murdered Mark Kilroy.

It wasn't Adolfo nor Sara, as dark as they were, and they did murder many Mexican nationals and do horrific things to them, before and after death. But, they were not stupid—you don't do blood sacrifices with little white, "All-American" American gringos. Iddy was an idiot and she wanted a damn spine necklace so badly with *heft* that she murdered Mark Kilroy and ran a wire through his spine after he was dead, making herself a damn necklace. Adolfo and Sara had made it weird and done things of which even the Gulf Cartel would not approve, all as a matter of public relations, but their prey were Mexican nationals, not gringos. They weren't stupid.

Adolfo slapped the shit out of Iddy when he got to the safe house the night she did it.

Iddy was nervous she'd be caught by summer 1989, and so was Thaddeus, but he knew he didn't have long, anyhow. So, he feared for his beloved granddaughter, how she was going to handle the legacy after making forces in Mexico very angry, their Gulf Cartel partners who were, more or less, truly in charge, Mexican cartel political economy an incredibly militarized force in the the Americas, whereas Iddy just had people like Hadley or Ugly and goofy Roy Patrick Williams, who, at least wanted to serve her and had shit like machine guns, but they weren't not damn military. She was getting increasingly nuts, too, about the Mennonites, her envisioning them as her toy soldiers; while there are remarkable facts about the Mennonites and the cartels, like the fact that an approximate twenty percent of marijuana trafficked from Mexico to Canada, for instance, was known to be the work of Mennonite gangs working in conjunction primarily with the Juárez Cartel, they weren't a damn military, just hands who had a cultural context.

Katherine's whole academic career, by the time she finished her groundbreaking work on the white power movement in the United States in her study of Mississippi Southern gangsters, her first project, was a front. She was simply a Fed, Katherine, aka Rivka. In any case, her undercover worked required being a genuine academic, a bit of a front but a true calling for her.

So, she had started the first drafts of her new academic project, and it was all about the face in the window, and, wildly enough, this crazy lady named Itragene was her muse. She was innovating in her field of sociology and beyond, she was finding as the work advanced and her analysis developed by late 1995, near Christmas, her getting much writing done over Thanksgiving, her and Maddie taking a trip to Gulf Shores to enjoy the South's mild winter beach.She was going to study the historical discourse surrounding the face in the window as a matter of evolution, using evolutionary theory to talk about the goings-on in Pickens.

Her big thing, the idea emerging: she was calling it "the theory of the bit." It was about how people lie and act to deny reality and in structural ways that could be studied in discourse and what was known as memes in evolutionary theory.

Katherine was really onto something, formalizing the crazy thoughts of this crazy lady from Gordo, Alabama, whose daughter she'd make her wife and take back to New Orleans, come time. It came to her out of nowhere: the theory of the bit, and, without the intellectual camaraderie of Itragene Belle McDaniel, Sr., Ma Iddy, Esther, she would've never cracked the case.

It was January and Katherine had begun working on a paper that she was going to present at the annual Sociological Epistemology conference abroad in rural Mexico, a trip coming up that she planned on sharing with Maddie, her first trip abroad. The conference was an

interdisciplinary meeting she attended every July, scheduled for that July in Tepoztlán, Morelos, Mexico the year of ’95. Katherine was going to write about the face in the window and the operant disciplinary Foucaultian politics of it, the “memes that matter to Pickens County,” she would rattle on about all the time to anybody who’d listen, rant and rave drunk or when she, herself, enjoyed a little Alabama street meth with Maddie and Columbus.

The working title kept changing, but by the end of May 1995 it was “Henry’s Garden: Race, Class, Legacy & the Memetics of Pickens County Folklore Discourse.” She thought it was funny to call the horror show known as “the face in the window” by the metaphor of a garden, likening the people in it to creatures being watched over by Henry’s supposed face, something that was clearly put up there. She had taken the phrase “Henry’s Garden” from our Itragene. She thought it was a brilliant commentary on the banality of evil around Pickens.

She’d come to define a “bit” as such, as she had perfected in her latest notes on her notions: “Bits are sequences of imitable behavior constituted by strings of discrete, replicable memes.”

When she felt these people in her face, their bodies in her body, she was experiencing, in fact and medically speaking, scientifically, the psychotic amplification of a condition, what you could call “mirror-touch synesthesia”…

Katherine had driven to the University of Alabama and done some research in the stacks at the library and she couldn’t find any such notion, so she coined “mirror-touch synesthesia” as the second meme in her work, following what she was calling “the theory of the bit.”

That’s what it was that she had going on with all of this feeling people’s faces in her face, their memes in her body, feeling as if she knew their bits, which sequences of memes they enacted that made them them, this subjective experience a transpersonal empathy fashioned from the tapestry of her mirror neurons, the biological mechanism for human imitation and empathy discovered in 1992 by Italian researchers, mirror neurons, Itragene’s so profoundly reflective

and high-absorption that, for her, to bear witness of the other was to experience the other's perspective for herself, osmotic and peripheral in her perception and active transport of attention paid, high-absorption Itragene Belle McDaniel, Sr., the paper towel person lady of Gordo, Alabama, a high-absorption fast one, our Itragene. This mirror-touch synesthesia meant that, when she saw somebody emote—or hallucinated a person emoting—she felt it in her face, too, the emotion expressed, felt the other person's face in her face, including their mannerisms and evident facial expressions—this is how she absorbed memes so well, her mirror-touch synesthesia, it was how she could imitate and hear people so clearly in her mind like they were there, her imitating in her mind the memes, the little bits of imitable culture that make an individual who they are in their repetition and variation, their recursive performance by an individual life, this the origins of personality and character in evolutionary terms, she believed. She knew about memes and evolutionary theory, "meme" a term coined in 1976 by Richard Dawkins in his book The Selfish Gene, him, there, defining a meme as "a unit of culture."

She wrote in her notes, notes she'd evolve into academic prose:

> What are memes in terms of how they affect personal and social identity (artifact) and historical process (becoming)? Memes are units of cultural—that is, non-biological, non-genetic—information. Memetics is the interdisciplinary study of such information's evolution. Memes are not simply cheap, replicable images. I am a trained discourse analyst, trained by the best, and I am a professional memeticist, a historian of the present...a sociological memeticist...
>
> Evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins started up memetics, or what would become memetics, the founding memes, came up with the idea as a bit of an afterthought in a text about genes' "selfish"-seeming nature. Building upon the 1950s work of Donald T. Campbell, who argued that the Darwinian function was actually algorithmic in nature, and applicable to all complex systems, relying upon variation, selection, and retention, Dawkins, coining

the term in his 1976 classic The Selfish Gene, derives "meme" from the Ancient Greek mīmēma [that which is imitated]; Dawkins extrapolated that a meme is "a unit of cultural transmission" and a "unit of imitation." The idea of the meme was presented in his 1976 book, but the idea of Universal Darwinism, the logical conclusion of the meme intervention, wasn't coined by Dawkins until 1983, in an article titled "Universal Darwinism," the idea of the meme just a small bit at the end of The Selfish Gene, but its implications as massive as the original Darwinian insight: Darwin's dangerous idea is a true pandora's box, and, with the memetic proposition adaptation, reveals the nature of human perception of reality itself, how, ultimately, our memes, divine images—that's what they are, simply divine, miraculous images of recursive self-reference in the strange loop that is consciousness, the evolving self—evolve our world, setting the course for human civilization.

Memetics should be a mainstream view across the academy and its disciplines—it is basic evolutionary theory based in information theory… not fringe nor pseudoscience: not only has this premise of Universal Darwinism been accepted within evolutionary biology discourse, but other fields as well, spanning all the way to cosmology, where Darwinian perspectives have been increasingly adopted, it not mattering if the complex system undergoing evolution is a galaxy, a primate, or a civilization. Memetics is an established framework, method, and theory of cultural change within Universal Darwinism; there is no reason why social and cultural historians should fear it, beyond its misuse, like with all dangerous ideas.

By moving from organismic biology to cultural information, the focus in both being complex systems, adding a second "replicator" to genes—memes—Universal Darwinism is an attempt to go beyond genetics, to go beyond "the selfish gene," as it were in evolutionary biology of the 1970s, according to Dawkins' 1976 contribution in The Selfish Gene. Though different instances of information replication, memes beyond genes evolving culture, there is a strong analogy between memes and genes, memes broadening the expanse of what sort of information can be replicated evolutionarily. Both genes and memes are replicators. Replicators are patterns that persist and change, carrying information, abiding by the Darwinian algorithm of

variation, selection, and retention; the takeaway, here, is that, in genetics, the gene is the replicator, and in memetics, memes are the replicator.

By looking for information's evolution beyond the biological, Dawkins admitted that information's evolution is substrate independent, as is the case for memes, too, synesthetically perceived(?); in this schema of design and evolution, DNA is incidental to biological evolution, with the information, genetically replicated, being the important "stuff" that makes up both genetics and memetics. So, there is a strong analogy between the gene and the meme, because it is the same mechanism; the analogy is strong, as well as further, considering that memes' success is a product of natural selection, like genes, those genes that Dawkins called "selfish"; these memes' success relies upon how popular they are, the memes only being there for replication, their sole purpose being replication, them "wanting" to be replicated like genes, so to speak. Like genes must be passed on, memes must be and so are imitated, algorithmically—variation, selection, and retention. When it comes to memes, like genes, if there is variation and replication with relative fidelity (i.e., heredity), there will be evolution. Like genes, memes are selfish, only "wanting" to replicate; memes, of course, do not truly desire anything in any sense where agency is involved, and nor do genes, but, rather, operate algorithmically, a situation in which a meme, if it can, will replicate, as it must, with no concern for the host in the aftermath.

Memes sometimes are damaging, like with fascism, a memeplex full of dangerous memes, a memeplex being a complex system wherein complementary memes constitute a universe of meaning, many overlapping worlds, to borrow from the Hebrew Bible, it being the case that the word for "world" in Hebrew, olam, means both "world" and "universe." I believe in multiple universes, held together by love, driven apart by hatred, the memes being the matter of it all.

A sociologist, I am not a trained biologist, but I understand that Charles Darwin had a simple idea, and that the idea is powerful, profoundly explanatory, as well as dangerous, nuclear knowledge, what we do with it a determination of good versus evil, as history shows, the Holocaust and the legacy of so-called social Darwinism coming to mind; I think that Dawkins

had a brilliant, simple idea, one that is profoundly explanatory, as well.

The meme meme is a productive one because it complements the gene meme; they point to a place beyond the veil, like, for instance, the nature of words in relation to human knowledge. Take natural language, for instance, in terms of how genes and memes collide in the material world in simply miraculous ways. Words are memes, copied between person and person, imitated with bits of mouth shapes, sentences, sequence of memes, bits of meaning, material words, discourse, genetically encoded biomechanics providing the way for air to travel through the larynx and across the vocal cords, creating sound waves with high fidelity and change over time, ears and eyes hearing and seeing these discrete, digital words, picking them out of the air and off the page; natural language is a product of evolution, a product of bodies grown from stardust with genes, navigating the soup of culture; evolution, if visualized as a long trip called human history, can be seen as a series of images, slowly changing images, something Foucault understood in his notion of biopolitics, the frame through which I translate memetics into a historical method of the present, a mode of psychedelic forecasting, as it were.

The multi-sensory—synesthetic?—experience of imitation demonstrates the universal nature of the synesthetic encounter with the memetic, divine image, this book will show in its curation of memes from Pickens County, Alabama.

Darwin, the nineteenth-century English naturalist, geologist, and biologist, figured out—before we even had the concept of an algorithm, as a species—the systematic way in which design arises out of apparent chaos, which is often put forth as evidence that there is no god, no creator, no gods, no creators, nothing bigger, nothing for which to carry on, even worshipping. In this book, I will argue exactly the opposite: there is a god, and this singular god is everywhere, and everything has a purpose, and meaning is everywhere, if you're looking for it and even if you aren't, the universe, a bunch of worlds, rejoicing, planets orbiting the sun, the solar system lost in that great disk of the Milky Way, all of it spinning, spinning inside spinning, each human being a universe of their own inside all of it, a whole world and a strange loop imprinted by shared reality; the chariot of Ezekiel might not be

the stuff of myth: it's the divine image of cultural evolution as encountered by human consciousness, made visible in a synesthetic, mystical encounter, the experience of evolution itself as an aesthetic encounter, the face of a god, and called the name, literally, in Judaism, "HaShem," the real name, for those of who practice Judaism, too holy to spell or write, except for special occasions, and a name you never say, also known as the tetragrammaton, which I won't write out here, but know that it's an unpronounceable set of four Hebrew letters, often transliterated as YHVH. I am not proselytizing, but contributing to human knowledge in my idiosyncratic way, also, as this text continues, outlining the unique ways Judaism and Jewish people have been subject to persecution in history, a unique experience like every experience, but rife with the special, ancient hatred that is antisemitism, a unique world-defining bigotry and memeplex, the underpinning of a psychic and social structure I will call the messiah complex, elaborated over the course of this book; so, I have to say a thing or two about Jewish theology and ritual along the way, in these pages, all part of my set.

Katherine had her latest interview scheduled, and this one was with Columbus Chulahoma, a conversation she was looking very much forward to having, her having done some homework on his family as a favor.

She met him at his house over on Lowell Hanks in the McShan Woods, unlike the other folks she had interviewed so far sitting over copious amounts of garlic sticks at the Carrollton Pizza Doctor. Columbus was busying about making a big supper for himself, John Henry, Maddie, Katherine and Itragene, the whole gang.

She sat reviewing her notes while he cooked. She was sleeping over with Maddie and they planned to do the interview the next day, Sunday.

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In preparation for her interview with Columbus, a deadhead and frequent meth user, Katherine had a treat in mind. She wanted to discuss the psychedelic experience with Columbus, as she saw a
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relationship between consciousness and the human condition of Pickens County

Mennonites recent settlers, only starting to settle around Reform in the 1990s, the Pentecostals there since the early 1900s, and, always having been there, the Southern Baptists and Methodists were in charge—and you know there's a big difference between Baptist and Southern Baptist; it's mostly a Black and white issue in these parts, the Southern Baptist Convention having formed in defense of slavery, breaking off from the Baptists in 1845; the Southern Baptists and Methodists ran the place, and, just as well, in fact, also the Mennonites and Pentecostals had a loose, secret alliance; well, actually, in fact, also and importantly, just speaking historically and looking at it, all of the white people had an alliance, between the white Baptists and Methodists as well as the Mennonites and Pentecostals—not that it was that secret, just unspoken, at least in the presence of white company—or, well, actually, mixed company with a white person—that's when you didn't bring it up, mixed company with a white person—no, no, no. White people, amongst themselves, said it all the time, "We're in charge," simply, something like that, maybe "white power" and "Heil Hitler"; they'd say and think such things, local axioms; they didn't need no goddamn window or arrow to remind them.T-town and "Roll tide," Alabama versus Auburn, Alabama college football plus the SEC, the n-word, what ABC 33's James Spann said about the weekend weather for the region, the n-word, poultry prices, the n-word, beef

and egg prices, how much more hyacinth there was this year clogging fishing routes up the Tombigbee River as well as the the n-word were some of the things you'd hear mentioned over the supper table in these parts, white households, at least; these white people, they lived in single- and double-wide mobile homes, what they called "trailers," and also in houses, some houses they built themselves and that looked like sheds, basically living outside, worse than a used, second-hand—or worse, a rental—trailer, but anyway, they lived in trailers and houses, for the most part, just a few in apartments, which were "for Black people" in Pickens County logic—who knows!—in any case, most people, Black and white, had a roof, even if they didn't have shoes or food.

Every store had a sign that said "no shirt, no shoes, no service," and it was meant to keep Black people out, plain and simple. Any white girl—and it was Pentecostal girls with their long denim skirts who crossed the color line more often than not, and they also acted out otherwise sexually from an early age, the teachers absolutely overwhelmed by these kids who wouldn't stop doing adult things every chance they got, all from good Christian homes, Pentecostal and beyond, Christian homes, knowing about things kids had no business knowing about—who was touched by a Black guy, well, she was an "n-word lover" for life, or, even, for that matter, any white person who looked in the direction of a Black person and didn't snarl was a [*you-know-what*]-lover.

Football games were littered with the what was known by then as "the n word"; the whole town was peppered with this word.

Black people said it, both amongst themselves and in public, mixed company or all white or all Black. Sometimes, often, Black people in Carrollton would say that there was a "[you-know-what] in the window"; they'd laugh at "that damn [you-know-what] in the window," screaming it, sometimes, when the school bus went around the country square, all of them laughing on the bus and the white kids calling them the n-word with the book bags over their mouths,

giggling but with a sinister glee; that's how they'd talk about it sometimes,Black kids and adults alike, those cross-generational bonds so important, they'd talk about "how fuckin' sick I am talking about that damn [you-know-what] in the window, shit"; they laughed at "the [you-know-what] in the window," laughed at how damn obsessed white people were with it, all of it truly hysterical in the Freudian sense, obsessive and excessive, obscene and absurd, cavalier, surreal the degree to which people carried on and openly got a hoot out of this lynching story. They seriously never shut up about it, and, while gruesome, it made Black people laugh so fucking hard. They would clown so hard on the those crackers.

White people said it amongst themselves in public and in private, that popular word around Pickens County, said it like Black people would, did, but mighty differently, even pronouncing it differently—with a hard "r."

Anyhow, as it all was, it was that this evenly split Black and white town was doing a two-party dossie doe avoiding one another, an elaborate dance at all deliberate speed to the beat of the n-word being said all over, different tones and enunciations, a set of samples they kept remixing.

Sometimes, white people would go to church with Black people with whom they were friendly, but the opposite rarely happened, just not the dynamic (it was observed that white people did not want not Black people in their churches); when this happened, when a white person went to a Black church, a Baptist Black church, not Southern Baptist, it was usually a white boss at a Black employee's church, paying a perverse form unnecessary, unwelcome, and undeniably annoying and intrusive form of perceived respect on the part of the white boss.

White people liked to assert access to places, keeping their eyes on everything; they would insist on their presence in Black spaces like the church—just to demonstrate they could and that the opposite was resolutely and decidedly not allowed. The Southern Baptists and

Methodists did this in particular.

Other than Sand Piper apartments and the housing projects in Gordo, nobody lived amongst the other. Some white people lived in trailers they had welded together, triple-wides and such, but they weren't living in no apartment like no damn [expletive]."

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So, there was this mass migration across the the United States of the Mennonites in the 1990s, them having settled in the early twentieth century in Indiana, Ohio and Pennsylvania; as well as places in Canada like Saskatchewan; Mexico, too, where Mennonites settled on the US border, mostly in the state of Chihuahua, such as the towns of Cuauhtémoc, Rubio and Namiquipa.

Pentecostalism was born in twentieth-century Hollywood, ecstatic and labile, Mennonitism Great Reformation Europe, demure and constrained. These two groups had converged in Pickens from worlds apart in evolutionary terms, at least when it came to some of their shared memes like their modest clothing, the Mennonites and Pentecostals, so similar in this regard, a main shared feature of their manner of going about things, the Mennonites and Pentecostals all shopping for clothes at the Pentecostal general store in downtown Reform that twelve sisters ran together, their one brother doing the books, Tent Revival Tablestand & Family, TRT&R. TRT&R was said to illegally traffic snakes for ecstatic rituals that the Pentecostals were known to enjoy, all of them a little too friendly with a widely known snake conservationist, a woman called statewide "the snake lady," a woman who toured Alabama schools showing them kids a whole bunch of different kinds of snakes, raising snake awareness, coming around to a school near you every year, $5 to go, and she went all over the state showing them snakes at $5 a pop everyday, carrying snakes in styrofoam coolers in a big truck bed with a big steel toolbox where she kept her pincers and such, carrying snakes around the state like a Pentecostal tent revival, letting student and teacher show-goers hold a
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giant yellow- and white-striped python in a group all lined up at the end of the snake show, pictures taken, the same show every year, and everybody loved it like they loved the face in the window, part of the yearly calendar, the snake lady coming around and performing, stunning the crowds as she poked angry snakes that coiled and jumped at her, their fangs out, these people loving a show and a ritual, loved watching her piss off these snakes and hold them up, poke at them with long metal poles until they struck out. "See? The fangs are how the poison is delivered," she'd say with a much-impressed faced to the crowds, a snake biting at her and her hitting it with a pole. She showed them a whole bunch of different kinds of snakes, and it was actually good knowledge to have in a snake-filled state like Alabama, especially if you lived somewhere like McShan with all them woods and creeks. They'd all be taught every year and misremember in a malapropism—"Red touch yellow kill a fellow; red touch black, friend to Jack," always getting the saying slightly wrong, backwards, usually and all of this about poisonous and non-poisonous coral snakes native to the area, nobody remembering correctly and just killing every snake they saw, anyway. The snake lady would beg these kids, teachers, administrators and other CUS onlookers, with tears forming her eyes, and at every school: "If you see a snake, call me; you don't kill a snake just for being a snake—how would that make you feel if you wahz a snake and somebody cut your head off with a garden hoe or shot your little diamond head with a rifle, a shotgun? Like a snake with its head cut off or its head shot off, and that'd be a shame, it would, and you wouldn't feel so fine it with it, then, not if you wahz the snake—they can't make your head unexploded even if the flat sisters of Gordo stunned all of Alabama, flattened like a python had gotten them but it was a chicken truck, but anyway—call me and don't kill no snake," Alabama, overall, such a snake-filled state, teeming with snakes and venom.

Beyond the noted Pentecostal snake handling, the Mennonites and Pentecostals were also similar in where they were on the totem pole

for white people in the Pickens County context, the Pentecostals and Mennonites religious minorities—white, but not Baptist or Methodist.

All the while the music penetrated the air, characteristic undulations in Henry's Garden.

The Pentecostal woman would scream and shout that night at her church, the Carrollton Church of God, speak in tongues, glossolalia, something of linguistic ecstatic concern that is to be regarded between matter and meaning, no telling, them not using translators like the Baptists did in their churches on the rare occasion when a nut would speak in tongues in one of their congregations, something that would usually transpire when somebody was trying to get out of trouble like an affair, them heading down to the alter and speaking in tongues, they'd say, making shit up, sounds and noise.

"Halamahnan hachalahua menalacha alapapa kazo, Jesus!"—always with what they called a witness, a "translator" for the tongues, the Baptists—"She said that she wahsz gonna take up the Lord's call and apply to that job down at the chicken house, she was gonna do it, praise Jesus! That's what she said!! Hallelujah!!!"

You were taking a risk, when you "spoke in tongues" and "replied on a translator"—they could stick you with shit like making you apply for a job at a chicken house when what you were going on about in tongues was getting a new Ford Explorer. They could say whatever they wanted. It wasn't smart to speak in tongues in a Southern Baptist church.

And, also, as it were, it was otherwise considered Satanic, tongues with no translation, just like snake handling, which only the Pentecostals did and to much Judgment with an occasional death every other few years.

The Mennonite woman, on the other Protestant hand, at home that Wednesday evening, on the other hand, for her part, she would sit like so—just plainly-like and so, there, in her house with her Lord, sitting plainly, what she would be up to, as was this Mennonite and what she did, so different and so similar to her Pentecostal kinfolk, yin and

yang, East meets West, both of them treated as second-class.

"Goddamn Pickens County gypsies, no tellin' what they get up to," people would say in Pickens County, especially about the reclusive Mennonites, and they sort of were like the Romani of Pickens County, though conditionally white; it's just that they were a sort of a type of kind of minority and, so, most of the other white people looked down on and made fun of them, but they loved their goddamn Mennonite bread and, at the end of the day, they were white and believed in God.

Like most of the South, they hadn't had any Mennonites living in or around Pickens under Ronald Reagan or anytime before, these darkly dressed people who were a distinct product of the Great Reformation in Europe about half a millennium ago, them only caravanning down to this very specific county square to sell their bread for generations, but being from and living elsewhere—Indiana, specifically, them beginning their ritual of heading down to Carrollton once a month at first wind of the story of "the face in the window," it very signifiant to them and some of their local prophets—nobody from Pickens really sure where they came from until they settled in Reform and, then, the Reform Mennonites began to sell the bread exclusively, some familiar faces from years past, prior to the great 1990s Mennonite settlement across the country's rural face, Mennonites en masse moving to rural locations across the United States in a great revival and mobilization of the Mennonite faith.

Nobody knew them, really, but everybody knew them, and they lived in Reform, a town they all called Reform and said it like "Ree-form."

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Following the murder of Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley, a first occurred in Pickens County—the legacy was handed to somebody who was not a Southern Baptist. This legacy of the so-called face in the window had, of course, been in the Calloway family for decades under the hand of Thaddeus during his extensive term as county commissioner. Big Iddy
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appointed Roy Yoder, a local Reform Mennonite, this appointment pretty much proving Itragene right: Mennonite machinations, perhaps a crow cult, were at work in Pickens County.

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A lot had changed. The first thing that changed was the Velveeta, before they changed their commercial format. By February 1995, almost nobody ate their Mennonite bread with Velveeta any longer, instead buying *Queso menonita* from the medicine man and putting it on their Mennonite bread, bread they could buy on demand any day of the week. *Queso menonita* was a Mexican Mennonite cheese, mostly produced in northern Mexico, Chihuahua famous in Mexico for its *queso menonita*.

The Mennonites and Pentecostal find themselves suddenly in charge, that it seems, that it seems. Itragene was losing it again, by winter 1995, though she didn't' know.

What Itragene had seen the night of the tornado, this apparent replacement of the window once it was knocked out by a June Alabama F5 twister was a sordid activity, one that had been going on since 1878, the window having been replaced a remarkable *five time* since, with all the tornadoes and all, hurricanes from the Gulf whipping them up reliably as well as the winds that moved east from Mississippi across West-Central Alabama, the whereabouts of Pickens County.

Jesús McCoy, a Mexican-born Mennonite from the state of Chihuahua of English and German stock by way of Indiana, he was lallygagging between the business of his work, one day. He was sitting with his legs
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dangling from the back of a Lavender Pest Control truck, fiddling with his RF bug detector, an analogue device that detected covert microphones or hidden cameras.

The FBI had asked of him, if he thought it were safe enough, to approach Ma Iddy—under the cover of surveilling Maddie and Columbus—to recruit her as an FBI informant in regards to her daughter.

He was swinging his idly legs back and forth, and, though his rear-end was right on the back bumper of the rather low-to-the-ground pest control truck, his feet didn't touch the ground. He was staring off, swinging his short little legs with his black suspender pants that he had to fold at the ankle because they were too long, staring off at the Tombigbee River that flowed over there through Pickensville, the wealthy river-side white town where, aside from Gordo, all of the Pickens County rich white folks lived.

Jesús McCoy was a small person, what they called back then a midget, a little man, he was, a Mexican midget of Anglo and German stock, a really pale man with dark features, all his black hair and his dark eyes, irises of a moonless midnight.

When he had seen Maddie in the middle of Rocky Ridge road March 1994, high off her ass, speaking in tongues, Columbus having abandoned her and headed down to the trailer castle at the Pascale Mountain bottom—it was him, indeed—he had just radioed Maw Maw Pascale, his handler, her an FBI asset and him a freshly recruited asset. He had radioed her that night in 1994 and also just then, in 1995, bouncing his short legs back and forth over the pest control truck's bumper.

~1996~

She had not felt this way since 1945 with the nuclear bombs. 1995—Oklahoma City bombing.

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She lived in Gordo and the townspeople had their rumors about her, poor *ole*' Itragene, in all the towns across Pickens County, Gordo, Carrollton and beyond, including the smaller towns that weren't technically towns at all. Some of them, the rumors, were true, though a lot of what they said was just local bullshit; some stuck and became her reality, whether it was true for her or not.

"Too much, too much. You are just *too much*."

She could just fucking hear it: her father, a cruel man, Thaddeus, would scold her growing up, "You're too much, Itragene—*you're too much*."

She barely remembered her mother, a woman who skipped town after her Vonnie was born and her Itragene was ten years old, 1940 the year, the year of her last childbirth, Itragene's sister Vonnie, 1940, the year she skipped town, it was said, nobody hearing a word from her ever again after the day she left the hospital of her own accord and without notifying anybody, Thaddeus asleep in a hospital chair at the time, or, at least that was the story, that was the official Pickens County story.

That's all she ever heard, poor *ole*' Itragene, that she was too much, that her existence was an offense—a burden, what she felt like, treated as such as much as she was told it.

Itragene's husband, long dead, he was no better than her father—worse, maybe. Wyatt.

Wyatt used to mockingly lambast her, it never ending.

"What your problem is, *Itragene*, is that you think you're better than everybody else," he's say all the time.

Supper was horrible with both of these men, Thaddeus known to throw liquor glasses full of fine amaretto at Itragene's head, Wyatt
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reserving supper as a portion of the evening set aside for an endless berating, him saying her name with venom, slowly uttering hurtful things to her over his whisky, getting slower and meaner and meaner over the evening as he got drunker and drunker, slurring and insulting her—as well, overall, big picture-wise in their marriage, he had been getting meaner and meaner over the years as he aged, her nothing but grateful when he died of Lou Gehrig's disease, amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS) in 1976.

She went to a disco in Birmingham that night, snorted Alabama coke and danced, the night Wyatt died; she went to Birmingham to dance alone, making it home days later, having had a great time. She was happy, relieved and pensive, joyous.

She married Wyatt Earl McDaniel—white trash, a Pentecostal, herself a Southern Baptist—against her father's wishes, tying the knot 1951 in front of the Biloxi Lighthouse on the Mississippi Gulf. She endured a decade of miscarriages before, seemingly a miracle, she had her twin girls in 1960, at the ripe age of thirty, something that happened once she quit abusing stimulants for a period.

1960, she was suddenly a mother to Charlice Pamela McDaniel and Itragene Belle McDaniel, Jr., her only dubbing the girl child who was her namesake a "junior" later, renaming her a "Jr." upon reading Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* in 1963 and it moving her in some mysterious manner regarding the name of one of her children, reading the book upon publication, three years after those babies were born and she was losing her goddamn mind at that dark house with her monster of a husband, her speed days over, the psychotic depression engulfing her for most of the decade beyond irregular spurts where she scored stimulants, her only able to read a little bit, not taking care of herself, much less her children.

Most often, the kids would often eat baked beans and cheese toast.

The town of Gordo was named for the Mexican-American War

1847 Battle of Cerro Gordo, the Spanish of which means "fat hill," Gordo indeed a hilly town in the hilly County of Pickens, this heart-of-the-Black Belt place set in the Appalachian foothills.

Were it not for the rise of Adolf Hitler and Nazi Germany, Katherine would have never made it to Pickens County.

Though risky in the case of Itragene, Maddie and Columbus, the FBI had determined that they could handle their rough edges. In fact, as psychological subjects, though fragile and thus risky material for the life of an undercover agent, they—particularly Itragene—had been right too many times.

They had plans for diner at Columbus and Maddie's house. Katherine had an announcement, unknown to the others, Maddie, Columbus, Itragene and Garland. It was March 1995. She was going to inform them of her undercover status as well as recruit Columbus as an FBI agent, Itragene too, and recruit as informants both Maddie and Garland. FBI informant Maw Maw Pascale, as well, was set to come by the house while they were all there, something planned in Birmingham by Special Agent Marvin Montgomery and in Pickens by Maw Maw Pascale and Katherine by way of Jesús McCoy.

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Katherine had done something out the gate that was incredibly dangerous, but she had never felt this way about another human being; she was realizing she had never been in love, but this Gordo girl named Maddie who was actually name Charlice had her. Katherine told her everything—she told her that she was a Fed and she also
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revealed that she were Jewish, her name not even Katherine.

Maddie and Katherine had been dating officially for about a about a year and a half, secretly, of course, beyond Columbus and John Henry, them being bold and going on double dates frequently in Tuscaloosa and Birmingham, but nonetheless, overall, secretly, it 1990s Pickens County, Alabama.

Katherine thought long and hard as to how to go about reaching out for an interview with Ugly. She just had to interview her, especially now that she knew Ugly were involved in the organized crime syndicate known as the McSham Mafia. She was a local fixture and surely had opinions on things and Marvin had told her all about her working for Iddy, Jane Ellen's working for Iddy, too.

She had hoped Mrs. Jane Ellen Hadley would connect her, even though Jane Ellen despised her so and had made clear that night at the Hadley supper table, two nights before her body was discovered stuffed with grapefruit.

But Mrs. Jane Ellen was dead, and, so, she made contact with Maw Maw Pascale, and cautiously so, informing Marvin of her plans.

"Ahahahahahaahah," Marvin had exploded in laughter on the phone when Katherine informed him that she had plans to interview Ugly, her giggling herself, always impressed with how ridiculous she could be, how far she could push it. She knew that Maw Maw Pascale knew Ugly but, given Pascale's role as an intelligence asset and the fact that so many eyes were on Katherine as it was, she wanted to check in with Marvin first.

"It is pretty funny, isn't it?" Katherine was tickled with herself and pleased that she had cracked up Marvin, whom she liked very much.

“Go on ahead, no problem here,” he had encouraged her.

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Five minutes into the interview, Katherine’s intuition kicked in and she knew that she were sitting across the table from Jane Ellen’s murderer.

Ugly didn’t knock, but used a key Itragene Sr. had given to Big Iddy and that Big Iddy made a copy of and gave to Ugly.

Ugly waited outside while Iddy called promptly at 11pm, Ugly instructed to wait outside and listen for the phone and to enter within the next two minutes no matter what, no matter if Maddie was home or not. She was instructed to intimidate Maddie into compliance. Ugly wasn’t alone, coming with Roy Patrick Williams, the two of them arriving in his old lily pad green, old Ford truck, exhaust everywhere, their turned out and ugly faces in the windshield.

Nobody was home, Maddie staying the night with Katherine at her place off of Phoenix Avenue right before you get into downtown Carrollton. Itragene was having supper at Bessie’s in Aliceville with her and Garland.

Ugly went into Itragene’s office and began putting everything into trash bags, it taking her several hours, her having shone up around 11pm. She then started putting guns in the room, nice and neat, prettily, Ugly did.
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To honor the life of Jane Ellen Hadley and to raise money for the Window Watchers, it was said, a play was orchestrated. The performance of this play would be interrupted by the start of something big, an international race war in the Americas.

And a plan was hatched by the Mennonites, them actually the ones who came up with the idea for a play, using it as a greeting like they used the bread, a way to introduce themselves; and so it was determined that the play would happen June 1994, them using a play that Jane Ellen Hadley had co-written with a deranged University of Alabama drama studies professor, or, rather, put her name on it as a sponsor, her barely literate though she "read" so many books and so many old newspapers, more liked looked at them without a clue as to what to do with these pages with these words ordered into a sequence.Big Iddy had set them to launch a race war.

The Mennonites decided that they'd sell their bread in the evening for a change that June, on that third Wednesday, and they'd have a play called "The Face in the Window"—they also decided to lace the bread with LSD—a little distraction as they declared war on the McShan Mafia by acting as double agents acting with Big Iddy like they were going to start a race war (that the Mennonites alone couldn't win), one Big Iddy had planned for all of the South, Southwest and Northern Mexico. In fact, they were working with the cartel; the CIA was aware of the far-fetched plan but their analysts could not interpret the signals they were seeing, none of hit making any sense, signals in intelligence wise.

Big Iddy was so crazy by then that she had become indecipherable to US intelligence agencies, despite the growing number of FBI

informants and agents on the ground in Pickens.

Many people in Pickens County—many with undiagnosed mood and thought disorders with psychotic features—have a messiah complex. Some of them want to remove the face in the window...

This is where our primary informant and subject of the study emerges, Itragene

Belle McDaniel, Sr., of Gordo, Alabama. I have studied her texts. She is called crazy, but she's right about some things, onto something.

…this is the theory of the bit, as I was seeing the fundamental underbelly of reality as my daily setting. People often refute evolutionary theory, saying "I didn't come from no monkey," but this misses the point.

In her notebooks, McDaniel, using Hebrew graphemes to write out English graphemes (Alabama accent and all), she wrote from Bryce Mental Hospital, spring 1994 (this has been "translated," if such a word is appropriate, "from" Hebrew-ish to English:

> As sure as our Itragene prayed in Bible for the Death of the Legacy, with the end of the Legend the Face in the Window as her object of prayer in History, Jane Ellen prayed in and for the Heritage, for, in her blinding and deafening Pride, she did not recognize the Word of the LORD and could not recognize the THE JUDGEMENT.
>
> Jane Ellen!
> She instructed people on how to look at the whole thing, but the thing is this: she didn't know how to look right at all, for the LORD hath *blinded*, and *deafened* her, too, and **she couldn't see *squash shit.***

She couldn't see *squash shit* for her furious **Pride,** *blinding* and *deafening* **h'white Pride**, **Pride** in the **Heritage** of the **Legacy** of the Old South. In her hateful and wrathful fury, she could not make measurements, and she could not tend to the garden of her mind for she was too proud—*a proud idiot*, didn't know Jack from Sally, didn't know *squash shit*.

It was for her *Pride* that she was a *fucking idiot*. She was a true idiot worthy of close study, and nobody was ever as proud as this woman was, either, nobody ever, it would seem; *she had* ***Pride*** *as she was the kind of idiot that the* ***Legacy*** *needed for this* ***Legend*** *to successfully spread over time and space as a matter of material concern, which is* the ***History*** *itself of the blinding and deafening fury of the* ***Heritage***—mind and understand, this is about legacy in legend and legend in legacy, a matter of the trellis of bigotry and the idiots who till as the fruit of their labor the Heritage, passed down and told over and over again in the famously recursive South, the Legend of the Face in the Window, the same things happening over and over again to the same people, and, it is the case, and truly it is, that it's the idiots who make the world go around in those parts, where they believe such things such as lightning printing a damn lave's face on a win*dah*.

A controversial consideration.

Jane Ellen Hadley was mildly retarded, just was and this was due to **her Pride in the Heritage of the Legacy of the Legend**. She was mildly retarded and hadn't been accommodated in any special way so that she could learn to do things like how to properly read, retarded in addition to her untreated schizophrenia, truly handicapped, but, in her idiocy which was an expression of **her Pride in Legacy**, she had been aptly apportioned a grace which she did not accept, the grace her privileged heritage in this world, and, in a place like that place, in relation to **the Legacy in her Heritage**, a **Heritage** she idiotically loved without abandon nor embarrassment, no shame, it made so clear that **her Pride in the Heritage** were her clear hatreds and bigotries as matters of concern. To be full of the fury that is of **the Heritage in the Legacy** is to testify to the witness of the idiocy in being one, a retard. This overwhelm of her mind, this mild retardation she had going on with the schizophrenia in toe, an energy that would boil over and by way of the excess in the channels of her countenance; this kind of spiritual

congestion all clearly plagued her so, clearly did, as for this was always, with her, happening so plainly for all in this world to see, her shamelessness in **Her pride in the Heritage of the Legacy**. The handicap has nothing to do with her worth, intelligence in all of its diversities nor her idiocy—this is a misunderstanding, as retardation of the sort here is **the Legacy of the Pride in the Heritage**. **The Pride in the Heritage** was the complex nature of her idiocy, a retardation in the development of the legacy to secure the heritage, for she was an obvious idiot in any assessment measured by the rods of regard in the attention to the virtue that the units of the relative measuring rods of regard outside of **the Legacy**, in **their Heritage** of a constitutive relative grace—which is a moral about measurement and kindness lost on the idiot—all assessments made and let Equality guide any consideration of Justice in the face of the retarded. This idiocy was not illness in her nervous system from the retardation—that was **the Pride in the Heritage** that was her idiocy for **the Legacy**. Her retarded taste and Judgment in this world was her mark on this world, an aesthetic intervention for the legacy in the name of **the Pride of the Heritage**, her own **Legacy** as a human being, her personal aesthetic, that is, which is idiocy—he ultimate idiot for an idiot plot such as those of this here tedious a sort, the idiots in the plot of the legacy in the ways of the heritage, idiots are the retards who play out their whole, entire full lives, squandering the liberties of development and the gift of a whole, entire full life, in the name of legacy in the places of legend as the history of the legacy, such as the pride of the heritage of the legacy in legendary Carrollton, Alabama; her idiocy, this was all that she had in the pride in the legacy as her heritage to the legend, her idiocy an imprint on this world through the materials around where her person was on this Earth with all of its creatures, idiocy in this world as a subject of the history of this Earth a strange and peculiar road for the aberrant constitution, the way of the retarded idiot in the plot who extends the plot in the name of the legacy in their pride in the heritage. This idiocy, all generally, and really specifically, is lost in the retardation that is the heritage of her forefathers as the pride in the legacy of the legend—it truly did leave her mighty confused, her retardation, mostly, the clearest symptom of the idiocy that was the legacy of the heritage as presented in her notions such as those she had about the schwa e, expressed over and over in her notions, contorting her sizzling tongue, and with a novel intensity that only a legacy girl like her could know in her

pedigree of debauchery and idolatry in her heritage which she claimed rather than rejected for Truth and Justice, her neglect born of an inability to choose such, for her confusion in the overwhelm of the channels of her thinned attention, things in this world such as this, such overwhelm of the channels of her knowing, understand, was all she had and was all she was, her lot in life. Imagine this sheer boredom—mind, all of this was to do with, but not due to, the fact that she didn't know how to look for *squash shit*, just didn't know Jack from Sally, so tipsy turvy in her notions that were her pride in the heritage as the legacy and contorted in her commitments, this all bigger than her tending of her attention to matters of concern as would be germane to any serious person trying to make significant progress in this world, this was about the thinning of her attention and so her channels glitched. She took it all in, she did, whatever it was that she saw but did not understand as for, for her, presence didn't demand of her in her notion of it to regard something beyond awareness, and as for such, she was not looking ever in her thin attention, and, whatever it be, she said stuff about it, whatever it was that she was on about when she'd find herself amidst whatever it was in this world that was a matter of concern, her usually confused amidst this stalemate with time in her thin attention her contorted sense of place, being intently focused in her hatreds while having no idea where she was or what she was doing—this, again, was for her lack for attention tended to matters of concern. She knew it was there, whatever she was ignoring but had to acknowledge, for she was aware in her ambivalence, awareness notably the one of the bluntest modes of attention, one which lacks a key for accurate perception, and that is regard, regard a trait shared by such modes of attention as worry, which can be contrasted with another modes of attention which exudes regard, and that is concern, worry versus concern, concern the former a stress, but worry, this is the more pointed partner in regard as it minds looking and paying attention, as, after all, people are known to worry themselves sick, but nobody ever died of being concerned. And, in turn, this general overwhelm in her channels in in her countenance that plagued her so, it would betray her lack of regard, as for, for her, the range of her thinned attention had no headroom, as for, for her, both the ceiling and floor of basic awareness was the register to which she tended to this world in her thinned attention, and, at that, only as required by the demands of acknowledgement in its appeals as part of the Judgment, and in such an architecture, where there is not an inch

between the floor and the ceiling, there was no room for growth and for deviation from the legacy as an opportunity afforded by history to her, her so privileged and having no reason to be so hateful and zero-sum as her bigotry's projection of her hateful idiocy, and so she could not feel the range of what she needed to feel, as for, for her, she never tried, and she was as such doomed to miss out on two modes of attention that are related in that they are variation in stage and not kind, which is a knowing and set of material facts that it is a historical Truth that only and only the experience of the exchange in the interlocution done in nature by mutual regard that is held in full attention with another creature before you in this world, a knowing that minding at all because you care about it, far more than being aware and ignoring something, is something is of the same season and theme, the same thing at different stages of the experience in the exchange, , people being known to worry themselves sick in medical fact. Many people have died from intimacy abut more have died for their lack of it.

McDaniel writes in our primary document of primary evidence:

I—Itragene McDaniel, soon to be Mrs. Wells— am the first speaker here, the other one Henry Wells, Jesus, HaMoschiach:

"I like what you've done with the place."

"Thanks, it is a nice waiting room."

"I really like it but I hate to see all that's going on out there."

"Hey, just don't pre-judge, don't be prejudiced."

"I try, it is exhausting and hurts the ocean. I don't want to be prejudiced…"

"Great."

"You like ghost stories?"

"Sure, but you should bone up on coding for work, learn how to use a computer. You need a job, you'd like it."

"I've seen it. I've seen it on the TV, code, they call it. I hate code—it's just a bunch of strings to me and it confuses my eyeballs, so I'll stick to eyeballing

> and being onto something as well as half-assed symbolic logic."
>
> "The face in the window is an educational game that you can use to pass time, you'll get a kick out of it."
>
> "Sure, but I'm not learning command line; I'm very busy but I am glad that there are experts like yourself who can play such games. Also, I love you, though this is no modern romance."
>
> "I don't know what you're talking about."
>
> "Me either, not at all. I'm not marrying the greatest computer hacker and wizard the world's ever known."
>
> "Iddy, baby, I'm a former slave and I'm dead, honey."

And so, what I will call "the bit" emerges in McDaniel's cogitations and writings, her psychotic but insightful writings: doing a bit is a way people get by, and bits are sequences in history. Bits are sequences of imitable behavior constituted by strings of discrete, replicable memes. Something like mirror synesthesia, a term perhaps worth coining and elaborating, it is the key mechanism of the love that binds us, empathy and pure awareness, us becoming replicas of one another, imitating one another, evolving, creatures made from stardust in each individual (divine) image, human history a psychedelic trail, a non-linear sequence of experiential images as encountered by the strange loop that is each unique instance of human consciousness.

Itragene's hallucinations of people—I conclude from extensive interviews with her and a substantial study of her written outputs from her times experiencing manic psychosis—were memes particular to those people. She memorized them, their memes...their memory a blessing, she'd often say in our interviews.

Itragene's story upends an axiom of memetics, which is that memes replicate between people—Itragene demonstrates that virtual personas can replicate and mutate memes, like her so-called Assembly of Israel…

○ ✦ ○

Mrs. Sanders took the stage under the window and began to wait for the music to start and her queue. She was about to sing "I swear" by All-4-One. Inside the courthouse, on the first floor, Garland, cast as Henry Wells in the play, was going over his lines one last time.

In her position, Itragene prayed about the hard image, the difficult likeness of Henry Wells, "the difficult likeness" a translation of some Hebrew she had assembled using the ten sefirot of Kabbalah, each associated in Jewish mysticism with a different letter —

ת ל מ י צ א ק ש ה

She knew what this meant literally—the difficult likeness—and she knew this Hebrew, Kabbalistic glyph was said as *"Tzelem Qasheh."*

צֶלֶם קָשֶׁה

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The gunmen were all positioned around the county square, all was ready to go.

All of a sudden, a rope appeared, flopping down the north side of the courthouse, and then legs appeared, and an ass, a very tiny ass, and this body was wearing leather. This figure descended, steadying itself on the rope with one hand and wielding a giant hammer with another.It was Itragene, dressed in a full leather cat woman costume
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The biggest sin in the South is doing something for attention. I didn't do it for the attention, and I didn't think I was better than anybody else. I am just an old woman.

There's nothing wrong with looking for a little attention. Jesus was only 33 and he wanted some attention. He got what he was asking for, but nobody deserves what he got—and that was a lot of attention. He's the most famous man in the world.

I am on the couch with Madonna and Sandra Bernhard. The next guess joins soon.

"These lights are so goddamn bright, my goddamn word," I was thinking, just sitting there in front of everybody, thinking, shifting in my itchy wool jacket.

It was so bright, it was so hot. I felt so much pressure to do good. You just had to get accustomed, I calmed myself with those words.

One must accustom oneself to things.

I was sitting next to the host, who is David Letterman, and he's on the stage-right side of the couch.

My black coffee, which was good, real good, was empty, my CBS mug they gave me in the dressing room sitting there empty. I wanted more coffee, but I didn't want to impose. One must ask for things, but one must also know when.

I was sitting up there on the stage. I was thinking, I was getting comfortable on a couch that was set before a studio audience. A professional makeup artist was busying about me, giving me a a final powdering. The lights were so bright. Above the studio audience, all sat and chatting, excited, all of us in the studio on a commercial break, everybody there—me, David Letterman, and more guests would come out soon.

The commercial break was over, and the show's signature sax reigned the air for a moment, afloat the applause.

"Welcome back, welcome back, ladies and gentlemen—and ghosts! Ghosts, too."

Letterman said that. I remember him saying that.

I had to pay attention again—the show was coming on.

"We're still here with Ma Iddy, Itragene Belle McDaniel—Sr., is it?"

I could feel all the saliva leave my mouth, my gut clenching, nerves running wild. I wanted a cigarette.

I answered, "Yes, Sr. My daughter is the Jr but she don't claim me no more."

Letterman continued, "Let's hear more about this 'Face in the Window'— the Face in the Window, folks," David Letterman said, throwing his hand up with his giant notecards in them, *The Late Show with David Letterman* music director Paul Shaffer riffing a quick saxophone note at the topical head nod from David in his setup of the conversation. This was live network television, July 1996. Letterman and the band were setting the conversation up for a humorous time, sure was, that David Letterman, with whom I'm wasn't very familiar because the only late-night TV I really watch is *911*, and that's really during the day day, daytime, because I watch recordings from the night prior.

"Iddy Jr. is in prison," I made sure to express.

"So it's like the Times Square of Carrollton—have you had a chance to go? A what was it," Letterman said, referencing his notecards, "a Gordo girl, Gordo, Alabama, folks—the Carrollton town square is a bit like Times Square but for an Alabama town. Do I have that right?"

"There's always people runnin' across the road real quick around the square, weekdays mostly, weekends, too, depending on what's going on; most of the traffic is on Highway 82, which is a speed trap —"

Paul Schaffer hit the drums regarding the Highway 82 trivia.

"That wouldn't be where, what was it," Letterman said, scratching his chin and referencing his giant notecards, "that wouldn't be where 'the Flat Sisters of Gordo' got ran over, would it? I understand they were hit by a chicken truck—" and Schaffer made a boing sound with something.

"Now, we've got a bit of a surprise for you, somebody who we thought you'd like to meet …" Letterman gestured wide and began to clap, the applause sign came on and everybody was clapping, but I had no idea what was next.

Letterman goes, "Welcome Supreme Court Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, folks!"

I couldn't believe it.

Ginsburg waved graciously at the audience as she moseyed towards me; she made her way to the couch, insisted on a hug from me which I barely recall, hugged Dave, sat down next to me, and adjusted her cuffs on her wrists, her real, physical, corporeal wrists.

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It was so bright. It was so hot. One must get accustomed, I calmed myself with those words.

I had to pay attention again—the show was coming on. "We're still here with Ma Iddy, Itragene Belle McDaniel—Sr., is it?"

I could feel all the saliva leave my mouth, my gut clenching, nerves running wild. I wanted a cigarette.

I answered, "Yes, Sr. My daughter is the Jr but she don't claim me no more."

Letterman continued, "Now that we have the Justice here, let's hear more about this 'Face in the Window'— the Face in the Window, folks," David Letterman said, throwing his hand up with his giant notecards in them, *The Late Show with David Letterman* music director Paul Shaffer riffing a quick saxophone note at the topical head

nod from David.

This was live network television, July 1996. I wasn't very familiar with David Letterman's program because the only late-night TV I really watch is *911*, and that's really during the day day, because I watch recordings from the night prior.

"Iddy Jr. is in prison," I made sure to express.

"Gordo. That wouldn't be where, what was it," Letterman said, scratching his chin and referencing his giant notecards that were littered all over his desk because he had thrown them in the air, "that wouldn't be where 'the Flat Sisters of Gordo' got ran over, would it? I understand they were hit by a chicken truck—" and Schaffer made a boing sound with something.

I couldn't believe it.

David then went, "A little birdie—" at which Paul Schaffer did a crow caw three times—"a little birdie tells me you're a bit of a singer."

Madonna had already performed "Secret," so it was a surprise that more music was up.

The chicken knows.

Non regrette rien.